

Audionarratology

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Edited by

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Audionarratology

Interfaces of Sound and Narrative

Edited by
Jarmila Mildorf and Till Kinzel

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Preface and Acknowledgments

Narratology or, more precisely, post-classical narratologies are fast-lived areas of research in the sense that, in the past decades, they have seen an incredible turnover of new concepts and technical or analytical terms. There are critical voices who see in this ‘explosion’ and diversification of narratological concepts a lack of coherence and consistency which also threatens the core of the discipline. At the same time, and on a more positive note, the creativity of narratologists and their readiness to call each other’s concepts into question also attest to the vitality of the discipline: narratology is here to stay and it vouchsafes continuous debates. We want to contribute to these debates and yes, we also offer a new concept and an attendant new term: *audionarratology*. The term is meant to do nothing less than inaugurate yet another postclassical narratology, one which takes into focus relationships between sound and narrative or more precisely, between oral and aural forms of expression in artistic and non-artistic media and genres and their narrative affordances, structures and functions.

We think that we are justified in proposing *audionarratology* for three reasons: first, it seeks to counter the visual bias that has hitherto predominated over much of literary and cultural studies and consequently also over narratology; second, it contributes to and, because of its particular angle, further refines current discussions in transmedial narratology; third, it encourages, even requires for its existence, interdisciplinary collaboration and support and thus furthers the idea of interdisciplinarity. Needless to say that the present book, in offering a first attempt at defining and circumscribing the concept, still contains numerous blind spots and opens more vistas to desirable lines of research than it can possibly already present in their entirety here. The theory behind *audionarratology* is emergent rather than predetermined. Therefore, the book’s aim is exploratory and it is meant to raise questions as much as it seeks to find answers. In this connection, we first and foremost thank our contributors, who kindly agreed to participate in this joint venture and who, with their innovative research questions and narrative materials, have helped to set *audionarratology* on a firm footing.

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Jarmila Mildorf & Till Kinzel

Audionarratology: Prolegomena to a Research Paradigm Exploring Sound and Narrative

1. Preliminary Thoughts

In 2002, Vera and Ansgar Nünning (2002, 18) ended their introduction to a collection of essays on transgeneric, intermedial and interdisciplinary narrative theory with a list of future avenues for narratological inquiry and desirable research questions. They contended, for example, that while film narratology was well under way, the arts, music and comics, as well as other culturally influential media such as narrative radio plays, hyperfiction, TV genres and further narrative media formats were still to receive heightened attention and to be explored in more depth. More than a decade later, the picture has considerably changed: inter- and transmedial approaches to narrative are everywhere (Hatavara et al. 2016; Olson 2011; Page and Thomas 2011; Strohmaier 2013, Ryan 2004). Interest in comics and graphic novels has increased exponentially (e.g., Schüwer 2008; Kukkonen 2013; Stein and Thon 2013; Trabert, Stuhlfauth-Trabert and Waßmer 2015); the same can be said of TV series and films (Bordwell 1985 and 2004; Brössel 2014). Hyperfiction, computer and video games (Domsch 2013), and other digital forms of narration (including, for example, fanfiction) have experienced a stellar rise both among users and scholars (Ryan 2005). Linguists have begun to explore social media formats such as social network sites, chat rooms, or instant messaging from a narratological perspective (Georgakopoulou 2013; Page 2012). Even paintings and other pictorial art (Bachmann 2014; Steiner 2004) as well as, to some degree, instrumental music (Almén 2008; Klein and Reyland 2013; Maus 1991 and 1997; Tarasti 2004) have been considered from a narrative-analytical perspective (see also Wolf 2002).

And yet, if one has a closer look, the preponderance of narrative approaches that focus on either verbal/textual in combination with visual or audio-visual media can hardly be ignored. This does not come as a surprise, given that cultural studies, which have been very influential in literary studies and analogously also in narratology, have in the past four decades largely followed in the wake of, first, the so-called “linguistic turn” (see Bachmann-Medick 2009, 33–36), and then the “visual turn,” which emphasized the various aspects of “visual culture” (see, e.g., Benthien and Weingart 2014). Schweighauser (2013, 476) also

talks about a “visualist bias of much scholarship on modernist and postmodern culture,” and he claims that research undertaken under the umbrella term “sound studies” seeks to offer “a corrective” to this bias (see also Filk 2005, 308). In these contexts, the role of language may also become an area of contention. Perhaps it is true that “the verbal media represent the domain *par excellence* of prototypical narratives,” as Werner Wolf (2011, 174) argues. However, the hierarchy of media with reference to narrativity that Wolf then suggests, of which “the top register would certainly be occupied by media that use the verbal in combination with other codes” (Wolf 2011, 174), also creates blind spots. This is particularly the case if, for one thing, visual codes continue to be overemphasized over codes relating to other sense perceptions and, secondly, if “verbal” is primarily used in its restricted sense of “relating to or using words” rather than its other meaning, which focuses on the *spoken* rather than the written word.

For linguists investigating narrative in conversational settings, the sound features of rhythm, tone of voice, prosody and intonation are self-evident parameters to be taken into account (see De Fina and Georgakopoulou 2012, 36–43), and the materiality of stories as well as speakers’ voice qualities have recently been given renewed attention in the study of multimodal narratives (Van Leeuwen 2009, see also Martínez’s contribution in this volume). In the early twentieth century, Russian formalists such as Boris Ėjchenbaum and Jurij Tynjanov recognized the importance of the sound component in literary language. They noted the significance of intonation and voice within narrative prose and pointed to the fact that the particular narrative form of *skaz* with its orientation towards oral storytelling “makes the word physiologically perceptible,” as Tynjanov says (quoted in Schmid 2014, 155). Ėjchenbaum (1969, 161) welcomed a suggestion made by German philologists such as Eduard Sievers and others to have an “ear philology” (“Ohrenphilologie”) instead of an “eye philology” (“Augenphilologie”). And yet, the sonic qualities of fictional texts and the perceived or imagined features of narrators’ and characters’ voices are still rarely taken into focus in narratological analysis (cf. Blödorn, Langer and Scheffel 2006, Delazari in this volume).¹ At the same time, aural media and sound artistic genres such as, for example, radio plays or audio dramas, audiobooks, sound installations or different popular music formats are still at the margins of narratological research, or lower down in the media hierarchy, to use Wolf’s image. Although they are obviously more central in media studies (Binczek, Demböck and Schäfer

¹ Saying this, Pinto (2012) has recently taken voices in theatre, radio play and film under closer scrutiny. However, as is to be expected in a media studies investigation, the book foregrounds technological realizations in the three medial contexts.

2013; Häusermann, Janz-Peschke and Rühr 2010; Ladler 2001; Rubery 2011), they have not necessarily been investigated with a view to identifying their specifically *narrative* qualities, affordances and potentialities (cf. Huwiler 2005b; Heuser 2013, 12).² We could say that, as far as narratology is concerned, sound in many art forms and medial contexts seems to have been relegated to what Leibniz called *petites perceptions*.³ An “acoustic turn” (Meyer 2008) may therefore be what is needed in narratology, too.

Some other areas where narrative and sound dovetail each other, e.g., in museum audio guides or when people read stories out loud, have been utterly neglected (cf., however, Trelease 2013). Arguably, some of the reasons for this oversight or lack of attention may be the very transitoriness of the object of study in aural/oral genres and media (Merkel 2015, 11). Sound and voice qualities are evanescent, and their narratological analysis requires first, that they are captured or ‘fixed’ in a recording and then made available in transcribed form (this involves important questions of *methodology*)⁴ and that, second, they are discussed as part of and with due attention paid to the medium within which they occur (this involves the question of *theory*, e.g., theories regarding different media). In this context, Wolf (2011, 174) quite rightly postulates a “media-conscious narratology,” which “would not only include comparisons of the technical and material aspects of narrative media but also analyses of their position within the framework of social history, the history of perception and mentalities, and the history of media configurations.” Audionarratology can be seen as one subcategory of such a “media-conscious narratology,” which not only aims at bringing together research on art forms of which the most elementary common denominator is sound, but also seeks to offer a disciplinary ‘home’ to all those scholars already working at the above-mentioned boundaries or margins of narratology. As we will discuss below, the two interrelated aspects of theory and methodology make interdisciplinarity and close collaboration among scholars from different fields absolutely vital for audionarratology.

However, interdisciplinarity also has its challenges, not least when it comes to agreeing on certain terms and definitions for perceived phenomena. Audionar-

² In this context, it is noteworthy that a recent authoritative sound studies reader (Sterne 2012) does not even have an entry on ‘narrative,’ nor on ‘story’ or ‘storytelling’ in its index.

³ In his reflections on philosophical perception Leibniz argued that we have sense perceptions which we are not aware of but which influence all areas of our lives. Interestingly, the image Leibniz uses is that of the sound of the sea. See Leibniz (1996, 10–11).

⁴ A curious example of a sound performance whose transcription looks like sound presentations in comic strips is Cathy Berberian’s *Stripsody* (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OdNLAhL46xM>). For a discussion of this sound piece, see Schulz (2014).

ratology, too, will have to carefully calibrate the terms and concepts it wants to operate with, especially because it borrows from two areas of study which in themselves have brought forth diverse, and sometimes conflicting, technical terms and toolkits: narratology and sound studies. To give only one example: the study of “soundscapes” is undertaken in academic disciplines as varied as architecture and archaeology, anthropology and sociology, geography, physics, music and museology, to name but a few. The term was originally and famously defined by Canadian composer R. Murray Schafer (1977, 274–275) as “[t]he sonic environment. Technically, any portion of the sonic environment regarded as a field for study. The term may refer to actual environments, or to abstract constructions such as musical compositions and tape montages, particularly when considered as an environment.” Schafer’s writings still constitute key texts within sound studies (and unsurprisingly some of the contributions in our volume refer to those writings; see Bernaerts, Festjens, Skoulding). And yet, despite – or perhaps because of – the widespread usage of the concept of “soundscapes” the term is full of creative fuzziness (“voll kreativer Unschärfe”), as H. U. Werner (2003: 18) puts it. In analogy to “landscapes,” “soundscapes” cannot easily be demarcated. Where does one soundscape end and another begin? What are constitutive elements (sounds) of a soundscape? How can one capture those sounds and then represent them in symbolic or iconographic form?⁵ And what happens to terms when they are translated into other languages? “Soundscape,” for example, is commonly translated into German as “Klanglandschaft” (Paul and Schock 2014, 19). Is this academic term in any way related to the word “Geräuschkulisse” (literally: “sonic set”), which is commonly used in everyday parlance and which draws on a theatrical rather than a geographical metaphor? As this brief example of soundscape research already indicates, finding a common language for interdisciplinary collaboration creates serious conundrums. Below, we will briefly present an example of how the study of particular soundscapes can also tie in with narrativization.

Let us dwell on the question of terminology for a little longer. For the purposes of this introduction, we largely follow the dictionary definitions of words like “sound,” “sonic,” “auditory,” “auditive,” “aural,” “auricular” and

5 This raises the above-mentioned question of methodology again. Schafer interestingly resorts to pictorial representations of soundscapes as means of notation, e.g., isobel maps, charts showing the loudness and temporal occurrence of different sounds and a variety of “sound event maps” that use symbolic or pictorial icons for sound sources and the movement of sounds emanating from these sources (Schafer 1977: 264–267). In this context, it is interesting to note that scientific representations of sounds (e.g., spectrograms) also *visualise* them and only thus manage to make them ‘readable.’

“acoustic” (see *Oxford English Dictionary*). What these terms precisely refer to in any given piece of research largely depends on the discipline(s) researchers draw on. For this reason, the contributions to this volume may well differ slightly in the way they employ certain terms, depending on whether they refer to physical, musical, neuropsychological, philosophical, etc. definitions (see also Sterne 2012, 6). One aspect to consider is how the above-mentioned terms are related to one another, both in present-day English but also etymologically. According to the *Oxford English Dictionary*, “aural” and “auricular” are considered synonymous and they mean “of or pertaining to the organ of hearing” as well as “received or perceived by the ear.” The first of these two meanings is also shared by the adjectives “auditive” and “auditory.” “Auditory” can additionally also mean “belonging to the auditorium of a theatre,” thus assuming an architectural dimension. The Latin word “*auris*” (Engl. “ear”), which forms the stem of “aural” and “auricular,” stresses the function of the hearing organ in sound perception, whereas “acoustic” always seems to imply the involvement of some technical or technological apparatus. Even in its ‘biological’ meaning of “designating the sense or the organs of hearing; of or relating to the sense of hearing; auditory,” “acoustic” points to some underlying mechanism (see, for example, expressions such as “acoustic organs” or “acoustic fovea”). The meaning of the adjective “sonic” is closely connected to the physical definition, which involves sound waves (“employing or operated by sound waves,” “of or pertaining to sound or sound waves”). Finally, the noun “sound,” which is at the core of sound studies, seems to be a ‘mixed bag’ of meanings including music, noise and voice.⁶ The first definition of “sound” given by the *Oxford English Dictionary* under the third entry for this noun – which is the entry most relevant for the purposes of this volume – reads as follows:

The sensation produced in the organs of hearing when the surrounding air is set in vibration in such a way as to affect these; also, that which is or may be heard; the external object of audition, or the property of bodies by which this is produced. Hence also, pressure waves that differ from audible sound only in being of a lower or a higher frequency.

What strikes one immediately when reading this definition is the apparent fuzziness of the idea of “sound.” Sound seems to permeate the boundaries between the subject and the object of hearing; it seems to relate to the characteristic features of bodies (“property”) as much as to their effects on other bodies (“sensa-

⁶ Interestingly, the word “sound” is also etymologically related to the Old English word for “melody,” “*swinn*” (Helmreich 2012: 172), which already points to a perceived connection between sound more broadly defined and music or even singing.

tion”). In this context, it is interesting to note that, from a philosophical perspective, it is extremely difficult to adequately define “sound.” Philosophical considerations precisely hinge on questions surrounding phenomena and objecthood, on the relationship between sounds and their causes, on the experience of sound in contrast to its physics, on the eventfulness and processuality of sound, and on how sound can be distinguished from other notions such as “tone” (Scruton 1997, 1–18). Given this broad range of ‘audio vocabulary,’ to which sound studies have added numerous neologisms, the ultimate question for audionarratology is which of these many and diverse terms can be fruitfully connected with questions of narrative and narrativity – in themselves contested concepts – and how this link can be accomplished. There is plenty of scope for future research.

2. Sound and Narrative in Human Cognition, Society and Culture

To relegate sound to the margins is the more the pity if one considers that sound and narrative in combination pervade our lives from an early age onwards. Audioception or the faculty to hear sounds is one of the earliest sense perceptions of human beings, well before they are born; and the perception of sounds, as Wulf (1997, 461) notes, is always linked to temporal sequences, a point we will return to below. More generally, auditory perception is intricately related to, and often becomes instrumental in, other cognitive faculties such as, for example, memory or spatial orientation, as psychologists have demonstrated (see contributions in McAdams and Bigand 1993). We are constantly surrounded by, and process in our minds, what physicists and acoustic engineers call “white noise,” i.e., “noise whose amplitude is constant throughout the audible frequency range. It is described as ‘white’ by analogy to white light, which is a mixture of all visible wavelengths of light” (Nave 2014). While natural sounds can be considered variants of white noise, purer, more high-pitched and structurally ordered sounds as can be found in bird song have developed into an art form that is universal to all cultures: music (Dutton 2009, 212). From an evolutionary perspective, music is of particular interest because of its affinity to human speech (Dutton 2009, 213–214). We will return to this and other points relating to music in section 4 below. Obviously, music as one sound component plays a major role in many kinds of narrative and therefore occupies a key position in audionarratology.

Sound, music and voices are also important because of their affective dimension. For historical anthropologist Christoph Wulf, the fact that the sound of the

voice allows us to perceive that we are addressed by others makes audioception a ‘social’ sense perception, not least because familiar sounds and voices may foster a sense of belonging to a group and of feeling sheltered (Wulf 1997, 459). The voices of our parents reading bed-time stories to us, the favourite song lyrics that form the soundtracks of our lives, the audiobooks we listen to when we need an alternative to reading stories, the radio plays we hear when tuning in to our favourite radio station, the sound effects and music that intensify our emotions when watching a movie: there are boundless examples for the ways in which sound and narrative intersect. And in all these contexts, sound, music and voices trigger in us an emotional response that we may still remember years later. Retailers have known this for a long time, and sound and music are designed and strategically employed to reach customers and clients emotionally so they are set in the mood to buy merchandise (LaBelle 2010, 170–179). Sound and music can thus have a regulative function as well. Think, for example, of how certain kinds of music and tones can be deployed to attract attention, thus fulfilling a signalling function, or how pleasant sounds are used in aeroplanes to keep customers calm and relaxed (DeNora 2000, 11–14). In this sense, what sociologist Tia DeNora (2000, 16–17) says of music applies to sound more generally:

At the level of daily life, music has power. [...] Music may influence how people compose their bodies, how they conduct themselves, how they experience the passage of time, how they feel – in terms of energy and emotion – about themselves, about others, and about situations. [...] To be in control, then, of the soundtrack of social action is to provide a framework for the organization of social agency, a framework for how people perceive (consciously or subconsciously) potential avenues of conduct. This perception is often converted into conduct *per se*.

Put differently, sounds and music are not merely backgrounds to our lives; they can become constitutive in the sense that we may arrange our lives to their rhythms and cadences. Thus, sound and music are intertwined with social life more generally and, what is even more, the ‘sounds of our time’ change together with our social, historical, political and cultural life. This becomes evident in light of the recent interest of cultural historians in the history of sounds, noises and voices that permeate modern culture (see Paul and Schock 2014). In this connection, the nexus of narrative and sound is shifted from more discrete, personal stories to larger cultural or ‘grand’ narratives of whole societies.

A good example of a project which explores specific sounds and soundscapes with a view to identifying their historical boundedness as well as their change over time is the recent EU project “Work with Sounds” (<http://www.work-withsounds.eu/>). It is based on a co-operation between six European museums

specializing in the history of labour and it archives typical sounds of industrial machinery and work-related soundscapes. While the individual sounds archived are not necessarily narrative in the strict sense of the word they are narrativized on account of their placement in a (virtual) museum whose aim it is to capture their historical specificity and development. Metaphorically speaking, these sounds come to ‘tell the story’ of a distant past, of obsolete work practices and lifeworlds within which workers spent years of their lives. As Karin Bijsterveld’s (2012) study of industrial workers’ justifications for refusing to wear hearing protection also shows, machine sounds assume a special cultural meaning for this social group and they play important roles in those workers’ life stories.

It is some of these interfaces of sound and narrative at the level of individual sound art pieces but also at a wider cultural level that are explored in more depth in the contributions to this volume, thus outlining a new “postclassical narratology” (Herman 1999; Alber and Fludernik 2010). Audionarratology is intended to function as an umbrella term for narrative approaches that take into view forms and functions of sound and their relation to narrative structure. Sound in this context incorporates the whole spectrum from structured sound, as in music or in spoken language, to prosodic features of voices, sound emanating from recognizable things and sources and more or less indeterminable noise, as well as electro-acoustic manipulation. The proposed research paradigm operates on the boundaries to related fields such as literature and music (Wolf 1999 and 2002) or, more broadly, word and music studies (Cupers and Weisstein 2000), as well as narrative and intermediality (Ryan 2004; Page and Thomas 2011). Unlike the former, audionarratology focuses more strongly on the relationship between forms and functions of *sound and/as narrative* (see also Keskinen 2008). In contrast to the latter, it narrows down its interest to aural media and to oral/aural channels in other media, thus shifting emphasis away from typical questions concerning text-image relations and the visual in recent cultural and literary studies (see above). The relationship between sound and narrative can be studied *within* audiovisual media and aural genres. Audionarratology can also be applied to a *comparison between* those genres as regards the nexus between sound and narrative. One can identify the following areas of study, some of which have already received comparatively more attention, as we mentioned above:

- a. cinematic film
- b. television drama and film
- c. video and computer games
- d. musical dramatic genres like musicals or opera
- e. radio plays
- f. audiobooks

- g. poetry readings and readings of other literary texts (e.g., closet drama, prose fiction)
- h. popular songs and other popular music genres
- i. sound performances and sound installations
- j. ‘pragmatic’ aural genres such as museum audio guides; audio travel guides; audio self-help literature and the like
- k. digital narratives on the internet

The list is by no means exhaustive. However, it already illustrates that audionarratology, rather than limiting itself to a clearcut set of media and genres, operates along at least three axes or trajectories: 1. from audiovisual (e.g., television, cinema or computers) to purely auditory media (e.g., radio); 2. from literary/artistic (e.g., opera,⁷ pop songs, radio drama or poetry) to pragmatic genres (e.g., audio guides); 3. from verbal to non-verbal forms of expression (e.g., audiobooks vs. sound installations). We must add the caveat that these axes are continua along which different media and genres can be placed. Thus, the categorisation of audio media and genres is a matter of “more or less” rather than “either/or.” Furthermore, the three axes we propose are not discrete but intersect in manifold ways. For example, radio as an auditory medium may be used to broadcast both artistic and pragmatic text genres, and while language arguably plays a major role in radio broadcasting non-verbal forms of expression such as music are equally important. In order to be able to reflect on the affordances and constraints of different media and genres in connection with narrative, it might be helpful to adopt some media typology, especially since the term “medium” is also far from clearcut. Mike Sandbothe (2005, xv; see also Filk 2005, 300 – 301), for example, proposes three major classes of media: media related to sense perceptions (“*Sinnliche Wahrnehmungsmedien*”) such as space, time and the five senses; semiotic media used to convey information and to communicate (“*Semiotische Informations- und Kommunikationsmedien*”), e.g., image, language, writing and music; and technical or technological media used for the recording, editing and dissemination of some content (“*Technische Verbreitungs-, Verarbeitungs- und Speichermedien*”) such as voice (!), print, radio, film, television, computer and internet. Whether one uses this typology or another one offered by media studies – what is absolutely vital for audionarratological research

⁷ Christian Schröder (2011: 55) argues that even the orchestra can assume a narratorial function in operas because the music and its instrumentation can introduce shifting perspectives and add an evaluative stance on the presented events. This is open to debate, and Schröder himself concedes that opera’s narrative potential only emerges from the interplay between text and music (Schröder 2011: 56). We will say more about narrative and music in section 4 below.

is that its focus must lie on narrative manifestations in and through the above-mentioned media and genres.

One theoretical question that therefore arises is to what extent the investigated artefacts situated on these axes can still be said to be or to contain narrative. Our list of potential research areas might at first glance suggest a pan-narrativist approach where anything might pass for narrative. And some of the sound art examples explored in the chapters of this book are admittedly borderline cases as regards narrativity. Thus, Elke Huwiler and Lars Bernaerts analyse borderline examples in audio drama, Thijs Festjens discusses an experimental theatre project, and Zoë Skoulding explores the margins of narrativity in performance poetry. Nevertheless, it is precisely at those borders that narrativity can be brought into sharper relief and lead to further narrative-theoretical reflections. We do not follow a narrow definition of “narrative” which requires a narrator. Instead, we subscribe to a slightly broader conception along the lines of Wolf Schmid’s (2014, 8) distinction between mimetic-narrative genres and diegetic-narrative genres.⁸ Within those genres, one can find degrees of narrativity. Sound performances or installations, for example, may or may not tell a story, or the story they tell may only be retrievable from accompanying verbal information. Audio guide texts are not *prima facie* narrative in nature because they mainly contain explanations, descriptions and instructions, but they can at least temporarily become narrative whenever they tell the story of a place, a picture or a famous person, for example. Monika Fludernik’s (1996) notion of “experientiality” is important in this context because it becomes the watershed by which merely descriptive texts are separated from narrative texts. Even descriptions of events are not necessarily narrative as long as they lack an expression of what it is like (see also the notion of *qualia* in Herman 2009, 143–160). So, what is needed is a first attempt at describing the relationship between sound and narrative or narrativity, which in turn requires reflections on what narrative is.

⁸ Drama, for example, does not as a rule feature a narrator and yet, a play can certainly tell a story. Poetry is primarily non-narrative (Hempfer 2014) but there are numerous examples of narrative poems and poetic subgenres. Similarly, pop music genres may display more or less narrativity (see Palmer, this volume).

3. Narrative and Sound: Theoretical Considerations

Let us try a thought experiment: Imagine you hear the sound of something plopping, then the familiar sound of liquid being poured into glasses and then the sound of glasses clinking. Without seeing the scene, you would probably imagine at least one person, more likely two or more people, having just opened a bottle and toasting to themselves or to one another, presumably for a special reason. This interpretation would be strengthened if you additionally heard laughter and human voices talking. We suggest that this is the kernel of a story because the sounds we hear make us ask: who is involved here and what is the occasion? In other words, drawing on our world knowledge, we are likely to assume at least some anthropomorphic figures (only people can open a bottle and drink from glasses) and to form hypotheses about the situational context (we know that the pouring of liquid and the subsequent clinking of glasses usually means the activity of toasting, which in turn is usually related to a special occasion such as someone's birthday, the celebration of a promotion or the like). Drawing on David Herman's (2009) basic elements of narrative, we can say that this sequence of sounds creates a storyworld, however indeterminate and tentative, including characters and a setting. The example also shows that (aural) narrative only works when recipients try to make sense of what they hear, filling in the missing information by making assumptions and drawing inferences. One might add that they draw inferences on the basis of certain scripts that could be understood as the basic building blocks underlying narratives, because they contain any number of naturally occurring events in a structured sequential order, something that has been thoroughly explored in connection with the narrative creation of humour, for example (see Raskin 2008).

Cognitive approaches to narrative can be informative in this context (Herman 2013). In this area of study, scholars reflect on the interplay of textual cues and readers' life world experiences and knowledge schemata, as well as on the cognitive processes that make it possible for meaning to emerge from this interplay. An example would be how readers construct mental images of characters on the basis of how these are described in the text (see, e.g., Schneider 2013), which of course also includes the characters' speech patterns, voice qualities and other sounds they produce or are surrounded by in their respective storyworld. Note that some of the metaphors used in cognitive studies (e.g., mental *images*) once again mirror on the level of theoretical abstraction the pri-

macy of the visual.⁹ And research in cognitive narratology is typically anchored in texts rather than sounds. Nevertheless, as the contributions by Alan Palmer, María Angeles Martínez, Anežka Kuzmičová and Ivan Delazari show, cognitive approaches can also be fruitfully adopted for multimodal narratives with a stronger emphasis on their sound side. We will return to this point in sections 4 and 6.

Another important factor for narratives is what Herman (2009) calls their “situatedness.” In our thought experiment above, the ontological status of the described sound patterns would certainly be gauged differently if these sounds were, for example, coming from a room adjacent to the one we are in (we would probably assume there was a ‘real’ toasting going on) compared to, say, the same sounds emanating from a radio (where this could be part of a radio play and thus artistic and ‘unreal’ or part of a reportage and thus again ‘real’) or from behind the scenes of a theatre performance. More importantly, the example shows that narrative need not be verbal. Of course one could object here that the *script* of toasting, i. e., our inherent knowledge of what this activity typically involves, is based on verbalizations of this activity that have been agreed upon in our culture. However, we do not believe that every activity by necessity already involves language use (one could call that the linguistic fallacy). At any rate, to debate whether sound or word comes/came first can only be speculative in a culture that is so focused on language as ours and where sound, word and image are constantly meshed. It therefore makes sense to build audionarratology squarely onto a semiotic foundation, as Elke Huwiler (2005a, 54–94) also suggests in her pioneering study of narrative and radio plays. Rather than considering narrative as a purely verbal phenomenon – as, for example, implied in Anthony Burgess’s notion of “words as sounds,” where radio is considered as a mere “extension of literature” (see Heuser 2013, 9) – audionarratology attends to sound narratives as a network of oral and/or aural semiotic systems. In his semiotic study of radio plays, Götz Schmedes (2002, 68–92) distinguishes between general sign systems, which can also be found outside radio plays (e.g., language, voice, sound, music, original sounds and silence), and audiophonic sign systems, which are specific to radio plays (e.g., fade in, cut, mixing, stereophony and electro-acous-

⁹ Psychological tests have shown that there is some foundation for the assumption that visual perception is in fact more dominant for humans. The rubber hand experiment, for example, in which subjects were shown a rubber hand being stroked lightly by a feather while the same action was performed on their real but concealed hand, confused the participants so much that they came to regard the rubber hand as belonging to their bodies. The experimenters took this to prove that visual perception has the power to overrule other sense perceptions, even if this effectually leads to misperceptions (Botvinick and Cohen 1998; for a re-evaluation of this experiment, see Tsakiris and Haggard 2005).

tic manipulation¹⁰). These sign systems combine in specific ways to create a narrative, and it is these combinations that need to be addressed more assiduously.

The very nature of sound makes it potentially narrative since sound moves and is received in time. If there is in addition a change in sound or sound quality we can already speak of a minimal narrative sequence because not only do we perceive a passing of time but also different sound events on that time axis. The criterion of eventfulness, which for many narratologists is a key criterion for defining narrative (see Schmid 2014, 12–30), can arguably be created through sound alone. Imagine, for example, the trampling sound of hoofs in the distance, which gradually seems to come closer because there is an increase in loudness, and then the sudden and somewhat surprising sound of a shot. The very positioning of sound sources can already be said to create eventfulness since the change of sounds in (real) time parallels the change of events in narrative time. If a new sound occurs, as the shot in our example does, Herman's element of "disruption" is also given. We involuntarily begin to wonder what happened, who triggered the shot and why. Furthermore, we are made to experience what it is like to hear such sounds (the question of *qualia*) and perhaps what it is like to feel disturbed or frightened by them. This point raises interesting questions for the comparison between film narrative and radio plays, for example. Does the fact that in radio plays we can only resort to a mental image of the presented events change our experience of these events? And to what extent are our mental images already influenced by pictures made available to us through audio-visual media such as TV and film? In other words, is there perhaps a mutual cognitive influence or even interdependence between sound and image in certain kinds of aural genres and formats?

Audionarratology may also challenge existing terms and theoretical conundrums in narratology to date. We have already pointed to the relative neglect of literary texts' sonic make-up and of narrators' and characters' voice qualities. In fact, the very term "voice" becomes problematic as it is used metaphorically in narratology, and yet is still linked to a speaking 'persona,' the narrator, in the Genettean framework (for detailed discussions of the metaphor and its implications, see the contributions in Blödnor, Langer and Scheffel 2006).¹¹ Voices in fiction and other written narrative texts are always mediated or, conversely, are not immediate. This no longer applies once these written narratives have been transposed into aural media, which raises interesting questions regarding

¹⁰ The latter involves the technical production and manipulation of sound effects by means of, for example, blending, mixing, cutting, etc. (see Huwiler 2005a, 57).

¹¹ On the conception of the narrator, see Patron (2009).

sound, voices and music as well as their reception in adaptations (see also Pross 2013). Another area where *mediacy* turns into *immediacy* is focalization. As listeners to sounds in oral/aural storytelling, we assume a position similar to someone in the story who experiences the same sounds. We can literally hear bottle corks plopping or a shot ringing out, or at least sounds which suggest (i.e., are sufficiently similar to sounds in) those kinds of events or actions. Fludernik's (1996) conception of "experientiality" assumes a very different quality in this context because the sound side of storyworlds is no longer textually mediated but can be experienced directly or immediately in aural media. Focalization, which is a controversial concept in narratology (see Niederhoff 2014), is based on the visual metaphor of a lens through which one can take things, characters, actions in the storyworld into 'focus.' It seems that a media-sensitive narratology has to revise this concept to accommodate all the other sense perceptions, too. For the specifically aural perception of storyworlds, William Nelles (1997, 95) uses the term "auricularization," not without suggesting, somewhat tongue in cheek, that one could find "less unwieldy alternative coinages." Bartosz Lutostański's contribution in this volume also discusses the need for a more finely-grained terminological and analytical toolkit for specifically aural forms of narration, so this theoretical/methodological question promises to be fertile ground for future audionarratological explorations.

Let us now provide a rough outline of this book. The three main points of interest rest on the following themes, around which our contributions are clustered:

1. forms and functions of music in narratives across media and genres and, inversely, narrativity and narrative genres in certain kinds of music (section 4 below);
2. audio art forms more narrowly defined, their relationships to narrative and their implications for narrative theory (section 5);
3. aural narrative genres' and media's capacity to create storyworlds in and through sound and to immerse listeners/recipients (section 6).

Despite this division, which is a matter of convenience rather than of discrete categories, many of the contributions in this book obviously address one or more of the issues just indicated. Other connections between sound and narrative which would illuminate the boundaries of the field to some of the other research areas mentioned at the outset had to be left out for reasons of space and concision. For example, presentations and functions of sound, voices, silences and music in fictional texts, which are covered by only one exemplary contribution in this vol-

ume (Delazari), is a fruitful terrain for future studies.¹² Likewise, one could further explore the interfaces of sound, vision and narrative in audiovisual and visual media such as film, painting, sculpture, comics and graphic novels. One representative chapter in this book is Domsch's contribution on video games. We will now take each cluster in turn and discuss some theoretical and methodological issues related to them.

4. Music and Storytelling

The relationship between narrative and music has of course been discussed in musicology for quite some time now. As Fred Everett Maus (1991, 3–5) points out, musical descriptions which link music to narrative structures generally work by means of analogy and metaphor, and the question, from a musicological perspective, is whether such analogies are useful for music theory. Drawing on Russian Formalist typologies, e. g., Propp's fairy tale plot functions, and structuralist concepts such as story/discourse or temporal ordering, Maus tests their applicability to instrumental music, for example, in Beethoven's Sonata Op. 14, No. 1 and a Beethoven Rondo. Maus' approach is somewhat ambivalent. He, for example, sees an important and legitimate foundation for these analogies in the fact that both narrative theory and music theory try to abstract from the materials they analyse to arrive at generalizable patterns. At the same time, he cautions against such deep-structural concerns because they make the analogy potentially extendable to other non-narrative realms with a focus on sequencing and ordering, e. g., numerology (Maus 1991, 6). More interestingly, Maus stresses throughout his article that the perception of musical movements as displaying temporal ordering and as representing action and counteraction, characters, goal-directed motions, resolutions and the like is largely a question of interpretation. Maus repeatedly points out "listeners' capacity for interpreting musical events anthropomorphically" (Maus 1991, 6; see also Maus 1997, 300), and he draws a parallel between music and narrative because they both hinge on "*intelligible* action" (Maus 1991, 7; emphasis original).

¹² For the sake of recognisability, one could call such fictional texts "fictions of sound" in analogy to "fictions of migration," "fictions of memory," etc. Saying that, there have of course already been individual studies exploring the nexus between sound and the novel (see, for example, Henkel 1996). Emily Petermann (2014) coined the term "musical novel" for novels that not only talk about music on a thematic level but also use musical structures in their very design. A recent article that offers a systematic exploration of the relationship between literature and music is Wolf (2015).

The nexus between narrative and music is also interesting when looked at from an evolutionary perspective. Even though it is difficult to say when or why music developed in human evolution, theorists like Denis Dutton, for example, assume that this development must have been founded on natural, evolved interests. Dutton (2009, 217) argues that:

The aesthetic effects of music universally depend on listeners being able to anticipate climaxes, resolutions, suspensions, or cadences – and then hear the music fulfill or foil those anticipations. Completely unpredictable music [...] can no longer surprise the mind: if just anything can be expected, nothing can enter experience as unexpected. It follows that nothing can surprise, jar, fulfill, shock, or in other ways please the listener.

Dutton describes here what, to his mind, makes people enjoy music and what warrants an evolutionary explanation of the art of music. One can object to the way in which Dutton uses this description to disqualify atonal music, which, in his view, “is unable to draw from the wellsprings of musical pleasure in the mind” (Dutton 2009, 217). After all, music lovers may derive pleasure precisely from the intellectual puzzle or indeterminacy that atonality poses. Leaving this criticism aside, however, Dutton’s description of musical pleasure is worth considering from a narratological angle because it is striking how similar this description sounds to a description of the pleasures of reading or hearing a story. Dutton mentions structural elements such as “climaxes” and “resolutions,” which can be found in most structural models of narrative. He also talks about the surprise element, the “unexpected” twist that evokes an emotional response in listeners. Here, one is uncannily reminded of William Labov’s (1972, 371) notion of the “reportability” of stories, which is the reason for why a story is told in the first place. And finally, Dutton uses the term “experience” to refer to listeners’ reception of musical movements, which, in its more abstracted version as the affordance of “experientiality,” is the key criterion for narrativity in Monika Fludernik’s (1996) theory of ‘natural’ narratology. It seems to us that these parallels are no coincidence and are worth exploring further in audionarratology.

Audionarratology of course cannot recapitulate, let alone offer conclusive answers, to the debates conducted in musicology. Nor can it say anything meaningful concerning human evolution. However, audionarratology can offer detailed analyses of how music is *applied* in various narrative forms and what *effects* it might have on listeners. Dolores Porto Requejo’s contribution, for example, explores multimodal, digital narratives created by lay persons all over the world and demonstrates how music is used strategically to create involvement and emotionality. More importantly, her analyses reveal that music itself assumes narrative functions, such as signalling a resolution or offering an

abstract, an evaluation or a coda to the actual (verbal) story. María Angeles Martínez draws on voice semiotics and on her concept of ‘story possible selves’ (SPSs) (Martínez 2014) to explore how and why listeners to different versions of the same country song may respond to and implicate themselves differently in these songs. Alan Palmer’s contribution applies the concept of ‘fictional minds’ to a country and a blues song and explores questions of narrativity related to the two musical genres. Finally, Markus Wierschem discusses the complex narratives often found in concept albums, a musical genre that has hitherto not received any *literary-critical* attention whatsoever. There is no question that musicological expertise is needed for the analysis of multimodal narratives if they employ music (and many do, as the examples dealt with in the contributions show). In an ideal world, audionarratology can be an umbrella paradigm under which scholars from different disciplines collaborate.

5. Sound Art: Audio Drama, Mobile Phone Theatre, Performance Poetry

Acoustic narrative art often takes the form of radio plays (Hand and Traynor 2011; Verma 2012; Binczek and Epping-Jäger 2012; Binczek and Mütherig 2013), and that is why audio drama as discussed in the contributions by Huwiler, Lutostański and Bernaerts is also central (albeit certainly not exclusive) to audionarratological inquiry. Even though this art form has time and again received the attention of literary scholars particularly in the field of English and American studies as well as in German studies (e.g., Frank 1962 and 1981; Prießnitz 1977 and 1978), there have been only few books which also looked at the audio works (e.g., radio plays) of writers like Ezra Pound (Fischer 2002), Samuel Beckett (Zilliaceus 1976; Guralnick 1996; Brannigan 2008), Louis MacNeice, Dylan Thomas (Cleverdon 1969), Ingeborg Bachmann (Hinterberger 2010), Heiner Müller (Souksengphet-Dachlauer 2010; Maubach 2013) or Fred von Hoerschelmann (Schäfer 2013). Some studies dealing with acoustic narratives do not approach them primarily as works of art but rather as phenomena of cultural and political history, as in the case of American radio drama during the Second World War and the post-war era (Blue 2002, Breitingner 1992). In other words, content is given priority over form.

Another problem in connection with the analysis of radio plays – and this applies to other forms of acoustic art, too – is the significance of the script. Historically speaking, literature has had an understandably strong influence on audio drama as can be seen, for example, in the German radio play especially after the Second World War, which consisted mostly of adaptations from litera-

ture and functioned as a substitute for books, theatre performances and film (Krug 2008, 51). More recently, Harry Heuser (2013, 10–11) has argued that “erroneous notions” about the purely oral essence of radio plays have contributed to the deplorable fact that “radio dramas and narratives have remained a largely uncharted territory.” Drawing on Walter J. Ong’s (1982) concept of the “secondary orality of our electronic age,” he suggests that the scripted nature of radio drama needs to be taken seriously. This means, according to Heuser, that “[r]eturning broadcast plays to the page by means of which they were translated by actors, musicians, and sound effects artists does not constitute the betrayal that some theorists of so-called ‘oral literature’ claim it to be” (Heuser 2013, 10–11). These arguments perhaps point towards a rapprochement of different ways of analysing radio plays: a narratological approach will profit from critical attention to both script (if available) and actual performance(s).

The distinction between aurality/orality and scriptedness in many ways becomes futile in view of the fact that the media through which aural/oral art is transported also contribute towards fixing or ‘congealing’ sound by means of their technological possibilities and make it amenable for editing. Thus, Olsson (2011, 66) discusses how “the tape recorder took part in *shaping* the genre of sound poetry” (emphasis in original) in the late 1960s and undermined the “immersive effects and physiological intrusiveness of sounds” because it

...manifested the voice as a plastic entity submitted to editorial interventions, as a time-based live event hypostasized into an object, which would only later on, in the act of playback, return as the simulation of a living voice present to the body and mind of a listener. (Olsson 2011, 66)

This shows that there is not only tension between sound art’s immediacy and the nature of scripts on the one hand but also between sound art and its technological production on the other. In light of these tensions, the question arises what the narrative in such art forms ultimately consists in if, for example, it emerges spontaneously in performance but is then recorded and manipulated for later reproduction. Elke Huwiler discusses precisely such examples of experimental and interactive audio art forms in her contribution, and Zoë Skoulding’s reflections on her own poetry and sound performances partially go in the same direction. Like Skoulding, Thijs Festjens additionally discusses the interconnectedness of sounds, voices and spaces as well as the intrusiveness of sounds in an innovative theatre project that has participants explore Berlin by means of mobile phone instructions and narratives while employing call centre employees in India as tour guides.

6. Sound, Narrative and Immersion: Aural Ways of World-Making

While the above-mentioned tensions among sounds, scripts and production obviously constitute a key concern, audionarratology also has to pay attention to the *transcriptive* nature of clearly scripted audio art forms such as audiobooks, exploring what reading a book (script or, more generally, text) and listening to it have in common (see also Kuzmičová's contribution in this volume) or, perhaps more crucially, where they differ. Listening to a text is, as Ludwig Jäger (2014, 243) argues, a very different cognitive operation than reading it. This difference is due to the fact that voice does not function as a neutral medium but rather creates a new meaning, which Jäger calls “audioliteral.” Jäger's concept of “audioliterality” implicitly provides support for our project of audionarratology because it also starts out from the premise that sound, voice and music carry (narrative) meaning in their own right.¹³ Audionarratology analyses how sounds and noises contribute to the creation of real and imagined spaces and worlds. Sound thus also operates as a specific medium of “cultural ways of world-making” (Nünning, Nünning and Neumann 2010), a concept which goes back to discussions in philosopher Nelson Goodman's work (on sound and culture, see also section 2 above). How precisely can sounds achieve the creation of storyworlds, which ultimately draw listeners in (see also Knilli 2009)? How is auditory input linked to mental images and to existing frames and scripts?

The specificity of sound-generated narrative world-making initially led radio dramatists to an artistically limiting misunderstanding of their own art (for further discussion, see again Huwiler's contribution in this volume). The absence of visual signs in radio art suggested to them that an appropriate setting would also have to dispense with visual imagery. Hence the emphasis on more or less complete darkness, e.g., in a coal mine (as in Richard Hughes' *A Comedy of Danger*, the first radio play ever broadcast), in the belly of a ship, in a dark railway carriage or in the catacombs of Rome, as can be heard in a number of early radio plays from the 1920s to the 1950s (see Schäfer 2013, 47–48; Heuser 2013, 18–19). Interestingly, one of Sebastian Domsch's video game examples, *Papa Sangre*, follows the same principle by being set in utter darkness. Players can only reach their goal by listening very attentively to the sounds that create their play world surroundings and indicate danger or the enemy's approach. This example

¹³ For further discussions of the concept of “audioliterality,” see the other contributions in Binczek and Epping-Jäger (2014).

supports our claim above that sound potentially has a propensity for being or becoming narrative in itself.

In the context of reading, author John Carey (2014, 112–113) noted, vis-à-vis the “audio effects that made Milton’s verse irresistible,” that poetic language can operate “like a film made out of sounds.” Similarly, John Sutherland (2006, 169) claims: “The acoustics of fiction matter.” An important consequence that follows from this is that audionarratological analysis may also extend to the aural dimensions (including silences) of written texts and their graphic representations on the printed page (see above). In this connection, audionarratology may well contribute to redressing an imbalance that Sutherland (2006, 169) deplors, namely “a disabling hearing problem when it comes to fiction.” Literary critic C. S. Lewis – not unlike the Russian Formalists – also drew attention to the fact that “good reading is always aural as well as visual” (Lewis 1992, 90; see also 102), thereby implying that the aural dimension is often neglected by literary critics. He also pointed out that disregarding the sound of a literary work leads to a failure in understanding it, especially if one considers that “the sound is not merely superadded pleasure, though it may be that too, but part of the compulsion [to “guide us into every cranny of a character’s mind”]; in that sense, part of the meaning” (Lewis 1992, 90).

Lewis’s suggestions do not refer to audionarratives as such but rather indicate that already on the purely textual level sound is inscribed in narratives and needs to be brought to our attention. This point is also elaborated by Ivan Delazari, who reads Toni Morrison’s story *Recitatif* as a text which not only plays with readers’ (mis)attributions of text passages to two indeterminable narrative voices (metaphorically speaking), but which also creates confusion because it forces readers to choose between two rather distinct imagined voice qualities (literally speaking) without offering sufficient clues in this regard. The underlying assumption is that sounds and voices are inscribed in fictional texts and come to life in people’s imaginations. Mikko Keskinen makes a similar point in his *Audio Book* (2008), which studies the representation of sound technologies in contemporary fiction. The book already suggests on its jacket that “literary writing is metaphorically conceivable as a transmitting and storing technology, as an audiobook of sorts, capable of recording (upon writing) and reproducing (upon reading) auditory information.”

These points become more pertinent when written texts are turned into audiobooks, as is explored by Anežka Kuzmičová in this volume. Kuzmičová discusses the audiobook experience from a cognitivist perspective. Instead of focusing on the differences between reading and listening (see above), she aims at dispelling some of the misconceptions about ‘silent reading’ and draws attention to reading and listening’s points of convergence. Finally, Mildorf’s object of

study, storytelling in art gallery audio guides which were turned into audiobook-cum-exhibition catalogue, brings together many of the points discussed across the three sections because these narratives not only combine orality/aurality with scripted text but also a wide range of narrative genres, from pictorial to conversational storytelling, life story and art history, artists' statements and intimate forms such as diary or letter writing. Furthermore, the application of storytelling in the pragmatic museum context and its subsequent reproduction for private use at home raises questions concerning the interplay of bodies, spaces, hearing and the visual.

As the contributions to this volume show, there is considerable overlap in scholarly interest as regards the nexus of sound and narrative even across disciplinary boundaries, and we hope that this book will further stimulate discussions and offer food for thought and future research in what we believe is a promising area of exploration. The strength of audionarratology lies in its thematic focus while still being flexible enough to invite cross-disciplinary dialogue as well as in its dual perspective on both aural/oral narratives and their possible effects on listeners.

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Music and Storytelling

M. Dolores Porto Requejo

Music in Multimodal Narratives: The Role of the Soundtrack in Digital Stories

1. Introduction: Digital Stories

Digital stories are short multimodal narratives created by non-experts in literature and in technologies that constitute a new emergent and rapidly expanding genre on the Internet.¹ In line with the recent democratization of the World Wide Web, the practice of digital storytelling allows ordinary people to narrate their own experiences and share them on the net. First developed by the Center for Digital Storytelling (CDS) in Berkeley in the 1990s, this practice has spread throughout the world, mostly through workshops held by non-profit organizations with educational purposes that intend to reach a widespread audience. However, there are also more limited, local purposes, especially in schools and higher education institutions for the teaching of specific contents, or with the aim of community engagement in residential areas (Lambert 2013). Thus, it is possible to find thousands of digital stories on the net with a great variety of purposes, but typically, digital stories narrate highly emotional, personal experiences of overcoming that are intended to denounce social wrongs or support others who might be suffering situations similar to those featuring in the stories.

Apart from this emotional, personal content, digital stories all share the same format, which consists of a multimodal narrative about 3 or 4 minutes long that matches the recorded voice of the narrator with a set of images – personal photographs, drawings, symbols, short videos or even generic pictures taken from digital repositories – and sometimes also background music or special sound effects. The brevity of the stories combined with the emotional content and advisory purpose of the narratives force the narrator to compress a maximum of information into a very short time span. Therefore, in a digital story there is no superfluous information, there are no side stories or ornamental effects; every aspect of the story – textual, visual or acoustic – must be maximally significant and contribute to the general purpose of the narrative.

¹ This paper forms part of a research project on *Discursive Strategies in English and Spanish. Socio-cognitive and Functional Interactions*, financed by the Spanish Ministry of Science and Innovation (FFI2012 – 30790).

Within the framework of a larger research project on Narrative and Cognition, we have worked on, and analysed in detail, the features of the genre, the structure of the stories, the kind of information provided by each semiotic mode and how the whole meaning is constructed through the integration of all these elements (Alonso Belmonte et al. 2013). In a second stage, we focused on the specific function of images in the construction of the story (Porto and Alonso Belmonte 2014) and concluded that they had an important “glocalising” function, i.e., they provided local stories with a universal meaning. At this point, it seems quite natural that the next stage of the project should address the role of the third component in these multimodal narratives, i.e., the music and sounds that accompany the narration. The main hypothesis in this chapter is that music, as much as text and images, is not merely decorative in digital stories, and that it plays an important role, even if optional, in the construction and interpretation of the story.

2. Sample and Methodology

As pointed out above, this study is part of a larger research project on digital stories. Consequently, the present analysis of the music and sounds has been done on the same sample collected by the team for that previous work.² Rather than a formal corpus, it consists of a sample of thirty stories taken from well-known, recognized nongovernmental organizations devoted to the creation and publication of this kind of narratives to serve their purposes of denouncing wrongs, supporting victims or building a community, such as *BBC Telling lives*, *Creative Narrations*, *Engender Health*, *Silence Speaks*, among others. Even if randomly selected, we deliberately searched for a variety of cultures and continents represented and so we included stories narrated by people from South Africa, Namibia, India, the Philippines, the USA, the United Kingdom, Peru, Mexico, etc. even if all of them are told in English or at least subtitled in English. This apparent contradiction responds to the acknowledged circumstance that English is the language of the Internet and any narrator who intends to reach a wide audience must tell their stories in English. As for the topics represented in the sample, we also tried to achieve a balance and decided to include both big global issues –

² The members of this research group, working as a sub-team in the project coordinated by Manuela Romano, are Isabel Alonso Belmonte, Silvia Molina and myself.

HIV, immigration, sexual discrimination, school bullying, etc. as well as small stories of personal achievements and life experiences.³

The thirty stories were coded by the acronym of the organisation that promoted and published the stories, e.g., Creative Nations CN, Bristol Stories BS and a number (see Appendix for a complete list of the thirty stories). Then they were transcribed in tables that matched every fragment of text with the image simultaneously displayed and a short description of the background music. This painstaking task allowed us to analyse in depth the way in which the meanings conveyed through the three modes were integrated in digital stories.

For obvious reasons, in this paper I will also draw on the analysis of the structure of the thirty stories performed in Porto and Alonso Belmonte (2014), where Labov's schema of oral narratives of personal accounts (Labov 1972; Labov and Waletzky 1997) was applied to the sample in order to identify the different parts of the narratives and the role of images in the different sections. Thus, a comparison will be possible between the role of images and the role of music in the digital stories analysed. Finally, some other theories and insights from fields other than linguistics or narratology, such as psychology and musicology will be taken into account to describe the effects of sound and music in the audience.

3. Sounds and Music in Digital Stories

Not all digital stories include music or sound effects. The essential features of the genre are the recorded voice of the narrator and the images, whereas the musical background is optional. As a matter of fact, manuals and guides for storytellers and workshop facilitators all warn of the “power” and also of the “dangers” of the musical background. According to these recommendations, music can set the tone of a story, enhance emotionality and add depth and complexity to the narrative (Lambert 2013, 64). However, musical soundtracks, especially those with lyrics, can distract the audience and compete with the narrator's voice, or else provide “unintended meanings.” Moreover, in order to avoid conflicts derived from the use of copyrighted material and music, some guides advise storytellers to use their own music, created by themselves or a friend, or just whistling, humming, singing (Simon Turner's guide at BBC Wales).⁴

³ As a matter of fact, we later found out that these “small stories” were also intended to convey a universal meaning for a global audience from faraway countries and cultures. See Porto and Alonso Belmonte (2014).

⁴ <http://www.bbc.co.uk/wales/audiovideo/sites/about/pages/recordingothers.shtml>.

In our sample, there are only five stories without any music. This can be due to technical difficulties or lack of knowledge on the part of the stories' creators, which is a very plausible assumption for those stories without any music that belong to the same website/workshop (DS1 and DS2 from *Diversity Hub* and TL2, TL3 from the *Telling Lives* program). However, the lack of music can also be intentional, so as to place more emphasis on the recorded voice of the narrator, whose tone and rhythm themselves can already convey powerful meanings and emotions (*Distance* SC9). As for the rest of the sample, a great variety of music and combinations can be found: pop, urban rap, gospel, folk, hymns, and many more. Some storytellers use only one song or melody to accompany the story, but many others combine more than one with interesting effects on the narrative structure and on the listener's attention, as we will see.

In the analysis of the role and effects of music and background sounds in digital stories, the following functions have been observed and identified: structural, evaluative, attentional and persuasive. It goes without saying that this classification is merely methodological and that those functions constantly mix and overlap in the narratives. Therefore, attracting the listener's attention to a particular point of the story can be both an evaluative and a persuasive device, just as marking the shifts from a section to the next in the story structure is aimed at guiding and maintaining the listener's attention on the narrative.

4. The Structural Function of Music in Digital Stories

Following the same methodology as in the analysis of the function of images in digital stories (Porto and Alonso Belmonte 2014), we found that music also proves to be a major structuring device, marking the moves from one section to the next. Table 1 summarizes the Labovian schema of narratives of personal accounts (Labov 1972; Labov and Waletzky 1997). According to this schema, this kind of narratives can be divided into three main sections, *orientation*, *complication* and *resolution*, with clearly defined functions, and they are sometimes preceded by a brief *abstract* and completed with a *coda*.

Labov and Waletzky also take into account a sixth element, *evaluation*, that is not confined to a specific part of the story, but can potentially be found everywhere in different elements of the narrative, often overlapping other functions. Since evaluation cannot be regarded a distinct section, I will not consider it at this point of the analysis of the structure. However, evaluation is an essential element in digital stories that reveals the real purpose of telling them to a given

audience and we will see that the soundtrack also contributes to this in a significant way.

NARRATIVE CATEGORY	NARRATIVE QUESTION	NARRATIVE FUNCTION
Abstract (optional)	What was this about?	Signals that the story is about to begin and draws attention from the listener.
Orientation	Who or what is involved in the story and when and where did it take place?	Sets the scene and thus helps the listener to identify the time, place, people, activity and situation of the story.
Complicating action	Then what happened?	Describes the action or events that occurred in the story.
Resolution	What finally happened?	Explains the outcome of the story
Coda (optional)	How does it all end?	Brings the listener to the present time

Now I will provide some examples of how music and sounds contribute to the different parts of the story following this schema.

4.1. Musical Abstract

The abstract is an optional element in narratives of personal experiences. Its function is to signal that the story is about to begin and to draw the audience’s attention to it. In digital stories, when present, abstracts can be textual, visual or musical, or a combination of these. Examples of musical abstracts can be found in the stories in which the music itself sets the tone and sometimes even offers a first clue about the topic of the narrative, even before any image is displayed or the narrator starts speaking. Typically this is the case in digital stories that start with a song that parts of the audience may already know and that thus activates certain associations, images and feelings that will play a role in the understanding of the story.

Thus, for instance in *Despite My Fears* (BS2), the first chords of a famous song by ABBA, *Dancing Queen*, can be heard before the narrator starts her story. She tells about her experience in an amateur theatre company, so the song introduces the topic of acting, being part of a show, etc. Also, *To Every Child* (CN3) starts with the instrumental beginning of a well-known gospel song while a Bible quotation is displayed. This music sets the tone of the story, which deals with inequality in education for black children in Boston

and the narrator's determination to fight against it by becoming an educator herself.

There are also musical abstracts where it is the lyrics of the song that constitute a message to the audience. This is the case of *The Day I Made Him Stop* (UM1), a story about a school girl who used to be beaten by her teacher, which starts with the music of a Christian hymn that the narrator sings herself:

Jesus loves me, this I know,
for the Bible tells me so.
Little ones to Him belong;
they are weak but He is strong

After that, the narrator starts her story without any additional soundtrack. It can be considered a musical abstract, even if it is combined with text, because the lyrics do not have a direct relation to the story itself. It is only the fact that it is a religious hymn that makes it an abstract. Moreover, the feeling of closeness is strongly supported by the fact that it is the voice of the narrator, that we can hear, without any instruments, instead of a commercial recording.

4.2. Musical Orientation

Orientation is the section of the story that sets the scene in a specific time or place or introduces the people involved in it. Music is a very basic device to convey this meaning, as it is so culturally embedded. In stories like *Sacrificios* (SC2) or *The Home Land* (BS1), music instantly contextualizes the narrative. In *Sacrificios*, a Spanish guitar serves as a musical abstract first, and then as an orientation as it plays in the background while the narrator introduces his grandparents both textually ("This is the story of my grandparents, Fernando and Emilia Sánchez") and visually by showing an old photograph. In *The Home Land* it is the sound of African drums that accompanies the beginning of the narrative about the African origin of the narrator who lives in England: "There was no particular time in my life when I thought to myself "I want to learn about my African heritage." Folk music is a recurrent tool for the orientation section in the digital stories analysed, as it is a straightforward way of setting the scene in a specific time and place. It can be found in many of them (Mexican music in CN1, Chinese in IL1, African in SC5, etc.). It has a localising function, comparable to that of images showing costumes, landscapes and people's racial features.

It is also interesting to note that not only the music, but also the sound of the narrator's voice has an orientation function. Because all stories are told in the

first person, the voice introduces the main character in them: gender, age, accent, mood or disposition.

4.3. Music and Sounds in the Complication

After the abstract and the orientation, the music is usually turned down or even stops, so that the voice of the storyteller can be clearly heard. However, as the story evolves, different musical and sound effects are used by storytellers for various purposes, one of them being to signal a change in the action. Thus, in some stories, a change in the background music marks a shift in the action. For example, in *Privilege* (SC3) soft music matches the account of the narrator's happy childhood on a big farm where her parents worked until the moment when the field workers went on strike and were fired. At that point the music turns up and becomes a protest song. In *Rock Bottom* (EH3), the narrator first introduces the story with an abstract without any music, then he starts telling the audience about his childhood, with a tinkling happy musical background. The music changes when he moves towards his days at university with an active social life, rife with parties and women. After that, the strings of a contrabass signal the change in his life when he meets his girlfriend. An electric guitar can be heard when he explains he decided to change his life, and at the end, a complete melody is used as the background to the resolution. Interestingly, in *International Living-Southern China* (IL1), several pieces of Chinese bamboo flute music are used to accompany parts of the story, whereas in others it is silenced so that the original sounds of the videos displayed can be heard – the sounds of traffic noises, street music, birds singing at an open market, children playing. This is a remarkable strategy that transports the audience to those places and provides a more vivid account of the experience narrated.

4.4. Music in the Resolution

Typically, the music turns up towards the end of the story, which serves to warn the audience that we are reaching the final part of the story and also connects this ending with the beginning, when the same music was heard (BS2, CN2, SC8, IL1...). It must be noted, though, that in almost half of the stories in the sample, we can talk of a “non-resolution component” (Porto and Alonso Belmonte 2014, 6), as the experiences narrated often refer to a global issue (environmental justice, school bullying, sexual discrimination) that they are denouncing and that cannot be solved by the individual. Even so, since the purpose of digital sto-

ries is that of advising and supporting, resolutions or endings are always positive and encouraging. Consequently, the music that goes with the resolution tends to be joyful and lively and the rising volume contributes to this effect.

In *Nelao's story* (EH1), the narrator tells about her difficulties to find a partner because she is HIV positive. However, at the end of her story she values other aspects in her life that make her happy and is optimistic about the future. While most of her story, except for the orientation, goes without music, thus increasing the strength and drama of her narration, in the final part some soft background music is heard accompanying the “non-resolution” of her narrative: “It’s the beginning of a new life. I’m young, beautiful and intelligent and I have a bright future ahead of me...” In *Privilege* (SC3), the positive feeling at the end of the story provided by the music is reinforced by an upwards movement of the camera to focus on the sky as the music’s volume also rises so that we can hear the lyrics of the song.

4.5. Musical Coda

Those narrators who use a song as the background tend to take advantage of its message and use it as a musical coda. In these cases, after the narrator’s voice stops, the music becomes louder so that we can hear the lyrics of the song. Thus, for example, in *To Every Child* (CN3), the chorus of the gospel song that served as the background to the whole story constitutes the coda, where the narrator reveals that she wants to change the future of black children by becoming a teacher: “Imagine me, being free, trusting you totally, finally I can imagine me, I admit it was hard to see you being in love with someone like me, finally I can imagine me, imagine me.” A message of hope can also be found in the musical coda of *The Balcony* (SC6), which goes without any soundtrack at all until the story is completely finished and the following can be heard while the slides of credits are shown⁵: “Someday, when we are wiser, when the world’s older, when we have learned [...]. I pray someday we may yet, live to live and let live.” Particularly effective in this sense is the case of *Memories of a Political Prisoner from Worcester* (SC5), where the background music is merely a humming during the narration, but that is finally sung by the narrator at the end as a hymn for South Africa.

The association of the background music with Labovian structural categories as presented above may on the surface seem to rely more on temporal place-

5 From the song *Someday*, in the film *The Hunchback of Notre Dame* (Disney 1996).

ment than on their actual relation to the text. This is partly due to the canonical, linear structure of these stories, which tend to strictly follow the schema where the complication follows the orientation and the resolution is always placed at the end. However, the fact that the music's volume is turned up or down at specific points of the story, or that the lyrics are highlighted for the abstract or the coda counteracts that first impression.

5. The Soundtrack as an Attentional Marker to Guide the Listener

Attention is one of our main cognitive abilities: It plays a leading role in the way in which we perceive and interpret the world around us by enabling us to focus on small parts of our environment before we organize our knowledge and understand the whole. Accordingly, attention is also reflected in language, in the way we speak about the world. Linguistic forms can direct our attention in discourse at different levels – phonological, lexical, syntactical, semantic, pragmatic, and so on – through various devices, all of which constitute what Talmy calls the “Attentional System of Language” (Talmy 2007, 2008). In narratives, attention also plays a leading part in their organization and interpretation (Romano and Porto 2013), since a narrative rarely has the linear, well-organized structure that we often assume.

In purely textual narratives, discourse markers work as attention guiding mechanisms in this sense, but in multimodal narratives, as it is the case with digital stories, various factors regularly interact to produce attentional effects. Thus, textual strategies, i.e., linguistic and pragmatic markers, are combined in several ways with visual and acoustic devices in order to catch the audience's attention and guide it to the most relevant parts of the narrative. Such visual and acoustic strategies have much to do with perceptual salience, e.g., colour and salience in images and volume or pitch in sounds, but also with the way in which these interact with structural, emotional and cultural factors, as we will see.

So for instance, the musical abstracts described in the previous section have an obvious attentional function overlapping the structural one, since catching the audience's attention is partly the aim of an abstract. When the ABBA song starts to play in *Despite My Fears* (BS2), or the rhythmic beginning of an urban rock piece precedes the narrator's account in *Bad Choices* (CN2), listeners get ready to listen and watch and take note of what is coming next. Similarly, the changes in the music that signal transitions between different parts of the story

also perform both a structuring and an attentional function (SC1, SC3, EH3, EH8, IL1...). As a consequence, every time the audience perceives a change in the music, they open their ears to a possible change in the story.

In addition, cultural identification overlaps with these functions and also works as an attentional marker. When storytellers use songs that can be easily identified by their potential audience, listeners are more readily attentive as they are caught by a familiar, well-known melody. This is the case with *Despite My Fears* (BS2), *To Every Child* (CN3) or *Memories of a Political Prisoner* (SC5).

Perceptual factors in music are the most obvious devices for catching attention: if the volume turns up or if, on the contrary, there is a sudden silence in the soundtrack, the listener will direct his/her attention to that point of the narrative. The effect of changes in the volume can be observed in most stories both in the abstract and the resolution. As already pointed out, music is turned down when the narrator starts speaking after the abstract and it goes up again in the resolution as if signalling that the end is getting closer. Even more interesting is the use of silence as an attentional marker in digital stories. In *Everyone Knows: Manoj's Story* (EH6), the narrator starts telling his story with some soft instrumental music in the background. He introduces himself, his age, his city until he says that he is HIV positive: "When I was 22, I donated blood for an operation. It was then that I found out that I had HIV." At that point, the music stops and the next words gain strength because of that sudden silence: "I felt isolated, scared, and so sad." Then, the music is resumed and the story goes on. A similar strategy can be found in other stories: *Bad Choices* (CN2), *Lillo's Story* (EH8), *Nelao's Story* (EH1), *Untitled* (SC1).

Perception is also the key to catch the listener's attention when specific points of the story are highlighted with particular sound effects. In *Nelao's Story* (EH1), the sound of footsteps running away accompanies the following text: "I have always had bad experiences with men who ran away when I disclosed my HIV status to them." And the sound of breaking glass matches the image of a broken heart, as the narrator explains her feelings: "I'm torn apart. I want to love and be loved as well." Such effects force the audience to have not only linguistic understanding, but also sight and hearing focused on the same idea: men running away or a broken heart, which provides great strength to the intended meanings and constitutes a persuasive element in the narration.

6. Music and Emotions: Evaluative Function of the Soundtrack in Digital Stories

It is a well-known fact that music influences emotion and behaviour. Major keys when combined with rapid tempos evoke feelings of joy and happiness in the listener, whereas minor keys and slow tempos may arouse sadness and melancholy to a certain degree. Moreover, dissonance consistently provokes negative reactions and when combined with rapid tempos it may cause emotions like distress or fear (Krumhansl 1997). Empirical experiments have been carried out (Sloboda 1992; Krumhansl 1997, 2000; Justin and Sloboda 2001; Zentner et al. 2008) in order to confirm these intuitions. These experiments have measured the emotional response to music in terms of physiological responses, such as heart rate, skin response, breathing or hormone secretion, as well as degrees of brain activation in those areas mostly involved in emotional responses, i.e., hippocampus and amygdala, and expressive behaviour of facial muscles. Presumably everybody has at some point experienced how music arouses different emotions and, as a matter of fact, music is widely used for this purpose in films and advertising.⁶

The point is that the background music used in digital stories arouses different kinds of emotions in their audience and that this emotional response is usually unconscious. After all, the music is not the main focus of the listeners' attention, so while the cortical areas of their brain are busy interpreting the textual part and relating this with the images displayed, music is working at sub-cortical levels, those in charge of emotions (Blood and Zatorre 2001). It is in this sense that background music and sounds can be said to have an evaluative function, since they can elicit positive or negative feelings in the audience about the events narrated.

In *My Iligan* (MS1), the musical abstract is a piece of orchestral music *in crescendo* that anticipates the intensity of the positive feelings of the narrator towards the city where he lives. Similarly, in *International Living-Southern China* (IL1), the narrator tells his experience as a leader of a group of students who went to China for the summer as part of the program *World Learning*, which promotes knowledge of other countries in high school students. It is presented as a highly positive experience and this evaluation is provided not only by textual and visual devices, but also, and probably at a less conscious level, by the

⁶ Not so well known is the application of this knowledge about the effects of music on emotions in different kinds of therapies for the treatment of emotional disorders or even to increase pain tolerance (see Zentner et al. (2008) for a list of references on empirical research on these matters).

music and sounds that can be heard all through the narration. Lively, joyful music is in the background of the story and, from time to time, one can hear different original sounds which evoke positive feelings: people laughing, children playing, dancing in the street, an open market, and so on.

In *Rock Bottom: James's Story* (EH3), the changes in music at different sections match the narrator's evaluation of what he tells at that moment. For instance, the strings of a contrabass go with the section where the narrator tells about his girlfriend for the first time, evoking a sense of sensuality that matches his words: "In 2004 I met my girlfriend [...] she was really beautiful, she always looked sexy." This sensuality is mixed with a negative evaluation as the low pitch provides a cue that something in that relationship is obscure and can go wrong. Also in this story, a negative feeling is prompted when a strongly dissonant chord is heard at the moment when the narrator explains that he had decided to change his life but his friends did not support this decision: "My friends thought I was becoming a wimp."

In *The Balcony* (SC6), the song that serves as a coda (see above) comes from a Disney film and is interpreted by a female singer. Therefore, apart from the message of hope conveyed by the lyrics, the soft music and the singer's voice also contribute to the positive evaluation of the whole account of events narrated. Moreover, for a part of the audience who may know about the source film of that music, a feeling of tenderness associated with childhood and innocence can be prompted. In this sense, positive evaluation can also be activated by the cultural conditioning associated with specific songs or certain kinds of music such as religious hymns (WL1) or political songs (SC2, SC5).

It is particularly interesting to observe that negative evaluation is usually associated with silence. It is at those points in the story when something goes wrong that music generally stops: in *Manoj's Story* (EH6) when he finds out he is HIV positive (see above), in *Bad Choices* (CN2), when the narrator and his brother are taken to Social Services: "Next thing I know, we were sent to an apartment within the Social Service. We spent two years in the System," or in *Rock Bottom* (EH3), when the narrator breaks up with his girlfriend: "But it was too late [...] it was the beginning of the end and we broke up." In short, music and sound effects, as well as the lack of those, may have an evaluative function in digital stories by arousing emotions and evoking positive or negative feelings associated with the meanings that are conveyed through simultaneous texts and images.

7. Music and Persuasion in Digital Stories

Digital stories also have a persuasive aim and music contributes to it. As a matter of fact, all kinds of narrative, even fictional ones, have an element of persuasion: the idea, inherent to any narrative, that the story is worth listening to and remembering. Besides, all narratives are told with a purpose, that of making the audience perceive the world differently. In the case of the digital stories analysed in this work, which are fostered and published by non-profit organizations, this persuasive function is quite straightforward as they are created with the explicit intention of changing attitudes and beliefs, for example about sexual discrimination, HIV, environmental issues, etc.

Among the persuasive strategies that can be found in narratives, emotional involvement is one of the most effective ones. *Pathos*, i.e., the appeal to the audience's emotions, was already considered by Aristotle one of the three main modes of persuasion and it is present in all kinds of narratives, from "small stories" in our everyday life to films or literature. There is extensive research on how this aim is achieved in narratives and the notions of *identification* (Cohen 2001), *transportation* (Gerrig 1993; Green and Brock 2000), *absorption* (Slater et al. 2002) and *narrative engagement* (Busselle and Bilandzic 2008; de Graaf et al. 2009) all converge in the idea that readers/listeners feel "transported" into the narrative, identify with the characters, adopt their personality and experience the same emotions as them. This emotional involvement has been tested empirically in some experiments (Green and Brock 2000; Slater et al. 2002; Busselle and Bilandzic 2009; de Graaf et al. 2009) that provide evidence for how readers are engaged in narratives.

As for multimodal narratives, it is quite obvious that the combination of images and sounds with the text strengthens the audience's involvement in the story. Music in particular proves to be a powerful tool to achieve this narrative engagement that leads to persuasion through several dimensions. One of them, emotional involvement, is easily inferred from the potential of music to arouse emotions discussed in previous sections. Several examples have been provided of the way in which the music that accompanies text and images induces positive or negative feelings and emotions of happiness or melancholy (IL1, SC6, MS1, SS1, etc.) with a combination of different rhythms, pitch, tempos.

Another significant dimension of narrative engagement is attention. According to Green (2006), when all mental resources are occupied with a narrative, there is no capacity left for a critical analysis of the story content. This means that the attentional focus of the audience on the story leads to a reduction of

negative cognitive responses, increasing acceptance of beliefs implied by the story (Green and Brock 2000). Therefore, music is not only an effective way of catching and maintaining the audience's attention, as shown in section 5, but the fact that it is combined with text and images also turns it into an outstanding persuasive device. In digital stories, listeners strive to integrate the meanings provided by three different modes, that is, they have to keep track of the narrator's textual account, the series of images displayed simultaneously and at the same time of the background sounds and music that go with them. Consequently, all their senses are focused on the story, which necessarily reduces their critical judgment of what is told.

Finally, the identification of the audience with the narrator is another dimension of digital stories to which music contributes and which leads to narrative engagement. Digital stories in the sample are always narrated in the first person and it is allegedly the narrator's own voice that listeners can hear in them. This creates a feeling of closeness that makes the whole story more credible and promotes a certain degree of personal identification with the narrator, no matter whether male or female. This feeling is reinforced when, instead of using commercial music or pre-recorded music, storytellers make their own musical soundtrack, especially when the narrators themselves sing the songs. This is the case with the Christian hymn in the abstract of *The Day I Made him Stop* (WL1), or the humming of a political song in the background of *Memories of a Political Prisoner from Worcester* (SC5), where the narrator finally sings the song at the end of his narration. The narrator's voice has a strong persuasive force both because of the intimacy it creates with the audience and because of the emotions that it can convey.

Apart from this personal identification, it is also possible to speak of cultural identification when the music chosen as a background has a strong cultural component. A Chinese bamboo flute in IL1, African drums in BS1, a Spanish guitar in SC2, a Mexican trumpet in CN1, as well as urban rock in CN2 or American gospel in CN3, they all situate the story from the very beginning and the audience, even if from a different country, feels involved, as if transported into that culture, and becomes ready to experience the narrator's emotions and thoughts in that context.

8. Conclusions

It must be noted that the analysis of the sample presented in this chapter is merely a first approach to the issue, as the number of stories collected and analysed is relatively small and not representative enough. Besides, the qualitative

analysis requires confirmation through a quantitative study on a bigger corpus of narratives. Another important caveat must be noted as for the results provided. As already stated, the creators of the digital stories in this sample are not experts, but ordinary people who attended a workshop to learn how to tell a story and how to use the right software to record their voices, edit images and sounds and put them all together. Therefore, some of the effects pointed out in the previous sections, such as the persuasive effect of the background humming of a melody instead of using commercial music, may be the consequence of the lack of expertise of storytellers, or of copyright issues, as observed. Even so, the effects on the audience are the same, independently of the real intentions and reasons of the narrator for making it that way. Similarly, the creators of these digital stories are not likely to be knowledgeable about the results of empirical tests on the effects of music on emotions that have been shown, but still they can intuitively choose the right music for the meanings they intend. Much of this intuition derives from cultural contexts and from their experience with films, TV commercials and the personal feelings and emotions evoked in them by different kinds of music.

Nevertheless, and taking into account these limitations, the results of this first approach reveal that background music and sounds in digital stories are an essential part of the meaning construction in these narratives. Several functions have been identified – structural, attentional, evaluative and persuasive – that belie the idea that it is merely an ornamental effect in multimodal narratives. An integrative part of their whole meaning, music i) signals transitions between the different segments that constitute the story, ii) directs the audience's attention to the most relevant parts or events, iii) provides an evaluative meaning that reveals the narrator's stance and guides the listener's attitude towards the events narrated, and iv) provides the mechanisms that can persuade the audience and produce a change in their attitudes and beliefs.

Music has proved particularly effective for these purposes for several reasons. Firstly, it tends to elicit an unconscious, emotional response because it is out of the focus of attention, as the listener's cortical areas seem to concentrate on the textual and visual elements of the story. Secondly, it provides evaluative conditioning regarding what is narrated because it is culturally charged with positive and negative associations. Thirdly, it contributes to suppressing possible criticism as both hemispheres are busy constructing the meaning provided by text, images and sounds.

It goes without saying that most of these results could be extended to other kinds of multimodal narratives, such as films. However, the digital stories selected for this paper constitute an excellent object of analysis because of their formal features. On the one hand, the aim of these narratives is quite straightforward

and their persuasive intention is unmistakable. On the other hand, because of their brevity, the narrators are forced to compress the maximum amount of information into a very short time span and for this reason they have to make the most of images and sounds. In more extensive multimodal narratives, the role of images and sounds are allegedly the same but they may be less obvious. This could be an object for further research.

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Appendix

(Last accessed 15 July 2014)

BS1	<i>The Home Land</i>	http://www.bristolstories.org/story/111
BS2	<i>Despite My Fears</i>	http://www.bristolstories.org/story/73
BW1	<i>Never Too Old to Learn</i>	http://www.bbc.co.uk/wales/audiovideo/sites/yourvideo/pages/catherine_collins_01.shtml
CN1	<i>What the Water Gave Me</i>	http://www.creativenarrations.net/node/16
CN2	<i>Bad Choices</i>	http://www.creativenarrations.net/node/76
CN3	<i>To Every Child</i>	http://www.creativenarrations.net/node/78
DS1	<i>Stop Bullying</i>	http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6YsFZjbH6_Y
DS2	<i>Culture Clash</i>	http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2wv37Co_aRU&list=PLE2571E3579DEA1CF&feature=plcp
EH1	<i>Nelao's Story (Stories from Namibia)</i>	http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ryAZINjGot8
EH2	<i>Ngamane's Story (Stories from Namibia)</i>	http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=30UuSNy4-pY
EH3	<i>James's Story Rock Bottom. (Stories from Namibia)</i>	http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=15Tb3vYgQ1U

- EH4 *The Positive Way: Naresh's story. I'm Not Alone (Stories from India)* http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rW4_m8K-WS4
- EH5 *Men As Partners: Sibongi-seni's Story* <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BI7DOgX6sAY>
- EH6 *The Positive Way:Manoj's Story.(Stories from India)* <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rRpxVwNHSp0>
- EH7 *Men As Partners: Gary's Story. Mission* <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mKHzMfhnpSw>
- EH8 *Men As Partners: Lillo's Story* <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Vs4PHB62TPs>
- IL1 *International Living in Southern China* https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pBR_gN87Wnc
- MS1 *My Iligan* https://www.youtube.com/watch?feature=player_detailpage&v=_aycmvgXp-0
- SC1 *Untitled- a Transgender Boy* <http://64.13.206.59/stories/index.php?cat=7>
- SC2 *Sacrificios* <http://64.13.206.59/stories/index.php?cat=4>
- SC3 *Privilege* <http://64.13.206.59/stories/index.php?cat=3>
- SC5 *Memories of a Political Prisoner from Worcester* <http://64.13.206.59/stories/index.php?cat=2>
- SC6 *The Balcony* <http://64.13.206.59/stories/index.php?cat=2>
- SC7 *Mixed Race Me* <http://64.13.206.59/stories/index.php?cat=7>
- SC8 *My Shoes* <http://64.13.206.59/stories/index.php?cat=2>
- SC9 *Distance* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qhd9SDFjopU>
- SS1 *A Struggle Within Reach* http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Z_D9arQ-4WU
- TL2 *Whatever Happened to Miss Pears?* http://www.bbc.co.uk/humber/telling_lives/humber_intermediary4.shtml
- UM1 *Real Men Do Housework* http://stories.umbc.edu/projects.php?movie=ELC054_S09ByungchangKim.flv
- WL1 *The Day I Made Him Stop* <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hneAZCEl5v4>

M. Ángeles Martínez

Staging the Ghost Blend in Two Versions of the Ballad “Big Joe and Phantom 309”

1. Introduction

In this study I am going to focus on two versions of the country ballad “Big Joe and Phantom 309,” one of them Tom Waits’ well-known 1975 version, and the other a later adaptation by the indie band Archers of Loaf. Using a cognitive-functional approach to multimodal discourse, my analysis will explore the ways in which acoustic semiotics, in combination with linguistic organization, may intervene both in the projection of a narrative storyworld in listeners’ minds (Herman 2002, 2008 [2005]), and in the projection of listeners’ different storyworld possible selves (SPSs), or imagings of themselves inside the fictional world (Martínez 2014).

Songs have been described as blends of words and music (Zbikowski 2002). The present study, however, has focused on the communicative power of language in combination with acoustic semiotics, rather than with musical organization, since a detailed musical analysis would have required the expertise of a musician. Acoustic semiotics, on the other hand, is integral to research in multimodal discourse (Jewitt 2009). Van Leeuwen (2009), for instance, analyses the semiotic potential of dimensions such as pitch and loudness in actors’ voice quality, as intervening in character construction in films. Similarly, Zbikowski (2002) emphasizes the semiotic weight of acoustic pitch and tempo in musical organization.

In line with these approaches, I will first focus on some of the semiotic resources involved in storyworld projection in songs, drawing on a) image-schemas for pitch and tempo (Saslaw 1996; Zbikowski 2002; Antovic 2009; Patel 2010), b) van Leeuwen’s (2009) study of voice semiotics, and c) Martínez et al.’s (2013) analysis of acoustic semiotics in multimodal storyworld projection in television commercials. Then I will consider these acoustic features together with linguistic organization across the two versions of “Big Joe and Phantom 309,” with a focus on the ways in which multimodality may affect the meaning construction processes at work in listeners’ minds. The research suggests that the different combinations of sound and language may invite the projection not only

of different storyworlds, but also of different types of storyworld possible selves. Furthermore, the effects of these different multimodal configurations on narrative processing seem to be intimately connected to narrative progression (Phelan 2007), which, in the case of this ghost narrative, involves delaying the presentation of the ghost until the narration is reaching its end-point (Martínez 2010). This will inevitably affect listeners' suspense, curiosity, and surprise, which are some of the components that Sternberg (1978, 2001) suggests characterize a narrative as opposed to a non-narrative.

2. Ballads as Narratives: Storyworld and SPS Projection

Ballads are inextricably linked to oral storytelling, as shown in this quote from *The Cambridge Guide to Literature in English*:

All ballads, of whatever type, must not only tell a story in verse, but also lend themselves to being sung [...]. These two defining conditions imply a third: the narrative and style must be simple enough to be followed at a hearing. So most ballads – but by no means all – are written in simple ballad metre: that is to say, in QUATRAINS of alternating lines of iambic tetrameter and iambic trimeter [...]. Though ballad metre is basically iambic, much syllabic irregularity is common – presumably owing to the demands of music, the early origins of the ballad, and the popular audience it mainly catered for. (Head 2006 [1988], 66)

The narrative nature of ballads makes them highly amenable to be studied in terms of narrative immersion and storyworld projection. *Storyworlds* (Herman, 2002, 2008 [2005]) are mental models for understanding narrative discourse, and, as such, “function in a top-down and bottom-up way during narrative comprehension. [...] Fundamentally, then, narrative comprehension is a process of (re)constructing storyworlds on the basis of textual clues and the inferences that they make possible” (Herman 2002, 6). But the projection of a storyworld in narrative experiencers' minds, be they readers, listeners, or viewers, is not the only prerequisite for immersion to occur, as these experiencers must also undergo a deictic centre shift (Duchan et al. 1995) in order to occupy the deictic parameters of the focalizing consciousness inside the storyworld, and thus partake of its perspectival vantage point.

The notion of *storyworld possible selves*, or *SPSs*, on the other hand, is introduced by Martínez (2014) to explain the metonymic nature of narrative immersion, as it is not the whole of experiencers' selves that is transported, but just a relevant part of their mental representation of themselves. Martínez defines

SPSs as blends resulting from the conceptual integration (Fauconnier and Turner, 2002) of two mental spaces. One of them is the mental representation that the experiencer is building for the focalizing character inside the storyworld, in the form of a *character construct* (Emmott 1992, 1997; Palmer 2010). The other is the real-world individuals’ *self-concept*, or mental representation of themselves, which in social psychology is conceived as a network of *self-schemas* and *possible selves* (Markus 1977; Markus and Nurius 1986; Dunkel and Kerpelman 2006). According to the theory of storyworld possible selves, during narrative immersion matching features across these two input spaces are selectively projected into an emergent blend, or SPS, which may be of five types (Martínez 2014):

- a) *desired possible self SPSs*, or blends containing those parts of the self-concept which involve a self that the individual would like to approach, like the ‘loved’ self in romantic stories or the ‘smart’ self in thrillers;
- b) *feared possible self SPSs*, or blends containing features of a self that experiencers would dread to become, such as the ‘abandoned’ self or the ‘unemployed’ self, and that match similar features in the mental construct for the focalizing character;
- c) *past possible self SPSs*, containing features of an individual’s past self that match similar features in the focalizer’s construct, such as the ‘self as a child’;
- d) *self-schema SPSs*, containing features of an individual’s mental image of him/herself as a social being at present time, such as the ‘sportive’ self or the ‘parent’ self;
- e) *past SPS possible selves*, containing previous narrative experiences which have been incorporated in the self-concept.

The most noticeable effects of SPS projection into the storyworld have to do with emotion and empathy, as deictic shifts involving a desired possible self are accompanied by feelings of happiness, while approaching a feared possible self usually brings about feelings of sadness and anxiety (Markus and Nurius 1986). Emotion, a side-effect of narrative immersion, thus emerges as a result of empathic attachment not only to a character or characters, but also to one’s mental image of oneself in the simulation environment of the storyworld. Another important effect of SPS projection is experiential training, as immersed readers, listeners or viewers may try out useful behaviours and attitudes within safely distant, fictional, situational models.

In view of these arguments, the initial research question is whether the multimodal resources used in Tom Waits’ and Archers of Loaf’s covers of the ballad “Big Joe and Phantom 309” could not only prompt differences in the projected storyworld, but also, and most importantly, trigger the projection of either a de-

sired or a feared listeners' storyworld possible self. The main concern will be the analysis of voice semiotics together with the acoustic properties of pitch and tempo, and their interaction with patterns of linguistic organization.

3. Artistic Adaptation and the Ghost Blend in “Big Joe and Phantom 309”

“Big Joe and Phantom 309” is a country ballad composed by Tommy Faile (North Carolina, 1928–1998), and made famous by country singer Red Sovine in the late 1960s (Sovine 1967). The lyrics, in aabb quatrains, contain the narration of a ghost story that has captured the imagination of audiences for decades, as the song has been repeatedly adapted to shifting socio-cultural contexts. As Hutcheon (2006, xiv) notes, the term *adaptation* is used “to refer to both a product and a process of creation and reception,” and adaptations can be defined as “deliberate, announced, and extended revisitations of prior works” (Hutcheon 2006, xiv). One of the best-known adaptations of “Big Joe and Phantom 309” is probably Tom Waits', included in the album *Nighthawks at the Diner* (Waits 1975). Within a blues/jazz tradition of live performances in late-hour clubs, the live recording of this version has a genuine ballad format, with the bard's idiosyncratic linguistic and acoustic contributions in real time, in front of a real audience. It was probably the success of Tom Waits' version which prompted a revisiting of the ballad in a 2007 homage album to the singer by the indie band Archers of Loaf (2007). This later version is not live, but studio-recorded. The two adaptations are deeply embedded in their respective socio-cultural contexts, as Waits abandons Red Sovine's 1960s country style to heavily draw on the on-the-road, Beat Generation tradition of the 1970s (Wills 2009), while Archers of Loaf's version reflects the artistic culture of a budding twenty-first-century audience. As Potter (2006, xiii) points out, “[...] however singing develops, [...] stylistic renewal is driven by the need to find more appropriate ways to deliver the text. Exactly what these ways are will depend on the sociological context in which the music is sung.”

In the song, the first-person narrator tells the story of the night when he met a ghost. It was during a hitch-hiking trip across the US that he found himself stuck in the middle of nowhere and was picked up by a truck driver who duly drove him to a nearby diner. There he learnt that the jolly fellow with whom he had shared cigars and small talk was actually the ghost of Big Joe, a truck driver killed in a road accident years before when swerving to avoid crashing his Phantom 309 truck into a school bus full of kids. The underlying assumption

of the study is that these two versions, even though retaining tune and lyrics, seem to highlight different aspects of the projected storyworld: the easy-going warmth of the on-the-road brotherhood impregnates Tom Waits’ (Wills 2009), while the shock of the grim meeting stands out in Archers of Loaf’s. As a result, different SPSs might be projected in listeners’ minds, with the consequent effects on narrative processing.

In a previous study, Martínez (2010) analyses the lyrics of Tom Waits’ version from the point of view of the blending operations likely to be linguistically triggered. Focusing exclusively on the language of this single version, the author makes the point that the revelation that Big Joe is a ghost is made linguistically explicit only near the end of the narration, which means that the ghostly entity is not projected until the very end. Martínez suggests a conceptualization of this ghostly entity as a ghost blend in terms of Fauconnier and Turner’s Blending Theory (2002), whereby mental spaces blend in listeners’/readers’ minds when certain linguistic triggers favour the onset of metaphorical links across matching features in two or more mental representations. In this case, it is listeners’ mental representation of Big Joe seen alive at the time of the narrated events which blends with the mental representation of Big Joe dead before those events. The research hypothesis derived from the comparative multimodal analysis of Tom Waits’ and Archers of Loaf’s versions in the present study is that the different acoustic and linguistic resources involved in storyworld and SPS projection in these two adaptations of the ballad may prompt different cognitive processes in listeners’ minds, to the effect that these will be differently prepared when eventually confronted with the ghost blend triggered in the final stanzas.

4. Methods

4.1 Acoustic Storyworld Projection

In verbal narratives, storyworlds and SPSs are linguistically triggered. However, in multimodal narratives such as songs, this triggering must necessarily involve a variety of modes. The analysis will first focus on the semiotic potential of the acoustic features which seem to have a bearing on storyworld projection in the two versions considered, and will then look into differences in linguistic organization. In their research on multimodal narrativity in television commercials, which comprised two hundred television commercials from British ITV, Martínez et al. (2013, 102–103) observe that noise frequently accompanies the projection in viewers’ minds of negatively evaluated storyworlds, usually featuring the protagonist in a troublesome situation prior to product use at the begin-

ning of the ad. Conversely, lively and strongly rhythmic music tends to be associated with the initial projection of storyworlds intended to be evaluated in a positive way, usually featuring happiness caused by product use.

Also relevant to the analysis seem to be the acoustic properties of pitch and tempo, whose role in storyworld projection can be comprehended in terms of image schemas. One of the most productive image-schemas intervening in cross-domain mappings in the Western conceptualization of *pitch* is the verticality schema (Saslaw 1996; Zbikowski 2002; Antovic 2009; Patel 2010, 12–14). This schema involves a high/low relation, and the related conceptual metaphors found in the literature are:

- PITCH RELATIONSHIPS ARE RELATIONSHIPS OF VERTICALITY
- SPATIAL MEASUREMENT SCALES ARE PATHS
- MORE IS UP
- HIGH IS GOOD/LOW IS BAD
- HAPPINESS IS HIGH/SADNESS IS LOW
- HIGH PITCH IS HAPPY/LOW PITCH IS SAD

Another productive image-schema intervening in cross-domain mappings in musical perception is the fast/slow schema, derived from the conceptualization of music as motion (Holst 2002; Zbikowski 2002, 63–95), whose connected conceptual metaphors are FAST IS HIGH/SLOW IS LOW, and HIGH IS HAPPY/LOW IS SAD, reflected in acoustic *tempo*.

4.2 Voice Semiotics

Pitch and tempo variations occur not only in the musical component of a song, but also in the singer's voice. On the assumption that voice is the embodiment of language, van Leeuwen (2009) explores the semiotic potential of vocal apparatus materiality, as vocal quality experientially communicates a wide variety of states of mind like anger, nervousness, fear, intimacy, or delight. Van Leeuwen mentions four main features of voice acoustics with strong semiotic underpinnings, namely *pitch*, *loudness*, *smoothness*, and *breath*. According to the author, male voices tend to be low in pitch, in the same way as high pitch is, by default, associated with female voices, so that a marked, high-pitched male voice would express dominance, while, conversely, a low-pitched woman's voice would be a sign of assertiveness. *Loudness*, on the other hand, is commonly associated with distance – physical and, by extension, social –, so that soft voices tend to suggest closeness, intimacy, and even secrecy and conspiracy, while a loud voice, typical in public speech, suggests social distance and detachment. In sim-

ilar ways, clean, smooth voices convey meanings of polished, innocent, immaculate youth, while rough voices are connected to wear and tear resulting from hardship, drinking, or old age. According to van Leeuwen (2009), these voice features tend to occur in combination, thus yielding extra semiotic potential. For instance, the high pitch (feminine) and breathy quality in voices like Marilyn Monroe’s would suggest feminine vulnerability and seductiveness, while Marlon Brando’s high pitched, rough, breathy, soft voice in *The Godfather* would invite the character construction of a dominating, harsh and unforgiving mafia capo, at the same time intimate and attractive, and thus irresistibly dangerous.

4.3 Linguistic Organization

In singing, these acoustic elements are complemented with the words in the lyrics. The fact that ballads are narrative poems suggests that the first person narrator in “Big Joe” can be considered a lyrical I (Susman 1910), a term intended to capture the imperceptible distance between the fictional speaker and the real author in poetry readings (Hühn 2014, 159). Waits’ singing of the ballad is a good example of the lyrical I. In her study of Tom Waits’ lyrics, Martínez (2010) already notes that the singer includes a remarkable amount of interactional facework not present in Red Sovine’s early country version. As the present study shows, interactional facework has also been removed from Archers of Loaf’s later adaptation.

Current approaches to interpersonal pragmatics sideline Brown and Levinson’s (1987 [1978]) theory of politeness but stress Goffman’s (1967) early reflections on interactional dynamics (Bousfield 2008; Arundale 2010; LPRG 2011; Haugh et al. 2013; Haugh 2014). As Haugh et al. claim (2013, 4), this involves “a move towards treating subjective (i.e., individual or personalised) understandings of relationships as an *outcome* of the process of achieving intersubjectivity rather than something that drives communication or interaction, as is more often than not assumed” (emphasis in original). In this sense, interpersonal language is here studied with regard to the relations and identities collaboratively construed in the course of linguistic interaction.

Interactional facework, on the other hand, may encapsulate two types of interpersonal attitudes, connectedness and separateness (Haugh 2006), reportedly originating in biogenetic tendencies of approach and withdrawal (Terkourafi 2007), and in a way traceable in Brown and Levinson’s (1987 [1978]) positive and negative politeness. Connectedness language would include those strategies which Brown and Levinson associate with positive politeness linguistic redress: the use of in-group identity markers like colloquialisms, inclusive *we*, implica-

tions of assumed shared knowledge, unrequested explanations, exaggeration, repetitions, and the use of jokes and slang, among others. Separateness language, on the other hand, frequently involves the use of linguistic strategies which Brown and Levinson associate with negative politeness redress, among them hedges and epistemic modality, indirectness, or fillers such as *well*.

The analysis will thus focus on acoustic pitch and tempo, voice semiotics, and the use of interpersonal language, with the aim of discussing the multimodal projection of the storyworld and of listeners' SPSs in Tom Waits' and Archers of Loaf's adaptations of "Big Joe and Phantom 309."

5. The Multimodal Projection of the Storyworld and of Listeners' SPSs

5.1 Music and Voice Acoustics: Noise and Rhythm, Pitch and Tempo

Seilman (1990, 338) refers to the world-creation power of text beginnings, as empirical research within the theory of personal resonance (Larsen and Seilman 1988; Seilman and Larsen 1989) shows that it is towards the beginning of a text that readers experience more relevant "reminders" conducive to narrative understanding (Reichl 2009). Storyworld projection can thus be assumed to be triggered in the early chords in the ballad. Tom Waits' ballad actually starts with a harmonious, syncopated guitar motif, while Archers of Loaf's opens with a creaking, monotonous noise. As mentioned above, Martínez et al. (2013, 102–103) observe that some television commercials start with the projection of a storyworld portraying a happy individual after using the advertised product. The authors note that, in these cases, the use of lively, harmonious music seems to be aimed at prompting a positive evaluation of this storyworld by audiences. Conversely, the initial projection of a storyworld portraying someone in trouble before using the advertised product frequently co-occurs with the use of disturbing noise. This seems to be the case in these two versions of "Big Joe" too, with the implication that Tom Waits' version would prompt the projection in listeners' minds of a situational model where happiness can be expected to reign, while the indie band's version would be likely to prompt the projection of a situational model in which something could easily go wrong.

This seems to be reinforced by the analysis of pitch and tempo. Pitch was measured in herzs using the online tool *musicdictionary*, which was applied to the opening musical motif on the one hand and the singer's voice at the first

tonic syllable in the first line of the two versions on the other. The analysis shows that Archers of Loaf’s version displays a lower pitch, both in melody (220.00 Hz) and singer’s voice (110.00 Hz), than Waits’ (261.63 Hz and 130.81 Hz). The tempo of the two versions was also measured, using the online tool *metronomeonline*, which calculates beats per minute (Bpm). The analysis shows that Wait’s version is faster (58 Bpm) than Archers of Loaf’s (48 Bpm). Hence, Tom Waits’ version has both a higher pitch and a faster tempo than Archers of Loaf’s, both in the opening tune and the singer’s voice. These two features suggest that the HIGH PITCH IS HAPPY and FAST TEMPO IS HAPPY metaphors may encourage different expectations regarding the situational model of the fictional world.

5.2 Voice Semiotics and SPS Projection

These considerations seem to be supported by van Leeuwen’s (2009) observations on voice semiotics, which suggest that Waits’ rough, rugged, and slightly higher-pitched voice could prompt the mental representation of a tough individual, experienced and hardened by the wear and tear of life. By contrast, the indie band’s singer has a clean, smooth voice. Although lower in pitch than Waits’, this smoothness is likely to prompt the mental representation of a young, innocent, and inexperienced character. These two widely differing character constructs might affect narrative processing when the lyrics eventually disclose that the protagonist has kept company with a ghost. The main effects could be on empathy and emotional response, as the feelings of sharing consciousness with either a tough, experienced focalizer, or an inexperienced, innocent traveler in a ghostly scenario must substantially differ. With these underlying assumptions, Waits’ version could be expected to prompt the projection of a desired listener’s storyworld possible self, not only because the initial acoustic triggers invite a positive evaluation of the storyworld, but also because the character with whom listeners are going to share consciousness is acoustically presented as well-suited to cope with the events and situations to be encountered.

Conversely, the acoustic prompting of negative evaluations regarding the storyworld projected by Archers of Loaf’s version may trigger a feared SPS in listeners. The projection of a feared SPS would be reinforced in this version when deictic shifting makes audiences share isomorphic features with a young, inexperienced individual who does not seem likely to come out of the experience unharmed. It must be noted that the appeal of desired and feared SPSs is very much the same in what concerns the thrill of safely inhabiting a possible world as someone that we would either love or fear to become in the real world. However, although undoubtedly varying from individual to individual

due to the idiosyncratic nature of the self-concept network, the emotions to be experienced when our minds are immersed in a narrative will strongly differ depending on whether the metonymic projection involves a desired or a feared possible self.

5.3 Linguistic Organization: Interactional Language

In fact, the linguistic part of the two versions seems to reinforce this interpretation. To begin with, the way in which the first person narrator introduces himself in the very first stanza, reproduced in example (1), seems to also prompt a different evaluation of this character, who in Waits' version (1b) presents himself at the time of the ghostly encounter as "down on my luck," while in Archers of Loaf's (1c) he claims "...and I was down." In this way, the former attributes his miserable condition that night to chance and external events, while the latter blames the frailty of his own mental state.

But this is not the only significant difference in the opening stanza of the two versions. In example (1b), Waits' singing enriches the original lyrics with a conspicuous presence of interactional language. By contrast, the 2007 adaptation of "Big Joe and Phantom 309" by Archers of Loaf in (1c) seems to remove whatever traces of interactional language exist in the lyrics of Waits' song, and retains only a minimum presence of separateness language. In order to better illustrate these points, the examples below will be preceded by the lyrics in Red Sovine's 1967 country version, which, being the earlier well-known adaptation, will be taken as a point of reference for the linguistic modifications introduced by later singers. Instances of connectedness language are underlined in example (1), which contains the opening verses in the song. Separateness language is presented in italics. (1a) portrays the ballad lyrics as originally sung by Red Sovine in the 1960s, while (1b) and (1c) present Tom Waits' and Archers of Loaf's, respectively:

(1)

- a. I was out on the West Coast,
 tryin' to make a buck
 and things didn't work out,
 I was down on my luck (Sovine 1967, 1–4).
- b. *well you see* *I happened to* be back on the east coast
 a few years back tryin' to make me a buck
 like everybody else, *well you know*. Times get hard and
 well I got down on my luck (Waits 1975, 1–4).

c. Back out on the East coast

I was trying to make a buck

Times were hard and...and I was down (Archers 2007, 1–3).

In (1b) we find the particle “well,” described by Brown and Levinson (1987 [1978], 146, 167) as a hedge on illocutionary force, and thus as a distancing device. This occurs on three occasions in Tom Waits’ extract, but is not found at all in (1a) or (1c). Something similar happens with “you see” and “you know,” which, according to Brown and Levinson (1987 [1978], 197) show speakers’ interest in hearers, and consequently function as connectedness devices. These are not used by the other singers either. Other frequent instances of connectedness language in Waits’ version are claimers of shared experience, such as “like everybody else, [...] you know” (l. 3), or “that dashboard was lit like the old Madam La Rue pinball” (ll. 40–41); colloquial expressions such as “caught myself a chill” (l. 16), “ordered me a cup of mud” (l. 55), or “Big Joe’s setting this dude up” (l. 56); terms of address such as “man” (ll. 40, 52) and “son” (ll. 30, 44, 63, 87); repetitions as in “I want you to hang on to that dime, yea you hang on to that dime” (ll. 90–91); and exaggeration as in “there ain’t a driver [...] that’s seen nothing but the taillights of Big Joe and Phantom 309” (ll. 32–36), or in “nothing flat they was clean outa sight” (ll. 52–53). None of these devices occur in (1a) and (1c).

Separateness language, on the other hand, is also frequently used by the narrator in Tom Waits’ version. Some of its linguistic realizations include the hedge “just” (ll. 5, 17, 29, 45, 47, 65, 70, 86); the filler “well” (ll. 1, 3, 4, 24, 28, 42, 79); expressions of indeterminacy such as “I made quite a few miles” (l. 8), “it was just about that time” (l. 17), “almost” (l. 42), “the waiter’s face turned kinda pale” (ll. 58–59), “some hitchhiker will be coming by” (l. 86); reporting expressions such as “he said” (ll. 26, 30, 44, 49, 60, 61, 62, 88), “well they say” (l. 79), “folks around here say” (l. 76); and verbs and auxiliaries expressing epistemic meanings, such as “I happened to be back on the east coast” (l. 2), “I figured I’d be home in a week” (l. 10), or “I’d have to say he must of weighed 210 the way he stuck out a big hand” (ll. 24–25).

These style features seem particularly significant at crucial points such as the verse containing the first linguistic hint that something unearthly may be going on. In both versions this cue occurs near the exact middle of the poem, when Big Joe drops the narrator at the diner – verse 42 out of 94 in Tom Waits’, and verse 23 out of 54 in Archers of Loaf. The relevant stanza is presented in example (2). At this point in the narration, the ghost blend has not yet been linguistically triggered, so the character construct of the truck driver should still

be one of a warm friendly fellow of the sort that any Beat Generation roadster might want to come across on a lonely road by night:

(2)

- a. When the lights of a truck stop came into sight
he said “I’m sorry son, this is as far as you go
’Cause I gotta make a turn, *just* on up the road.” (Sovine 1967, 22–24)
- b. [...] until almost mysteriously, well it was the
lights of a truck stop that rolled into sight
Joe turned to me and said “I’m sorry son
but I’m afraid this is *just* as far as you go
you see I kinda gotta be makin’ a turn
just up the road *a piece*,” (Waits 1975, 42–47)
- c. And we rolled along until, mysteriously,
The lights of a truck stop came into sight
“I am sorry, son,” he said,
“This is as far as you can go.
I have to make a turn *just* up the road
And...I have to dash you off here.” (Archers 2007, 22–27)

(2b), from Waits’ adaptation, starts with an *it*-cleft, “it was the lights of a truck stop that came into sight,” an emphatic construction functioning as an intensifier device (Brown and Levinson 1987 [1978], 105), and expressing connectedness. This syntactic device is not used when the episode is narrated in the original ballad (2a), nor in the indie band’s adaptation (2c). Tom Waits’ version not only makes more extensive use of connectedness language in the narrator’s speech, but also attributes the use of such interactional concern to Big Joe himself. The driver’s reported utterance “I’m afraid this is just as far as you go” (2b) contains the hedge “I’m afraid,” showing reluctance to impinge on the hearer, as well as hedging “just” (Brown and Levinson 1987 [1978], 177). When Big Joe is reported to have said “you see I kinda gotta be makin’ a turn just up the road a piece” (2b), he not only offers a reason for his uncomely behaviour, but also redresses the inconvenience involved in dropping the hitch-hiker in the middle of the night with hedges – “kinda, a piece” – that “give notice that not as much or as precise information is provided as might be expected” (Brown and Levinson 1987 [1978], 166). The use of imperfective aspect in “gotta be making” (2b: 46) can also be considered an indirectness strategy not present in the other two versions, which contain the simple infinitive “I gotta make” (2a), or the even more formal “I have to” (2c). As a result, Tom Waits’ version seems more likely to prompt the mental representation of Big Joe as an extremely

kind and warm individual, highlighting the friendly interactional verisimilitude of that conversation, and disguising the ghostly nature of the speaker. This, in turn, mitigates the disquieting “mysteriously,” and further contributes to a strategic delay in the emergence of the ghost blend.

“Mysteriously,” however, undoubtedly sets into motion a shift in the type of SPS blend being projected by Tom Waits’ listeners, who have so far been invited to project matching features with the construct of the narrator as a tough, easy-going roamer making the best of a night ride, and thus probably projecting a desired SPS. However, at this point, “mysteriously” is likely to activate different types of features in the storyworld, casting the desired free adventurer SPS into a potentially dangerous scenario, and thus offering listeners cues for re-shaping it as a feared possible self. This new SPS is confirmed in the final verses of the ballad, in which the waiter at the diner tells the hitch-hiker that he has just had a lift by a ghost (example 3):

(3)

- a. [...] but he turned his wheels.
Well, Joe lost control, went into a skid
And gave his life to save that bunch-a kids
And there at that crossroads, was the end of the line
For Big Joe and phantom 309. (Sovine 1967, 40–44)
- b. [...] except Joe turned his wheels, and
he jackknifed, and went
into a skid, and folks around here
say he gave his life to save that bunch
of kids, and out there at that cold
lonely crossroads, well they say it
was the end of the line for
Big Joe and Phantom 309. (Waits 1975, 73–81)
- c. [...] except old Joe turned his wheels
and jack-knifed. He went into a skid.
So here, son, get another cup of coffee, [...] (Archers 2007, 48–50)

Here we can find the explicit linguistic projection of the ghost blend in the three versions. In all cases the revelation that Big Joe had actually died ten years before occurs just a few verses before the ballad comes to an end. In (3a) and (3b) we duly learn that the driver “gave his life” to save the kids, and that “was the end of the line” for him and his truck. However, in Archers of Loaf’s version (3c), Big Joe’s death is not explicitly mentioned. In fact, this may no longer be necessary because the song has already provided acoustic cues that have allowed the

reader to gradually project a fearsome storyworld, a feared SPS, and a ghost blend.

6. Discussion

The analysis of these two adaptations of “Big Joe and Phantom 309” suggests the presence of certain acoustic and linguistic resources whose interaction may affect storyworld projection and the triggering of different types of listeners’ storyworld possible selves. From an acoustic point of view, Tom Waits’ (1975) version starts with a harmonious, high-pitched, and lively tune, a semiotic resource which previous research connects to the prompting of positive evaluations of the fictional world. At the same time, the singer’s rough, breathy voice conveys features of tough experience to the character construct of the first-person narrator-focalizer, which in turn may invite the projection of listeners’ desired SPSs from matches with their free adventurer possible selves. Conversely, Archers of Loaf’s (2007) version opens with unpleasant noises likely to trigger a negative evaluation of the projected storyworld. This seems enhanced by the low pitch and slow tempo in both the tune and the singer’s voice. The latter’s smoothness, in turn, associated in acoustic semiotics with innocence and youth, could contribute to this character construct features of inexperience and feebleness to be matched with isomorphic features in listeners’ self-concept network. The blend of these two sets of features is likely to result in the projection of a feared SPS, ill-suited to cope with the demands of a grim scenario.

On the other hand, this further suggests that listeners may have deictically shifted into the storyworld through the metonymic projection of either a desired or a feared possible self. It could thus be claimed that the early acoustic triggering of a fearsome scenario and a feared storyworld possible self in Archers of Loaf’s listeners may result in a more gradual onset of feelings of suspense and intrigue. However, when the initially triggered scenario and SPS are of a non-threatening, reassuring nature, as is the case in Waits’ version, more evident features of shock and surprise may be expected when the ghostly presence is eventually disclosed.

These acoustically prompted cognitive processes seem to be reinforced by the presence of interactional language in the lyrics. Tom Waits’ version, involving the likely projection of listeners’ desired free adventurer, on-the-road brotherhood SPSs in a positively evaluated scenario, displays a massive presence of interactional linguistic expressions, inviting strong interpersonal links between the audience and the singer/narrator. However, Archers of Loaf’s adaptation is almost totally void of interactional language, so that listeners are forced to rely

more heavily on acoustic triggers, both for the projection of a ghostly scenario and for the projection of their own SPSs into the storyworld. It could be claimed that the effects of immediacy in Waits’ version derive from the fact that this was recorded during a live performance in a club, but the added effects of strong interpersonal concern contributed by the singer seem to exert a pressing urge pushing audiences into SPS projection, an urge that will remain in the recording across the years for future audiences to share.

7. Conclusion

This study has focused on two versions of the country ballad “Big Joe and Phantom 309” from the standpoint of multimodal storytelling. The findings suggest that the different acoustic and linguistic configurations are likely to result in different evaluations of the storyworld by listeners, as well as in the projection of different types of storyworld possible selves to be involved in perspectival deictic shifts. In turn, these different mind sets might affect listeners’ processing of the ghost blend when this is linguistically triggered in the closing stanzas of the narrative poem.

In multimodal narratives such as ballads, both acoustic and linguistic devices may intervene in storyworld and SPS projection, and it is through the fertile interplay of these multimodal resources that meaning is constructed. Although a detailed musical analysis is beyond the scope of the present study, further research might address the role of musical organization in multimodal storyworld projection in this particular ballad and its well-known covers. Nevertheless, the analysis of meaning construction in songs from a cognitive-functional perspective that looks into acoustic and voice semiotics as inseparable from language, may hopefully enhance our understanding of narrative immersion and, more specifically, of the ways in which cognition, emotion, and narrative techniques build and depend on each other in the effective telling of a good ghost story.

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Alan Palmer

“Put the Heart Into it!”: Narrative in Country Music and the Blues

I would like to begin on a personal note. I have been listening to the John Lee Hooker song “Wednesday Evenin’ Blues” for over 45 years, and a country song by Hoyt Axton called “Left My Gal in the Mountains” for only 30 years or so. Simple as they are, both of them sound as fresh to me today as the first time I heard them. In this essay, after an explanation of my cognitive approach to stories and a brief consideration of the concepts of narrative and narrativity, I will contrast the lyrics of the two songs. In adopting a cognitive and narratological perspective on them, I will pay particular attention to the minds of the two narrators, the level of self-attribution of mental states and the different sorts of information available to the listener regarding the causes of, and reasons for, those mental states.

The discussion will show that the country song has much more narrativity than the blues. The essay will then widen in scope, because it will argue that this difference is characteristic of the two genres generally. I will tentatively suggest some historical reasons for this difference in narrativity between the two genres, but also raise a difficulty with this sort of explanation. That is: given the large amount of black/white cross-fertilisation between these genres, why has the difference in narrativity remained?

The new subject area of audionarratology should be flexible enough to encompass a variety of different approaches towards the narratives that occur in musical settings. For example, studies will vary to the extent to which they take account of the role of music in the effects of those narratives. The purpose of this essay is to show that cognitive analyses of song lyrics are worth undertaking. As such, it is not, primarily, an examination of the relationship between words and music, although I refer to that relationship in passing while discussing both my examples. Obviously, much more work can be done on the role that music plays in the presentations of fictional minds in musical narratives.

1. Fictional Minds

In *Fictional Minds* (2004), I outlined a theory for the study of the novel which seems to me to be equally applicable to the narratives contained in popular songs. I argued that, in order to understand a novel, we have to try to follow

the mental functioning of the characters who operate within its storyworld. The constructions of the minds of fictional characters by narrators and readers are central to our understanding of how novels work, because readers enter storyworlds primarily by attempting to follow the workings of the fictional minds contained in them. Fictional narrative is, in essence, the presentation of mental functioning. These storyworlds are aspectual. As the philosopher John Searle explains, “[w]henever we perceive anything or think about anything, we always do it under some aspects and not others” (1992, 156–157), and this is equally true of fictional characters. Like real people, characters experience the same events in different ways.

A key tool for analyzing the process of recovering and reassembling fictional storyworlds is the application of attribution theory: the study of how we ascribe states of mind to others and also to ourselves. The ability that we have to infer the mental processes of others from their behaviour is often referred to as *theory of mind* (Zunshine 2006). In relation to fictional minds, attribution theory can be used to formulate tentative answers to questions such as these: How do readers attribute states of mind such as emotions, dispositions and reasons for action to characters? How do heterodiegetic (third-person) and homodiegetic (first-person) narrators attribute states of mind to their characters? How do characters attribute mental states to themselves and to other characters? And, finally, with regard to the issue of characterization, how does an attribution of a mental state help to build up in the reader a sense of the whole personality of that character?

Extending these ideas to song lyrics, I propose that it is only possible to understand the attenuated, minimal, and sketchy narratives contained in the lyrics of popular songs by following the mental functioning of the narrators of those songs and the other characters who inhabit the storyworlds created by their lyrics. We understand the two songs discussed below by following what their narrators tell us about the workings of their minds, their thoughts, feelings, and emotions, and also the workings of the minds of the other characters in the songs.

2. Narrative and Narrativity

Definitions of narrative are often focused on minimal narratives that sometimes consist only of single sentences and so can be suitably applied to the extremely short stories contained in song lyrics. Several definitions have a noticeable emphasis on events. For example, narration is “a discourse representing one or more events” (Prince 1987, 57); narrative fiction is “the narration of a succession of fictional events” (Rimmon-Kenan 1983, 2); a narrative is “the semiotic repre-

sensation of a series of events, meaningfully connected in a temporal and causal way” (Onega and García Landa 1996, 3). Mieke Bal defines an event as “the transition from one state to another state, caused or experienced by actors” (1997, 182). What is either missing from, or not fully explicit in, these definitions is a recognition of the importance of fictional minds. Although Onega and García Landa talk about events being meaningfully connected in a causal way, they do not specify that the causal links between events are nearly always formed by fictional minds. Many events are actions caused by fictional minds and those that are not generally have significance only if they are experienced by those minds. This point is behind Monika Fludernik’s (1996) argument that the fundamental element in the concept of narrative is not event, but what she calls *experientiality*: her term for subjectivity, an experiencing consciousness, self and what I call a fictional mind. Walter Scott puts the point very well in his novel, *The Fair Maid of Perth*:

The reader, however gentle, will not hold himself obliged to rest satisfied with the mere fact that such and such occurrences took place, which is generally speaking, all that in ordinary life he can know of what is passing around him; but he is desirous, while reading for amusement, of knowing the interior movements occasioning the course of events. (1908, 300–301)

I think Scott is right about how readers typically read narratives, and I would suggest that the “interior movements occasioning the course of events” are the workings of fictional minds.

On the other hand, though, it is important to bear in mind that the term *narrativity* is indicative of a recognition that the concept of narrative is a fuzzy one. Various discourses exhibit *degrees* of narrativity; some narratives are more narrative than others. This way of thinking is preferable to seeing discourses as a string of words that may be classified as a narrative if and only if certain necessary and sufficient conditions are met. This approach is rather like the way psychologists study our acquisition of concepts. The famous example is that of birds. Some birds are part of our *core* concept: say, in Britain anyway, garden birds such as sparrows, robins and wrens. Some others are a little further from the core – perhaps more specialist varieties such as birds of prey and sea birds. Then, I would imagine, come the more exotic (for the British at least) varieties such as jungle birds. Finally, on the periphery of the concept, are the flightless birds. So, in the same way, there are core and peripheral narratives. Narrativity is a spectrum or a scale, not a dichotomy, in which, in popular music, narrative is at one pole and lyric at the other. Confusingly, this use of the term *lyric* does not refer to song lyrics generally, in this context, but means “any fairly short poem expressing the personal mood, feeling or meditation of a

single speaker” (Baldick 1990, 125). It seems to me that country and folk songs are often at the narrative end of the spectrum, though there are plenty that are located towards the lyric end too. Blues and soul songs, by contrast, tend to be grouped much more at the lyric end, with very few at the other pole. I will be arguing that my country song example is a core narrative and the blues song is rather more peripheral.

I would suggest that, when judging the degree of narrativity in a particular discourse, the following five elements should be borne in mind:

1. the creation of a storyworld, however minimal;
2. the existence of at least one fictional mind within that storyworld, though usually more;
3. the passing of time, however short the duration;
4. the occurrence of at least one event within the storyworld, though usually more; and
5. the existence of causal connections between the events that are, in the main, related to fictional minds.

These five elements share a single common factor: *action*. There must necessarily be a storyworld in which actions are performed (1). Actions are events that occur within this storyworld (4). Behind any action must be a mental network consisting of reasons, causes, intentions and motives (I will say more on this later), and it therefore requires fictional minds to have these intentions and motives (2). This mental network is, in the main, the causal connection that exists between events (5). Finally, in addition to the antecedent causal mental network, actions have consequences, and so duration over time is guaranteed (3). Narrative songs are primarily about actions, while, as specified in the definition just quoted, the emphasis in lyric songs is more on moods, feelings or meditations. I will now consider my two examples in the light of these general theoretical remarks. (As the copyright status of the two songs is uncertain, I do not quote the lyrics in their entirety.)

3. “Left My Gal in the Mountains”

In this song, the narrator leaves his girl in the mountains, standing in the rain, as he goes down to the railroad to catch a midnight train. He travels through Georgia and ends up in a “gambling town.” There, he gets into trouble by shooting the county sheriff. At the subsequent trial, he is convicted of first degree murder and taken to the penitentiary. He tells how they put handcuffs on him as he is put on a Pullman train, carried to Atlanta and then tied to a ball and chain.

In prison, he dreams that he receives a letter from his girl asking him to come home. She needs his arms around her and she has missed his loving since he left. He describes the cold prison bars all around him and the guards walking by his cell. He is so sad and lonely because he will never see his girl any more. The first verse is then repeated, and the performance ends with the narrator saying that he wishes he could yodel as the “Singing Brakeman” did.

This country and western song was written and recorded in 1929 by a little known singer-songwriter called Carson Robison, but the version I am looking at here was made nearly 50 years later, in 1978, by a country singer called Hoyt Axton (whose mother co-wrote Elvis Presley’s “Heartbreak Hotel”!). The song is written in the style of the traditional ballads that have been circulating in the United States, and particularly in the south eastern states, for hundreds of years ever since they were brought over by immigrants from England, Scotland and Ireland. Many of these settlers created the remote, insular and inaccessible communities of the Appalachian Mountains known as ‘hollers.’ When country music became a commercial industry in the 1920s, following the development of new technology such as the radio and the phonograph (i.e., the record player), record company executives arrived in local towns with their portable recording equipment to find that the music had changed very little over the years and still bore marked similarities to British folk music. However, when the supply of genuinely traditional material began to dry up, professional songwriters like Carson Robison wrote many new songs in order to satisfy this rapidly expanding market. It is noticeable that a good number of the composed songs that were first recorded during the initial explosion of recorded music, like “Left My Gal in the Mountains,” reflected the old ballad tradition.

The instrumentation on the Hoyt Axton recording is very simple: it consists of acoustic guitars, banjo, harmonica and recorder. There are no bass and drums, and, significantly, no fiddles and steel guitars – country music does not have to have those instruments. The song is a good example of the advice that the great singer-songwriter, Jesse Winchester, gave to aspiring songwriters weeks before his death in April 2014: “Say what needs saying ... and then try not to say anything else” (taken from the liner notes of the CD *A Reasonable Amount of Trouble*). It consists of a mere 149 words (excluding the repeated last verse). Of these, 115 are one syllable words, 31 are two syllable words and only two have three or more syllables (“Atlanta” and “penitentiary”). If you exclude words such as “I,” “me,” “myself,” “my” (21 instances), together with “the,” “a” and “an” (16 instances) and prepositions such as “in,” “to,” “on,” and “by” (13 instances), there are only 99 what might be called “concrete” words.

In spite of its extreme simplicity, the song clearly has a strong narrative. It is worth looking to see how it achieves its high degree of narrativity. First, it meets

all of the five criteria mentioned earlier. The storyworld created by the song is remarkably detailed. Using Marie-Laure Ryan's principle of minimal departure, it is safe to assume that the world of the song is that of the south eastern states of America at the time it was composed (i.e., the 1920s); the mountains referred to in the title are presumably the Appalachians. It refers to the state of Georgia and its capital, Atlanta. The mind of the narrator is clearly in evidence and other minds are also briefly indicated: the gal he leaves behind, the members of the jury, the judge and the guard walking by his cell door. A period of time elapses between his leaving home at the beginning of the song and his being in jail at the end of it. Several events are described: his farewell to his gal and then his travels through Georgia; the killing of the sheriff; the trial and verdict; transportation to jail; a dream about receiving a letter; and, finally, the mental event of his emotional reaction to his situation. (Not bad for 149 words!) Finally, there are causal connections between the events that are related in the main to his mind. That is to say, the "interior movements occasioning the course of events" in this song relate, as in all narratives, to the workings of the narrator's fictional mind.

All of the narrator's actions are *caused* by his mind. However, the word "caused" needs further explanation. Some of his actions arise from his *intentions*, he has clear *motives* for performing them. They include leaving his gal, boarding the train, and travelling through Georgia. Other actions may not be intended in this strict sense, because he may not have self-conscious motives for doing them, but they still arise out of *reasons* or *causes* that relate to his mind. We do not know why he shot the county sheriff down, but let us suppose that it was an accident. Or it may have been in that grey area of intention that many actions occupy: say, an impulse while drunk. But this does not matter. The key point is that the reasons why the killing occurred, the causes of the event, relate to his fictional mind, to the sort of person that he is. He is someone who likes to get drunk in rowdy bars in gambling towns. I am of course extrapolating here, but plausibly, I think. And casual killing, accidental or intended, is the sort of thing that happens in those sorts of places, and is typically caused by the sort of people who frequent them.

I stated above that we do not know why he shot the sheriff. This is a homodiegetic narration about some important, life-changing events in this young man's life, but there is a complete lack of self-attribution of mental states until the end of the song. It is only then that his feelings are explicitly expressed, when he says that he's so sad and lonely because he'll never see his girl any more. This delay gives those feelings additional force. But, until then, explicit reference to motivation and emotions is missing. He does not say *why* he does the things he does and he does not say how he *feels* about the things he does. He does not say why he left his gal or how he felt about it; why he continued trav-

elling or how he felt about the killing or the trial. The song is laconic, impassive and taciturn. Motives such as pleasure-seeking and restlessness and emotions such as regret may plausibly be inferred but are not directly attributed by the narrator to himself (until, as I say, the end). The workings of his mind are realised in his actions, but the mental network of causation behind the actions is not explicitly there in the words. This reticence, by the way, is characteristic of most traditional ballads and so is likely to be found in many of the later songs that are modelled on them, such as this one.

Our default expectation of a first-person narration is that it will contain sufficient self-attribution to allow us to have a good idea of the causal network behind actions. In particular, as part of that network, readers or listeners will generally expect to be given attributions of the emotions related to the reasons for action and also the emotions that arise from the consequences of actions (such as regret). It is in this way that what might be called the *narrative causal chain* is created. In a typical chain, reasons for actions (including emotions, beliefs, desires and so on) result in decisions to act. In this song these are not made explicit but presumably include restlessness and a desire for adventure. The decisions result in actions (leaving his gal, catching the train, travelling through Georgia, landing in a gambling town). The actions have consequences (shooting the sheriff, arrest, trial, conviction and jail). The consequences produce emotional reactions (the dream of the letter, feelings of sadness, loneliness and regret). These reactions result in fresh reasons for further actions (wishing he was back with his gal). However, in this case, the chain comes to an end at this point because the action of going home that would naturally result from the last-named emotion is not possible. Part of the deep satisfaction of this song is that, despite the lack of self-attribution, this causal chain can easily be inferred. And, at the end, causation, like emotion, is made explicit. The concluding repetition of the first verse begins with the word, “because.” He is in the situation that he finds himself in *because* he left his gal in the mountains. He left her because of the sort of person that he is. Because he is the sort of person that he is, he did the things that he did and is now facing the consequences of his actions.

The final line of the song may seem rather puzzling to most readers of this essay: “And I wish I could yodel like the Singing Brakeman did.” It is an oddity because it does not appear in any of the early versions of the song so it is not part of the lyrics proper. It seems that Hoyt Axton is unique in adding it onto the end of the song. The “Singing Brakeman” is the nickname of the first great country and western singer, Jimmie Rodgers, who worked on the railroad as a brakeman before becoming a professional entertainer. He is known as the father of country music. He became a household name and the first country music superstar at about the time when the song was written (1929) as part of the explosion in re-

corded music that I mentioned above. Although he was not the first to use the yodel in country songs, he was the first to popularise this device in a series of 13 songs called “blue yodels.” The inclusion of the line is presumably meant to convey, in a convincingly casual and detailed way, the narrator’s feelings of loss and loneliness. It is a kind of transference of his true feelings onto what, in his current situation, is obviously a rather trivial and irrelevant concern.

One final thought on the cognitive aspects of the song relates to the aspectuality of fictional storyworlds that I mentioned earlier. When a narrative is focalized through the consciousness of a single character, we experience the storyworld in a particular way. However, the same storyworld might look very different to us if the narration utilised the point of view of one of the non-focalized characters. This song presents the storyworld as experienced by the narrator. The events that are recounted are the ones that involve him. But always, as a substratum to these events, is the experience of the gal he left behind. She continues to exist while the described events occur. And, although we are told that her letter is written only in his dream, and although it is possible that she has forgotten about him, we feel, nevertheless, that it is the sort of letter that she would write if she knew where he was.

Up until now, I have talked only about the words of the song. If the sub-discipline of audionarratology is to develop in the ways that I hope it does in relation to American popular music, it will need to find a vocabulary to talk about the role that music plays in the effects that songs have on listeners. What is the difference between reading the words of “Left My Gal in the Mountains” on the page, as a poem, and hearing them performed as part of the song? The obvious answer is that there is a huge difference. As is well known, song lyrics tend to look rather trite on the page but many will nevertheless sound great, especially when sung by a good singer such as Hoyt Axton. This may be a poor poem, but it is a great song. But how can we find the words to describe the difference that the music makes? Obvious factors include tune, voice and instrumentation. First, the tune suits the words. The steady pulse of the simple melody is the appropriate vehicle for the lyrics. It is not fast and jolly in tone, but stately and melancholy, and beautifully enhances the yearning and regret in the words. Next, the voice of Hoyt Axton is right for the song. His rich, deep, relaxed baritone has the same quality of reticence and impassiveness that the lyrics have. He uses his voice in a restrained way, with no over-singing and no histrionics. Nevertheless, it is deeply expressive and allows the emotional effect of the retelling of the story to emerge naturally. I feel a thrill every time I hear the lines about him being sad and lonely, and part of that thrill is the way he uses his voice – the bluesy tinge given to the words “sad,” “lonely” and “gal,” and the distinctive rhythm that he imparts to the two lines. Finally, there is the instrumentation: the guitars

and banjo are warm and discreet, and the wistful wailing harmonica perfectly expresses the emotions that are latent in the words.

4. “Wednesday Evenin’ Blues”

The words to this song are extremely simple. The narrator explains that a woman left him one Wednesday evening when the sun was sinking low. She said “good-bye Johnny I’m leaving you now.” He replies that she should not forget that he is the father of her child. She has been gone “one long year today,” but he still thinks about her every Wednesday evening when the sun is sinking low.

This song was written and recorded in 1960 by the great black blues singer, John Lee Hooker. The instrumentation is even more sparse than that on the other track – it is just the singer himself, playing electric guitar, with an unusually light, unobtrusive accompaniment of acoustic string bass and drums. This gives the track an eerie, ominous feel that is typical of much of his work. In terms of the five criteria mentioned above, the song certainly creates a storyworld, albeit a minimal one, in which a man is left by a woman who had a child by him on a Wednesday evening a year ago and he is still thinking of her. And that is all; we are told nothing else. This world has none of the detail of the Hoyt Axton song, but it is still a storyworld. Importantly, this world contains an experiencing mind – that of the narrator. And there is also the mind of the woman who decided to leave him and who is being reminded that they have a child together. Obviously, time passes – in fact, we know that a year has passed. The song also relates events. The main event is the separation, but there is also a series of iterative mental events – his continual thoughts of her, culminating in the memory, a year later, that the song recreates. Finally, the causal connection between the events is made entirely clear – he thinks of her *because* he remembers her leaving. But this is certainly not an eventful song, as the other one is.

So the song qualifies as a narrative, albeit a much simpler one than the other song. It is not a core narrative but is more peripheral; it is further along the scale from the narrative pole towards the lyric pole. But that is hardly surprising when a condensed version of the lyrics, with all the repetitions taken out, is only 60 words long. One gap that is apparent from seeing the words on the page divorced from the music is any explicit expression of emotion. It came as a shock to me to realise that, when you actually look at the lyrics simply as words on the page, there are no direct expressions of emotions contained in those words at all. I had become so used to feeling the emotional impact of the song while listening

to it as a musical experience that I had not noticed that the narrator does not explicitly attribute to himself any emotional states.

This brings us to the music. The difference between the appearance of words on the page and the impact of the whole musical performance is even greater than in the other song. What accounts for this? The simple answer is that John Lee Hooker was a great blues singer. He had a speech impediment, a kind of stutter, and so found some difficulty in communicating with other people in everyday life. However, once he began singing, he was transformed. Any blues fan will know instantly, within seconds, that they are listening to a John Lee Hooker record. The brooding intensity of performances such as these is unforgettable. There is a very obvious difference between the restraint of the singing and instrumentation on the previous record, and the unrestrained passion on this. His highly accomplished, intensely expressive guitar playing seems to be inseparable from his totally distinctive voice. The guitar expresses the emotions that the words merely imply. This is especially true of the passage at the end of the song, when the lyrics dissolve first into repeated fragmentary phrases, and then, when the discreet bass and drums accompaniment ends, into wordless humming in unison with his guitar. This is the point at which he conveys best what he feels about being alone.

The two songs are similar in that both are about a man and a woman parting. Both brood on the past. However, the differences are, perhaps, more interesting. In one, the man initiates the parting; in the other; the woman does. In one, a good deal happens after the parting; in the other; nothing does, as far as one can tell. One is full of action and events in a detailed world; in the other, a man sits alone in a bare room (as I imagine it), brooding. One is full of other people; the other conveys an overwhelming, almost Beckettian sense of anguished solitude, despite it being an address to “people.” In summary, they achieve similar ends – conveying feelings of sadness, regret, loneliness and isolation following separation from a loved one – but in completely different ways.

5. Narrativity and the Two Genres

These two songs are fairly typical of the genres to which they belong. The predominantly white genres of country and western and folk music have noticeably more narrativity than the predominantly black genres of blues and soul. This is not a hard and fast rule and there are exceptions. Many country songs gravitate towards the lyric end of the spectrum. Also, some black artists are interested in narrative. For example, Mississippi John Hurt was an early blues singer who

liked to sing narrative ballads, and Chuck Berry was a rhythm and blues artist who wrote lots of narrative songs such as “The Promised Land” and “No Particular Place to Go.” Nevertheless, as a rough generalisation, the distinction does hold true.

So why does white music tend to be more narrative than black? The reason is probably that country and American folk music have their roots in the traditional narrative ballads that I mentioned above, the ones that were carried over to America from the British Isles by the early colonial and later settlers. Country songs down to the present day have carried on this tradition. A typical country song will feature the narrator sitting in a bar complaining about his life. He or she will often say where the bar is, what their job is, what the name of their spouse is and so on. A typical blues will not have this kind of specificity. The storyworld will be much sketchier, and the emotional content will rely more on the expressive qualities of the singer’s voice and the instrumental virtuosity of the musicians, as with the guitar playing in the John Lee Hooker example.

This is probably because blues and, later, soul music derive originally from Africa and then from the slave plantations. This music was intensely social in character and geared much more towards large-group contexts such as dancing and religious ceremonies than to the telling of stories about individuals. Also, given the position of black people in America, first as slaves and then under segregation, they were understandably reluctant to be too specific in their music about the precise nature of their troubles. Songs about “having the blues” have to be understood, therefore, as shorthand for a wide range of problems, social as well as personal, that will not be made explicit in the lyrics. As a result, the blues songs that arose from this tradition have tended to be more lyric than narrative in character. As Norm Cohen remarks in his book, *Long Steel Rail*, “blues songs do not have the narrative continuity of Anglo-American ballads. They occasionally do tell, or comment on, a story in a disjointed fashion, but more usually they consist of only loosely related stanzas that may share a common theme” (2000, 401). Another musicologist, Richard Crawford, agrees, commenting in his book, *America’s Musical Life: A History*, “[n]arrative shape [is] usually missing from folk blues” (2001, 560). Soul music, developing as it did out of the blues and black gospel traditions, is similarly lyric in character.

There is also the obvious point that the 12-bar structure of the blues (first line, then first line repeated with occasional variations, then response line) does not lend itself to story-telling. It lacks momentum. But two caveats are necessary on this point. One is that the argument is a little too chicken-and-egg to be a satisfying causal explanation. It does not clarify whether the structure that was adopted for the blues inhibited storytelling, or was determined by a particular level of interest by its practitioners in storytelling. Second, there are many tradi-

tional narrative ballads, in the British as well as the American tradition, that make generous use of repeated lines. Generally speaking, though, the historical analysis that I have just presented is a very simple, plausible and satisfying explanation for the difference in narrativity between genres. However, there is a complication. It is that there has been a good deal of trans-racial cross-fertilisation between the black and white genres. There are countless examples of such crossovers and I will mention just a few.

From the beginning, blues was an integral part of country music, and many early country performers display the undeniable influence of the blues. The greatest of these was Jimmie Rodgers, the first country superstar. He was the “Singing Brakeman” who is mentioned in the last line of “Left My Gal in the Mountains.” The 13 “blue yodels” mentioned earlier became a nationwide sensation. One even featured the jazz trumpeter, Louis Armstrong. His influence has been felt to the present day in the blues-tinged vocal styles of Lefty Frizzell, Willie Nelson and Merle Haggard (who recorded an album called *I love Dixie Blues – So I Recorded Live in New Orleans*). Both the father of bluegrass music, Bill Monroe, and the greatest country singer-songwriter of all, Hank Williams, claimed to have taken early lessons from local black blues singers. Two entirely different sub-genres of country music – bluegrass and western swing – are heavily influenced by jazz and blues.

From the other direction, black artists love singing country songs and many soul and rhythm and blues singers have recorded whole albums of them. When blues and soul singers like Ray Charles, B. B. King and Chuck Berry talk about their childhoods and early musical influences, they invariably mention listening to the radio broadcasts of country music such as the Grand Ole Opry and the Louisiana Hayride. They frequently acknowledge the profound influence of country singers such as Hank Williams, Jimmie Rodgers and Roy Acuff. Ray Charles’s first job was in a country band and he made several highly influential recordings of country songs. “Chuck Berry was a St. Louis bluesman who mimicked white country music” (Giddins and DeVeaux 2009, 530), and “sometimes sounded white” (Crawford 2001, 736). The famous recordings that Aretha Franklin, Wilson Pickett, Percy Sledge and others made in the legendary Muscle Shoals studio in Alabama during the 1960s were masterpieces of black soul music, but those singers were the only black people in the room during those recordings.

This extensive crossover is also apparent in the large store of songs that regularly appear within the various genres of blues, gospel, country and folk. “Goodnight Irene,” “Will the Circle be Unbroken,” “Corrine Corrina,” and “Sitting on Top of the World” are just some of the well-known examples. Given this intense cross-fertilisation, which is so great that I have only briefly hinted at the scale of it, why has the marked difference in narrativity between the genres

survived to the present day? Why has the narrative element that is derived from old-world Appalachian ballads still survived throughout the history of country music, given so much black involvement? Why has black music been so resistant to narrative, given the white involvement? I should mention at this point that I know nothing about contemporary black music such as rap and hip-hop. The most likely answer to this mystery is simply inertia – the very strong tendency of musical traditions to stay the same at their core, despite being so ragged around their edges. However, it is apparent that more research is needed on this important topic.

6. Conclusion

According to the sleeve notes of a compilation record that I own, the “richest strains of native music produced by any nation [are] the strong, exciting, vibrant country and urban folksong traditions nurtured in the United States over the last three centuries” (Pete Welding, *Roots of America’s Music, Volume I*). That feels right to me. This is music that values conviction, authenticity and soul. To quote Walter Scott again: “But for a’ that, ye will play very weel wi’ a little practice and some gude teaching. But ye maun learn to put the heart into it, man – to put the heart into it” (Scott 1940, 120). Country, folk, blues, soul and gospel music certainly “put the heart into it.” I hope that audionarratology becomes an established research field within the wider discipline of narratology generally, and that there is a focus within the field on this tradition of American popular music.

Within any worthwhile study of this tradition, there are at least two issues that would benefit from further thought, both of which I have briefly explored in this essay. First, it should be borne in mind that the cognitive functioning presented in all country and blues songs takes place within social networks. The listener’s understanding of the minds presented in country songs and traditional ballads is enriched by an awareness of the complex cultural contexts and reception histories of these songs. These factors affect songs and novels differently. The second issue is the role of narrative in popular music. Much has been written about the various genres of American popular music, but more needs to be said on the specific topic of this essay – the differing levels of narrativity between genres. It is an important perspective on country, folk, blues and soul, but one that has yet been fully explored, as far as I know. There is a lot of work that can be done within the sub-discipline of audionarratology on these and other related issues.

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Markus Wierschem

Animae Partus: Conceptual Mythopoeisis, Progressive Rock, and the Many Voices of Pain of Salvation's *BE*

I am...

I am...

I am!

I was not, then I came to be. I cannot remember NOT being, but I may have traveled far, very far, to get here.

Maybe I was formed in this silent darkness, from this silent darkness, BY this silent darkness. To become is just like falling asleep; you never know exactly when it happens – the transition, the magic – and you think, if you could only recall that exact moment of crossing the line – then you would understand everything. You would see it all. (*BE* 2)¹

In a sense, the cosmological event par excellence has always been a sonic one, signifying the passage from endarkened nothingness to enlightened being through *sound*. So it is in the vision of Genesis, where the original state of the earth is one of *tohu wa-bohu* (Hebrew ‘waste and void’; ‘formless and empty’) out of which the godhood issues a first, verbal command, marking the beginning of orderly creation: “Let there be light” (Genesis 1:3). So it is, too, in the the Gospel of John, whose famous opening lines assert: “In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God” (John 1:1). Beyond the act of creation itself, the Pythagoreans and others conceived of the order of the *cosmos* – that is, of the rationally organized universe as opposed to the formless, primal *chaos* (Greek ‘chasm, gap’; later: ‘unformed, primordial matter’) from which *cosmos* arises – in terms of an encompassing, mathematically proportionate music of the spheres. Conversely, modern physics puts forth a less articulate or musical, yet still fundamentally aural theory: Where before there had been only a dense, hot ‘nothing,’ with the advent of the singularity, there was suddenly something – space, matter, time itself, a *universe*. As the theme song to a popular sitcom would have it: “It all started with the big bang!”²

1 Unless stated otherwise, I am referring primarily to the 2004 studio album and the liner notes of the CD booklet, rather than the “Original Stage Production.” The latter was recorded live at one of the early shows at the Lokomotivet in Eskilstuna, Sweden, on September 12, 2003 and released on DVD/CD in 2005. For her helpful comments on the musical aspects of *BE*, I thank Daniela Glahn.

2 Interpreting data of cosmic microwaves, “a faint glow in the universe that acts as sort of a fossilized fingerprint of the Big Bang,” physicist John Cramer has simulated what the ‘big

Paralleling events of such cosmological magnitudes, it is the first wail of the newborn that marks each childbirth's human sunrise. In a sense, listening to a splendid anomaly of an album like Pain of Salvation's *BE* (2004), too, amounts to the witnessing of a wholly improbable kind of birth. Where before there was only silence, at the pressing of the play button, a new microcosm opens up before the mind's eye as the inaugural soundwaves leave the speakers and pass through the auditory canal. There, they vibrate the eardrums and stimulate the hair cells of the inner ears, creating the sensation of *music*. Yet the opening track, which bears the title "Animae Partus (I Am)," is designated as a "Prologue." Accordingly, it begins with words rather than music, though this is not quite accurate either as the first of these words, barely noticeable, are sung softly and almost immediately muted: "I'm at the line, I see ..." (Track 1, 00:00 – 00:05). Fading in, there is a slow, pulsating beat, and then, about six seconds in, a loud gasp. This is followed by the actual first spoken words, as the clear and brilliant voice of a child penetrates the dark and hollow soundscape, proclaiming: "I am." The phrase is repeated twice by two other voices, male and female. In the background, fading in and out, we hear as yet unidentifiable, vaguely melodic sonic fragments. As we will learn, these are fragments from the songs that follow.

Beginning to interpret these sonic data, I repeat, we are listening to a birth scene – the slow pulse like an echo of the opening of *Dark Side of the Moon*, signifying the heartbeat of a new life, the gasp a kind of *vagitus* as this life takes its first breath. Lyrically, the three-voice-narration stands in contrast with the first person singular used, and as the voices encircle and echo one another – overlapping and blending together, sometimes slightly distorted and sometimes syntactically finishing each other's sentences – we get the impression that these are not three different characters, but rather three aspects of a single one. The title "Animae Partus" – as well as the booklet or libretto – tells us that this entity is Animae. The consistent use of the Latin plural form, while faulty, actually serves to reaffirm the impression of multiplicity evoked by the three voices, just as the following, wrongly declined title "Deus Nova" reflects Animae's multiple genders. Her name is fitting, too, as 'anima' means soul and spirit, as well as life and breath; likewise, it immediately suggests Carl Gustav Jung's *archetype of life itself*, 'the anima' (see Jung 2001, 35). The birth-scene is thus saturated with mythological and psychological resonance, invoking "a silent darkness" as that of the darkness "over the face of the deep" in the Book of Genesis (Genesis

bang's "real soundwaves" could have sounded like when made audible for the human ear (Stricherz 2013).

1:2), and as *Animae's* awareness pronounces itself, the world is also *spoken* into being.

Following her birth, the next act is one of autobaptism, as *Animae* gives herself another name: "Who I am? In the back of my awareness, I find words: I will call myself God" (*BE* 3). In the context of her awakening consciousness, *Animae's* first words "I am" thus refer simultaneously to the Cartesian '*cogito*' and the divine "I am who I am" that addresses Moses from the burning bush (Exodus 3:14).³ Figuratively speaking, what takes its first breath is therefore both life itself in reflexive awareness of itself *and* a male-female-child god as the source of that life and the locus of that awareness. Curiously though, rather than an all-powerful and omniscient being, this god, if she is truly so, is characterized by a sense of wonder and curiosity at her own existence: "Somehow I seem to have this predestined hunger for knowledge; a talent for seeing patterns and finding correlations. But I lack context" (*BE* 3). *Animae's* final words express at once a prediction and a resolution: "I will spend the rest of forever trying to figure out who I am" (*BE* 3). This, then, is the frame of what is to follow: The musical tale that Daniel Gildenlöw, the lead songwriter, lyricist, singer, and guitarist of the Swedish progressive metal band, spins for his listeners is a kind of quest, a search for one's self and identity in a void of context and origin: like each of us, *Animae*, too, "cannot remember NOT being" (*BE* 1). As may be inferred even from this short primer on the first hundred seconds of the album, it will be a narrative rich with religious, scientific, and philosophical implications.

Before continuing on the quest of this essay, words are in order to problematize, however sketchily, both the object I am looking at *and* the theoretical locus I am speaking from. To my mind, this entails at least three problems. First of all, the album I am looking at belongs to a specific musical format one would likely not immediately think of when hearing the term "audionarrative." Like practically all of Pain of Salvation's studio records, *BE* is a *concept album*, and like a typical concept album, it contains both music and a rather extensive amount of

3 The ESV notes: "In response to Moses' question ('What is [your] name?' v. 13), God reveals his name to be 'Yahweh' (corresponding to the four Hebrew consonants *YHWH*). The three occurrences of 'I Am' in v. 14 all represent forms of the Hebrew verb that means 'to be' (Hebrew *hayah*) [...]. The divine name Yahweh has suggested to scholars a range of likely nuances of meaning: (1) that God is self-existent and therefore not dependent on anything else for his own existence; (2) that God is the creator and sustainer of all that exists; (3) that God is immutable in his being and character and thus is not in the process of becoming something different from what he is [...] and (4) that God is eternal in his existence. [...] the word translated 'I am' (Hebrew *'ehyeh*) can also be understood and translated as 'I will be' [...] a clear reminder of God's promises to his people" (ESV 149).

words both sung and spoken. Secondly, the music, while eclectic and defying easy categorization, is overall best described as *progressive* or *art rock*. One will need at least a vague notion of what this entails artistically. A third, more basic point that has to be addressed is that of the general relation between music, words, and other extramusical signifiers, that is, the question of what constitutes the *musical text*. Since these issues are closely connected, it makes sense to discuss them in conjunction.

1. Progressive Rock, Concept Albums, and the Musical Text

Following the pioneer work that the Beatles, the Beach Boys and others had done in the mid 1960s, rock musicians began to challenge the standard radio formula of the three minute pop song to venture on experiments in sound and song-writing which would soon blossom into the musical adventures of psychedelia and, later, progressive rock. This is where the terminological imbroglio begins, as the musical nature of the genre is almost per definition anathema to classification. As Will Romano writes in his *Illustrated History* of the genre:

Historically, progressive rock had been forged from the musical fires lit by American blues and R&B pioneers as well the major proponents of the 1960s' psychedelic movement. In part, progressive rock was a natural outgrowth of flower power and hippie/utopian sensibilities. [...] With a classicist's sense of precision and ambition, "the progressives" gave shape to amorphous forms of drug-addled and hallucinogen-inspired rock music and [...] approached rock music as an art form while developing along a completely different evolutionary musical branch (and occupying a different head space). (2010, 1)

Taking cues from classical forms and compositional techniques, rock musicians put forth increasingly accomplished works that displayed an artistic sensibility, complexity, and musical virtuosity that had been theretofore unknown in pop and rock. Within compositions grand in scope and length, they used odd time signatures and polyrhythms as well as 'exotic' instruments and the latest in synthesizer and studio technology. Their lyrical visions plundered the realms of history, mythology, fantasy, science fiction, utopian, and dystopian literature. In a word, these musicians were *progressive*. They also sounded wildly different from one another. Thus – at the danger of egregious reductionism – King Crimson were heavy and symphonic with a dark, jazzy vengeance, while Genesis turned more to the pastoral, lyrical, and surreal, ELP focused on individual virtuosity and showmanship, Yes were esoteric and symphonic, Jethro Tull hard-rocking

and folky, Gentle Giant incorporated complex counterpoint vocal arrangements from baroque and modern chamber music, and the former psychedelic pioneers Pink Floyd became known as visionaries and virtuosos of the studio.

With band styles so widely diverging, the existence of the genre itself may be called into question. Sociologically, there is little contention that what became known as prog rock sprang primarily from an English upper middle class and art school environment and recruited the mass of its audience “from a post-hippie extension of the counterculture” (Macan 1997, 13). Musically, the lines are less clear. Like Romano, Edward Macan singles out “an intimate relationship between progressive rock and classical music” (1997, 12), which musically manifested itself in “a style that sought to expand the boundaries of rock on both a stylistic basis (via the use of longer and more involved structures) and on a conceptual basis (via the treatment of epic subject matters), mainly through the appropriation of elements associated with classical music” (1997, 12, 27). Yet, the classical influence, while initially central, is arguably but one ingredient among many in a musical dish that evolved and diversified over time. Thus, Andreas Hinners rightly points out that progressive rock is not characterized by a unified style, but rather by an eclectic multitude of various musical concepts and sound aesthetics that may well exclude one another (cf. Hinners 2005, 18). Deena Weinstein (2002) asserts that progrock is “less than a genre and a lot more than one, too [...] because its defining feature is not a set of concrete sonic elements, such as particular rhythms or instrumentation,” but rather “a conceptual trope,” namely “the appropriation of nonpopular musical forms” (91). Originally, these were European classical music, jazz, and avant-garde music, but over time, developments culminated in the principal availability of musical styles across historical and geographical borders, a Neverland of categories [“Niemandland der Kategorien”] that characterizes the overall musical map of progressive in the present (Hinners 2005, 70–71).

Stepping into the limelight towards the end of the 1990s, Pain of Salvation provide a perfect example. Even their first four albums feature a highly diversified blend of ‘traditional’ progressive metal with excursions into jazz, funk, folk, gothic rock, and hip-hop territory, incorporating acoustic elements of world music and the collage-like use of samples. Beginning with *BE*’s orchestra-supported foray into classical and Broadway musical idioms and *Scarsick*’s (2007) more straightforward songwriting, a somewhat heavier reliance on the hip-hop element and a more synthetic sound, the band has since continued expanding its musical vocabulary, radically evolving almost on an album-to-album basis. In this sense, even as the practice continually threatens to alienate parts of the audience, Pain of Salvation embody the progressive spirit of eclectic diversity

and evolution. As Romano puts it: “In theory, no barriers exist in progressive rock: at its best progressive rock is postmodernism run amok” (2010, 2).

What, then, one may ask, unites progressive bands and simultaneously separates them from your traditional contemporary rock, pop, or folk act? In Paul Stump’s words, ideologically, prog is primarily a matter of an “artistic idealism,” a “particular strain of ‘thinking’ rock music” (2010, ix), foregrounding “*musical expression of the imagination as the paradigm of the text*” (2010, ix, 6).⁴ Arguably, no sonic artifact better exemplifies this artistic spirit than the concept album. During the first flowering of prog, albums like the Moody Blues’ *Days of Future Passed* (1967), Jethro Tull’s *Thick as a Brick* (1972) and *A Passion Play* (1973), Genesis’ *The Lamb Lies Down on Broadway* (1974), and all of Pink Floyd’s from the *Dark Side of the Moon* (1973) up to *The Wall* (1979), were not only commercially successful, but count among the great artistic achievements of their creators. As such, though it is hardly exclusive to this style, these “high-profile albums, made the ‘concept album’ synonymous with progressive rock,” as it

allowed scope for narrative, for genre mixing, for instrumental development that echoed jazz and sonata forms, and for lyrical complexity that was not possible in shorter form or even in single extended tracks [...]. The full-blown concept album would expand on a theme over many tracks, and match this with musical and formal structures that advanced over the course of an album. The repetition of instrumental and lyrical conceits would offer an immediate coherence on first listen, only for other resonances to emerge on subsequent hearings. (Halliwell and Hegarty 2011, 65)

While some concepts are purely musical, many more are either written around a certain theme – e.g. absence, stardom, and the cynical music business in Pink Floyd’s *Wish You Were Here* – or even tell a story. Those that do the latter may be wholly original creations or adaptations, and of course, a good story usually deals with certain themes or broader questions as well. Subgenres like the rock opera further complicate classification. In this sense, it seems well-advised to speak of varying degrees of realization [“Verwirklichungsgraden”] of the concept album (see Halbscheffel 2013, 100).⁵ The only *conditio sine qua non*, it would

⁴ Classification is further complicated today by the fact that, more than 40 years after King Crimson practically inaugurated the genre with *In the Court of the Crimson King* (1969), many bands, particularly of the Neo- and Retro-Progrock varieties, are making music that, while still potentially challenging, complex and accomplished, is explicitly backwards-looking by following the style of the progenitors, and is thus anything but ‘progressive.’

⁵ Halbscheffel observes that the criteria of what makes a concept album are not carved in stone (2012, 259). Definitions may demand “only slight thematic unit” of individual songs “running consecutively as a means of conveying a narrative,” as does Allan F. Moore’s, or they may in-

seem, is the very existence of a concept, that is, the discernability of an overarching, unifying theme, often a story – realized through words, music, the use of samples and sound effects – that connects one song with all others. Beginning with The Beatles' *Sgt. Pepper's Lonely Hearts Club Band* (1967), extramusical elements such as the album artwork and the lyrics – which *Sgt. Pepper* set in print allegedly for the first time in pop music – were likewise utilized to immerse the audience into an at least ideally unified work of art. In its holistic delivery of aural, visual, and literal stimuli, the concept album thus hearkens back to classical program music, especially the symphonic poem, and expresses clear aspirations to the status of the Wagnerian *Gesamtkunstwerk* (cf. Halbscheffel 2012, 251; Stump 2010, 139).

In this endeavor, however, many musicologists paradoxically emphasize the heightened status of the lyrics only to consecutively relativize it again. In part, this is due to the generally contested relation between pop music and its words. Discounting ways of extramusical and nonverbal storytelling – such as the newspaper of Jethro Tull's *Thick as a Brick* or the photo essay accompanying Genesis' *The Lamb Lies Down on Broadway* – this is an issue of some importance for the study of audionarratives. In “Why do Songs Have Words?” Simon Frith cites various studies that indicate that, even in a culture as supposedly sympathetic to the spirit of critical reflection as the US counterculture of the 1960s, “most listeners had neither noticed nor understood the words of ‘Eve of Destruction’ or ‘The Universal Soldier’ and the minority who did [...] were not convinced by them” (1989, 98). To Frith, the sound of words thus takes precedence over their meaning, the *metteur* trumping the *auteur*. Conversely, Weinstein points out the lyrical artistry of the works of Roger Waters and simultaneously laments:

clude only such albums where “the subtraction, addition or alteration of specific musical moments in the whole detracts from the narrative,” as does Macan's (see Stump 2010, 139). In lieu of a definition, Halbscheffel suggests several key indicators. Among them are the telling of a story over the course of several songs, a certain centrality of ‘the text’ even as instrumental sections are allowed (excluding instrumental jazz), the importance of internal coherence and integrity, which does not allow for comfortable separation, creational origin within a band context, i.e., the identity of composer(s) and performers (discounting musicals and operas), and the existence of an overarching theme that is developed throughout (see 2012, 259–261). Depending on how highly one values thematic, narrative, and musical unity, coherence and development, song anthologies like Woody Guthrie's *Dust Bowl Ballads* (1940) or Frank Sinatra's *Come Fly With Me* (1958), which some call (forerunners of) concept albums, may not be counted. Conversely, rare albums with purely *musical* rather than *narrative* or *thematic* concepts, such as Mike Oldfield's largely instrumental *Tubular Bells* (1973) or Dream Theater's *Octavarium* (2005), where the eight tracks and artwork are intricately construed around the concept of the octave while lyrically treating disparate subjects in the songs, can still present a problem.

“Lyrics have never been much of a selling point of rock anyway. They’re ignored, misinterpreted, or misheard. When words are grasped, it is fragmentarily through phrases or a chorus rather than as the full lyrical text” (2002, 98). One may even go as far as to characterize the overall status of texts in rock and pop as functional poetry, or, worse yet, a necessary evil (see Halbscheffel 2013, 486). Referring specifically to concept albums, Halbscheffel finds that generally, musicians do not have a sense of mission or message [“Sendungsbewusstsein”], but instead use the text, story, or plot as an element to give form to the music (see Halbscheffel 2014). He further suggests that these issues really belong in literary studies rather than musicology. If this is indeed so, one can surely agree that few musico-literary forms have ever been at once so popular and utterly neglected by the field as has the concept album.

As to the notion, to paraphrase Mozart, that ‘poetry be but the obedient daughter to music’ – to which Halbscheffel’s contention is heir as much as Frith’s suggestion that the importance of words in pop songs lies more in their auratic than their semantic qualities – I must confess serious reservations as far as progressive rock and the concept album are concerned. Insofar as the issue is one of both the lyrics’ content and quality, it is true that prog rock has built a reputation for esoteric, cryptic, and downright nonsensical lyrics that may present forms of escapism into either the inward spaces of new-age spiritualism, or else the realms of science fiction and fantasy – complete with evil super-computers, flying castles, and unicorns. Yet such clichés hold true only at a surface level, at least as much of the genre’s defining work is concerned. In fact, many of progressive rock’s leading voices were not only keenly aware of the issues of their day, but actively used their music and lyrics to address them.⁶ Consequently, if the concept album can indeed be regarded as a *Gesamtkunstwerk* that represents simultaneously “the apotheosis of the album and the

6 So, while King Crimson’s lyricist Peter Sinfield may have been influenced by Romantic poets such as Byron and Tennyson when he wrote the lines to songs like “21st Century Schizoid Man,” and the superficially more fantastical “Epitaph” or “In the Court of the Crimson King,” he had his feet firmly planted in the sociopolitical issues of the day: “‘The whole album was quite political, because I am a political animal,’ says Sinfield. ‘We were living in very political times in ’67 and ’68, and the record was recorded in ’69, and we were all influenced by various things happening in the world, like Vietnam.’ ‘Every song Peter wrote about was about the generation gap, the Establishment, and how people in power were in control of other people’s lives,’ says McDonald. ‘As the record says, ‘An Observation by King Crimson.’ It’s observing what’s happening politically and socially” (qtd. in Romano 2010, 36). Jethro Tull’s Ian Anderson was moved by a similar social awareness: “‘When I sing the song ‘Aqualung’ on stage, I hope homelessness is something that doesn’t leave the forefront of my mind,’ says Anderson, who calls the song a ‘fleshed-out social documentary’” (qtd. in Romano 2010, 86).

pushing of its limits" (Halliwell and Hegarty 2011, 70), it stands to reason that this aspiration may be expected to extend to lyrics and narratives as well. After all, it is exactly the progressives' open 'high art' aspirations that the traditional blue collar/low brow school of rock criticism spearheaded by such critics as Lester Bangs often took offense to and opposed with charges of pretentiousness and the betrayal of rock's working-class allegiances. And if the music were truly, in Stump's phrase, "all that matters," then why all the fuzz about intricate artwork and printed lyrics? Is it just about offering additional selling points, or – to adopt a less cynical perspective – about opening up possibilities for "an immersion that engages the intellect as well as the senses" (Halliwell and Hegarty 2010, 69), or is there something else of substance at stake?

In a sense, these deliberations reflect a deeper problem that has plagued the study of pop music for a while, namely the question of what constitutes the musical text, and how "musical meanings [...] *constituted* in (extramusical) discourses [...] are also *constitutive* of such discourses" (Middleton 2000, 11). In dealing with these phenomena, a divide exists between traditional musicological approaches, which are uninterested in and usually unable to account for a lot of the extra-musical signs surrounding the musical text, and approaches from cultural studies, which arbitrarily focus on various related items ranging from fashion, social uses and practices, institutions of distribution, visual art, etc. – that is, on practically anything *but* the music itself. In the concept album, these issues come to a head, and *BE* is as dense and elusive a specimen of the form as has been written and recorded.

It is here that I stake my claim: Contrary to how little scholarly attention they have received, I contend that many of the best concept albums from the 1970s up to the present day both warrant and reward being taken seriously in form and content as complex multimedial narratives where music, visual art, literature, and performance combine into a whole that – as the saying goes – is larger than the sum of its parts. As has been shown, however, musicologists tend to see lyrics and story as primarily form-providing subordinates to the 'musical text,' doubting an authorial consciousness of message that extends beyond the music, whereas the representatives of literary and cultural studies have hardly noticed the concept album as a form worthy of attention, nor do they usually have the musicological expertise needed. As a consequence, both perspectives fall short of grasping the phenomenon in its full complexity, both with regard to popular music in general and concept albums in particular. While, for the re-

mainder of this essay, I will primarily argue the literary side of things, what is truly needed is a systematic holistic approach.⁷

2. Conceptual Mythopoeisis and the Many Voices of *BE*

Returning to *BE*, it is apparent even from its extramusical signifiers that the album, which was originally written to be performed by the band and a nine-piece orchestra, is nothing if not ambitious. The CD artwork alone already features not only the lyrics and a series of about 60 photographs arranged in topical, essayistic manner to match the story, but also an introduction penned by Gildenl  w, to which the extended DVD booklet adds pictures of the stage show as well as an appendix including various lists of personal hypotheses, theories, key words, and concepts, and finally an extensive bibliography of fiction and nonfiction works that served as inspiration.⁸ In his introduction “Layers of Creational Saw Dust,” Gildenl  w describes *BE* as the culmination point of several ideas he had been occupied with since 1996. The first concept, which one might assume grew from his own ongoing experience of creating art, hinged on the notion that “all creation comes from an urge to understand oneself,” which *BE* expresses in “the idea that if God ever existed he might just have been as lost and seeking as we are – creating the world as an image of himself/herself just to simulate conditions that might tell him/her of his/her origins” (*BE* 24).

The second concept would not seem alien to anthropologists or scholars of myth such as Joseph Campbell, Claude L  vi-Strauss, or Ren   Girard: “[It] derived from the assumption that there is something hidden in our tales and myths of creation,” the impression of “glimpses of a deep pattern” which does not exhaust itself in surface similarities, but rather manifests itself in “values that go in phase” once “you take away language, semantics and imagine the situations as something more abstract” (*BE* 24). To account for this pattern, Gildenl  w of-

7 In this respect, Ole Petras’ (2011) ambitious conception of pop music as a rhizomatic phenomenon of multiple “signifying units” offering diverse, context-dependent potentials for creating meaning might prove a more inclusive way of looking at concept albums especially and pop in general than the vaguely defined dialogic approach Middleton sketches.

8 The lists’ contents range from fractals and game theory to notes on hyper-individualism, global warming, and a correlative account of human population growth and the development of reindeer population on St. Matthew’s Island, Alaska, as an example of overshooting a particular ecosystem’s carrying capacity.

fers two scientifically informed, yet explicitly *fictional* mythopoeic hypotheses. The first is the existence of a matrix, “a layer of creational saw dust” (*BE* 24), informing all life and taking different shapes according to language and cultural context. The second hypothesis played with is the notion of “extreme events” having taken place “before our ancestors were widely spread or had a language” and that that was passed on either genetically, as biological knowledge, or else performatively, by continual “wordless re-enactment” (*BE* 24).

BE bears the subtitle *Chinassiah*, combining ‘china’ and ‘messiah,’ and is subdivided into a Prologue and five parts into which the album’s 15 tracks are bracketed. Each part signifies a part of human history. After the prologue, the ceremonial “Deus Nova” is dominated by a deliberate and darkly resonant cello that creates a sense of suspense against the delicate melody of the oboe and the fragility of the accompanying piano arpeggios. It is a music of the dawn of time, and time seems to accelerate as hard-riffing electric guitars and drumming set in and a voice counts down the exponential increase of the world’s population. The short dialogue that follows relates how Animae’s quest “to understand the system of life” (*BE* 5) leads her to create the world, Imago, “as an image of myself,” forming humans as “a new way to be” (*BE* 5). In this, one finds reflected Jung’s characterization of the archetypal anima as a *factor* in the literal sense:

Man kann sie nicht machen, sondern sie ist immer das Apriori von Stimmungen, Reaktionen Impulsen [...]. Sie ist ein Lebendes aus sich, das uns leben macht; ein Leben hinter dem Bewußtsein, das nicht restlos diesem integriert werden kann, sondern aus dem letzteres im Gegenteil eher hervorgeht. (2001, 29–30)

[You cannot make her; rather, she is the a priori of moods, reactions and impulses [...]. She is something living of itself that makes us live, a life behind consciousness that cannot be completely integrated into it, but from which, in contrast, consciousness itself arises. – My translation]

Animae reflects: “And now I am many, so many. So much larger than ever I were. Yet, at the same time so much smaller and more vulnerable. They all carry shards of the whole. Together they become me” (*BE* 5). With its teleology driven by the imperative *nosce te ipsum*, the attainment of self-knowledge through creation, the cosmology of *BE* oddly resembles a kind of reverse gnosticism as described by Hans Jonas. As in gnosticism, the world and human beings contain sparks (here: shards) of the divine creator who “is hidden from all creatures” and is knowable only through “supranatural revelation and illumination,” that is, through the attainment of gnosis (Jonas 2001, 42–43). Contrary to gnosticism’s disdain for the material world, which casts the cosmos as “a vast prison whose innermost dungeon is the earth, the scene of man’s life” (*ibid.*) and ruled

over by malevolent archons whose goal it is to keep the alienated divine spark in humans from returning to its original source, here, the creator is as lost as his creations, nature no prison but a mirror. At the outset, *Animae's* expectations for *Imago* are thus positive: "I think they will teach me something..." (*BE* 5).

In another, Feuerbachian twist, humans consecutively multiply and in turn create religions in their own image. However, the same drive to understand oneself that inspires *Animae's* creation in humanity turns increasingly ravenous, the initial wonder at the marvels of the world giving way to the appropriative desire to possess and control them. This evolution is concisely depicted in "*Imago (Homines Partus)*." Kept in an acoustic folk setting and $\frac{3}{4}$ meter dominated by mandola, woodwinds, and 'tribal' percussion, the dance-inducing song evokes a scherzo or jig that provides a feeling of optimism and endless possibility as characteristic of the 'birth of man.' Lyrically, it envisions human evolution as a cycle of seasons, each associated with an emotional state or attitude, spring with awakening, innocence and joy, summer with restlessness and curiosity, autumn with ego, pride, and shamefulness, and winter with anger and bitterness (*BE* 5). The chorus initially expresses the joy of life and discovery itself, but eventually turns to totalizing, voracious appropriation and thus identifies what is perhaps the reason for shame and anger. The imperative which initially read "Take/teach me anywhere/anything as long as you take/teach me" is now "Give me of" and eventually "Give me *all* the breathing BE" (*BE* 5, my emphases).

The sound of rain segues into "*Pluvius Aestivus*," a delicate and peaceful instrumental for grand piano, strings, and woodwinds that creates at once the narrative sensation of the subtitle's "summer rain" falling and the dreamlike flow of time passing. By the point of "*Lilium Cruentus*," a song that mixes jazz and heavy metal with samples and rap-vocals, the narrative perspective has fully shifted to *Imago/man*. The song, which is composed of four "scenes" in different colors, essentially deals with the problem of theodicy. Encapsulated in the title metaphor of the 'bloodstained lily,' the experience of suffering, death, and the concomitant loss of innocence leads man to question his life "under the icon's weight" (*BE* 8). Desolate yet strangely hopeful, "*Nauticus*" then radically shifts gears again. Its slow, deliberate pace, spare percussion and minimalist blues instrumentation evoke a black spiritual, as does the sharp contrast between low, bass singing by the band and fragile, head voices in the chorus which calls out for God's help: "Save me, I'm drifting..." (*BE* 9).

The overall narrative gradually assumes an apocalyptic outlook as mankind begins to subjugate and drain the earth. As the planet slowly turns into "*Terra Sterilia*" (*BE* 14) and mankind keeps multiplying, *Animae's* shards "become shards of their own [...] pieces of pieces, impossible to put back together" (*BE* 13). If *Animae* as the source of life can be regarded as a sort of pan(en)theistic

conception of the world itself, it bears resemblance to James Lovelock's Gaia Theory from 1979, which conceives of the earth as a biological super-system keeping itself in homeostasis through feedback and constant adaptation to change. Yet, if, as Lovelock (2000, 6) claims, the basic criterion for life is a "decrease in entropy" and the concomitant evolution of higher, more complex structures and lifeforms, the latter-day world of *BE* too is that of the Swedes' debut, *Entropia* (1997): a world characterized by the Second Law of Thermodynamic's tendency towards the dissolution of all biological, psychological, and social systems. Like gnostic humans ensnared by the material seductions of the world, its inhabitants by their very choice of lifestyle are also "entropyple," as Gildenl w characterizes Western society on *Scarsick's* "Cribcaged."

As if the album's mythical-existentialist themes were not already enough to corroborate every prejudice that exists about progressive rock, the concept is rounded off by the incorporation of "sociopolitical notions," that have been a part of Gildenl w's mental life⁹ and art at least since *Entropia* and *One Hour by the Concrete Lake* (1998), which dealt with such serious subjects as war, nuclear waste disposal and human displacement. Four years before subprime lending and wantonly negligent financing plunged the global markets into a deep crisis, *BE* offers a devastating (if hardly subtle) critique of capitalist ideology. The latter comes in the shape of several allegorical figures, particularly a certain Mr. Money, who is introduced in "Dea Pecuniae." The piece is segued into by way of a short audio drama (Track 6, 3:44–4:59). Set in a car, one hears the noise of other automobiles speed by. In the 'background,' the radio broadcasts a recorded interview wherein Mr. Money discusses hibernation technology, all the while he tries to woo a woman, Sandra, in the present. His dialogue smacks of hyperinflated misogyny and purposefully bad sexual innuendo, such as his suggestion that Sandra might get to drive, provided she proves apt at "handling the stick" (Track 6, 4:27) of the *automatic* car. Obviously, Mr. Money sees little more than an opportunity for sexual gratification in Sandra, whom he wrongly calls Cindy. He cares more about his Bentley ("the love of my life," Track 6, 3:52) – signalled by the sound cue of 'roaring engine' – than the woman. Having offended Sandra to the point of leaving, he appeases her by excusing his behavior as "a joke" that, however, only serves to reaffirm his machismo in a final punchline: "I mean of course I was joking! I would *never* let you drive my car" (Track 6, 4:52–4:59).

⁹ There is more than a little of the activist in Gildenl w, a former vegetarian. He boycotted playing in the USA for years to protest the Bush administration's infringement on personal data at airports, and the fanclub magazine *Machinah* offered a regular column humorously titled "Danielic Solutions to Global Dysfunction."

The suspiciously sensual and laid-back opening baseline of “Dea Pecunia” sonically continues along this storyline as Mr. Money serenades another woman, the likewise allegorically named Miss Mediocrity. The lushly orchestrated three-movement mini-musical is pure excess at ten minutes, betraying its initial blues with increasingly orgiastic bombast, as the song turns into a duet between Mr. Money and the eponymous goddess of money (Cecilia Ringkvist) herself, and then, after a brief moment of potential reflection is thwarted, ‘climaxes’ into a grandiose finale straight out of a Broadway musical. Vocally, Gildenl w pulls out all the stops as he explores the five-octave range of his natural baritone and switches registers from the seductive to the deceptively vulnerable to the snide and cynical: with his “winning team” composed of “Me, Myself and I,” Mr. Money sardonically proclaims: “I could have bought a Third World country with the riches that I’ve spent. But hey all modern economics claim that I deserved every single cent” (BE 11). In the final movement, the listener is then addressed directly, which reveals at once the mindlessness of western hyper-individualism and all the cynicism capitalist rationality is capable of:

So I raise my glass to all of you who really believe that I get paid for my big responsibility. To all of you who suck it up and pay my debts. To all of you who think that my lifestyle does not affect the environment or the poverty. Well, maybe not more than marginally anyway. [...] Here’s to you.... (BE 11)

The song thus provides at once a scathing character-portrait of Mr. Money and modern capitalism as such, using satire to attack justifications of managers’ hyper-inflated wages or the notion of public bailouts for companies deemed ‘too big to fail,’ protecting them from the negative consequences of the kind of high risk capitalism they themselves have unleashed.

Aurally, “Dea Pecunia” also serves as a good example of how the overall album is held together by the use of samples, fades, and blending effects, and the consistent orchestrated sound. Another important unifying factor is the reprise of various themes at later instances. Thus, “Nauticus” chorus is taken up again in “Diffidentia,” the “Deus Nova” riff and melody resurface in the highly complex, tempo- and time-signature changing “Nihil Morari,” and “Imago” is reprised at the very end of the album. What is musically remarkable in this is that band and orchestra not only blend well, the compositions leave space for both to breathe and assert their respective voices. Gildenl w’s double role as both *metteur* and *auteur* is pivotal. With regard to the orchestra though, the stated goal was to avoid “doing a Metallica,” that is, simply adding an orchestra to band-oriented music “to make it more impressive. I wanted the orchestra to play a crucial part in the music and have a key function in the musical and compositional

structure" (*BE* DVD Commentary, 00:17:50 – 00:18:20). Narratively, this function seems at least in part to be that of representing forces on a cosmic scale. The 'Orchestra of Eternity' takes the role of time passing, of worlds coming into being or ceasing to be – in a word, of *the sublime* – whereas the band may be associated more closely with human experience.¹⁰

Thus, the character of Mr. Money is encountered again in "Iter Impius," after the 'end of the world.' Waking up from cryogenic hibernation, he experiences first-hand the effects of humanity's exploitation of the earth, finding himself the last man on a devastated planet, "at the top of every hierarchy," yet only a "ruler of ruin" (*BE* 16). Speaking of voices, however, it is Gildenlöw's earlier, 'Swiftian' gesture of addressing the audience from the point of view of a character that they cannot identify with (cf. *BE* 26) that calls attention to what is perhaps the most intriguing feature of *BE*, namely its way of including the audience in its artistic design: most of the voice actors, whom we hear reading fictional radio reports of global catastrophes and play such roles as Mr. Money, Miss Mediocrity, as well as three-fold *Animae*, are friends or fans of the band. The most radical testament of this inclusive practice is the harrowingly intimate – or, to some, "shamefully voyeuristic" (Anderson) – pastorally orchestrated "Vocari Dei." The band describes the creation of this song as follows:

During a few weeks in the indian summer of 2003, the subscribers to the Pain of Salvation newsletter [...] were given the chance to participate in "BE" by calling to God's answering machine. The rules were simple – do whatever you feel like, but do it full-heartedly. The feedback was amazing. Hundreds of people spilled their guts, laughed, cried, shouted, cursed and thanked, asked for help and forgiveness. The listening process was a tumbling ride through a wide spectra of emotions, both beautiful and frightening, and it was very hard to pick the handful that eventually made it to the album. (*BE* 19)

Lyrically, the messages primarily circle around the same issues of theodicy touched upon in other songs: grateful assertions of the beauty of life and human connections are radically juxtaposed with confessions of doubt and despair at the realities of suffering and evil in the face of historical events such as 9/11. Most lingering, perhaps, is the utter regret of the penultimate message "I think this time, we have really screwed things up and I am so, so sorry," followed by another caller's plea for help: "I need you now. I need you" (*BE* CD, Track 8 3:32–3:50).

¹⁰ A notable exception to either is the use of a church organ, the *vox humana*, featured in the sample-laden and requiem-like "Omni (Permanere?)."

With followers of the band from the US, Sweden, Mexico, Greece, Japan and other countries “bringing their own selves into the realms of [the band’s] music” (*BE* 19) we have touched upon what I think may actually be the hidden core of progressive rock music as a whole. Just as it is eclectically ‘intermusical,’ this core is likewise fundamentally intertextual and dialogical. In “Vocari Dei,” listeners become creators and creators listeners as we enter a soundscape where the layers between the fictional world of the narrative collapses with the real-world expression of personal experience. Gildenlöv and pianist Frederik Hermansson confess that listening to the messages was “thrilling” as well as “devastating” and “very heartbreaking at times” (DVD Commentary 00:34:50 – 00:35:10). Somewhat like *Animae*’s creation in the album, the creational process involved in this track challenged the capacity of the band to control it, not only when confronted with callers speaking Greek or Japanese.

3. Conclusion

By necessity, this analysis of the *BE* project remains unfinished. The discussion of storylines, music, words and extramusical themes and contents could be extended indefinitely, and that is without touching upon the album’s artwork or the performative aspects of the stage production. In its incompleteness, the analysis shares a common fate with its object: part of Gildenlöv’s original dialogic vision of passing *BE* on to the fans was the creation of an online space for “facts, downloads, discussions and all that feeds the mind and expands the *BE* universe.”¹¹ A decade later, the website still exists, yet the project never materialized.

In sum, what emerges from this cursory discussion of *BE*’s pertinent features, to me, are at least three potentialities of ‘reading,’ or rather ‘listening’ to it: first, as a musically set, self-reflexive meta-myth about origins and artistic creation as a form of self-understanding; second, as an apocalyptic vision the ultimate import of which is political, its professed “mission” being manifest in the imperative: “Change the world!” (*BE* DVD 47). Third and finally, *BE*’s most radical and encompassing aspect lies in its multiplicity of voices, real and fictional, persons and personae, musical and literary. It is finally a realization both of linguistic and Bakhtinian *heteroglossia*, a network “of discursive conventions resulting from never-ending, historically contingent exchanges” which creates “a kind of giant intertextuality, operating both between utterances, texts, styles,

11 See <http://www.painofsalvation.com/be/more.htm>.

genres, and social groups, and within individual examples of each" (Middleton 2001, 13).

It has been suggested that progressive rock originally arose out of a post-World War II sensibility that "it [was] time we open[ed] up conversations about things that can be really important to us. [...] It wasn't a goal: I think it was a conversation" (John Lodge, qtd. in Romano 2010, 3). Regardless of whether one enjoys its music or is intrigued by the story and the questions it raises, from this dialogic perspective, *BE* is truly a progressive album. To judge it "pretentious" or "overwrought" (Anderson) is to underestimate how fundamentally the reader/listener is by design part of the album's musical DNA – and, by extension, of the concept form and the progressive genre in general: to get something out of it, one has to show the conscious, sustained engagement of an open heart and mind. And thus, the final musical statement of *BE*, "Martius/Nauticus II," ends with the sci-fi vision of the probe Nauticus, containing all the knowledge and artistry of mankind, on its journey into the void of space. The final drums of the joyful "Imago"-reprise explode in another 'big bang.' Nauticus crosses the line – "an eternity at the blink of an eye" (*BE* 27), and the circle of birth begins anew. Breathing. A mind awakes. A heart beats. A voice calls out in the silence: "I am."

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Sound Art

Elke Huwiler

A Narratology of Audio Art: Telling Stories by Sound¹

1. Introduction

Radio Drama, or *Hörspiel* in German, has developed in various directions throughout the almost 100 years of its existence.² Depending on the country and the ideas of the producers at the radio stations in charge, radio drama was shaped and perceived differently and even within one country different conceptions of this art form emerged throughout its history.³ While at the beginning of its development radio drama was partially granted the status of an acoustic art form in its own right especially in Germany, most of the countries in which radio drama became an artistically recognized form shared the idea that radio drama was a *literary* art form. Within this framework, the word had to be the most important feature, and the technical side of the medium had to be concealed as much as possible so that it would not ‘distract’ the audience from the story being told or remind listeners of the production process behind the piece of art. In German radio drama, emphasis was laid on the notion that this art form was a form of prose literature, whereas in English-speaking countries, there was a stronger focus on radio drama as a dramatic literary form. Due to this development, radio drama research for a long time assumed that analytical tools for radio drama pieces had to be developed against the background of literary-analytical methods, and that the word had to be given priority status within this analytical framework. Radio drama was seen as a ‘theatre for the blind,’ which emphasised more the shortcomings

¹ This article expands on previous research (see Huwiler 2005a, 2005b, 2006, 2008).

² Radio drama research usually mentions Richard Hughes’ *A Comedy of Danger* as the first radio play (radio drama) ever made, broadcast on 15 January 1924 by the BBC. Yet, this assumption rests on the notion that adaptations are not real radio plays (as there were radio drama adaptations prior to *A Comedy of Danger*), as well as on the fact that due to its development, the English radio drama has gained widespread publicity, whereas in other countries radio plays have never achieved any high profile artistic status. In the Netherlands, the first radio play – *Nieuw-jaars-wensch van de Amateurs Thomasvaer en Pieternel* by Willem Vogt, broadcast by PCGG – was already broadcast twelve days prior to *A Comedy of Danger*. For details, see Huwiler (2005a, 90–91).

³ See Huwiler (2005a, 90–105).

than the strengths of the medium and equated it with a literary form in another medium.⁴

However, in the production of radio drama, the notion that the art form is a *literary* one has been abandoned during the last decades, and nowadays it is common for producers to include numerous features in the production of a radio play, e.g., noises or music, but also technical features like cut or electro-acoustic manipulation. It is no longer taken for granted that the story has to be told merely through words. The development of German-speaking audio drama productions in recent years shows a vast variety of different styles and representational forms. Experiments with new formats in particular, like interactive radio plays or radio play performances, show that this art form can no longer be defined as purely literary, but must be seen as an independent art form that is still developing and in search for new ways of expression.

In general, two tendencies can be observed in most (German-speaking) audio drama productions of the last decades. First: most of them can be defined as narrative, yet they tell stories not merely with words, but by using all possible acoustic features as storytelling devices. And second: there is an increasing emphasis on the representational devices involved in the narrating process in acoustic storytelling. The *act* of storytelling is foregrounded by means of all kinds of different technologies and forms of expression, as opposed to imitating 'reality' and relying on language. Storytelling by sound is no longer based on the spoken word, imitating literature in an oral manner, but it integrates all aural and technical features that the medium affords. Moreover, as mentioned above, media artists explore new ways of expression: the interactive radio drama, once described by Bertolt Brecht as a radio drama format to strive for but utopian (Brecht 1993, 17), has become technologically possible, and live radio drama performances are becoming more and more common in German-speaking radio drama productions.

In this article, I will present a model for radio drama analysis which starts out from the premise that radio drama is an art form in its own right and which looks at the different features of radio drama as being all potentially of

⁴ It has indeed always been quite common to define radio drama through its limitations rather than its intrinsic features. Tim Crook elaborates on the incorrectness of the blindness concept: "Notions of radio's 'blindness' [...] need to be abandoned as a gesture of intellectual and philosophical insecurity. Radio's imaginative spectacle presents a powerful dynamic which is rarely prioritised by alternative electronic media. By giving the listener the opportunity to create an individual filmic narrative and experience through the imaginative spectacle the listener becomes an active participant and 'dramaturgist' in the process of communication and listening. This participation is physical, intellectual and emotional" (Crook 1999, 66).

equal importance for the unfolding of a story. Moreover, I will describe various possible radio or audio drama formats and elaborate on their narrative potential.

2. Analysis of Radio Drama: Narratology and Semiotics

For a while now, narratology has widened its scope away from the narrow definition of narrative as a piece of literary prose with a narrator⁵ and has taken into consideration as new materials to analyse not only other literary genres (like drama and poetry), but also other media (film or theatre), other disciplinary fields (like psychology or history), as well as other theoretical angles: “The phenomenon of narrative has been exploded in many terms: existential, cognitive, aesthetic, sociological, and technical” (Ryan 2004, 2). When analysing a piece of radio drama in narratological terms, the focus lies on analysing an artistic product in a specific medium, which therefore employs a wide range of audible and technical features.⁶ However, new forms of aural storytelling have emerged which challenge the merely technical approach of describing audio drama even in narratological terms. Therefore, I will discuss different ways of approaching audio drama from a narratological perspective later in this article.

In media studies in general, a narratological approach has been applied for some time, particularly to film.⁷ Camera angles, lighting and framing are categories as important as setting, gesture and dialogue when it comes to analysing what is being told (story) and how it is being told (discourse). There is no reason why such technical features should not be as important in the analysis of radio pieces, since here the audience’s understanding of what is told is also influenced by elements like acoustic manipulation, mixing and cutting. Moreover, these acoustic and technological features may be as important to the shaping of the radio piece as is the spoken word. Therefore, a narratological methodological model for analysing audio drama must include special terminology for describing the medium-specific features of this art form, and this can be found in semiotics. In a printed literary work, narratological meaning is derived from the sign system of language. In a radio piece, there are other sign systems beside language that can also convey meaning to the audience. We must devise terms

⁵ As in the work of Gérard Genette; see Rimmon-Kenan (1976).

⁶ The following part of this article is a shortened version of Huwiler (2005b), 50–56.

⁷ See, for example, Chatman (1978) and Bordwell (2004).

for those parts of what we hear in radio drama that actually tell the story. A comprehensive analytical model to be applied to all kinds of radio pieces, non-narrative or narrative ones, was developed by Götz Schmedes in his excellent study of the semiotics of radio drama (Schmedes 2002).⁸

Language is of course the most complex of sign systems to generate narrative meaning in a radio piece: “It seems clear that of all semiotic codes language is the best suited to storytelling” (Ryan 2004, 10). However, to create narrative coherence, other sign systems can be functional as well: “While it may be true that only language can express the causal relations that hold narrative scripts together, this does not mean that a text needs to represent these relations explicitly to be interpreted as narrative” (Ryan 2004, 11). Other sign systems that can create narrative meaning in a radio piece are *voice*, *music*, *noise*, *fading*, *cutting*, *mixing*, *the (stereophonic) positioning of the signals*, *electro-acoustic manipulation*, *original sound (actuality)* and *silence*. The sign system of the *voice* is not to be equated with the sign system of language, although the two are closely connected. The voice as a sign system generating meaning in its own right covers a character’s tone of voice, which also includes his or her idiolect (individual linguistic choices and idiosyncrasies), as well as pronunciation (accents, dialects) and intonation (the structure of emphasizing words or so-called melodies within the sentences uttered). While in the history of radio drama, *noises* have often been used to denote a certain setting, and *music* to connote an atmosphere, these two sign systems can generate narrative meanings in much more varied ways, as my example at the end of this part of the chapter will show. The same goes for *cutting* and *fading*, which can do much more than to structure a radio piece or to denote changes in settings, story times or narrative levels. The *mixing* of a radio piece can also be seen as a sign system in its own right: it is responsible for the acoustic setting of the scenes, especially the volume of the different acoustic signals. The way in which the acoustic signals are arranged generates meaning, for example, when footsteps become louder, this means that a person moves closer to the centre of attention in the story. The *(stereophonic) positioning of the signals* is a sign system in its own right in stereophonic and binaural radio pieces. Here, too, the positioning of the signals can be used in a much more varied way than just to indicate the positions of people or objects in a realistic setting as either on the right or on the left of a scene. The *electro-acoustic manipulation* of a sound can be classified as a sign system when the manipulation is

⁸ Schmedes’ semiotics of radio drama draws on the theoretical work of Charles Sanders Peirce rather than on Ferdinand de Saussure’s semiotics, since de Saussure mainly describes the sign system of language, whereas for Schmedes’s and also in my analysis it is crucial that the ability to generate meaning is ascribed not only to verbal but also non-verbal signs.

detectable as such. In radio art, a lot of sounds are generated electro-acoustically – for example noises – but they nevertheless indicate ‘real’ sounds, which in turn belong to the sign system of noise. Only when the manipulation of the sound becomes noticeable, the generated narrative meaning can be attributed to the sign system of electro-acoustic manipulation. The same holds true for *original sound* or *actuality*, which must be overt to figure as a sign system in its own right in analysis. Original sound is mostly used to indicate a historical time or an actual place, which the audience recognises just by hearing a familiar sound. Finally, *silence* can also generate narrative meaning. Although it has a much more limited range of applicability than the other sign systems, it can be used very effectively, as my analysis of the following example will show.

In a radio piece in general, the listeners make sense of the narrative by relating the different acoustic signs they hear to specific narrative functions and by combining them into a coherent whole. As stressed above, the functions that the different sign systems can perform when the story unfolds are not to be regarded in isolation and as having fixed meanings. Rather, they must be considered as flexible storytelling devices that derive their meaning only during the unfolding of the story and from the coherence of the narrative which gradually emerges while it is presented. As David Bordwell cautions us in relation to film narrative, there must be no “atomistic conception of narrative devices” (Bordwell 2004, 204) since every acoustic sign can in principle assume any narrative function within a specific context: “Narrative structure and narration mobilize all sorts of material properties of the medium, in a wide variety of manners” (Bordwell 2004, 207).

A brief example of a radio drama analysis will show the applicability of the envisaged methodology: the German writer and media artist Dieter Kühn wrote his radio play *Das lullische Spiel* in 1975 (Kühn 1975) and was involved in the production process of the radio play. It is a story about the life of Raimundus Lullus or Ramon Lull, a Catalan monk who lived in the thirteenth century and who invented a number of eccentric logical techniques, among others the ‘lullic system,’ the so-called *Ars magna combinatoria*, in which he took words from different fields of knowledge and combined them in a systematic way. The old Ramon Lull recounts his life story in this stereophonically recorded play. His voice is always located at the centre of the acoustic space. When recalling an episode from his early life, Ramon is suddenly accompanied by a voice uttering (almost) the same words but coming from another position within the acoustic space. While in his account the old man uses verbs in the past tense, the other voice gives the same account using verbs in the present tense. This other voice grows louder while the old man’s voice grows softer, eventually fading out completely. It becomes clear that the second voice is that of the young Ramon, de-

scribing his life in the present tense. After a while, old Ramon's voice takes up the account again, starting to talk about another event in his life, until another voice located at a position different from those of the first two voices comes in to take over the story, this time representing Ramon at yet another stage of his life. In the course of the play, four different voices, located at four different positions in the acoustic space, are heard, representing Ramon at four separate stages of his life. Moreover, the accounts at these different stages are accompanied by specific musical pieces: medieval dance music for the episode when Ramon was very young, Gregorian chant for the time when he worked as a missionary. Thus, various sign systems are used to perform a specific narrative function: fading-in and fading-out, music, voice, and, above all, the positioning of the signals in the acoustic space, indicate the different episodes within the overall story told, the life of Ramon Lull. This illustrates that the positioning of signals within the acoustic space is not a feature with a fixed narrative function, either. Although throughout the history of radio drama production it has been used primarily to indicate the *spatial* positions of characters in a realistically represented setting, this example shows that it can be used for other purposes, too.

After listening to the play for some time, the audience has no problem in locating the different episodes of Ramon's life, mostly just by realising which acoustic positions the accounts come from. At the end of the play, the storytelling itself draws on our ability to differentiate between the story times: old Ramon Lull becomes ill and develops a fever. At this point, the audience realises that the positions of the signals do not stay static anymore but seem to wander around in the acoustic space: the voices and music, until then assigned to one specific position and therefore one story time, begin to be jumbled up with voices and music that belong to other episodes in the story. Also, words are cut off in the middle or put together with other words or fragments of words. All these processes indicate the increasing fever of old Ramon and his decreasing ability to recall the events of his life correctly. At the end of the play, a multitude of non-verbal sign systems tells the final events of the story: while the audience first hears the diegetic noises of waves and birds (the old man is lying on the deck of a ship), a non-diegetic 'white noise,' used purely as a storytelling device at the level of discourse, takes over and soon smothers the whole scene, representing the loosening of the sick man's grip on reality. At the end, the white noise cuts off, leaving total silence – another sign system that is used here to indicate the final event of the story: the old man's death.

3. Radio Drama: Broadcast, Performed Live and Distributed

As already stated, the radio drama format of the type of Kühn's *Lullisches Spiel* is nowadays only one form amongst others when it comes to aural storytelling. Audio drama can also be performed live in front of a theatre audience, be broadcast live on radio at the same time, and later brought out on CD for the public to buy and listen to in private whenever they want.⁹ Different representational forms and perception modes of audio drama are at stake here: 'representational form' in this context means a specific material or technical means of artistic expression; a live performance of an audio piece can therefore be seen as a specific artistic form of expression which differs from the radio transmission of the audio piece, which in turn differs from the public broadcast of a recorded audio piece in front of a live audience, as well as from a recorded audio piece played on a recording device rather than on radio. Therefore, narrative audio art can no longer be limited to radio drama alone although this representational form is probably still the one most well-known and certainly counts as the origin of the art form as such.

Andreas Ammer, one of the most successful German radio drama artists of the last two decades, works with audio art on the border-line between the 'classic' radio drama and other representational forms.¹⁰ His radio plays work with various acoustic features like music, noises and language, and they can always be defined as narrative: they tell stories, yet not merely with words, but by using all their possible acoustic characteristics as storytelling devices. Moreover, Ammer's audio plays are performed live on stage and in front of an audience, recorded, simultaneously broadcast and later brought out on CD. Since these performances are always produced in cooperation with a radio station, the acoustic art works are still called *radio* plays. The performances themselves are called *audio* performances, although of course the audience sees the performance: they see the actors who give their voices to the characters of the play, the musicians and sound artists, who play the music and provide the sound material in general, as well as the 'conductor' or director of the play, who coordinates the course of the play and gives cues. In the live performance, the bodily present performers add another sensory data layer to the acoustic one. Basically, three different representational forms of

⁹ This part of the article draws on Huwiler (2006).

¹⁰ Among his most famous radio plays are *Radio Inferno* (Ammer 1993), *Apocalypse Live* (Ammer 1995), *Odysseus 7* (Ammer 1998) and *Crashing Aeroplanes* (Ammer 2002).

audio drama can be identified here: the live performance, ‘live’ broadcasting¹¹ and the recorded sound piece. While the broadcast and electro-acoustic recordings address only one’s auditory sense, live-performances address one’s visual *and* auditory (sometimes also olfactory or tactile¹²) senses (see Ryan 2004, 19). Still, in all three different representational forms of radio drama, the basic type of sensory data is *sound material*. What are the main characteristics of these new representational formats with regard to the storytelling?

At the beginning of its development, radio drama used to be ‘live’ since recording devices were not used until the 1940s (Crisell 2002, 61–62; Würffel 1978, 22). Radio plays were usually broadcast directly, and the actors in the studio often even wore theatrical costumes, which was “intended to help them enter into the spirit of the play despite the absence of spectators” (Crisell 2002, 21).¹³ Although the technological possibility of recording radio plays was available in the early days of radio, it was only in the 1940s that it became a standard procedure to record and edit material before broadcasting.¹⁴ One essential difference between the ‘live’ radio drama productions of the 1920s and Ammer’s ‘live’ broadcasts is that in the 1920s this technique was used because of a lack of recording devices, while in the case of Ammer’s ‘live’ broadcasts the ‘live-ness’ is the result of a conscious choice of the artist not to work with established recording and studio processing techniques in radio drama broadcasting. This choice is also integrated in the production and distribution of the recordings, since the product sold here is the (audio-)recorded live performance that has not been reworked in a studio. In the live performance itself, the decision to use this particular cultural institution for the transmission of the audio play raises many questions surrounding the live performance of a primarily auditory art form. The tendency towards highlighting the act of storytelling while telling a story, which was described at the outset of this article, can be seen very well in this new representational variant of the art form. The story in a live performance is the story that is vocally presented by the actors and other people on

11 The term ‘live’ is put in quotation marks in this article whenever it denotes a representational practice that can only partly be called *live*. In the case of ‘live’ radio broadcasting, the audience is experiencing the transmission as live in a temporal dimension, but not in a spatial dimension.

12 Occasionally the haptic sense also plays a role, for example, when vibrations of a bass instrument are felt.

13 This demonstrates that in the beginning radio drama took the form of a (poor) imitation of stage drama rather than of an art form in its own right (see also Würffel 1978, 12).

14 Kurt Schwitters, for example, experimented with manipulations of sound material at a very early stage of sound production by using the technique of wax cylinders since the audiotape was not yet invented: “Using sound film, Schwitters edited and collaged his nonsense poems after he recorded them and before he pressed them into records” (Concannon 1990, 167).

stage. Everything that does not belong to this story has to be called nondiegetic. To elaborate on the question of the relation between story and representation in the radio drama formats under discussion, I will take a closer look at Ammer's *Lost and Found: Das Paradies*, which was performed in front of a live audience, simultaneously broadcast and later distributed on CD.¹⁵

In *Lost and Found: Das Paradies*, the story told is that of how Adam and Eve lost their place in the Garden of Eden and of the origin of Satan. In the live performance, the audience was confronted with a stage on which musicians were located in the background, the director of the play on the left, also having a variety of percussion devices at his disposal (like metallic pipes hanging from the ceiling on which he slammed with a metallic stick), and the three performers speaking the parts of Adam, Satan and Eve in the front, all three of them having a microphone before them. The play as such consists of accounts of Eve, Adam and Satan, who partly read passages from Milton's epic poem (in English and German), but also make comments on it, summarize the 'plot' and repeat certain passages several times. Furthermore, there is an almost continual musical accompaniment, and the music – blues, flute music and above all pop music – also often dominates the play. There is also singing from time to time, and during one scene in which the victory of Satan is celebrated, noise from metallic percussion devices dominates the sound scene for several minutes. As an overall characterization of the presented sound material one can say that the story is *evoked* by this mixture of musical styles, rhetorical features and acoustic sign systems, rather than *told* in the classic, language-based meaning of the word or presented dramatically by actors enacting the characters of the story, thereby imitating 'reality.'

The story told is the one of Satan, Adam and Eve, yet the way this story was presented in the live performance constantly foregrounded representational, non-diegetic features, thus precisely not striving "to elide the act of representing [...] so as to foreground [the diegesis]" (Wurtzler 2002, 88). On the contrary, the performance deliberately displayed representational techniques by constantly using non-diegetic music, noises as well as language material. This was done not only for the live performance, but also for the broadcast 'live' radio play and the recorded audio play, and the same can be found in all of Ammer's radio plays which were performed live. In his work on the concept of liveness, Philip Auslander states that live performance and mediatized representational techniques should not be seen as opposites, and he emphasizes "the mutual dependence of the live and the mediatized" (Auslander 11). In the different repre-

15 The performance took place at the *Münchner Haus der Kunst* on 8 October 2004.

sentational techniques and practices of the radio plays under discussion, this interdependence is very noticeable. The live performances of Ammer can be defined as highly mediatized¹⁶ not only because they use electric amplification, but also due to their adaptation of mixing techniques that were elaborated for working on radio plays in the studio. The conductor on stage directs the different sound providers in a way that imitates fade-ins and fade-outs, cutting and mixing techniques. Moreover, in some of Ammer's performances, even *prerecorded* material is played during the performance.¹⁷ The live performance does not try to hide those similarities to the mediatized but stresses its dependence on mediatized techniques.¹⁸ Furthermore, allusions to the simultaneous status of the production as a live performance *and* a 'live' broadcast radio play (as well as a recorded one) are being made by the actors of the plays, as, for example, in Ammer's *Apocalypse live*, where a speaker says: "For all of you here, and out there at your loudspeakers, we have someone special for you now" (Ammer 1995).

The mediatized is constantly integrated into the live performance, and at the same time the representational character of the storytelling is foregrounded.¹⁹ As already stated, genre-mixing techniques and the use of a wide range of acoustic and technical devices for storytelling have become very common. Such techniques show a relationship with narrative material that does not imitate 'reality.' And this is precisely where the strength of acoustic storytelling lies: while in the beginnings of this art form the absence of the visual track was perceived as a shortcoming by radio drama theorists, developments in radio drama productions have shown that precisely by telling a story through the intrinsic features of the acoustic medium, and by accentuating these intrinsic medial fea-

¹⁶ While usually the *mediated* is essentially equated with the *recorded* and therefore denotes everything that is *not live* or, as Steve Wurtzler (1992, 89) has it, "the defining fact of the recorded is the absence of the live," Auslander's term 'mediatized' leaves space precisely for this *interdependence* between the live and the recorded. He employs the term 'mediatized' "to indicate that a particular cultural object is a product of the mass media or of media technology" (Auslander 1999, 5). Therefore, a live performance can also be called 'mediatized' when it is a product of the mass media or of media technology. This is the case with a live radio play performance, for example. Since Auslander's 'mediatized' per se denotes a possible interdependence of the live and the recorded, it is a more useful term to be employed in the present article.

¹⁷ Like, for example, a recording of the voice of the Pope in *Radio Inferno* (Ammer 1993).

¹⁸ This is already the case when the live performance is called a *radio* production.

¹⁹ This storytelling technique is, of course, also typical for a lot of 'postmodern' novels, and in my opinion it is also to be observed widely in filmic narration. See in this context Bordwell's discussion of the functions of filmic storytelling (Bordwell 2004).

tures, the art form has been able to establish itself as an independent one; independent from literary as well as filmic techniques.

As I already pointed out, the visual component of the live performance adds another layer to the representational technique: while the audiences of the 'live' radio broadcast and the recorded radio play on sound transmission devices are also continually reminded of the mediatized representational techniques through the extensive use of non-diegetic auditory features, the physically present audience at the live performance can, in addition to that, observe the actors and musicians *visually*. Since the actors do not imitate the characters of the play as physical characters, but only as vocally represented characters, they actually stress this representational act precisely by *not* imitating the whole bodily experience of the characters they give their voices to.²⁰ Furthermore, incidents that do not belong to the actual acoustic performance of the story underline the representative and non-diegetic dimension of everything that can be seen, but not heard. At the live performance of *Lost and Found: Das Paradies*, when an actor forgot his cue, he was reminded of it by the director walking up to him, while the director usually does not approach the actors during the play. And during a very loud scene, the actress vocally enacting Eve saw a crying girl in the audience, so she addressed her by gestures and tried to console her by indicating that she could soften Satan's loud and terrible howling by holding her hands onto her ears. As such, these visually perceived incidents, and above all their lack of consequence for the aurally transmitted story, indicate that the bodies of the actors in this case also function as a sort of a representational device that does not "strive to elide the act of representing" (Wurtzler 88) but rather underlines it. The representational acting becomes therefore a kind of *event* in itself; however, it does not point to the story that is told, but to the *way* it is told. Hence, in the case of an audio play that is performed live, the primary source of interest is the *making of an event* out of the mediatized representational practice. Therefore, this new radio drama format with its potential for radical invention as is embodied in the visual staging of an auditory narrative reinforces in a unique way the already existing tendency in auditory storytelling art to emphasize representational techniques and to foreground the *act* of storytelling. Another tendency which widens the scope of aural narrative storytelling is the involvement of the audience in the storytelling process in interactive radio plays. Here, the question also is: what implications does this new representational technique have for narratology?

²⁰ In avant-garde theatre, this technique has been used for quite a long time. See, for example, Kirby (1984, 100), who refers to this kind of acting as "nonmatrixed representation."

4. Interactive Audio Plays

Interactive audio plays are based on the strategy that the audience is enabled to interfere with the presented play. The field is very wide since it includes, amongst other forms, locally fixed sound installations (at exhibitions, for example), pieces of the type of digital games, as well as plays distributed in the form of radio broadcasts during which the audience can interfere by phoning in. In the first case, there is often no narrative involved in the piece, and therefore these kinds of installations will not be further discussed in this article.

One example of an interactive radio play is the detective series *Der Ohrenzeuge* (*The Earwitness*), which was broadcast on Radio Fritz between 1993 and 2005.²¹ Here, a fictitious detective or detective team describes unsolved mystery cases, and on the basis of the descriptions given, listeners can call the radio station and give clues to the detectives as to how they should act and what they could do next to solve the case. However, the audience's influence on the plot itself is not big, as Vowinckel (1995, 100) points out: "Das interaktive Moment ist stark beschränkt, da der Reporter durch seine Antworten die Hörer lenkt und ihnen mitunter den richtigen Tip mehr oder weniger in den Mund legt. Die Geschichte liegt im Grunde fest, es bleibt dem Hörer nur überlassen, sie zu erraten" [The interactive moment is heavily restricted, since the reporter guides the listeners with his responses, placing the right clues more or less directly in their mouths. The story is basically fixed; the only thing the listener can do is guess at it; my translation]. So, while the story is fixed, it is its representation which depends on the interactive moment. The interfering listeners can actually influence the sequence of the different parts of the story from time to time, and thus they can take part in the storytelling to a certain degree, or at least they believe they can take part in it. Here, too, it is most of all the discourse side which this new interactive moment has an influence on; the story itself remains unaltered by the intervention of the audience. Nevertheless, the audience's involvement in the storytelling brings a whole new dimension to the narrative and has ramifications for how to describe it: the story is a fixed entity, yet the storytelling process itself, which is responsible, for example, for the sequence of the story parts, is not fixed. In this context, the concept of interactivity as described by Marie-Laure Ryan is useful. She describes the interactivity of computer games and focuses on the production side of such storytelling, where it is essential to have a fixed storyline while also creating the illusion that users are able to engage actively in the story: "The ideal top-down design should disguise itself as

21 See: <http://www.raumstation.de/?p=303> (31 January 2015). See also: Föllmer (2015, 167).

an emergent story, giving users both confidence that their efforts will be rewarded by a coherent narrative and the feeling of acting of their own free will, rather than being the puppets of a designer” (Ryan 2006, 99–100). Put differently, the story remains fixed whereas the storytelling can be affected by users in the case of computer games, or by listeners in the case of an interactive radio play. Again, the main implications for storytelling rest on the representational side of the story.

My final example extends the discussion of the narrative implications of new aural storytelling formats even further since here the audience’s altering of the story itself comes into focus: Uwe Mengel’s *2 ½ Millionen* (*2 ½ millions*) is an interactive live performance which was conducted several times in the later 1990s.²² The performance was a theatrical event where the audience was given the opportunity to talk to the protagonists, yet at the same time the event was recorded and the material was later reworked and made into a radio play, which was then broadcast. It can be argued that the performance was not an audio play in the strict sense. However, as in Ammer’s performances, the audience was present at the production process of an audio play, although in the case of *2 ½ Millionen* it was not broadcast simultaneously and did not remain unaltered. Nevertheless, it is worth having a look at this performance from a narratological perspective as the audience not only witnessed the production of a radio play but even participated in this production and thus truly helped shaping the story itself.

At the live performance, the audience was sitting opposite the actors, the latter representing characters of a plot which, at the time of the performance, had already happened and which was roughly known to the audience. In order to learn more about the motivations of the past actions (a murder and a suicide), the audience engaged in a dialogue with the actors and thus produced the dialogues which were recorded and later processed as part of the radio drama. The actors and the audience attending the live performance were no longer separated in this production. In a way, the audience also figured as protagonists, ‘co-telling’ the story by asking the actor-protagonists about the events that had happened before in the storyworld, about their motivations for their actions, their thoughts about the future, etc. In this sense, the audience was on the same level as the actors. However, aspects related to the vis-

²² The performance was conducted for the first time in Germany by the performance company *Mixed Blessing Theater e.V.* in collaboration with the radio stations SFB, RB, the Hebbel theatre Berlin and the *Künstlerhaus Bethanien* in May 1996. The original auditory material of three hours was shortened to one hour and produced by the SFB, RB and HR. It was broadcast on 24 September 1996.

ual, the interactive as well as to the improvisational, come into focus in this kind of live performance. The question is how these aspects can be theorized in narratological terms.

One essential difference between the radio play broadcast and the performed interactive play is that in the first case, the story presented is fixed, whereas in the latter case, it is open and, regarding its course, entirely dependent on the questions of the audience. Therefore, as in Ammer's performance of *Lost and Found: Das Paradies*, it is the narrative *process* of telling a story that is at the centre of attention. Unlike in the above-mentioned interactive radio play *Der Ohrenzeuge*, where the audience calling in is directed towards guessing the right steps for the reporter to take – i.e., steps that have already been 'scripted' before –, in *2 ½ Millionen*, the clues of the audience's questions are taken up by the actors and elaborated on in an impromptu manner. The unpredictable course of events, which is closely related to the characters' motivations and to the character traits they develop, emerge through the interrogation process and add a whole new dimension to the performance. Nina Tecklenburg (2014), who elaborates on narratology in modern performances, argues that in such examples narratological concepts must be revised. While in cognitive narratology, for example, the focus lies on how the audience perceives and makes sense of a story – how the narrative is "reconstructed in an ongoing and revisable readerly process" (Jahn 2005, 67) –, the focus here lies on actually constructing (and not re-constructing) the story. In general, such aspects of the performance are not seen as part of the narration until they are told later in retrospect, as Porter Abbott (2005, 341) points out: "Whether one agrees with this or not, art forms like role-playing games, theatrical improv, or 'happenings' would all appear to be as unmediated as life itself and therefore not examples of narration until rendered in retrospect." While the story stays fixed in immersive and interactive computer games, it is precisely new forms of interactive performances like *2 ½ Millionen* which show that a new concept of narrative is needed, as Tecklenburg emphasises, since even the live performance is clearly narrative. The difference lies in the different stories' closure and materiality: in the live performance, the audio piece is directly created in the very course of the listening and participating process itself, yet the story is no less relevant. Tecklenburg argues that, even when we look at interactive modes of storytelling, the focus of narrative theory seems to insist on a paradigm of the *product* versus a paradigm of the *process* (Tecklenburg 2014, 90). In *2 ½ Millionen*, a large part of the murder plot is already known and fixed when the interrogation of the protagonists through the audience begins. Nevertheless, what follows then is also a continuation of that plot, for example, when a protagonist, asked if she likes being interrogated by people, answers that these dialogues help her make sense of what happened

and in finding a bearable mode of living with the murder (Tecklenburg 2014, 96). In this sense, the plot and most of all the thoughts and reactions of the protagonists regarding the murder are extended and narrated further. The “diegetic reality” (Tecklenburg 2014, 97) is not closed and fixed, yet it is no less narrative in nature. The *process* of narrating is foregrounded here, something we already saw in Ammer’s performance. However, while in Ammer’s case, the audience witnesses the process of *storytelling* while the story remains unaltered, in Mengel’s case it is the *story* itself which is altered by the process of storytelling in which the audience participates.

5. Conclusion

The survey of the development of radio drama as an art form as well as of the various representational forms it evolved into show that audio drama is an extremely lively, flexible and open art form which cannot easily be defined. Experiments with, or inclusions of, representational forms based on sensory data other than auditory ones seem to be very fruitful when it comes to testing new ways of expression and playing with the boundaries of this art form and its medial possibilities. Certainly, the emphasis on the representational side of storytelling described here is only one tendency in audio drama development. There are other trends which have not been mentioned here, for example, the common practice of radio stations to adapt famous literary pieces and to broadcast them as literary radio plays, or performances which abandon the narrative element of audio drama and develop in the direction of sound art.²³ However, the tendency in narrative audio plays to negate the dramaturgical demands of the radio stations of the 1950s and to work with all kinds of auditory features as well as with other medial and sensory forms of expression is certainly a very strong and also prom-

²³ The first development has to do with the fact that due to the privatisation of radio broadcasting in the 1980s, radio drama was in danger of disappearing altogether since it did not seem to be popular enough. However, big adaptation projects like the one using Umberto Eco’s *The Name of the Rose* managed to keep the art form alive on radio. Radio stations usually produce these adaptations in collaboration with audio book publishing houses in order to keep the costs down. Non-narrative sound art tends to move towards pieces of experimental music and sound experiments (for an example, see Zoë Skoulding’s performance poetry, as described by Skoulding herself in this volume), which can no longer be called audio drama pieces, at least not in the English use of the term. In German, ‘Hörspiele’ is a more open term which also includes non-narrative audio pieces (for these developments, see Huwiler (2008, 281–282) and Bernaerts, this volume).

ising development that is also vital in helping audio drama claim its own originality as an art form.

As far as the narratological implications of this development are concerned, the discussion in this chapter shows that it is precisely this open and un-defined nature of the art form which continuously challenges notions of narrative and narrativity and the ways in which they can be defined in relation to auditory art forms. Narrative concepts must therefore constantly be reviewed when analysing narrative audio art, and new ways of approaching auditory art forms in narratological terms have proven to be very fruitful in this regard. They capture the richness of the development instead of pressing these art forms into a scheme. In a way, audio drama's constant development mirrors the development of narratology and can be instrumental when it comes to theorizing new ways of storytelling.

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Bartosz Lutostański

A Narratology of Radio Drama: Voice, Perspective, Space

Literary theory has seen narratology expanding considerably in the last decades. A vast field of literary studies as it is, we find it difficult to speak about one unified theory of narrative; the mere concept of narrative has been successively broadened to go beyond its ‘mother domain,’ literature, and to be applied to other literary modes and media (see Meister, Kindt and Schernus 2005, x–xii; Burzyńska 2004, 43–64; Lebkowska 2006, 181–215; Głowiński 2002, 149–159). Moreover, narratology’s terminological frameworks sometimes transcend art and are applied in the humanities more generally: psychology, philosophy, sociology, or law (Heinen and Sommer 2009, 1; Reut 2010; Rosner 2006; Trzebiński 2002; Bolecki and Nycz 2004). A host of prominent narratological scholars hold that there is no one narratology but narratologies as “structuralist theorizing about stories has evolved into a plurality of models for narrative analysis” (Herman 1999b, 1; see also Meister, Kindt and Schernus 2005, xiii). However, it might be argued that the multiplicity and diversity of narratology (narratologies) still fails to address some art forms that could also be categorised as ‘narrative arts.’ *Narratologies* (1999a) edited by David Herman, *A Companion to Narrative Theory* (2005) edited by James Phelan and Peter J. Rabinowitz, *Narratology beyond Literary Criticism* (2005) edited by Jan-Christoph Meister, and, especially, widely acclaimed *Narrative across Media* (2004a) and *Storyworlds across Media* (2014a), edited by, respectively, Marie-Laure Ryan and Marie-Laure Ryan with Jan-Noël Thon, overlook some of these specific types of narratives. I provisionally call them “audionarratives” inasmuch as their medium is not verbal or visual but exclusively sonic or sound-based.¹ In this contribution, I examine a specific audionarrative, radio drama, with narratology as my main theoretical framework. I therefore follow in the footsteps of a number of scholars such as Elke Huwiler, one of the pioneers of employing narratological tools to this medium, and semioticians Andrew Crisell and Jerzy Limon.

¹ In the “audionarrative genre” we might also include audiobooks. See, for example, Anežka Kuzmíčová’s research into this text type (also in this volume).

1. Theoretical Considerations

The fact that narratology is a *semiotic* discipline legitimises a narratological examination of radio drama. The argument is also predicated on the dominant sign system in this medium, verbal language, which, according to Ryan, is “the native tongue of narrative, its proper semiotic support” (2004b, 9). Other sign systems (voice, music, noise, silence, fading, cutting, mixing, the (stereophonic) positioning of the signals, electro-acoustic manipulation, and original sound (actuality) (Huwiler 2005, 51)) play an ancillary role and necessitate “textual pointing” or “anchorage,” defined by Roland Barthes as “fix[ing] the floating chain of signifieds [by means of verbal signs] in such a way as to counter the terror of uncertain signs” (qtd. in Crisell 1994, 48).² In addition, to agree with theses such as Roland Barthes’ or Claude Brémont’s from the 1960s, human artistic creation, including radio drama, is marked by narrative or a narrative-like dimension.³ Huwiler defines radio drama as “the acoustical art form that emerged from the development of the radio medium and in which *stories* are told or presented by means of electro-acoustically recorded and distributed sound material” (2005, 46, my italics; see Limon 2003, 145), and for Tim Crook radio drama is a “*storytelling genre*” (2001, 3, my italics). Indeed, when looked at from a general perspective, a (conventional) radio drama “tells a story” by means of various, more or less complex, acoustic techniques. The radio drama’s story is of narrative structure as it presents a series of events which are (chrono)logically and/or causally interosculated (see Abbott 2008, 13; see Meister, Kindt and Schernus 2005, xiii; see Ryan 2004b, 4). The narrative that effectively emerges from the complex storytelling process (see Herman 2009) can be divided into story and discourse, two fundamental narratological distinctions.

However, narratology speaks not of a binary opposition but a triad; the third element is *narrating*, defined by Gérard Genette as the act of “reproducing narrative action and, by extension, the whole of the real or fictional situation in which that action takes place” (1980, 27). The narrating, with its emphasis on the act of production and communication, seems to come to the foreground in

² On purpose I disregard here numerous experimental radio dramas that displace the centrality of language. I admit that non-verbal sign systems may not be ancillary but indeed central in specific audionarratives. The balancing between verbal and non-verbal sign systems is an intriguing question worth looking into in future.

³ I am aware that this claim has met with critical response (see, for example, Strawson 2008; Ryan 2004b). It is not the subject of this article to examine or prove (the degrees of) narrativity of specific art forms. As I go on to demonstrate, radio drama, at least its conventional realisation, is a narrative art form.

the context of radio drama. As Crisell contends, “radio, even when its programmes are prerecorded, seems to be a ‘present-tense’ medium, offering experiences whose outcome lies in an unknown future” and therefore “it seems to be an account of what is happening rather than a record of what *has* happened” (1994, 8; see also Ryan 2004b, 19). The narrating, in addition, makes the radio drama appear to be dynamic, direct and “intimate” (Crisell 1994, 11), short-lived and “evanescent” (Crisell 1994, 6). These qualities, arguably, significantly affect the “imaginative” of radio drama (Limon 2003, 150; Bachura 2012, 179). Moreover, the time-dependence is yet another narrative-related property insofar as narrative also develops *in time*: interrelations and interlacements between plot events evolve successively and progressively as they are being perceived, experienced and processed. This narrative structure of radio drama acquires meaning gradually, with every individual event, yet, akin to the Schleiermacherian wheel, can be comprehended only from the perspective of events already presented. Radio drama can therefore be conceived of as *narrative* par excellence.

The narrative of radio drama, unlike in other artistic forms we can think of in this context, e.g., theatre and film, is unique in its being sound-driven. This is to say, in radio “all the signs are auditory” (Crisell 1994, 42; Limon 2003, 150) and can be divided into speech, music, sounds and silence (see Huwiler 2005, 51). Yet their one-channelledness presupposes specific semantic resources and thus requires a specific terminological apparatus. The resources effect and affect the narrative structure of a given radio drama. Universal to all radio dramas as they are, their functions are particular and individual, differing from one drama to another due to specific properties of a recording device. The role of the device needs to be emphasised insofar as in radio play, like in film, a narrative represents “story events through the vision of an invisible or imaginary witness” (Bordwell 1985, 9; see Schlickers 2009, 243–244). This “witness” bears a functional resemblance to the extradiegetic narrator in fiction: “any event a narrative recounts is at a diegetic level immediately higher than the level at which the narrating act producing this narrative is placed” (Genette 1980, 228). Analogously, we can call the microphone an extradiegetic narrator or, to use Ivor Montagu’s concept from film theory, an “ideal observer” (Bordwell 1985, 10) with the caveat that in radio the entity does not observe but hears and hence must be rather christened an “ideal hearer.” What microphone in radio drama, camera in film and the extradiegetic narrator in literature have in common is that they establish frames: everything that characters say becomes a sort of meta-

language.⁴ The more languages there are, the more extensive the Bakhtinian plurality of meta-languages. The (more or less active) presence of a technical device makes the concept of frames even more pronounced. Finally, as radio is all about voice, the role of the microphone is far more important. It is *the* element of radio: critical and indispensable, world-creating and world-constituting.

2. Auditory Signs and their Narratological Implications

Radio's auditory signs have been divided into speech, music, sound and silence. Each of these semiotic codes is channelled through the microphone. It thus not only creates the fictional world of a radio drama but also potentially atomizes it by associations with narrative levels or characters, as will be demonstrated in the analysis below. Moreover, the microphone 'positions' various objects (signals) in space and affects their proxemic and kinesic properties, or the physical distances between the various characters and their movements relative to one another and to the listener, respectively. In order to address these issues, we need to hone narratological terminology to adjust it to the purely acoustic medium.

The first and foremost is focalization (see also the introduction to this volume). Since the microphone is considered as the 'hearer' or 'narrator' of the events, it might be argued that the 'hearing' or 'narration' is executed from a specific stance. As Manfred Jahn elucidates, "*Narration* is the telling of a story in a way that simultaneously respects the needs and enlists the co-operation of its audience; *focalization* is the submission of (potentially limitless) narrative information to a perspectival filter" (2007, 94). Useful in my analyses as it is, the concept of focalization seems odd when it is used in an acoustic, sound-only art form. Focalization, frequently defined as a specific "point of view," refers to sight and the act of vision. In radio dramas it seems more beneficial to employ parallel terminology for "a perspectival filter" with respect to other senses. The dominant sense in the medium in question is, of course, hearing. William Nelles, Jahn quotes, "has coined useful terms qualifying types of focalization by perception channels, yielding "ocularization" (sight), "auricularization" (sound), "gustativization" (taste), "olfactivization" (smell), and "tactivilization" (touch)" (2007, 99). Auricularization, with its various grammatical functions (auricular, auricu-

⁴ "A meta-language 'talks about' an object-language and transforms it into content by naming the object-language [...]," says Colin MacCabe (qtd. in Bordwell 1985, 18).

larize, auricularizer), seems most crucial in the examination to follow (see Schlickers 2009, 250).⁵

Another aspect in which the microphone is critical is the determination of space. Space, in radio drama theory, is understood as a “timeless and spaceless ‘setting of silence’” (Limon 160–162). In narrative theory, space was, until quite recently, blatantly overlooked. Most possibly, this has been caused by Aristotle’s concept of plot and its focus on time and time relations and the resultant dismissal of space. In the twentieth century, famous narratologists continued to omit space in their theories. A good case in point is Genette, who does not mention space in his writing at all, and Seymour Chatman, who claims in *Story and Discourse* that space is only used as background to “set the characters off” or as a Barthesian *effet de réel* (1980, 138–145). However, many theorists of narrative, such as David Herman, H. Porter Abbott and Michail Bakhtin, have worked to amend the current state of affairs (Herman 2002, 265–269). The first of these researchers offers some useful theoretical tools in his *Story Logic* (2002, 269–284). Yet, as with focalisation, the terminology is sight-derived. Melba Cuddy-Keane’s observations might therefore enhance our terminology by proposing concrete changes: *soundmark* instead of landmark for reference object and *soundscape* instead of landscape or region for concrete space of action (2005, 385; see Herman 2002, 277–278). Finally, instead of Herman’s “path,” which might be useful for our discussion, we might use an alternative term of route to denote the particular ways characters travel to “get from place to place” (Herman 2002, 278).⁶ These introductory theoretical discussions serve to “follow upon our efforts to emancipate our vocabulary from an excessive dependence on the visual” (Cuddy-Keane 2005, 385).

5 In her 2005 article, “Modernist Soundscapes and the Intelligent Ear: An Approach to Narrative Through Auditory Perception,” Melba Cuddy-Keane proposed “the terms auscultation, auscultize, and auscultator to parallel the existing terminology of focalization, focalize, and focalizer” (385). However, I am more bent on using Nelles’ nomenclature because it refers to hearing while Cuddy-Keane’s to listening. As a result, the former appears more useful in the context of radio drama whilst the latter in the context of literature.

6 It is important to note that radio drama’s “space of the presented world exists mainly in the imagination of the listener” and thus it is “an imaginary space (internal space of the recipient) resulting from the reconstruction of space, action, and the actions of the characters, made at the time of emission of the drama, by combining all the elements constructing the presented world into one coherent whole” (Bachura 2012, 179; see Bachura’s differentiations of space in radio drama (179–187)). Furthermore, this space is co-constructed by various verbal sounds (actors’ voices) and nonverbal sounds (set design, the so-called “acoustic kitchen”).

3. Dan Rebellato's *Cavalry*

Having established a narrative ontology of radio drama and worked out its theoretical apparatus, let me now move on to the analysis of a specific radio drama, Dan Rebellato's 2008 *Cavalry*.⁷ I have chosen the English playwright's work for three reasons. Firstly, the radio drama in question seems to be a perfect example of a drama in which the role of the microphone is highlighted and thematized. Second, the categories typically considered as narratological, for example, narrator, narrative levels or focaliser, are put to an intriguing and important use in *Cavalry*. Finally, the spatial aspects of the drama require closer examination, especially with regard to the radio drama's setting and space constitution and construction.

Cavalry is an apocalyptic radio drama broadcast on BBC Radio 4 in March 2008. Claire, a young and inexperienced journalist from a local radio, receives an unexpected commission from the BBC to interview four jockeys. In the course of the conversation it turns out that Mark, Sean, Gary and Aleks are no ordinary jockeys: they are the Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse, War, Pestilence, Famine and Death, and Claire is recording the last minutes before the end of the world. *Cavalry* was nominated for the Writer's Guild Award for radio drama and the Sony Award for drama production.

3.1 Voices and Auricularization in *Cavalry*

I commence with an analysis of the most important narratological category: voice. Genette's metaphor to discuss the narrating agency under this name seems exceptionally apt in a discussion of radio narration. It now acquires an uncannily literal meaning: in radio dramas we *hear voices*. In line with Genette's understanding, voice is the subject that carries out or submits to or reports the narrating activity (1980, 213). In *Cavalry* a microphone can be said to 'report' characters' conversation(s). Yet it is far more than that: the presence of the microphone is evident and transparent from the word go because the radio drama follows the convention of an interview, which is conducted by Claire. The microphone, therefore, is physically present in the fictional world of *Cavalry* and we hear it only too well in the initial parts:

⁷ The radio drama and full script are available free of charge here: www.danrebellato.co.uk/cavalry. All the following quotations from the script come from this online edition. They are indicated only with a page number.

1.

Claire it on?**Pestilence** Well the light's on.**Claire** Where?**Pestilence** Just**Claire** Oh, it's going!**Pestilence** Looks like it.**Claire** No wait a sec.**Pestilence** Right.**Claire** That's the battery light. I need to change the

2.

Pestilence goes in that way**Claire** No, no, it

3.

Claire Okay... Yep, I think we're all systems go.**Pestilence** Right.**Claire** Just say something into the mike.**Pestilence** What sort of thing?**Claire** Anything, it's just for level.**Pestilence** Okay, testing, testing.**Claire** Come back a bit.**Pestilence** Hello. Hello.**Claire** Just like you're talking normally.**Pestilence** Okay, this is Gary, talking normally, um, I had eggs this morning, um, I was born a long way away. Um. (This sort of thing?)**Claire** It's just for a level.**Pestilence** I'm in a changing room. Er, there's lockers, over there, they're blue. Concrete walls. The other guys aren't here yet. I don't know what's going to happen today but –**Claire** That's fine thanks, now I just need to listen to that back.**Pestilence** Weird the way your mind goes bla (Rebellato 3–4)

In the excerpt above the microphone provides frames for the radio drama's fictional reality. The pauses between the first and second, and between the second and third parts – lasting for a few seconds when Claire is trying to replace the batteries – represent the ontological boundaries of the drama's world. In the pauses the microphone is not working, and without the microphone's recording there is no acoustic signal and hence no message.⁸ The sense of the radio

⁸ At the public hearing of the play at the “Between.Pomiędzy” conference and festival in Sopot, Poland, from 14 to 20 May 2012, the pauses at the outset of *Cavalry* caused quite a stir as the audience looked to the technician responsible for the audio equipment to check if everything was all right.

drama's present-ness, immediacy and evanescence is acutely felt.⁹ The gaps, whenever they occur, are invariably realistically motivated by how the microphone is operated: either Claire fails to operate it correctly or simply switches it off. Consequently, the story time fully overlaps with the discourse time, resulting in the so-called real-timeness that establishes a strict spatiotemporal continuity throughout the drama. Finally, the gaps at the outset are technical faults on the part of Claire. They therefore symbolise and emphasise her incompetence, inexperience, amateurism and unpreparedness.

The microphone not only actively constitutes and creates the drama's world. The convention of the interview thematizes this faculty and makes the workings of the device acquire auto-reflexive status. This results in a paradox: on the one hand, we are to notice the process of message communication and thus the ongoing mediation, in accordance with the theoretical property of a microphone as the "intermediator" of acoustic information (Schlickers 2009, 243). Hence our awareness of the mediation process endows the message with an ambiguous journalistic dimension (Ryan 2014, 38). On the other hand, the strong impression of the present-ness, immediacy and indirectness of the drama is preserved. It rests on the idea that the microphone records events as they *are* happening in real time; the gaps are authentically motivated and various quality deficiencies are accepted or taken for granted.

The interview convention puts another formal feature of *Cavalry* into the spotlight. The recording of the interview (on the intradiegetic level) is formally ensconced within the recording of the radio drama world (extradiegetic level). Framing has been common in literature since antiquity and it is so widespread that some theorists and literary scholars hypothesise that it is a quintessential or indispensable feature of narrative (Paxson 2001, 128; Nelles 2002, 339; Genette 1980, 231; Williams 1998, 99). Employed in the radio drama, the framing places *Cavalry* in a group of artistic narratives that use this centuries-old tradition. Functionally speaking, the intradiegetic status of the interview alters the status of the events and characters as well: they all become intradiegetic. The framing and interview lead the listener to perceive the fictional world of the radio drama as relatively objective, neutral, and surprisingly authentic.

Furthermore, each horseman at one point tells Claire the story of his recruitment:

⁹ The stage directions set the time of action for "Tomorrow." This indefinite quality of temporal location provides the radio drama with allegorical collocations. It also implies some "day after tomorrow." The interview occurs in the last hours before the end of the world and the recording of it must have survived the Apocalypse.

Claire Aleks told me his story. What's yours?

Pestilence My call up?

Claire Yes.

They look to Death.

Death Go ahead.

Pestilence I'm a general in the Parthian army. We're putting the Syrian to flight. Black helicopter appears above the trees. You wouldn't believe the sound, the power. The ground is pounding beneath our feet. We're all firing arrows at it. We don't know what it is.

Famine I was commander of the Mongol cavalry into Armenia on our campaign to take the Caspian. The helicopter bursts from a cloud. It whips the sea water into a storm. I thought it was the wrath of God come down upon us.

Claire And you're a knight, I suppose.

War I joined the Third Crusade. One night we're encamped. Then all the tents are open and a light is shining down on us, like a great sun. That same steel thunder in the sky. I am caught in its beam and a rope ladder is lowered to me. I thought, do I climb this ladder? (Rebellato 2008, 39–40)

Even though the radio drama does not usually employ any special sound effects, in the case of the Horsemen's stories it is different. Each story is accompanied by an outstanding external sound effects background: the swishing slowed-down sound of the helicopter's blades derives from the past although the characters are telling the story in the present. Therefore we might assume that other intradiegetic characters do not hear the blades and that, effectively, they must belong to a separate spatiotemporal realm, that is, narrative level. On the metadiegetic level, in Genette's (1980, 228) sense of this term, the radio play presents various historical events, from the fourth century BC to the twelfth century, occurring in various distant locations from the world's history, from ancient Greece to Syria to the Mongol empire to the crusades. Going back in time as they do, the intradiegetic narrators give homodiegetic accounts of their personal history. The metadiegetic levels thus become analeptic, and because of their function (providing additional information on the characters), they must be categorised as external to the current action and as explanatory. Finally, the homodiegetic stories of the horsemen's recruitment might also be defined by the "perspectival filter." In other words, the stories are clearly auricularized, perceived from a specific standpoint. The auricularization strengthens the impression of the personal, intimate and direct account of the characters' past.

Yet the function of auricularization pertains more to Claire. Let us consider the following excerpts from the drama's script:

Death Do you want to see them? The horses?

Claire Oh. Well. Um. Yes, okay.

Death Follow me.

Claire Can I record in there?

Death As you wish.

Claire Okay, I'll just turn it off for now (Rebellato 2008, 28)

Claire, who at first finds it incredibly difficult to operate the microphone, gradually becomes closely attached to it. She recuperates her journalistic flair, regains her confidence and curiosity. The microphone accompanies her at every move; she does not part from it and, more importantly, records almost everything that takes place in the main locations of the radio drama. The passage above is a good case in point, "Can I record in there?" asks Claire boldly, unwilling to stop recording in the stables. Getting an affirmative answer, she continues to interview Death as he is showing her their horses of the Apocalypse.

In part 9, Claire is shut in a bathroom and speaks nervously into the microphone:

(whispered, panicked) This is Claire Webster, reporting for the BBC. I'm in a stableyard off the A535. I'm being held prisoner by an armed gang. I've not been hurt but I think they're mad and they're probably dangerous. At least one of them has a sword. Around ten minutes ago, the whole complex came under attack from what looked like a military helicopter. If I hold the microphone to the door you can hear part of a ritual which I have been prevented from seeing.

We hear part of the ritual. [...] (Rebellato 2008, 44)

In this excerpt we realize that the extent of information recorded by the microphone extends its usual interview functions: characters' utterances. Claire is beside herself with fear and horror and the microphone 'reflects' these emotions just as it indexically 'reflected' her inexperience, lack of familiarity with the equipment and unpreparedness at the beginning, and subsequently revealed her fear, excitement and disbelief in the true identity of the jockeys or the pending apocalypse. As a consequence, Claire can be considered as an auriculizer in *Cavalry*.

With easy and immediate access to Claire's emotional state, the account of the Armageddon acquires a personal dimension. No higher-level, impersonal or omniscient narrative agent intrudes upon the story. The interview device,¹⁰ technical problems at the outset, the real-time technique and Claire's auriculari-

10 One more element of this device, which has so far gone unmentioned, is the *you* address: "If I hold the microphone to the door you can hear part of a ritual which I have been prevented from seeing" (44). Apparently, the recipient of the interview is constantly projected, which makes the interview seem news-like, as if Claire is a reporter doing a feature for an 8 o'clock news bulletin at the BBC.

zation endow *Cavalry* with almost a sort of mockumentary status, in which the audience derives cognitive pleasure from a witness's first-hand account without losing sight of the recording device and communication process (see Limon 2003, 159). When it comes to Claire's role and position in the drama, it is set on maximising emotional engagement in her fate. Moreover, the personal dimension of the account makes the whole story a sort of 'personal tragedy': we know nothing about politics, environment or any social unrest (although the characters sometimes make perfunctory references to these issues), and instead the epic events are narrated from the perspective of an unknown ("I'm new, actually. I covered the garden festival in March, that's probably the biggest thing I've done so far. Well until you" (Rebellato 17)) and mediocre ("no one else was available" (17)) journalist from some local radio.

Claire's auricularization has one more function. She continues to reject the possibility of the Horsemen's being real Horsemen of the Apocalypse. Even towards the end of the drama she rationalizes what turns out to be true but seems to be beyond belief, "I'm being held prisoner by *an armed gang*. I've not been hurt but I think they're *mad* and they're *probably dangerous*" (Rebellato 44, my italics). The listeners, however, tend to be rather more perceptive in this respect. In other words, Claire-auricularizer knows less than the characters and the listeners and it is legitimate to conclude that, despite being intradiegetic, she is an external auricularizer. Moreover, her perspectival (epistemological) limitations are ironic. Rebellato explains: "The journalist is very much me [...]. If I were in that bizarre situation I would also be quite reluctant to believe someone saying that they are the Four Horsemen. The play is therefore a mechanism to test the limits of our rationality" (2013, 265).

3.2 Creating Space through the Microphone

Cavalry is a "hyper-realistic" (Rebellato's expression, 2013, 264) and personal account of the Apocalypse. Yet every catastrophe must take place somewhere so let me move on now to the examination of space and how the microphone works to address it. At the beginning of this paper I outlined a basic terminological toolkit for these analytical operations. To recapitulate, I mentioned soundmark, soundscape, and, last but not least, route.

The stage directions specify the setting: "A changing room with tiled walls and lockers, with a large shower room behind, all attached to a stableyard, off the A535, between Holmes Chapel and Alderley Edge" (Rebellato, 2). Clearly, the setting echoes other realism-associated techniques and devices at work in the drama. The location is given in such a meticulously detailed and precise

way that finding the stableyard on Google Earth could not be any easier.¹¹ These juxtapose with the Bible's mythic tale creating a sort of tension and dissonance. Also, the low-profile status of the setting jars with a common view of the Armageddon.

In addition, the dressing room is further depicted as "tiled walls and lockers, with a large shower room behind." Pestilence right in the beginning, in part 3, textually points out the most vital elements of the soundscape with its soundmarks: "I'm in a changing room. Er, there's lockers, over there, they're blue. Concrete walls" (4). Since a predominant chunk of the action takes place in the dressing room, it can be considered as the soundscape while the lockers and showers are the soundmarks. The riders repeatedly move around the space: they go to and from and between the soundmarks as in part 6 when Pestilence and Famine take a shower, which the stage directions indicate in the following way: "*Pestilence is in the shower*" (16), "*The shower stops*" (18) and "*Famine and Pestilence are out of the shower*" (24). Other elements of the soundscape are also frequently referred to in the directions: "*Death goes to his locker, gets out medical kit*" (22) or "*They [Death and Famine] open their lockers and dress quickly*" (25). Every instance of crossing the room from or to any of the soundmarks maps a specific route and, more importantly, it is established synecdochically; for example, a specific sound signals the existence of showers (by means of the running water, for instance), likewise the lockers are opened and closed in such a way as to be easily and readily recognizable. In terms of kinesics, therefore, the characters, once in the dressing room, move along similar and repeated routes: the dressing room-lockers-showers. Only in *Cavalry*'s parts 7 and 9 does the action leave the main location. Here, Death and Claire go to the stables where he presents her their horses (animals' grunts are heard in the background). Then, Claire is forced into the bathroom because she must not witness the ritual. Importantly, every time the action shifts to another soundscape, the microphone stops working for a short time. The ending of part 8 and the beginning of part 9 is a good case in point: "*Rattle, disturbance. Claire being manhandled. The recorder falls. Tape clicks off*" (43) and "*Bathroom next to the changing room. We hear the horse-men's ritual from the next room, distant and muffled. Claire is whispering nervously very very close into the microphone*" (44). It can be seen again that the world of *Cavalry* stops existing without the microphone. Moreover, the switch-offs of the recording device imply that the boundaries between the three major soundscapes are profound and significant. They are separate worlds generating diverse

11 Holmes Chapel and Alderley Edge are real towns in northern England, south of Greater Manchester, over 10 miles apart.

connotations. In the stables Claire sees the horses and hears Death's life story and gets the first glimpses of what is really going on. In the bathroom, lonely, humiliated and terrified she reports the Earth's last moments until "*Tape ends abruptly*" (48).

To recapitulate, there are three soundscapes in total: the dressing room, stable and bathroom, all linked together by routes to create a specific, solid and stable location for the action. In addition to that, the location is provided with depth by means of the routes as well as various proxemic phenomena. In part 4 Sean, Mark and Aleks come into the locker room and are heard at a distance (respectively on pages 8, 13 and 15); in part 6 Gary takes a shower, and Mark sharpens the sword blade (16). Due to the volume of the audio signal, it is possible to establish the "degrees" of the soundscape:

1. Claire + microphone and the person she is talking to at the moment (acoustic foreground¹²),
2. the "deep space" with lockers and showers (intermediary plan; background),
3. bathroom and stables (further plan), and, finally
4. the external world, whose existence is experienced synecdochically. In part 9, the Four Horsemen ride out from the stables, we hear a voice coming from a military helicopter, "Drop your weapons. Lie on the floor with your hands behind your head. I repeat, lie on the floor with your hands behind your head" (48), and Aleks responds by giving an order: "(very *distant*) Present weapons! We ride!" (48, my italics). Then the riders attack and the helicopter opens fire; the Earth begins to tremble and thus begins the end of the world, and simultaneously of the radio drama as well.

To map the scale, *Cavalry* opens with a small and confined space of the dressing room as Claire and Pestilence idly discuss the weather and their morning's breakfast. The outset is serene and tranquil, albeit somewhat stressful for the journalist. Subsequently, other characters enter (Famine on page 8 and on 12 War, who subsequently goes to take a shower on page 13, and finally Death on 15) and the soundscape previously described only verbally, gradually materializes, as it were, and deepens considerably: "*Pestilence is in the shower. War is sharpening a sword in the background*" (Rebellato 16). Towards the end of the drama, the space continues to enlarge and comes to include locations beyond the three basic and clearly demarcated soundscapes. Simultaneously, the drama extends and includes the external world with spectacular scenes of the

¹² This is Bachura's (2012, 232–239) term.

Armageddon: crashing metal, trembling ground and boiling skies. The internal is destroyed by the external.

The gradation of space depth in *Cavalry* is recorded by and with the microphone. To be more precise, the microphone held by Claire comes to present the space from her standpoint. As a matter of fact, Claire and the device are inseparable throughout the drama and hence she might be considered the most important soundmark: the entity that influences the space structuring in the drama as her kinesic qualities determine the space's dimensions globally. Moreover, she decides what is recorded and what is not (note the stables part), and without her there would be no audio material. Finally, she significantly determines and auricularizes the spatial features.

4. Conclusion

"Radio drama has been one of the most unappreciated and understated literary forms of the twentieth century and the purpose of this book is to demonstrate that this neglect should not continue into the twenty-first century." Thus opens *Radio Drama: Theory and Practice*, a study by Tim Crook (2001, 3). Publishing his study around the turn of the century, the author expressed a generally accepted opinion about the status of radio drama in contemporary discourse, that is, its low status. As a narratologist, when I look around, I cannot help agreeing with Crook. As one of the main narrative art forms, next to literature, film and theatre, radio drama seems the least studied and the most underrated. This article's aim was to put radio drama on its right tracks and to bring it into the mainstream narratological investigations. These investigations can focus not only on the narrative dimension of radio drama but, meta-theoretically, for example, they can shed new light on the ever disputed concepts of narrativity and mediality.

This short study, being far from exhaustive, might serve as a matrix for future narratological studies. These should definitely consider narration, temporality, perspective, and setting since they form key aspects of radio drama. A narratological toolkit might prove useful in their examination. The tools that I employed here must be divided into medium-specific concepts (auricularization, space terms) and medium-free concepts (narrator, narrative levels, analepsis) (Ryan and Thon 2014b, 4). Hopefully, more narratologists and other scholars will rise to the challenge.

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Lars Bernaerts

Voice and Sound in the Anti-Narrative Radio Play

In his 1976 essay about listening, Roland Barthes emphasizes that our daily experience of the world depends to a great extent on sounds. Integral to our experience of being home, for example, are familiar sounds of which “l’ensemble forme une sorte de symphonie domestique: claquement différencié des portes, éclats de voix, bruits de cuisine, de tuyaux, rumeurs extérieures” (1982, 218) (“whose ensemble forms a kind of household symphony: differentiated slamming of doors, raised voices, kitchen noises, gurgle of pipes, murmurs from outdoors” 1985, 246). It is this effect of familiar sounds that the conventional radio play capitalizes upon. The radio play – a narrative form that relies solely on audible signals – often introduces a selection of such sounds to evoke the “domestic symphony” Barthes talks about. The sound of a creaking door or of footsteps on a wooden floor can function as an indexical sign for familiar environments, creating a realist effect. This narrative technique elicits a listening strategy which resembles that of mass music in the way Theodor Adorno has described it: the listeners “lose, along with the freedom of choice and responsibility, the capacity for conscious perception” and “develop certain capacities which accord less with the concepts of traditional aesthetics than with those of football and motoring” (Adorno 1991, 46). Also, the indexical and iconic uses of sound and voice in the radio play contribute, along with the dialogues and narratorial guidance, to narrativity and narrativization. If we adopt Monika Fludernik’s definition (Fludernik 1996), narrativity implies the ability for the listener to project human experientiality onto the acoustic composition. If the listener can mobilize human experience to connect the distinct elements of the composition, it gains narrativity.

This essay deals with the negative of such realist narratives in radio plays, which is to say, the radiophonic experiments that reveal or reject the illusion of realism and that defy narrativization. In that way, they become the kind of critical art forms Adorno advocates. To achieve this, experimental radio plays can deploy all the sign systems of the acoustic channel: sounds and sound effects, sonic texture (loudness, timbre, pitch), voice, language, music, silence, mix, and montage (cf. Crook 2012, 16; Huwiler 2005a, 54–70). The question here is how we can analyse and make sense of these unconventional audionarratives from a narratological point of view. Structuralist narratology does not offer a satisfactory equipment for that job. It identifies the textual building blocks of stories and their narrative presentation and it leaves some room for the analysis of

visual meaning-making in audiovisual narratives, but narrativization through the acoustic channel has gained little attention. Moreover, as the recent narratological strand called “unnatural narratology” has extensively demonstrated in its publications (see, for example, Richardson 2006, Alber et al. 2013, Alber 2014), structuralist narratology displays a mimetic bias, whereas so many novels and plays have an anti-mimetic dimension. According to unnatural narratology, narrative theory “since Aristotle” has presupposed the idea that “the basic aspects of narrative can be explained primarily or exclusively by models based on realist parameters” (Alber et al. 2013, 1). Since this tendency is so ingrained, classical (i.e., structuralist and prestructuralist) narratology has its limits when it comes to describing avant-garde fiction and, more germane to the current discussion, experimental audiophonic narratives.

Narratological concepts and strands that have emerged in recent decades, however, provide us with additional means to distinguish and describe the compositional characteristics of these narratives. Unnatural narratology, in particular, has developed an “anti-mimetic poetics that supplements existing mimetic theories” (Richardson 2006, 138). In order to explore the form and function of the anti-narrative radio play, I therefore propose to combine unnatural narratology with the study of narrative across media (transmedial narratology),¹ and the narratology of the radio play in particular (Dunn 2005, Huwiler 2005a). Up until now, transmedial narratology has dealt with many kinds of textual, visual, aural, and audiovisual narratives, such as video games, film, music and TV (see, e.g., Ryan 2004; Ryan and Thon 2014; Wolf and Bernhart 2006; Alber and Hansen 2014), but the poetics of the radiophonic narrative is rarely taken into account.² Exceptions can be found in German studies such as Nicole Mahne’s *Transmediale Erzähltheorie* (2007) and Elke Huwiler’s *Erzähl-Ströme im Hörspiel* (2005a). Mahne compares the proper narrative systems of novels, comics, movies, audio drama, and hyperfiction. Huwiler outlines a narratology for audio drama, which is firmly rooted in semiotics and narratology. In particular, the transmedial approach, complemented with insights from unnatural narratology, will allow me to explain how narrative voice and audible voice are used in counterintuitive ways in experimental audio drama to extend and enrich the anti-mimetic and anti-narrative dimension that can be found in experimental written narratives. In narratological terminology, “anti-narrative” is a predecessor of “unnatural,” as can be gleaned from Brian Richardson’s entry in the *Routledge*

1 The combination of approaches has been explored in application to other media in the volume *Beyond Classical Narration* (Alber and Hansen 2014).

2 Still, the signifying power of sound and its various forms and functions are being scrutinized in the interdisciplinary field of sound studies (see, for example, Crook 2012, Schafer 1994, Sterne 2012).

Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory (2008, 24–25), where he defines “anti-narrative” as a term used for “narratives that ignore or defy the conventions of natural narrative” (24). Unnatural narratology has catalogued devices of anti-narrative literature and criticized the mimetic paradigm of classical narratology. In *Unnatural Narrative: Theory, History, and Practice* (2015) Richardson strongly pleads for the principle that phenomena seemingly marginal to narrative studies deserve close consideration *within* the field of narrative theory. This implies that the most accurate toolbox to describe the anti-narrative features of an experimental piece of audiophonic fiction should be (and is) supplied by narratology. As I also wish to demonstrate, classical narratological concepts and categories, such as “voice,” are useful for the analysis of unusual narratives. However, they deserve close inspection from an anti-mimetic and anti-narrative perspective and that is what unnatural narratology can offer.

In a structural approach to narration in audio drama, the concept of “voice” is pivotal and at the same time somewhat equivocal. Obviously, the metaphor of voice is one of the most central ones in any type of narratology. The impact of Gérard Genette’s theory of narrative discourse can hardly be underestimated in this matter. Taking his departure from Todorov’s distinction between tense, aspect, and mood, Genette suggests a reshuffling of the latter two categories into “mood” and “voice.” For Genette, the term “voice” is a grammatical one; he considers a narrative as an elaboration of a basic verbal form (“*Je marche, Pierre est venu,*” 1972, 75) and voice as a component of this grammatical structure. In his introduction to *Narrative Discourse. An Essay in Method* (1983 [1972]), he dismisses the alternative term “person” because of its psychological connotations and explains that voice “will refer to a relation with the subject (and more generally with the instance) of the enunciating” (31–32).³ But even the metaphor of voice is not devoid of mimetic connotations. As the editors of the volume *Strange Voices in Narrative Fictions* state, the concept “would seem to combine the stabilizing function of an always-necessary narrator with the seductive mimetic intuitivity of someone talking (to us)” (Hansen et al. 2011, 2).⁴

It is vital to keep in mind Genette’s motive for choosing this term as we move on to a more literal understanding of “voice” and to the practice of “strange voi-

3 “designera un rapport avec le sujet (et plus généralement l’instance) de l’énonciation” (1972, 76).

4 For a thorough discussion of the way “voice” is conceptualized in the communicational theory of narratives and in the critical responses to it, I refer to Richard Aczel (1998) and Sylvie Patron (2011). Andreas Blödmann and Daniela Langer (2006) have offered an incisive analysis of the implications of the metaphor of “voice” in the discourses of Bakhtin, Derrida, and Genette. Matthias Aumüller (2006) compares Genette’s concept with the concept of “skaz” in Russian Formalism, which complements the conceptual history of the metaphor.

ces” which resist psychological motivation. When the textual, grammatical voices are transposed into the audible voices of a radio play, it seems inevitable that “voice” will become uploaded with anthropomorphic and even psychological traits again if only because the listener catches a glimpse of the sex and age of the character (and/or actor). Experimental audio drama often impedes this naturalizing interpretation by defamiliarizing the physical voice itself – for example by multiplying voices, by using unusual intonation or sound effects. In the 2011 adaptation of Ferdinand Kriwet’s experimental text *Rotor* (1961), for example, the voice of the performer Michael Lentz is electronically manipulated: its pitch is changed, a metallic sound is added, it is mixed in several layers and so on. In such a configuration, the introduction of the human voice does not necessarily strengthen psychological coherence, it can also be deployed in more aestheticizing or defamiliarizing ways. Another good example is Georges Perec’s original radio play *Die Maschine* (*The Machine*, 1968), which imposes a number of permutations upon Goethe’s “Wandrer’s Nachtlied II.” In accordance with Perec’s Oulipo poetics, new creative combinations of words emerge from a series of constraints in this radio play.⁵ The computational nature of the procedures is reflected in the mechanical performance of the male voices in *Die Maschine*. They do not seem to belong to persons. In more general terms, it is clear that experimental radio plays often favor the aesthetic and thematic over the mimetic use of voices and sounds.⁶

As the examples already indicate, the metaphor of “strange” or “unnatural voices” gains particular significance in the study of experimental audio drama. I will demonstrate this in more detail for the case of *Orchis Militaris*, a piece adapted from a novel by the Flemish author Ivo Michiels. The “strange voice” metaphor is widespread in unnatural narratology. Scholars such as Brian Richardson in *Unnatural Voices* (2006) and the contributors of *Strange Voices in Narrative Fiction* (2011) notice that the aspects of narrative voice that are hard to naturalize – hence the term “strange” or “unnatural” – have escaped attention in narrative theory. As I hope to show, the case of experimental audio drama can enliven and sophisticate our understanding of unnatural voices and thus contributes

5 Ulrich Schönherr discusses Perec’s experiment of *Die Maschine* at length in a recent essay (Schönherr 2014). In order to understand Perec’s piece, one should also take the German context into consideration (see Steiner 2001): namely, Perec wrote the play for a German radio station (Saarländischer Rundfunk), where the susceptibility for radiophonic narrative innovation was strong.

6 I am referring to concepts of naturalization (Culler 2002 [1975]) and motivation (Tomashevsky 1965 [1925]) here: artists and listeners can adopt various interpretive strategies to create coherence in a work’s stream of voices, words, sounds, and music. Broadly speaking, they can either motivate the elements of a piece mimetically, thematically, or aesthetically.

to the narratological debate. The following section delineates the genre and the medium of the radio play more clearly to enable us to examine how boundaries of narrativity are explored in its experimental forms.

1. Audio Drama and its Experimental Tradition

The terms “radio play” and “audio drama” are used interchangeably to denote a genre and a medium of audiophonic fictional narratives which combines dialogue or at least expressive spoken language with sound, music, and silence.⁷ Of course, there are many variants and borderline cases which, for example, only use spoken language plus silence and no other acoustic signs. One can think, for example, of the meaningful ways in which dialogue and silence are combined in Nathalie Sarraute’s *Le Silence* (1964).⁸ In other pieces, only one actor is involved, as in the example of *Rotor*. In that respect, it may be more fruitful to distinguish between a prototypical radio play on the one hand and a strong affinity with contiguous genres on the other hand. The prototype is a composition of several voices, sound, and music arranged in a sequence of scenes, which evokes a narrative development. Originally, the prototypical radio play was broadcast by a radio station. Today, the internet, new digital formats and electronic devices contribute to the distribution of audiophonic art. Although it is, as a consequence, doubtful whether a listener would still consider radio transmission as the prototype, the development, the technological aspects, and the aesthetic codes of audio drama are inextricably connected to those of the radio. To a certain extent, the radio is definitely more than merely a means of distribution.

The contiguous genres can help us to specify the nature of audio drama. First, the radio play uses the same techniques as the radio commercial, but its purpose is to entertain and to edify rather than to inform and appeal to the audience as a group of consumers. In contrast to the radio documentary it is fictional. Unlike the audiobook, it features more than one voice or at least features one voice impersonating a particular character. It also differs from sound art and *musique concrète*, since it is narrative and it includes linguistic signs. Unlike sound poetry and sound collages the radio play is a narrative form and finally it is very akin to audio-recorded theat-

⁷ Useful standard definitions of the radio play can also be found in Binczek and Mütterig (2013, 467) and Huwiler (2005b, 46).

⁸ Commissioned in 1964 by the German radio station Süddeutscher Rundfunk and adapted from the novel of the same name. See Jiša (2011).

rical plays. Although some of the earliest instances of audio drama⁹ were already exploring the specific means of the radio, a lot of these early radio plays tended to adopt the features of theatrical plays. The paradoxical medial logic we can observe in this development is that of remediation (Bolter and Grusin 1999): the medium defines itself by at the same time mimicking an older medium and claiming that it offers a more authentic, direct experience.¹⁰ Also, radio stations could of course broadcast theatrical plays live. Gradually, however, radio plays began to insist upon their own semiotic system, for example by using a cluster of the indexical signs I mentioned at the start.

The radio play is not necessarily a critical narrative art form. The most popular radio plays in the Western world are soap operas, detective stories, thrillers, science fiction, and fiction for children. One could even contend that the most widespread form of audio drama is actually the radio commercial, often dramatic and narrative in and of itself. Still, there is no doubt that audio drama can be a form of art, which becomes clear, for example, in Samuel Beckett's radiophonic pieces, audio drama written by French experimental writers such as Michel Butor, Georges Perec, Robert Pinget and Nathalie Sarraute, the German 'neues Hörspiel' and experimental audio drama in Dutch. Taking these examples into consideration, one might wonder why I have not called the radio play a *literary* genre. As Huwiler (2005a) has argued, that would imply a reductive view of a genre that functions as an art form in its own right. This has led to misguided forms of radio drama analysis as well: "the tendency of literary analysis to ignore the non-verbal acoustical elements of these plays has led to the notion that the word is always the paramount element of radio drama" (Huwiler 2005b, 50). If literature is verbal art, then we are putting too much stress on just one of the semiotic systems of the radio play if we call it literature (and analyse it accordingly), while ignoring other essential ones, such as sound effects, music, and montage (on this point, see also Huwiler in this volume).

Experimental radio plays position themselves against the background of the prototypical form I just sketched. In other words, the prototypical form should be understood as a cluster of expectations for the listener, and the experimental

⁹ (*A Comedy of*) *Danger* (BBC, 1924) by Richard Hughes, considered by many studies as the first radio play, emphasizes the imaginative power of auditive storytelling, in that the story is set in a totally dark coal mine. The first German radio play, Hans Flesch's *Zauberei auf dem Sender: Versuch einer Rundfunkgroteske* (*Wizardry on the Air: Attempt at a Radio Grotesque*; Frankfurt Radio Station, 1924), also experiments with the means of the medium, as the title already indicates.

¹⁰ The radio play responds in interesting ways to the rise of other media. To take the case of the Low Countries (Bulte 1984): when the TV makes its entry, the radio play more firmly exploits the features proper to the medium and to the mode of transmission. In the digital age, audio drama is revived as "audiofilm," again defining its own identity via another medium (Bernaerts 2014).

form is approached from this angle. This is an important point for the understanding of the anti-narrative radio play. It is not likely that sound art or sound poetry are generally read as “anti-narrative,” since there is no expectation of a narrative, and there are less triggers for narrativization. Although you could project, by way of an experiment, a narrative into a performance of sound poetry by Jaap Blonk, Ernst Jandl, or Kurt Schwitters, the dominant thrust of what you hear is not narrative at all. In my view, the term “anti-narrative” does not apply in those cases. Other experimental acoustic compositions are interesting borderline cases, for example Ernst Jandl and Friederike Mayröcker’s pioneering piece *Fünf Mann Menschen* (1968, *Five Man Humanity*), Gerhard Rühm’s radio play *Wien wie es klingt* (*Vienna how it sounds*, 1994) or John Cage’s *Roaratorio, an Irish Circus on Finnegans Wake* (1979).¹¹ A brief look at these pieces can illuminate the ways in which sound and voice can be introduced as forces acting counter to narrativity. Voices can become “disembodied entities” or “bundles of sound” (Schätzlein 2008), and sounds can lose their referential qualities.

The story progression that can be derived from *Fünf Mann Menschen* is the course of a human life. *Fünf Mann Menschen* evokes places associated with significant life events: a maternity home, the parental home, a school, the military and so on. But this mimetic layer has to be fathomed through layers of word play and sound effects. In particular, the piece is considered to be the first one that fully develops stereophony as an aesthetic and narrative procedure. The distance and the position of the sound source relative to the two microphones is part of the signifying structure of the play. In a comment, Jandl and Mayröcker explain that their point of departure is not the story, i.e., an arrangement of ‘persons, fates, experiences, objects, etc.’¹² but the acoustic materials. These materials are brought into play, as they say, and from this play a story can result, almost as a side effect (Jandl and Mayröcker 1970, 88).

Rühm’s acoustic portrayal of Vienna is built from documentary sounds (“O-Ton” in German), recorded across the city, starting with the soundscape of a train featuring a train conductor announcing arrival in Vienna. The piece trades on the effect suggested by Barthes: by offering familiar elements of the urban soundscape, it induces the experience of being in a certain (public) place at a certain time. Since several places are presented acoustically in the chronological order of one day, a rudimentary narrative progression can be construed. Combined with the projection of human experientiality this progression increases the degree of narrativity.

11 IRCAM radio production (Paris, 1979), presented as a multimedial performance at the Brooklyn Academy of Music in 1986.

12 “Personen, Schicksalen, Erlebnissen, Objekten, etc.”

In the example of John Cage's *Roaratorio*, a selection of words from James Joyce's *Finnegans Wake* (1939) is combined with Irish traditional music and sounds inspired by the novel. Because of its direct connection to the novel, listeners are arguably encouraged to narrativize this radio play intertextually. Moreover, the soundscape – which weaves together sounds of dogs barking, bells tolling, children laughing, a baby crying, water rippling, and so on – transports the reader into a distinct narrative world, even if there is no distinct story development. Clearly, this wonderful collage of sounds, music, singing voices and spoken language generates mimetic effects but remains impervious to smooth narrativization or general mimetic explanations. If the listener is invited to approach Cage's piece as a narrative, which he is, then he is surely dealing with an “unnatural” narrative. The work's aim, Marjorie Perloff writes in her insightful analysis of *Roaratorio*, is “to produce simultaneous layers of sound and meaning that correspond to the complexity of the parent text” (1989, 216). Any attempt to narrativize *Roaratorio* is therefore bound to the intertextual dialogue orchestrated by this avant-garde radio play.

As the examples indicate, the configuration and purpose of the anti-narrative radio play vary from individual piece to piece. In order to demonstrate the way anti-narrative uses of “voice” are woven into a play's structure and meaning, I will zoom in on one particular case in the final section of this essay.

2. Strange Voices in *Orchis Militaris*

Whereas the examples of Rühm and Cage put emphasis on sound and music rather than voices and words, the case to which I now turn hampers narrativization by staging unnatural voices and dialogues. *Orchis Militaris* is an adaptation from a 1968 novel by the Dutch-speaking Belgian author Ivo Michiels. As a novel, it is part of Michiels's *Alpha Cycle* (1963–1979), a series of five experimental texts in which linguistic and narrative conventions are decomposed and partly replaced by alternative ways of creating coherence (such as rhythm, abstraction, alphabetical ordering, and game rules). The visual and auditive dimensions of these texts are foregrounded on a story level as well as on the level of discourse. For example, the soundscape of the storyworld is particularly obtrusive in the first two books, where the overwhelming noise of modern war is prominent; and the texts themselves stress their aural layer through a repetitive, rhythmic style. Another of the five texts, *Samuel, o Samuel* (1973),¹³ was initially conceived as a compilation of audiophonic and theatrical pieces. The first two books, *Book Alpha* and *Orchis Militaris*, were adapted for the

¹³ The title refers to Beckett.

ear later on. Together with Freddy De Vree, who was the co-director,¹⁴ Michiels wrote the script for *Orchis Militaris*. The play went on the air in 1971 and was broadcast by the national channel, first in Flanders, Belgium (BRT, May 30) and then in the Netherlands (NCRV, October 18).

Orchis Militaris reflects upon mechanisms of oppression against the backdrop of the Second World War. The anonymous main character is a man from an occupied country who is sent to Germany for compulsory work as a nurse in a hospital. In the five episodes of the novel, the identity and ethical positioning of the nurse and a soldier, a soldier and a prisoner, and soldiers of two different fronts are commingled. However, the aboutness of the story soon appears to be subservient to the meaningful form, namely the experimental stylistic and narrative presentation. The form embodies the idea that ideological and ethical positions are interchangeable on an abstract level. Because of the abstract, rhythmic presentation the distinctions between characters and situations become blurry for the reader, too (Bernaerts 2010). The voice of the heterodiegetic, extradiegetic narrator is often backgrounded in the novel, while a polyphony of characters' voices is presented in repetitive dialogues.

The radio play does more than adding a layer or transposing the readable voices into audible voices. It uses the intrinsic aesthetic means of the genre to achieve similar effects of defamiliarization and abstraction. This is obvious right from the start of the radio play: the motto of the novel, an excerpt from Filippo Tommaso Marinetti's futurist manifesto, is read by a female actor (Marleen Verhaar) impersonating a child.¹⁵ An uncanny ironic tension emerges from the discrepancy between, on the one hand, the stammering voice of the child and on the other hand the added sound effect (a subtly metallic echo) and the content of the manifesto, which celebrates the aesthetics of war: "For seventy-five years we, futurists, have been raising our voices against the notion that war is not aesthetic... Therefore we declare: war is beautiful because [...] it enriches a flowering meadow with flaming ORCHIDS—machine guns" (Michiels 1979, 82).¹⁶ In a simple gesture, the natural innocence symbolized by the child and the flower are "unnaturally" aligned with the violence of war. In the original novel, there was no indication whatsoever of a child's narrative voice behind the motto, so the way the scene is set in the radio play differs significantly.

To be able to dig deeper into the way audible and narrative voices contribute to the experiment of *Orchis Militaris*, I will zoom in on one representative ex-

¹⁴ The other director is Ab van Eyk.

¹⁵ This is common practice in audio drama and, more generally, in voice acting (commercials, cartoons, animated films, etc.).

¹⁶ Here and below, I am quoting from the English translation of the novel by Adrienne Dixon.

cerpt. It takes approximately two minutes of the piece's total play time (34'41") and is situated near the beginning (3'27"–5'17"). The setting is a German hospital during the Second World War. In the dialogue with which the quotation starts, the main character is addressed by a German nurse:

Maybe you are afraid of us? Yes, sister. Because we fought against you? Yes, sister. And won? Yes, sister. Did we win? Yes, sister. Do you believe that we won? Yes, sister. Do you believe that we shall win again? Yes, sister. In the east too? Yes, my lady baroness. In the west too? Yes, my lady baroness. And you understand our language? Yes, my lady baroness. There ought to be only one language, one language used over the whole world. Yes, my lady baroness. One language used over the whole world would promote peace among the nations. Yes, my lady baroness. One language and one God. Yes, my lady baroness.

A female actor (Hilde Sacré) impersonates two distinct voices in this dialogue. Although the actress remains the same, the voices can be discriminated because of the tone (commanding versus submissive) and the stereophonic effect. What thwarts straightforward narrativization is the repetitive nature of the dialogue and the textual shift in characters (sister, baroness) while the voices remain the same. As the dialogue continues, the defamiliarization through the performance of the voices increases. The exchange that immediately follows the previous quotation is read by a female and a male voice (Hans Veerman) simultaneously in a neutral intonation and a low pitch:

Our language. Yes, general. Shall I really be able to walk properly again? Yes, general. The doctor says I shall be able to walk properly again, do you believe what the doctor says? Yes, general, I believe what the doctor says and what the sister says and the superintendent the baroness and the general and yes, general, I believe what the general says, look at my fingers here, how I believe it, and at my eyes, how I believe it, and at my mouth, how I believe it, especially at my mouth, general. Yes, general.

The almost hypnotic simultaneity of the two now impersonal voices further distances us from the actual situation the dialogue suggests, namely that of a general who discusses his recovery with the nurse. More important than the situation is the speech act: the submissive answers of the nurse take the shape of a credo. Interestingly, this unnatural combination (dialogue + credo) is naturalized in the radio play, as the simultaneous voices can be interpreted by the listener as the familiar sound of a group of worshippers praying together in Mass.

If this passage is soothing to the listener, then he or she is quickly stirred by what follows. Two voices shout: "Would you cut my hair if I ordered you to cut my hair? Yes, general. Good, help me up and cut my hair. Now." The simultaneous voices produce a higher pitch and an increased volume, which we can decode as a commanding tone of voice. This is the only time the voices really leave the neutral

zone and give the listener the chance to infer emotion from the diction. The same voices, one male and one female, continue in the soft tone of the credo:

said the general, and then he firmly took hold of the general under the arms, helped him stand up in the mud and for one moment the general's head was resting against his shoulder while the body raised itself heavily out of the bathtub and when finally the general had been helped to his feet beside the tub he knew that on one side the mud had come off the body onto his white uniform so that he was now standing there with his uniform divided into a white and a brown half, standing side by side with the general whose skin was divided into a white and a brown half, and once again he said: yes, general (92–93)

We can now summarize the interplay of textual and physical voices we observed in the scene – an interplay that is representative for the composition of *Orchis Militaris* as a whole. If we focus on the words, which are identical to the text of the novel, then we notice that the passage consists of a dialogue in which the narrator gives the floor to several characters in direct discourse, while the extradiegetic, heterodiegetic narrator remains covert. Then a shift occurs to the voice of the anonymous extradiegetic, heterodiegetic narrator who relates the events after the facts (Fig. 1).

Would you cut my hair if I ordered you to cut my hair? Yes, general. Good, help me up and cut my hair.
Now, **said the general, and then he firmly took hold of the general under the arms, helped him stand up in the mud and for one moment the general's head was resting against his shoulder while the body raised itself heavily out of the bathtub and when finally the general had been helped to his feet beside the tub he knew that on one side the mud had come off the body onto his white uniform so that he was now standing there with his uniform divided into a white and a brown half, standing side by side with the general whose skin was divided into a white and a brown half, and once again he said: yes, general**

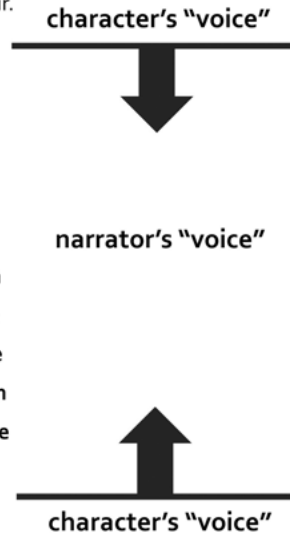


Fig. 1: Narrative voice and character's voice in *Orchis Militaris*

The narrator becomes visible but not prominent in an inquit formula and subsequently in the scene description. But also within the dialogue, the text shifts from one voice to another, it seems. The voice which is obeyed by the other voice is a nurse, then a baroness and finally a general (Fig. 2). These quick unmotivated shifts are not accompanied by idiomatic or stylistic shifts which could mark a difference in character. What is more, the text conflates these figures: the nurse, the baroness, the general. They become interchangeable as figures of authority and oppression.

Maybe you are afraid of us? Yes, sister. Because we	
fought against you? Yes, sister. And won? Yes,	"sister"
sister. Did we win? Yes, sister. Do you believe that	
we won? Yes, sister. Do you believe that we shall	
win again? Yes, sister. In the east too? Yes, my lady	
baroness. In the west too? Yes, my lady	
baroness. And you understand our language?	
Yes, my lady baroness. There ought to be only	"baroness"
one language, one language used over the whole	
world. Yes, my lady baroness. One language used	
over the whole world would promote peace	
among the nations. Yes, my lady baroness. One	
language and one God. Yes, my lady baroness.	
Our language. Yes, general. Shall I really be able to	
walk properly again? Yes, general.	"general"

Fig. 2: Characters' voices in *Orchis Militaris*

Through the abstraction the listener may begin to grasp how several domains – religion, political and military ideology, nationalism – use the same procedures, which are reduced to speech acts: commanding and obeying.

If we focus on what is audible, the narrative technique of the written text is not simply reproduced but extended and enriched. There is not a one-to-one relationship between the textual plurality of voices and the plurality of physical voices, nor between voice and character (or "persona," a term that is better suited in view of the anonymous and vague nature of the characters). A female voice is used for a male persona; two voices are used for one persona; voices are multiplied; and the voice of a child is used for a violent manifesto.

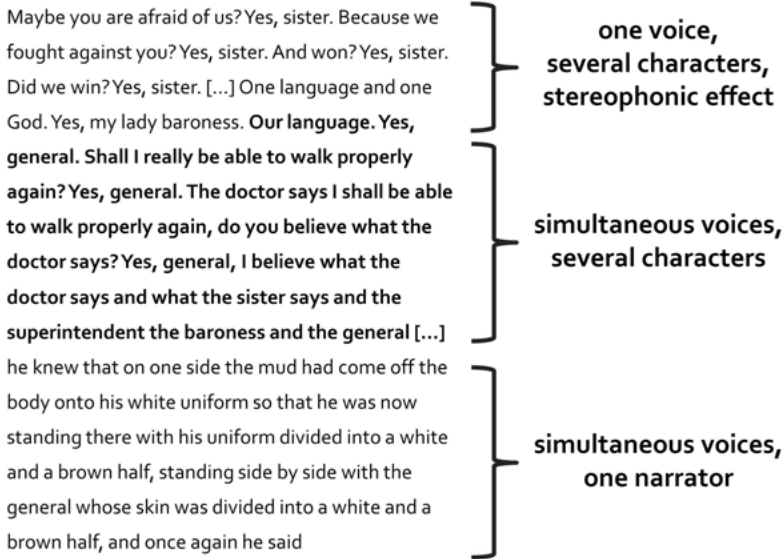


Fig. 3: Simultaneity and alternation of voices in *Orchis Militaris*

Finally, the simultaneity and alternation of monotonous voices can be naturalized on an aural level as a litany. A liturgical layer implicit in the text is foregrounded in the radio play. It is as if we are listening to a Credo or to the Q&A of the catechism. In that way, the form defamiliarizes the content and performs the theme of the radio play: the form shows how language itself takes part in building a community that then considers itself superior, as well as in erasing the differences between oppressor and oppressed, war and religion, ethics and aesthetics. Beside this thematic function of the anti-mimetic, unnatural use of voices, aesthetic aims are involved: the writer and the director of the radio play foreground the rhythmic and ritualistic quality of voices as an alternative to more traditional principles of narrative coherence (such as chronology, causality, psychological motivation). The anti-narrative and anti-mimetic tendency of the piece is also part and parcel of this positive, aesthetic choice.

3. Conclusion

The way in which voices are introduced and arranged in *Orchis Militaris* raises the expectation of narrativity and thwarts narrativization at the same time.

While the content of the dialogues suggests intense human experience, their repetitive and abstract form as well as their vocal presentation suggest distance and disembodiment.

From a narratological point of view, it is interesting to see how “voice” and “character,” “voice” and “person” are severed, so that the radio adaptation of the novel extends the anti-narrative potential of the text. This puts the idea that audible voices elicit a more mimetic response in another perspective. A written text leaves room for the reader to project natural voices (e.g., a natural intonation, a colour and tone that match the content and the presumed sex and age of the narrator or character) onto an unnatural narrative, whereas the radio play can defamiliarize by creating discrepancies between the physical voice, the textual voice, and the content. Zooming out, we can say that experimental audio drama deploys voice and sound in creative ways to question conventional assumptions about narrative logic and about the world outside.

On a theoretical level, then, the study of the radio play, which is largely neglected in transmedial narratology, can enrich narratological debates. The issue of “voice” is only one example of this, and not a minor one, since “voice” is central to the act of narrating and as such a core issue of narrative theory. Our discussion has also shown that the radio play and its theoretical tradition can offer additional insights into the narrative function of soundscapes and the workings of unnatural narratives. In my view, it has also shown that experimental audio drama has a huge potential relevance for unnatural narratology. And if audio-narratology can exist, then the radio play undoubtedly deserves a central role in it.

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Zoë Skoulding

Disappearing Sounds: Poetry, Noise and Narrative

While the musical heritage of lyric poetry clearly offers scope for discussion of sound, its tendency to dwell on states, and even stasis, makes it a less obvious area for discussion of narrative. However, narratives also have points of stasis, and states change. When defined as a lyric poet as opposed to a narrative poet, Peter Gizzi once responded in a discussion: “I think I am a narrative poet – I’m just narrating my bewilderment as a citizen,” explaining the role of “not-knowing” in relation to writing a poem (Casper 2007). “Bewilderment,” through its etymology of leading or going astray introduces a sense of the poem as a journey in which straying may take multiple unknown paths. Through its link with “wilderness,” Gizzi’s remark also suggests poetry’s potential for re-wilding language and unsettling meaning, including the meaning of the term “citizen.” Citizenship is largely taken for granted but it becomes bewildering when its exclusions or injustices are questioned; such is the ethical stance revealed by this comment. The narration of bewildered citizenship therefore questions what appears “natural” and creates alternative perspectives.

In the following discussion, which is based on my own work as poet and sound performer, I will explore the relationship between narrative and nature in the context of sonic environments. I will be discussing my own poetry as a speculative means of creative-critical investigation, rather than from the point of view of a reader or listener, while drawing on anti-mimetic and unnatural narrative theories, particularly as outlined by Brian McHale and Brian Richardson (2013). Although written primarily for the page, my work includes poetry/sound-scape collaborations as well as solo voice performances mediated through electronic effects. These different approaches share a concern with acoustic space, which develops thematically from the written texts that form their starting point. The spatiality of the text and its performance comes to the fore as soon as we consider sound, evoking environments and also being physically shaped by them, from the open air or the city to the dimensions of a room or the spaces in the body. I will consider, from a practitioner’s perspective, the relationship between space and different kinds of narrative time in poetry as it is sounded in performance. In order to do this I put the term “segmentivity,” developed in a narratological frame by Brian McHale (2013), in dialogue with effects noted in sound studies, such as synecdoche, asyndeton and noise.

Peter Hühn and Roy Sommer (2015), defining narration after Jörg Schönert (2004) as “the representation of chains of happenings in a medium by a mediating agent,” suggest that lyric texts “are distinguished by a characteristic variability in the extent to which they use the range of levels and modes of mediation.” In the work discussed here, the medium is both a voice in a space and the writing that precedes voice, providing a score either for my own performance, the reader’s performance or the reader’s imagined silent voicing. The “levels and modes of mediation” therefore include various kinds of focalization and foregrounding of poetic form as well as the ways in which the voice is treated and contextualized in performance. The interface between sound, performance and narratology therefore offers a useful frame for the critical reflection that informs my practice.

Narratological approaches have not been widely embraced within criticism of experimental anglophone poetry; consideration of the poem as narrative has often involved the kind of realist, representational approach that is associated with more mainstream works. This is a concern voiced by Rachel Blau DuPlessis, who has suggested “segmentivity” as a distinguishing feature of poetry, aiming to assert the status of poetry that falls outside of “the hegemony of narrative poetry / mainstream poetry” (DuPlessis and Watkin 2008). She sees narrativity on the one hand, and performativity on the other, as erasing the distinctiveness of poetry. McHale develops the notion of segmentivity in a narratological context in his discussion of poetry as unnatural narrative. Taking issue with Monika Fludernik’s scant attention to poetry in her argument that “we *naturalize* texts by *narrativizing* them,” he draws on avant-garde theorizations of poetry by Veronica Forrest Thomson (1979) and Charles Bernstein (1992) to explore the role of poetic artifice in resisting this assimilation. He notes that artifice is not the same as the unnatural, since “Unnaturalness is a question of a text’s divergence from the model of natural conversational narrative” and can therefore, potentially, be naturalized within that model (McHale 2013, 199). By contrast, he points out that artifice “cannot be naturalized in terms of the natural narrative model; it can only be *motivated* [in the sense used by Jonathan Culler’s *Structuralist Poetics* (2002), referencing Russian formalism] in terms of functional necessity or generic requirements or expectations” (McHale 2013, 200). His analysis explores the way in which poetic artifice may undermine and counterpoint narrative in ways that resist naturalization in texts that do not cease to be narratives. An additional aspect raised by audionarratology is the relation between the “nature” of naturalization and nature as it may be understood in terms of sound and environment.

My work has developed alongside an interest in the experimental poetics of Bernstein, Forrest-Thomson and others, but also in response to a different immediate context in Wales, where there is relatively little in the way of an avant-garde tradition. There is, however, a bilingual situation, which means that everyday life involves tuning in and out of different languages, creating a heightened awareness of how the aural signifier creates a social and political space. For English-speakers with only partial knowledge of Welsh (I fall into this category), the plurality of languages may be experienced as part of a welcome and familiar local soundscape even if the languages are not equally understood. However, when my English voice speaks in this context, the sound of it carries markers of class, region and national identity that are in tension with its environment; it is not “natural” in the sense of transparent or self-evident, just as my citizenship in Wales, though happily adopted, is not genetically derived. This sense of conflict within voice has made me interested in poetic techniques that simultaneously exploit and disrupt traditional forms of lyric expression; it has led me to mesh the voice with field recordings while imagining it as part of a broader social and cultural environment, to use loops and effects that multiply it into a sound texture so that its freight of association can be re-registered as music, or to juxtapose it with other voices in other languages in an attempt to diffuse the dominance of English.

These concerns have led me away from natural conversational narrative and into modes that are less “absorptive” in Bernstein’s terms. Yet as McHale points out, commenting on Bernstein’s poem “The Klupzy Girl,” “poetry that is antiabsorptive at one level can nevertheless be absorptive – hypnotic, enchanting, entrancing, swoony – when we pull back to view it from another, higher level” (206). The inclusion of non-linguistic sound in poetry performance allows absorptive and anti-absorptive elements to work alongside each other. Presenting poetry with music was something I initially developed collaboratively, and with the hope that the non-linguistic aural textures would enable listeners to suspend expectations of narrative clarity or discursive transparency – to hear the poetry in the way that one hears a foreign language as sound, without straining for meaning.¹ From 2004 onwards I had opportunities to perform in international poetry festivals, where the typical pattern of the visiting poet reading first in his or her own language, followed by translation, means that for half of the reading some of the audience will be hearing the sound of the words without fully understanding them. The reading therefore follows a narrative structure in which the audience supposedly moves from hearing language as sound to

1 See Barthes (1985).

the subsequent revelation of meaning, but since meaning in poetry is intricately connected with sound, this process may not be as straightforward as it seems.

Using sound in performance presented itself as an interesting response to this situation because it allowed both languages to be meshed together in a listening experience in which “meaning” may not be the primary concern.² They can take on an equal weight, so that the translator (or reader of the translation) becomes a performer rather than someone functionally providing information, or the revelation of what the poem is “about.” Sound-based performance emphasizes multiplicity of meaning because the performance is one in which the source text is interpreted through translation, and the sound provides a further, complicating dimension of interaction. The narrative movement from incomprehension to epiphany via the translated text is therefore replaced by a situation in which both languages may be heard as sonic material within a soundscape. Rather than inviting inattention to the poem in either language, or attention only to the embodied presence of the foreign poet as she speaks, I was interested in creating a performance space in which both languages could be heard as part of an environment that incorporates non-linguistic sound.

Translation of texts is usually perceived as simultaneous or parallel, but placing the poems in the context of an aural *dérive* allows it to be considered as a journey from one language to another. The aim here was to acknowledge the difference of languages without erasing what may be partially incomprehensible. Translation erases at the same time as it creates, but performance can put both languages into the context of a place in which difference can be encountered. Not all of my sound-based performances have involved translation between languages, but all of them to some extent concern intersemiotic translation in the terms described by Roman Jakobson (1959, 127). This approach also allows a variety of responses to disruptive textual strategies via a non-linguistic form. The sound is not illustrative but has some techniques of collage and repetition in common with the poetry. Having explained some of the context of my practice, I will go on to discuss two different approaches to sound and narrative in performances I have developed in recent years.

² See Skoulding (2011).

1. Narrative Spaces: Synecdoche and Asyndeton in the City

You Will Live in Your Own Cathedral (2008), a sound and poetry collaboration with Alan Holmes, was structured around a sequence of poems from my 2008 collection *Remains of a Future City* that draws on Ivan Chtcheglov's situationist text "Formulaire pour un urbanisme nouveau" (1958). Bearing the titles of a series of different symbolic urban locations such as 'Castle' or 'The Old Walls,' the poems form a *dérive* through an imaginary city, hence there are temporal aspects although the narrative is perceived in terms of space.³ The collaboration involved numerous live performances between 2007 and 2011, and a recorded version published as a pamphlet and CD in 2008.

If narrative relies on memory, then it is always spatial, as suggested by classical and medieval techniques for memorization using the visualization of architectural spaces, such as those of Quintilian and Augustine. Drawing on Michel de Certeau's influential chapter "Walking in the City" (1984), my poems explore street-level experiential perspectives reshaped by memory – the walk as a series of connections in urban space rather than the overview of mapped space. Certeau brings together narrative and spatial elements as he refers to Jean-François Augoyard's analysis of walking in urban space as exhibiting synecdoche and asyndeton.

Synecdoche expands the role of a spatial element in order to make it play the role of a "more" (a totality) and take its place (the bicycle or the piece of furniture in a store window stands for a whole street or neighbourhood). Asyndeton, by elision, creates a "less," opens gaps in the spatial continuum, and retains only parts of it that amount almost to relics. (Certeau 1984, 101)

Certeau's evocative text has informed my composition methods for many years. Fragments observed from different urban locations were brought together as "relics" in my poems, hence the title of the collection, *Remains of a Future City*. Holmes' technique of making field recordings in a number of different European cities, and later collaging them together, exhibits these dual aspects of synecdoche and asyndeton, as auditory information is either selected and amplified, or erased and forgotten. This is an expansion into artistic practice of what already happens in everyday life, as noted in a more recent work jointly

³ For fuller discussion, see Skoulding (2011).

edited by Augoyard and Henry Torgue, where asyndeton is given a specifically sonic context as:

The deletion from the perception or memory of one or many sound elements in an audible whole. Surveys studying everyday sound behaviour show that the amount of “forgotten” or unheard sound is extremely prominent. The asyndeton effect allows the valorization of a portion of the sound environment through evacuation of useless elements from our consciousness. Asyndeton, through its rhetorical origin, refers more to the generic notion of forgetting, whereas erasure is used specifically in relation to practice. (Augoyard and Torgue 2005, 26)

The CD of *You Will Live in Your Own Cathedral* is in three sections, the first with my reading of original texts accompanied by field recordings from our mainly rural locality in north Wales, the second part in Czech, with field recordings from the Prague area, and the third in German, with recordings from Berlin and other German locations. The sites of the recordings, which are logged in the booklet, have a synecdochic relation to place, though the asyndetic linking of these places deliberately “forgets” certain narrative contexts to assert the interlinking of city and countryside as well as a possible parallel between Bangor, a very small Welsh cathedral city, with two major cities of Central Europe. The recordings are altered in length and placed alongside each other but are never otherwise treated, so the dimensions of distinct spaces can still be heard, for example in footsteps in a cathedral that offer moments of locatedness.

There is some degree of representation in the sound although it is disrupted and disruptive. *You Will Live in Your Own Cathedral* suggests a movement through space, but since different recordings are layered over each other, the sound rarely offers a coherent narrative. Placing language within a sound environment places it in a particular temporal and spatial structure that is also related to the process of translation. For example, the German translator Monika Rinck made her own recording of her texts at dawn in Berlin with the sounds of birds echoing outside her window. The place of the translation process is thereby brought into the material fabric of the performed work. However, using recorded sounds has not been intended to validate the authenticity or “naturalness” of the poems but to explore different constructions of sound in space. As Brian Richardson comments, “Antimimetic texts [...] locate impossible perceptions in natural spaces as well as fixing ordinary perceptions in impossible spaces” (Herman et al 2012, 109). The “impossible space” of overlaid recordings is one that breaks down distinctions between rural and urban spaces in ways that undermine the implied narrative of an urban walk.

This echoes a process explored in the poems, as in the following extract from “The Old Walls,” where lichen and wet earth are juxtaposed with the technological city:

behind the smell of wet earth the voice leaves
 the shape of itself and the footprints of walkers
 trace the shell of the city its dead words
 we crawled out of our words tender like snails
 and the new city grows from the loins of the old
 as lichen spreads in acid maps invading and
 retreating the city runs along fingers runs along
 roads and wires and into fields and the sightlines
 run back to the city in wires and the walls
 keep nothing out and the nothing beyond as a cloud
 of eyes moves through the streets and falls like rain

(Skoulding 2008, 13)

There is a collective “we” telling a story about a city in which, as the poem begins, “The wall is who we are and they are not,” but I wanted to disturb this identity by introducing a longer historical perspective on a city’s development and its growth around “dead words,” the linguistic constructs (such as the naming of this or that community and its identification as “we”) that fossilize into architecture, and the dispersal of the collective into technologized and militarized communication, not a “we” but a “cloud of eyes” or “I”s in a city that also inhabits the body. The details are synecdochic, such as fingers and eyes, or the minute patterns of lichen on stone. The process is also asyndetic, structurally if not always grammatically, as it leaps across different time periods to contest the boundary (the wall) that exists at one particular historical moment. The poem does not accept the collective identity of those who might narrate a “natural” version of events. In the same way, the sound that accompanies the poem is multiple and multidimensional.

It is this multiplicity that undermines a singular narrative of place. One of several definitions of noise, from information theory, is a disturbance in a communicated message, and if I thought of poetry as delivering a “message,” that message would doubtless be clearer without the sound. However, I see the relationship between poetry and sound as a response to complex environments, whether culturally, in the clash of languages, or ecologically, in the clash of human and non-human worlds. As Michel Serres writes, “Myriad things shout out. Often deaf to unusual transmissions, our hearing is astonished by the shouts of things which have no name in any language” (Serres 2008, 111). If all matter is expressive, the expression of language can be related to the “expression” of place. However, this is very different from saying “the land speaks” be-

cause this is usually a political claim that hears only one “original” language. The use of sound brings the materiality of different places into conjunction in order to make a new narrative of complex patterns and relationships. The CD version gives the same sequence of poems translated not just into different languages but into sounds corresponding geographically to each one, but the expression of place is arbitrary in terms of national boundaries because what we hear is minutely local – a piece of metal here, a tree creaking there, a footstep there. The artifice of synecdochal detail, asyndetically linked, is a means of exposing the more readily naturalized artifices at work in the narratives of collective identity and nation.

2. Rooms and Noise

Canadian composer and sound ecologist R. Murray Schafer’s question in *The Soundscape: The Tuning of the World*: “Where are the museums for disappearing sounds?” (1977, 180) prompted the explorations developed in my 2013 collection *The Museum of Disappearing Sounds*. Schafer’s work is focused on the traditional rhythms and sound patterns of particular communities as they are being erased by continuous noise of industrialization, and while engaging and important in its time, it is ultimately based on a static notion of place. Rather than seeking the preservation implied by a museum, I am interested in the repetitions and erasures of everyday life that create a noisy relation to lyric and memory. Museums often aim to trap time but sound is experienced as temporal. The title poem dramatizes Schafer’s image of the museum, but this is exactly what the advent of recording technology creates: the computer becomes a repository for all the sounds that happened once in the real world but that can be stored, rearranged and recontextualized. This also is what writing does, incompletely, to the voice, trapping it in time that is outside the social rhythm of speech and therefore fundamentally altering it.

In performances of “The Rooms,” which has a looping and repetitive rather than linear structure, I juxtapose spoken elements with layers of vocals that erase each other, testing the boundary between speech and song. “The Rooms” has also been presented as a collaborative performance with recordings made in different rooms, and with translation.⁴ However, I will focus here on the solo version, which uses only mediated voice and makes use of technology for

⁴ For example, with a Polish translation made and read by Julia Fiedorczuk at the Ars Cameralis Festival, Katowice in 2012.

looping and layering the voice that, in its language of echo and reverberation, refers specifically to aural environments created by different types of room. My live experiments with electronics and manipulation of vocals had begun alongside field recordings in the collaboration with Alan Holmes described above, but I was interested in pursuing the logic of “The Rooms” by thinking about the voice as the primary sonic material. In every case so far, my written poems have preceded their performance; they are not improvised and the thematics of the writing tend to inform the use of sound rather than vice versa.

One theme that kept surfacing during the writing of *The Rooms* was the narrative perception of time. Alva Noë has suggested that a narrativized perception of linear time, which views future activity in terms of arcs of meaning, makes time appear to move more quickly when those arcs are familiar (Noë 2010). Regular habits and predictable behaviours allow us to imagine the unfolding of arcs of future time in such a way that our experience of them is wholly or partly unconscious. “Natural” narratives not only erase multiplicity, but in doing so they also speed up time. If breaking patterns and habits defamiliarizes activity, and thus makes us more aware of time passing, then an important function of artifice in narrative is to slow time. In *S/Z* Roland Barthes emphasizes the importance of re-reading texts in order to discover their multiplicity. If we do not, he argues, we fall prey to consumer society’s pressure to devour texts and then throw them away, and furthermore every new text we read becomes the same text because we do not allow other possibilities to develop (Barthes 1975, 15–16). The slowing of time therefore contains a resistance to marketization as well as having the benefit of making life seem longer. If absorption in narrative makes time pass more quickly by “killing” it, poetry’s artifice and segmentivity, particularly in poetry that deploys the anti-absorptive strategies described by Bernstein, deliberately slows time. Although Bernstein is referring primarily to Language poetry with a high level of linguistic disruption, his comments may be applied to a broader range of poetry that does not offer transparent language or a singular narrative.

The structure of “The Rooms” is a sonnet sequence, though it uses a syllabic rather than metrical count, and the lines are broken into sentence-like units surrounded by white space. To return to McHale,

Poetry *spaces* language – it literally introduces white space (or, in oral poetry, pause or silence) in places where natural narrative (or written prose) has none. The multiple kinds of segmentation in a poem interact with each other in counterpoint (or countermeasure, to use John Shoptaw’s term), producing “chords” (DuPlessis, “Codicil 51”), complex interplays among segments of different kinds or scales. (McHale 2013, 200)

If segmentation produces silence, it must also, as we know, produce noise, since the body is never silent. John Cage, describing his experience in an anechoic chamber notices that “silence was not the absence of sound but was the unintended operation of my nervous system and the circulation of my blood.” He notes also that “silence is not acoustic. It is a change of mind, a turning around” (Cage 1991). This paradox is explored in “Room 201”:

When entering the room he's listening
 for the two silences
 the one inside
 and the one outside the window
 still air
 settled over plumbing and the vague
 hush of wind or traffic
 the way they
 fight each other in his ear

 If there is
 a third silence in the high-toned hum of
 blood
 he's paying no attention

(Skoulding 2013, 58)

My performance of this work with vocal sound only is an intensification of the body's noise that fills all silence before speech begins. The segmentivity of the poem shifts the emphasis on to space rather than onward narrative movement – in this case the space of the body.

Every poem begins “When entering the room,” since what is being presented is a habitual pattern, but I wanted to test this fixed pattern against the notion of multiplicity, which is what the rest of each poem goes on to explore. The numbers of rooms I had entered were initially used as a constraint, and some of the poems contain traces of this process, for example “you / take three steps” and “it's here that everything / is happening twice / once in the body / and once in the words for it” in “Room 321.” As the writing continued, these references became more elliptical, for example “Room 117,” which references 4711 Eau de Cologne, which was itself arbitrarily named after a street number. What had started as a gesture towards OuLiPo evolved into a more personal set of associations, not all of which are evident in the finished poems. The narrative perspective shifts throughout the sequence, beginning in the second person but frequently switching to the first or third person to suggest multiple and unreliable viewpoints.

Within this repetitive pattern katabatic narrative of descent and return is loosely established through intertextual reference to Dante's *Inferno* (“where

we descend / mid-way through this life a tangled wood”), and Dante as filtered through Alice Notley’s epic poem *The Descent of Alette*, in which a mythical heroine enters a series of underground spaces. Jean Cocteau’s film *Orphée* is also directly referenced. The moment in the film where Orphée obsessively listens to the car radio voicing messages from the underworld, such as “L’oiseau chant avec ses doigts,” exemplifies one of the effects of sound filtration – the sense that a voice is coming from somewhere else.⁵ By quoting the line, which is referenced in translation at the end of “Room 204,” I was thinking of the poem as a similar kind of filtration effect:

Room 204

When entering the room you’ve already
crossed it in an arc completing itself
without your knowledge

Footsteps tick digital
this foot
that foot with no memory
while the mind sweeps analog through sound waves
bouncing off four walls

This was the phrase you
remember
each note altering the last
this was its cadence falling from major
to minor
willow over water where birds
chant in broken rivers

It seems that you’re
addicted to this music however
hard you try not to listen to it
The bird sings with its fingers

Twice
The bird
sings with its fingers

Twice
I repeat

(Skoulding 2013, 61)

⁵ In the film, this evokes the wartime radio messages decoded by the French Resistance, so it creates a recent historical as well as a mythical suggestion.

The numerical references, combined with repetition as both a structural device and a thematic interest, led to my realization through the writing process that I was imagining the room as a sounded space as much as a metaphor. Each entry into it is literally, and not only figuratively, an entrance into sound. This is inherent in the sonnet form, both in the meaning of “sonnet” as “little song” and the stanza as a room, a meaning played on in John Donne’s line “we’ll build in sonnets pretty rooms” (Robbins 2014, 154). Beyond these formal literary-historical connotations, performance of the poems led me to consider the relation between the poem as room and the poem in a room, its physical existence through the voice in a given space. In order to consider “expression” as physical and sonic rather than purely emotional, it is helpful to refer to Greg Hainge’s description of noise as a “relational ontology,” its capacity to resist similar to the resistance found in electrical circuits, where:

any expression [...] necessarily enters into a systemic process with its own material ontology (read medium). This medium resists the transmission of the expression at the same time as the expression is entirely dependent on the system at the most fundamental level of base materiality, for its expressive potential can only be actualised in a material assemblage formed between the system and the expression that reconfigures both of them. (Hainge 2013, 16)

A poem operates within several systems and is differently expressive in each of them. There is a relation to noise in my effort to find resistances in the sonnet form, but a more direct link emerges in consideration of the voice. The composer Alvin Lucier’s exploration of the acoustics of recording in a room makes a connection between voice and space that became important for the development of the project. His 1969 composition “I am sitting in a room” begins with Lucier’s voice describing the process that is taking place:

I am sitting in a room different from the one you are in now. I am recording the sound of my speaking voice and I am going to play it back into the room again and again until the resonant frequencies of the room reinforce themselves so that any semblance of my speech, with perhaps the exception of rhythm, is destroyed. What you will hear, then, are the natural resonant frequencies of the room articulated by speech. I regard this activity not so much as a demonstration of a physical fact, but, more as a way to smooth out any irregularities my speech might have. (1969)

What we hear is exactly this process, through 32 repetitions, with the voice distorted at first, but then gradually dissolving into chord-like sounds as the room amplifies frequencies that were not at first audible. Meaningful language disappears and we are left with the recording of a recording of a recording (and so on) in which personal particularity, such as Lucier’s stutter, has given way to pure

noise: it is the resonance of the room itself that we are listening to. The environment, which is normally something to which we pay no attention, becomes an audible focus; it stops being the background.⁶ Commenting on Lucier's work, Timothy Morton notes that "the voice and the room are mutually determining. [...] The voice was always already in its environment. 'I am sitting in a room' sits in a room" (Morton 2007, 48). In referencing Lucier's work in "Room 127," as in the following extract, I am not doing the same thing, since the poem comments on an environment rather than revealing its inseparability from it; it remains a work in the medium of language rather than sound, even if sound is added to it. However, it is in the differences that the audionarratological aspects of my own project emerge.

I'm just playback
 all pauses and stutters
 smoothed out in the dimensions of a room
 you're hearing from another room
 voices
 uninterruptedly saying nothing

 where all that remains is the body's pitch
 inside the words and beyond them
 the size

 of the words filling the room
 no longer
 a voice but the room itself repeating
 the evidence tone for tone
 faithfully
 erasing every note it remembers

(Skoulding 2013, 68)

Narrating a journey into the room of Lucier's work, the "I" of the poem comments on its own derivative status, since it is in a sense playing back Lucier's text as well as referring to the techniques that might be used in performance. My poem does not erase speech as Lucier does but it refers to that process of erasure within a performance that foregrounds the filtration effects of recording. One technique I use is to overlay sung notes or other vocalizations and sustain them with a guitar effects pedal or Kaoss Pad, while another is to make several layers of my voice reading the poem so that the words become fragmented or indistinct, like voices from another room. In this I am aware of the machines'

⁶ Morton's argument for "ecology without nature" notes the discomfort that such a shift in attention can create (2007, 1).

memory-like function, and also their gradual forgetting as further layers are added. Parts of speech remain while others are lost, just as in the field recordings the effects of synecdoche and asyndeton appear in places. The overall sonic effect, frequently drone-like, is not necessarily anti-absorptive, in Bernstein's terms, although the narrative of the poems is disrupted by repetition. In making a sound performance out of the vocal materials of the poem, I was responding to a longstanding interest in noise music, including that of Merzbow, KK Null and Lasse Marhaug. Maja Ratke's work, in which a highly accomplished range of vocalizations breaks down the distinction between speech and noise, body and space, provides a parallel in poetry. I would not, however, describe my work as "noise poetry," or see it as operating in the same way, because although noisy effects emerge they are subordinated to the narrative explorations of the poem.

An elucidation of this distinction is made by Hainge, who argues that by his definition John Cage's "4'33" is not "noisy" because the sound is ultimately subordinated to a musical structure – if everything is music, then noise no longer exists. By contrast, he argues, Lucier's "I am sitting in a room" is noise because it is formed out of an intensification of the noise that already exists in speech, so what we hear is the interrelationship of voice, room and technology unfolding in time. One of the ways in which the artifice of poetry distinguishes it from "natural" narrative is by foregrounding the material signifier in its construction. However, it is artifice, too, paradoxically, that separates the poem from a process like Lucier's in which the materiality of sound is asserted to the extent that the work of art no longer just references but actually becomes the environment in which it takes place. The artifice in question is the illusion of a voice that, despite the mediation of recording, is able to give fragmentary perspectives on its world rather than being part of it. A comparison with Lucier reveals the degree of artifice involved in creating a voice, written or spoken, that is capable of something that might be considered natural narrative. Lucier's voice might be said to be most natural when it has been fully broken down into the flute-like, organ-like tones of the room's resonance, and when language has been erased, although it is at this point entirely mediated by technology.

3. Conclusion

The use of audio effects in narrative is often related to or even described as background sound or background music, but bringing the background into the foreground reveals both system and expression as simultaneously natural and constructed. In performance, the poem in an unfamiliar language may recede into

the background for one listener and not for another, or at one point and not another. When poetry is juxtaposed with environmental or other vocal sound as I have described, multiple foci may similarly be created through the effects of synecdoche and asyndeton. If lyric poetry is characterized narratologically by variable mediation, as Hühn and Sommer suggest, an audionarratological approach may reveal how its shifts and mediations of perspective can be heard in relation to place. Heard as an expression against a background, whether cultural, formal and aesthetic or physical and spatial, its artifice creates resistance and noise as we locate ourselves in linguistic and ecological environments.

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Thijs Festjens

Aural Energies in Rimini Protokoll's *Call Cutta*: Sound, Documentary, Performance and Narratological Aspects of "The World's First Mobile Phone Theatre"

The mobile phone theatre project *Call Cutta* (2005) is a one-to-one performance conceived by Rimini Protokoll, a label for the documentary and experimental theatre of the Swiss German, now Berlin-based Helgard Haug, Stefan Kaegi and Daniel Wetzel, three directors quite well-known for their situated theatre actions in urban space (*Stadtrauminszenierungen*). In this paper, in order to position Rimini Protokoll as part of a neo-documentary trend, the most recent turn towards *real* people, I will give a short history of documentary theatre in Germany. Furthermore, it is not my aim to undertake a full narratological analysis of Rimini Protokoll's *Call Cutta*.¹ Rather, I will document a number of recent theoretical and conceptual debates in sound studies which touch upon the analysis of this play. As I see it, narratology has to take note of these debates in order to avoid the simple shift of metaphor from sound to vision. I will not argue that audioception should be prioritized. Rather, I would like to give more prominence to the "intermediary sensory role" (Goodman 2010, 47) that sound and thus auditory impressions could play in the analysis of performances, in particular performances like Rimini Protokoll's that link back to the tradition of epic theatre and documentary experiments. Drawing on sound studies will supplement the visual and tactile modalities of sensory information that we acquire.

1. Denouncing the Ocular Tyranny

Due to a phenomenon known as noise pollution, which in recent years has spread from the urban to the global world by gradually conquering the acoustic space, we are made aware that our soundscape has been transformed enormously. Steve Goodman (2010), for example, elaborates in his book with the ominous

¹ For some pointers to a narratological analysis of Rimini Protokoll, see Martens and Elshout (2012). For recent theoretical takes on the compatibility of narratology and theatre/performance, see Vanhaesebrouck (2004), Breger (2012), Tecklenburg (2014) and Nünning and Schwanecke (2015).

title *Sonic Warfare* on the intertwining of sound, affect and the ecology of fear. Coincidentally, upon writing this article, the intervallic blaring and droning of a generator that was used to carry out demolition work close to my work place could best be described as an invisible sonic force of which the centrifugal radiation was not just heard, but also felt as it pervaded my body and turned it at times into a mere entity in a vibrational event. As a corollary of the emanation of those visceral vibrations, my sensory balance was each time slightly shaken as the brain waves were transiently modulated in a negative manner by the sheer impact of the undesirable sound that I could hardly filter out. I am aware that my take on sound and its apperception is familiar. This ecological understanding may be seen as typical of the early phase of sound studies as pioneered by Raymond Murray Schafer in the 1960s. By recalling this sonic event, it should be clear that, from my point of hearing, the eye (the master trope of early narratology, but more generally also of Western science) should gracefully dismount “the pyramid of the senses” (Goodman 2010, 7) and make way for a new, more symbiotic sensory dispensation, in which the whole spectrum of senses may be emphasized.²

This overvaluation of sight, which is quite common nowadays, stems from the period of ancient Greek philosophy and experience. Don Ihde refers to Heidegger, who recognised “the intimacy between vision and the ultimately real for Greek thought” (Ihde 2007, 6), but he also points out that there had already been some minor warnings in the past, like Empedocles’ emphatic call “for a democracy of the senses” and Xenophanes’ holistic notion that “experience in its deepest form is global” (Ihde 2007, 8). To support my claim for the need of a sensorial paradigm shift, it is worth taking a look at the sensory organisation of both spatial and temporal perception. Hatwell (1993) refers to experimental situations with visually non-impaired children and adults. Since these experiments revealed that “vision is dominant in spatial perception,” she concludes that “non-visual spatial information (haptic and auditory) tends to be coded visually” (Hatwell 1993, 18). More interestingly, though, if the experimental task concerns “temporal perceptions (rhythmic structures, for example) or if it is verbal and implies linguistic material, audition dominates vision and perceptual conflicts are

² Already in the 1980s, Joachim-Ernst Berendt called for “the transition from a visual to an auditive culture” (in Welsch 1997, 150). Near the end of the last century, Wolfgang Welsch reinforced this idea and called for an “auditive cultural revolution,” stating that “the person who hears is also the better person – one, that is, able to enter into something different and to respect instead of merely dominating it” (Welsch 1997, 150). Whether or not they are right, it is true that the visual dominance has lasted for more than two thousand years and unfortunately, not always for the good of mankind.

solved by auditory capture” (Hatwell 1993, 17).³ By moving our body through urban space, spatial as well as temporal perception comes into play. Moreover, as we stride along, we cannot solely rely on the five exteroceptive senses, but they must be supplemented by the interoceptive (also called visceral) and first and foremost by the proprioceptive ones, as those relate to one’s position, gravity, orientation and equilibrium. It is by combining all those different “sensory modalities” that we are able to grasp Brian Massumi’s notion of “affective sensorium” (qtd. in Goodman 2010, 220) as it correlates with what Michel Chion has called “transsensorial perception” (Chion 1994, 136). In Chion’s model, “there is no sensory given that is demarcated and isolated from the outset” (Chion 1994, 137). He distinguishes it from the Rimbaudian and Baudelarian correspondences as in his idea of “intersensoriality,” “each sense exists in itself, but encounters others at points in contact” (Chion 1994, 137). By linking the affective sensorium to our transsensorial perception, we might break the dominance of vision that “depends upon the separation of the senses one from another, and the existence of vision as an arbitrating meta-sense, capable of distinguishing, overseeing and correcting the operations of the other senses” (Connor 2004, 65–66). It is with the transsensorial, but primary aural perception in mind that I will focus on Rimini Protokoll’s mobile phone theatre *Call Cutta*. To situate this intercontinental phone play within the context of German documentary theatre, the following paragraph aims at giving a brief overview of the genre’s history.

2. Sailing the Three Waves of German Documentary Theatre

When one thinks of theatre, it is mostly understood to be the performance of a dramatic script by professional actors who know their lines by heart and who are instructed by directors devoted to breathe new life into canonical works. As I will show, documentary theatre deliberately breaks with these conventions. The first wave of German documentary theatre rose under the sign of the historical avant-garde movements and got a firm foothold in the period of the Weimar Republic and its radical turn towards modernity. The post-World War I vacuum provided a favourable climate to socio-political and economic upheavals. Drawing on the

³ In the introductory chapter to a book about tactile perceptual processes, Hatwell later restates those conclusions, as she notes that “[a]udition is specialized in the perception of successive information and it is therefore the most efficient modality for the perception of temporal stimuli (duration, rhythms, speech, etc.), whereas vision excels in space perception” (Hatwell 2003, 2).

forms of Expressionism that strove for social renewal, the stage director Erwin Piscator had also taken note of the positively destructive forces of Dadaism. Thus he became eager to mobilize the great potential of theatre as a vehicle of propaganda, resulting in the foundation of the Proletarian Theatre in Berlin in October 1920. On this theatrical platform he was able to launch “massive agit-prop productions” (Irmer 2006, 18) in order to buttress the class struggle. With his experimental use of documentary material, Piscator generated widespread public resonance. The theatrical innovator also took his cue from the New Objectivity movement’s radical coming to terms with social reality, describing his play *Trotz alledem! (In Spite of Everything!)* (1925) as “a montage of authentic speeches, essays, newspaper cuttings, appeals, pamphlets, photographs, and film of War and the Revolution, of historical persons and scenes” (qtd. in Fisher Dawson 1999, 69). Indeed, the introduction of *epic* techniques such as film- and slide-projection, scene-titles on placards, and newspaper cuttings into theatre was revolutionary and broke down prevailing stylistic conventions of naturalistic drama.⁴ The concept of *documentary* drama was hypostasised by Piscator himself when he reflected back on *In Spite of Everything!* and saw it as the first play where “zum erstenmal das politische Dokument textlich und szenisch die alleinige Grundlage bildet” [‘the political document was the sole basis for text and scenic work’] (Piscator 1968, 63; see also Barton 1987, 42; Irmer 2006, 18). Innovative in this respect was Piscator’s rearrangement of factual elements taken out of a referential reality and put into a dramatic montage that did away with both the aesthetics of illusionist drama and the subjectivity of Expressionist drama. In their stead, the documentary drama served an immediate and radical political purpose. The documentary material consists of either original documents or artefacts as its primary sources. One could thus argue that the documentary material used and composed for the scenic performance was not subordinated to the dramatic narrative, but rather acquired agency itself. As such, documents were either presented on stage as sheer artefacts endowed with documentary value, or they were mediated as orally recited texts through the bodies of the performers. By their very nature, Piscator’s early and highly politicised agitprop performances were also affectively contagious sonic and vibrational events during which sound energy was radiated massively. As sound colonises the audience, the sound waves that were then created by the performers propagated and reverberated deeply within the proletarian audience. The impetus of

4 Brecht’s famous epic style, focusing on the so-called alienation effects (*Verfremdungseffekte*), his visions of an alterable world and his Marxist method of dialectical materialism were greatly indebted to Piscator’s political-revolutionary theatre.

Piscator's political theatre thus not merely lay in disseminating truthful political facts, but in its aim to revolutionize the existing political order.

If the first wave in German documentary theatre emerged in the 1920s (Irmer 2006, 17), or more precisely from 1924 to 1929 (Barton 1987, 1), the second one must be situated in the long aftermath of post-World War II. This second wave arose in the neo-avant-garde of the 1960s (Irmer 2006, 17), more exactly from 1963 to 1970 (Barton 1987, 1). Touching upon war-related politically sensitive issues "not yet being debated in public," its documentary plays "offered a dramaturgy that replaced fictional narrative or parable with 'real' situations and characters based on documents and research, structured and arranged for the stage" (Irmer 2006, 17). With his staging of the first documentary plays by Rolf Hochhuth, Heinar Kipphardt and Peter Weiss at the *Freie Volksbühne* in Berlin, Piscator made a decisive contribution to the rise of this second wave (Barton 1987, 48).⁵ Moulded by the discipline of fact, the documentary plays were therefore characterised by their reliance on historical documents. Although Hochhuth's play was meant to provoke new historical insights, his idea of an "imaginative truth" (Innes 1979, 168) still prevailed over the sources of factual evidence. To catch the historical reality as adequately as possible, Kipphardt, by contrast, based his play solely on transcripts. His respect for factual accuracy notwithstanding, he still had to condense thousands of pages into a dramatic play of three hours, so he had to select, arrange and (re)formulate the material (Innes 1979, 168–169). Every selection is subjective and therefore *suspicious*, as the material that is being highlighted and juxtaposed in the resulting play might conceal significant information that was left out by the author. The discontinuities caused by this selection might also lead to misunderstandings, contradictions and even paradoxes. Finally, Weiss' first play lingers between "factual accuracy and imaginative truth," because his factual language was based on Naumann's reports of the Frankfurt Auschwitz Trials, but he still managed to introduce "interpretation as if it were testimony" (Innes 1979, 175), as Naumann himself indicated in hindsight. Moreover, as the subtitle suggests, the documentary play was an oratorio in eleven cantos, thus aestheticising the discourse through sung free verse lines. The authors of the second wave may have come to an understanding that the factual material utilized could no longer be impartially put at the service of scenic agitation, as had been the case with Piscator's early productions. Contrary to the anti-aesthetic fervour of this phase of documentary poetics (Zeller

5 The premieres in case are Hochhuth's *Der Stellvertreter* (*The Representative*) (1963), Kipphardt's *In der Sache J. Robert Oppenheimer* (*In the Matter of J. Robert Oppenheimer*) (1964) and Weiss' *Die Ermittlung* (*The Investigation*) (1965).

2010), one can only conclude that the document was being integrated into the artwork in such a way that the final product was likely to be understood as a work of art itself. The tape recorder was the iconic marker of authenticity of this age, but none of the plays actually delivered on the promise (or phantasm) of yielding unmediated access to the voices of victims that had been hitherto silenced for various ideological reasons. The terseness of the aesthetic means of the second wave of documentary performance is to some extent compensated for when one takes into account the spectacle of scandal these montage plays undoubtedly sought to elicit. Authors such as Hochhuth certainly used this extended stage to substantiate their conviction that documentary stage plays remained a political forum with a possible political impact.⁶

Since the “late 1990s” (Irmer 2006, 17), we have entered a third wave of documentary-based theatre projects in Germany. According to Irmer, this third wave “explores the phenomena of the present through an elaborate understanding of media culture, the theory of deconstruction, and forms of theatre that are not primarily based on text” (Irmer 2006, 20). Contemporary directors like the theatre collective Rimini Protokoll resort to documentary strategies when they attempt to document new realities, such as the conditions of labour under the spell of flexible working arrangements and the precarious short-term information economy. When they do so, they either have recourse to tried and trusted methods of the documentary avant-gardes of the first wave, or they call those methods into question. Their works often deal with the performativity of subjective realities within an urban and social context that is shaped by a series of communicative attempts between performers, presented or mediated documents and a more participatory audience. As Shannon Jackson specifically refers to Rimini Protokoll, who “began to grapple with art’s imbrication *within* rather than valiant separation *from* the social formations they critiqued” (Jackson 2011, 168), examining their at times eye- and ear-catching theatrical approach thus offers a good opportunity to show that the status of the document has undergone an essential change.

⁶ Peter Handke strongly contested such a possibility, as in his view, “Das Theater als gesellschaftliche Einrichtung scheint mir unbrauchbar für eine Änderung gesellschaftlicher Einrichtungen. Das Theater formalisiert jede Bewegung, jede Bedeutungslosigkeit, jedes Wort, jedes Schweigen: es taugt nicht zu Lösungsvorschlägen, höchstens für Spiele mit Widersprüchen.” [‘theatre as a social institution is unusable for a change of social institutions. Theatre formalises every movement, every insignificant detail, every word, every silence; it cannot be used to suggest solutions, at most it can play with contradictions’] (Handke 1969, 305, my translation).

3. Rimini Protokoll's Experimental and Documentary Approach

Being one of the leading exponents of present-day theatre for which they have acquired international recognition, Rimini Protokoll's productions show that they have re-thought theatre from the bottom up. Since the turn of the century, this non-hierarchical "directorial cluster" (Mumford 2013, 153) has worked together in different combinations and it has produced over fifty works in the fields of theatre, live art, radio plays and installations. I consider their theatre to be documentary because it tends to join the *reality trend*⁷: it is testimonial in nature and brings the *theatre of the real*⁸ not only to the stage, but also into city spaces. The term documentary refers to Rimini Protokoll's use of *theatrical ready-mades* as a primary resource for their works: instead of performing drama texts in which they re-present persons from the past or present, non-professional performers *act* or rather present themselves on stage as *experts* of their own quotidian lives. These *real people* are being found through intense research, interviewing and casting procedures. In this regard, the theatricalisation of society in which everyone enacts one's own role has been essential to the development of Rimini Protokoll's documentary approach. It is important, though, to distinguish between works in which the classic mode of the front stage is being kept and those on location. The former comprise theatre projects *Sabention* (2004) and the *100% city series* (since 2008), the latter include works in which the supposedly direct encounter with the *experts of everyday life* proceeds via ambient co-presence in non-theatrical spaces, like in *Call Cutta* (Berlin, 2005), *Cargo Sofia – A Bulgarian Truck Ride* (2006) or *50 Akten-kilometer (50 Kilometres of Files)* (2011). Another distinction could be drawn as well. In the *100% city series*, the stage is being utilised as the representation of the city in which the play takes place. In *Call Cutta*, however, it is the other way around as the city spaces themselves represent the theatre stages on which the audience member has to perform. One could argue that in the latter case, voices and

7 According to Mumford, Reality Theatre is "a mode of theatre performance that has been prevalent since the early 1990s and which exists across diverse historical and emergent genres, including autobiographical, community, documentary and verbatim theatre" (Mumford 2013, 153). It is thus a term we use to denote performances that present contemporary people and their lives on stage, either in person or in a scripted text based on real life interviews and documents.

8 *Theatre of the Real* (2013) is also the title of Carol Martin's study of international theatre plays and performances that engage with contemporary epistemologies of reality.

sounds become even more important because there are no longer *spectators* who have actors in sight.

It is important to emphasize that Rimini Protokoll themselves are very aware of the fact that their plays are not just about the “intrusion of reality” (Lehmann 1999, 175) into the theatre. Fictional aspects are inherent in their aesthetics. A play like *Sabonation* might be less characterized by a close-meshed interweaving of reality and fiction, but *Call Cutta* certainly is, as the call-centre agents are, for instance, free to shape the conversation the way they want. There is only a basic script that should be followed. Either way, the so-called real aspect in Rimini Protokoll’s plays consists of “various facets of fictionality, reality and theatricality” (Dreyse 2007, 97). Thus, I should invert my previous statement about the intrusion of reality into the theatre, as the impression of authenticity arises precisely thanks to the theatrical framework. The impression of authenticity is an effect of the staging. Consequently, in the light of an aesthetics of authenticity, the question is not if authenticity on the stage is possible, but if it should be striven for at all. As the experts are brought on a stage, the theatrical framework ensures that a certain distance is being created. Even if the experts sound real, the possibility of fiction (as an alternative status of reality) can never be excluded. So the claim of an *intrusion* of reality should be reduced to a *reminiscence* of reality, because it is only in moments in which the fictionalization falls through that we are reminded of reality. Fiction is only possible if a split, a distance to reality is kept. So in moments in which one of the experts does something *wrong* on stage, like forgetting his lines, reality really breaks out and we are reminded of the staging as such.

4. Summoning Aural Energies

Before we delve deeper into *Call Cutta*, it is useful to draw on the notion of theatrical energies as developed by Freddie Rokem in the field of dramaturgy studies. In his book *Performing History: Theatrical Representations of the Past in Contemporary Theatre* (2000), he pursues the question of “how the complex semiotic economy of emotions” is being “transposed, perceived, and experienced in specific performances about history, and in particular how the actors on the stage transmit such moments [where everything seems to be at stake] to the spectators” (Rokem 2000, 188). Interestingly, he devotes the last chapter of his book to what is called *theatrical energies*, which “shape a very crucial dimension of the notion of performing history” (Rokem 2000, 188), which in turn, he believes, helps one to better understand theatre in general. Rokem refers to Aristotle, for whom the concept of energy belonged to the field of rhetorical ex-

pressions. It is the art by which a speaker is able to present the facts before the eyes of the listener, something which of course is not limited to the theatrical stage. The energies that the actors create while performing can trigger emotional responses in the spectators. In this regard, Rokem argues that “artistic creativity in general, and acting in particular, seems to carry a strong transgressive potential” (Rokem 2000, 190), and because of this transgressive potential, I would like to bring his notion of theatrical energies to the documentary theatre of Rimini Protokoll. I will argue that in Rimini Protokoll's mobile phone theatre *Call Cutta*, transgressive potential is being realized by way of summoning performative and, more specifically, aural energies from within the participants themselves.

Call Cutta investigates what happens when the Transatlantic dialogue does not serve some sale or trade, but the seduction of a participant through his own urban space. As an intercontinental phone play between two people that have never met before, it also deals with the theatricality of service in the light of the globalization process. According to Wetzel, Rimini Protokoll got the idea when they were in New York: when one calls to order a pizza, a call-centre employee based in India will answer and take your order as “several New York Pizzerias have outsourced their telephone ordering services” (qtd. in Van Lindt 2008) to low-wage countries. As a consequence of these globally outsourced customer service operations, these Indian call-centre employees often adopt an industrial personality by anglicising their names and by trying to mimic the accent of the (potential) customers. The documentary aspect of the call-centre's mimicry lies in the fact that the reality particles of a theatricalized society have spread globally as daily professional *performances* are demanded from the Indian phone operators, who are “actors by training and definition” (Wetzel qtd. in Van Lindt 2008). The performative displays of the Indian customer service employees are theatricalized simulations that mirror a Western (or even global) economic reality, or, as formulated by Balme, “[p]erfect role-playing and identification with character, long since derelict in postdramatic theatre itself, have been resuscitated and re-evaluated in the global economy” (Balme 2014, 187). For their mobile phone theatre, Rimini Protokoll managed to aestheticize this given economic reality by casting a few of Kolkata's Bengali call-centre employees (and even some people with no prior experience in this field) and turning them into aural tour guides.

5. Sharing the Acoustic Space

Now that I have contextualized *Call Cutta* in its documentary framework, it is possible to examine to what extent the voice of the Indian phone operator serves as a sensory navigation aid for the audience member's sequence of experiences in his bodily as well as urban resonating space. On Rimini Protokoll's website, the following introduction words to the play can be read:

The play starts the moment your cell phone is ringing. You walk through the city, the show is at the phone. A voice comes closer – whoever it is on the other side of the line [,] the two of you are transcontinental partners for the next 60 minutes. You head off as a spectator, but you might become the user, the agent, the hero of your personal set (Rimini Protokoll 2009).

From this statement alone, we can deduce that *Call Cutta* is a one-to-one performance that consists of a telephone conversation and a guided interactive city tour. For this theatre to succeed, audience participation is mandatory. Equipped with a mobile phone and headphones, the participant gets walking directions from the voice of an invisible and unknown Indian call-centre agent and sets off on a journey of discovery through a partially unfamiliar Berlin. As indicated, *Call Cutta* turns the city into a theatre space. The classic co-presence of actors and audience is transformed into an acoustic presence as there is no longer a concrete geographical place to be shared. The mobile phone is used as a technical extension of the body, a perceptual prosthetic device that works as an amplifying, detachable organ which helps the participant to overcome some limitations of his biological sensorium. In this case, it is about capturing the sound waves of deliberate linguistic commands, uttered by an agent located at a distance of several thousands of kilometres and whose voice is converted into transmitted signals that pass through communication satellites stationed in space. As a result, the internal soundscape of the participant is being entered and extended for the duration of the interactive city tour.

The question arises: where is the exact location of the conversation, in Berlin, in Kolkata or somewhere in between? As soon as the connection is established, both the participant and the agent are immersed in a shared acoustic space that varies as *placelessness* is precisely a characteristic of the mobile phone. The user of a mobile phone is part of the immediate surroundings in real space as much as he is part of a virtual space in which he imagines his conversational partner. Consequently, proximity might grow as distance is being upheld and the agent is indeed very well able to affect the participant's perception whilst walking, as calling consists of a special combination of closeness and distance,

which is similar to Walter Benjamin's pairing of trace and aura.⁹ Whilst the participant's sense of hearing is being enhanced through the mobile phone, he is not deprived of the sense of sight, which thus resolves the so-called "conflict between sight and sound" (McLuhan 1964, 16) that seems to be inherent in overly mediatized urban societies. In the shared acoustic space, the intersubjective perception of each other's presence is auditory only, both participants sense the presence of someone who is absent at the same time. This shared acoustic space appears ghostlike as it solely comes into being by way of auditory sense perception. It is precisely that layer of invisibility that makes the shared acoustic space present while one is partly absent from one's physical space.¹⁰ In contrast to the immobile structure of visual space, the spherical and dynamic character of acoustic space turns one into the centre of a virtually borderless space, or as Schafer puts it, "[w]e are always at the edge of visual space, looking into it with the eye. But we are always at the centre of auditory space, listening out with the ear" (Schafer 2005, 72). In his article about the role of interactivity in *Call Cutta*, Ernst has a clear grasp of one's unavoidable entanglement between hearing and seeing whilst one participates in the interactive mobile phone theatre play:

Walking with your ear pressed to a stranger's voice (alienated twofold by accent, dialect and electronic transmission) is, in itself, a very special experience. It ultimately entails splitting one's own audio-visual perception. The city's sights, which usually serve as very familiar means of orientation, are transformed metaphorically through the stranger's voice, the constant voice-over, leading your steps into a movie before your eyes. (Ernst 2009, 21)

The "visual-aural split in telecommunication" (Ernst 2009, 22) widens the participant's hearing space and it becomes more receptive to the call-centre agent's voice. In general, the characteristic of voices, tones and noises is such that we can separate them from their origins. When we just listen to them and do not think about the objects and subjects from which they spring, they become tactile

⁹ In his *Arcades Project* we read: "*The trace is the appearance of a nearness, however far removed the thing that left it behind may be. The aura is the appearance of a distance, however close the thing that calls it forth. In the trace, we gain possession of the thing; in the aura, it takes possession of us*" (qtd. in Hansen 2008, 340). The original reads: "Die Spur ist Erscheinung einer Nähe, so fern das sein mag, was sie hinterließ. Die Aura ist Erscheinung einer Ferne, so nah das sein mag. In der Spur werden wir der Sache habhaft; in der Aura bemächtigt sie sich unser" (Benjamin 1982, 560).

¹⁰ Something similar arguably happens when visitors in museums and galleries use audio guides. See Mildorf, this volume, for further discussion.

in their quality and we perceive them as a modification of the space of our own presence. It is similar to the Heideggerian concept of being beside oneself (*ein Außersichsein*) that leads to better awareness of being-in-the-world (*Dasein*).

6. Aural Navigation through Urban Narration

The unmistakably personal approach in this kind of contemporary documentary theatre obliges us to rethink the existing concept of the theatregoer. The prominence of sound in this transformation may help us to attend to the one-sidedness of the very term *spectator*. In *Call Cutta*, the spectator is a performing participant whose movements are directed by a phone operator. By following the directions given aurally, his visual focus is reshaped to such a degree that the urban places that are usually experienced unconsciously are performatively transformed into meaningful spaces and become the scenes of a personal affair. By contrast, the phone operator remains static, but becomes the director of each individual theatre walk that he guides. Remarkably, this phone operator has never been to Berlin, his knowledge of the city is limited to what he is given in the script that is seen on the computer screen. In this regard, Bastajian rightly speaks of “somewhat pre-mapped choreographies” (Bastajian 2008, 2). The script indeed serves as a map in which many visual details are listed by which the operator is able to determine the constantly switching locations of the participant. The starting point of the mobile theatre play is thus not of a textual kind, but rather spatial as the participant has to walk from the theatre Hebbel am Ufer (HAU) to the historic Potsdamer Platz. By walking and moving through the urban space, the participant creates a linear trajectory similar to writing narrative lines for a story. By doing so, he transforms a small part of Berlin into a text that is only readable in a metanarrative sense. Or as the French historian and philosopher Michel de Certeau suggests, one should be lifted to the summit of a high tower and look down to see all the different pedestrian trajectories that make up the “immense textur-ology” (de Certeau 1984, 92) of the city.¹¹ Whilst the participants are thus following a scripted pattern provided by Rimini Protokoll, it is particularly noteworthy that the scripted steps are not obligatory. Thus, the participant is not forced to stick to the prescribed path. In this kind of documentary approach, no overpowering narrative voice is to be heard. The participant might thus want to interrupt the narrative flow and decide to sit on a bench and focus entirely on the exchange with the agent. The conversation might even turn into an aural love af-

11 On de Certeau's conception of spaces, see also Skoulding, this volume.

fair. Thus, a question about political-historical information about the relationship between Germany and India can be followed by: "Have you ever fallen in love on the phone?" (in O'Rourke 2013, 93).

As the act of telling, in itself, represents a special course of action, a narrative, too, is able to create spaces that can be experienced and co-created. As a mobile phone theatre (or performance) walk, *Call Cutta* is full of the episodic narratives of chance encounters, urban legends, confidential self-narration and intercultural exchanges. In addition, it revolves around the macro-narrative of big history via the historical account of Subhas Chandra Bose's visit to Berlin. Bose was a controversial Indian freedom fighter who in World War II sought to forge ties with the Axis powers of Germany and Italy in order to fight against British colonial rule.¹² As the participant follows the urban itinerary as a narrative trail, he is confronted with/guided through a succession of five scenes with photographs that relate to Bose. We can easily draw parallels with the five act story structure of classical drama and with the stationary drama (*Stationendrama*) of many Expressionist plays. As Jen Harvie points out, this particular form of moving around has precedents not only in medieval biblical drama, "where audiences would walk around a series of pageants to follow a developing story," but also in site-specific theatre such as "promenade theatre" and even in the forms of the "*flâneur* and the *dérive*," types which challenge the dominant coding of urban spaces (Harvie 2009, 57). The presented photographs serve as historical documents, visual traces that are aurally backed by partly real and partly fictitious stories about Bose. The Indian history lesson, though, is only one in a myriad of narrative threads and cues that can help to keep the conversation going. More important are the effects it has on the imagination of the participant, the experience in itself and the interpersonal aspect of a co-operative intercontinental dialogue (Ruesch 2007, 177). The walking narrative itself is made possible by a multitude of spaces that the participant generates and/or passes through. We could divide these spaces into four categories: perceptual and physical spaces on the one hand, and real and imaginary spaces on the other hand. While the physical space that is relevant for the walking narrative has a four-dimensional structure, the private perceptual space consists mainly of separate and at times co-present sense modalities such as visual, tactile, acoustic and proprioceptive perception. Interestingly, in the experience of directionality, only the visual and tactile modalities are able to indicate clear spatial

¹² On 29 May 1942, Bose managed to meet with Hitler, but their encounter was not fruitful as the Führer comprehended that there was no clear advantage to be gained by supporting the Indian cause and therefore "rejected Bose's request for military assistance" (Getz 2002, 65).

directions. In contrast, as each sound reveals a kind of shape that has an “auditory aura” (Ihde 2007, 79), one’s auditory field is omnidirectional by nature, which makes it harder to get a precise sense of directionality. As real as aural spatiality is, it does not need a physical space. A part of the participant’s perceived acoustic space can thus be linked to a part that is spatially separated from him, namely that of the phone operator. For as long as the theatre walk lasts, this shared acoustic space is casting a virtual veil over the scenes that the participant experiences. In that sense, the dialogue of this shared acoustic space gives birth to an imaginary diegetic space, too. Therefore, as the theatre walk progresses from one scene to the next, the participant’s imaginary space is coloured by the stories about the Indian freedom fighter.

With de Certeau’s *The Practice of Everyday Life* in mind, Nina Tecklenburg contends that spaces are generated performatively (Tecklenburg 2014, 204), mostly by people in motion. Her interest lies in the narrative qualities that art walks possess.¹³ At the borders of all the different spaces that are generated and moved through, “metaleptic effects appear” (Tecklenburg 2014, 212, my translation), resulting in many overlapping diegetic levels. Different acts seem to converge in the creation of the participant’s own narrative space as long as he is performing the theatre walk: the act of listening to the phone operator, the act of interpreting the stories that are heard, the act of imagining, the act of intervening (in the conversation) and the act of inscribing the moving body into the urban text of the city. Theatre performances in a classic setting are mostly limited to visual and aural input. By contrast, in order to create and perform a personal narrative spatiality, a play such as *Call Cutta* not only stimulates the participant’s visual and auditory, but also his kinaesthetic imagery. In his approach to the urban sense-scape, almost the whole of the participant’s affective sensorium comes into play. Agreeing with the premise that there is a “generative nexus between action, perception, and conception” (Manning 2009, 2), it is the embodied experience of the participant that is foregrounded. An embodied cognition benefits from this transsensorial perception, turning the theatre walk into a kinaesthetic performance. It should be noted, however, that the experience might be impacted and fragmented by sensory overstimulation such as sound overload, as urban noise tends to complicate or even disrupt mobile conversation.

¹³ In the introduction to her book, Tecklenburg briefly summarizes her experience as being a participant in Rimini Prokoll’s site-specific truck ride performance *Cargo Sofia* (Tecklenburg 2014, 20–21). *Call Cutta* is not mentioned.

When Oberländer states that *Call Cutta* could well be “eine verstörende Mischung aus Stadtführung, Geschichtslektion, Telefonflirt und Selbsterfahrungstrip” [‘upsetting mixture of city tour, history lesson, telephone flirting and self-experience trip’] (Oberländer 2005, my translation), it is because the transition between the different diegetic levels might unsettle the participant’s own positioning in relation to the theatre walk. Not unlike a mission-based real-time game with a first-person perspective,¹⁴ the participant has to jump between different levels, being “teleguided” (O’Rourke 2013, 91) as he is in this “instruction-based” (O’Rourke 2013, 93) theatre play. Consequently, he has to switch quickly between the, at times, highly varying roles allocated to him, such as being an observer, a listener, an interlocutor, a witness, a protagonist, a detective and even an accomplice. Although, since Goffman, we know that most social interactions are not unlike theatrical performances, in *Call Cutta* these interactions and thus the role-playing are restricted to an aural co-presence of two persons who are spatially separated. Hence the importance of invoking aural energies from within both the participant and the phone operator, as they are the co-authors of a script that can only be completed while it is being performed narratively in an ephemeral conversation that cannot be repeated and which leaves no physical traces. Certainly, all of this also holds true for the classical fourth wall theatre situation with its well-made, plotted narrative drama, in which spectators are made to experience by proxy or vicariously. But the specific embodiment of the peripatetic experience is directed critically against the exclusions of the classical theatrical space. In the soundscape of Kolkata, traffic, coughs and other mishaps are not perceived as illicit mishaps in an otherwise perfectly planned universe. The question then arises whether physical presence is still required as a precondition for theatre to happen.

7. Conclusion

With *Call Cutta*, Rimini Protokoll have created a mobile phone theatre play that goes far beyond the classic production of theatre performances. Through the aesthetic method of montage and through the use of a wide range of media, the first wave of documentary theatre saw the introduction of factual elements into drama that underpinned the need for immediate political action. In the second wave, historical documents were being dramatized, mainly so that the processes and mechanisms that govern the German socio-historical matrix – the dramatur-

14 For a discussion of sound and narrative in video games, see Domsch, this volume.

gy of the prevailing system – could be made transparent. A corollary of these dramatizations is the reduction of the documents' reality status. In the third wave, personal epistemology and experience come to the foreground as new realities are being put under scrutiny. As a collective, Rimini Protokoll have developed various productions in which the documentary and the theatrical are most intricately entangled. The interpenetration of real world and fiction are inherent to their works. As a one-to-one-performance, *Call Cutta* is an experimental theatre play in which the theatregoer is turned into a participant who is challenged by an aural guide into searching for visual traces of a past Indian presence in Berlin. In order to be comprehensible to the participant, his tracking of visual traces demands meaning-making through narration. Here, the narratorial interventions of the aural guide come into play. Without them, *Call Cutta* would be a mere dialogue between invisible performers. For this particular situated performance to work, it must contain narrative elements. Thus, at times, the aural guide is required to slip into the role of a historical documentary narrator who periodically tells fragments of the macro-narrative of Subhas Chandra Bose. This way, the Indian past not only surfaces in present Berlin's map, but also in the storyworld that the two protagonists of this performance share.¹⁵ The urban spaces through which the participant moves and the intersubjective acoustic space are split up, giving birth to a shared diegetic space. Consequently, as the performative acts of walking, listening and imagining colour the participant's perception, a narration emerges and rises above the factual presence of what is perceived. When Lehmann refers to Robert Wilson's ideal theatre experience as being a mixture of silent movie and radio drama (Lehmann 1999, 273), *Call Cutta* comes astonishingly close to this ideal. That is to say, in the participant's intensified kaleidoscopic sensory experience, the interior as well as the exterior auditory and visual screens of the multiple realities he is exposed to become inextricably intertwined in a newly carved out aestheticized and mediated space. As a result, through the walking narrative that is being performed against the backdrop of Berlin's cityscape, visual and aural dramaturgy synaesthetically merges within the participant's associative and imaginary space.¹⁶

¹⁵ As they are connected by subjectively spun threads, further narrative analysis could help reveal how coexisting fictitious and documentary realities precisely merge into one another.

¹⁶ For reading and commenting on the present contribution, I would like to sincerely thank Prof. Dr. Gunther Martens.

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Sound, Narrative and Immersion

Sebastian Domsch

Hearing Storyworlds: How Video Games Use Sound to Convey Narrative

1. Introduction:

A (Short) History of Video Game Sound

This chapter wants to look at the different ways that video games use sound in any form to create or enhance the narratives that they are telling. Video games have from their beginning been a medium that integrated visual *and* aural information in order to heighten gameplay fun and have first and foremost undergone changes, we tend to think, in terms of graphics (this is, after all, what the term “video” in video games refers to). Everyone is aware of the rapid development from a few crude monochrome pixels to high-definition and highly realistic visuals. But from the beginning, video games have also been audio games, and the technical development of the sound is no less staggering. If anything, sound and especially music have preceded the visual aspect in gaining widespread cultural acceptance. Long since common in Asian countries like Japan, video game music has now also entered European symphonic concert halls, for example with the show *Video Games Live*, created by Tommy Tallarico.¹

The history of video game music has seen a number of different technologies come and go, all with their different limitations and affordances. In the first kinds of arcade games and consoles in the 1970s, music was still stored on physical media in analogue waveforms such as compact cassettes and phonograph records. Though this meant that almost any sound could be included, the method had the drawback of being rather expensive as well as unstable, and not really amenable to interactivity. So instead, sound had to be created digitally. For this purpose, a specific computer chip would change electrical impulses from computer code into analogue sound waves on the fly for output on a speaker. These sounds were very limited in their options, and yet they were so characteristic (and have by now acquired a nostalgic aura in the ears of people who were young when these games originally came out) that they constituted a whole new music genre in its own right. The music that derived from this technology has

¹ Cf. <http://www.videogameslive.com>.

been called “chiptune,” and has seen a rise in popularity in the twenty-first century, with artists like Eminem or Timbaland integrating 8-bit sounds into their own music. Among the limitations of this technology were the facts that the sound was mainly monophonic (meaning that only one sound could be played at the same time) and that for storage reasons the melodies could not be very long, which is why they were used either sparingly (where a short tune would, for example, only play at the completion of a level or at the start of a new game) or looped. One of the reasons why some of the game melodies like the themes of *Super Mario Bros* or *Tetris* are so well known is that they were relentlessly repeated while the game was playing.

As the chips used in arcades and consoles became more advanced, so did their sound affordances: More channels could be added to create polyphonic sounds and to combine game music and game sounds, and a larger range of types of sounds could be created. Still, all sounds were clearly and rather primitively synthesized, which means that there could be nothing more than approximations to natural sounds. To create a recognizable sound of a creaking door was far beyond these games’ possibilities.

An important step in that direction was the next generation of synthesizers that used frequency modulation. These were introduced to arcade systems in 1984 and could provide much more realistic sounds. For an example of what this method was capable of, one might listen among many others to the game *The Revenge of Shinobi* from 1989.² As the game starts up, a (relatively) complex and driving music, composed by Yuzo Koshiro, is played, while a text on the screen explains the background situation to the game that is about to start (a cross between a jump’n’run and a fighting game). It is interesting to note that the more complex music here seems to allow time for narrative exposition. With a more simplistic and repetitive tune, the player would feel bored more quickly and would probably want to skip reading the text. Thus, the music’s complexity can be helpful in the movement towards an “epic scope,” fully realized later on in the orchestral music for the *Final Fantasy* games.

The lack of realistic or recognizable sounds only changed with the introduction of sampling technology in the 1980s, used by such popular gaming systems as the Nintendo Entertainment System (NES) in 1985, or the Commodore 64 from 1982 onwards. Namco’s 1980 arcade game *Rally-X* was the first known game to use a digital-to-analog converter (DAC) to produce sampled tones instead of a tone generator and in the same year, Sunsoft’s shoot ’em up game *Stratovox*

2 <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Pv6tDtDrkkk>.

was the first known video game to feature speech synthesis. Still, with their limited quality, most of the sounds were only approximations to the original.

The most important technological step towards a use of sound that was almost limitless in its scope and length came with the use of CD-ROMs as storage devices. It had always been a major problem that samples of a good quality used up a lot of memory, so that they could only be used sparingly. But a new generation of personal computers as well as the fifth generation of video game consoles were equipped with optical disc drives, which meant that they could suddenly store hours of high quality sound or music, where before it had been minutes or even just seconds. In 1994, the CD-ROM-equipped PlayStation supported 24 channels of 16-bit samples of up to 44.1 kHz sample rate, samples equal to CD audio in quality.

In 1993, the game *Myst* popularized the CD-ROM as a storage medium for video games on home computers, not least by making use of the new sound features to create a new gaming experience. Importantly, *Myst* arrived shortly *before* the introduction of powerful game engines that enabled consoles like the PlayStation to create a three-dimensional navigable space for their players to move in. Lacking this feature to make the gameworld intuitively appealing, *Myst* put a lot of emphasis on making the world that the player encounters meaningful. This was done by enriching its narrative content and by creating a convincing atmosphere, which meant that an unprecedented amount of care was given to the sound and music design.

The shift towards CD-ROMs and the extensive use of samples had a number of consequences, also for the type of music used in video games. It expanded the scope of music to any kind of recordable music, all the way up to complex symphonic work. An example of this is the Japanese game series *Final Fantasy*, which has been noteworthy for spearheading the introduction of orchestrated music, in this case mainly composed by Nobuo Uematsu, into video games. But the CD and the sound quality that it brought also made video games attractive for established musicians, because it allowed these musicians to create music without having to know code, as had been the case with chiptune music. An early collaboration of a rock musician with a video game was the 1996 soundtrack to the game *Quake* by *Nine Inch Nails* frontman Trent Reznor.

But the move from synthesized to sampled sound also had important consequences in narrative terms. First of all, it allowed the inclusion of realistic and recognizable sounds, e. g., for doors opening or weapons firing. This is the equivalent of aural realism in a medium that until then could often only indicate that a sound occurred in the gameworld, but had to rely on a symbolic convention (almost like the sound-words in comics). The same beep could be a gun firing, or a door opening, or anything else.

Secondly, as soon as the storage capacity was large enough, sampling technology allowed the inclusion of human speech of a length that it could be used in narrative. While before, games had barely understandable one- or two-word commands, now there could be actual dialogue. Of course, this did not mean that video games instantly turned into high drama, or even a decent soap opera. The game *Resident Evil* from 1996 is at the same time famous for being the game that introduced and popularized spoken dialogue in video games, and notorious for the incredibly bad results. While today, voice acting for video games has turned into a specialized profession, in the late 1990s it was not uncommon to use whoever was at hand at the moment, members of the developer team or the janitor included.

2. Differentiations

The use of spoken dialogue is of course an obvious and easily recognizable element of narrative storytelling, whether it occurs in a movie, on a stage, or in a video game. But in order to discuss the relation between video game sound and narrative, we first need to clarify a few points about our objects of analysis. First of all, we will have to look at the relationship between the game (as game), its rules and those parts that can be perceived as narrative, and then we must differentiate among video game sounds according to which of these elements they are related to. I have dealt with the first differentiation at varying length, so in order to prepare the ground I will quote from one of my articles:

To begin with, it is helpful to remember that games are first of all a set of rules, or a system of rules. In fact, most games can be defined as rule systems. Generally speaking, there are two different kinds of rules that make up the systems we call games: rules that describe existents (i.e. everything that ‘exists’) in the gameworld and those that describe values that hold in the gameworld. Among the existents are for example the size and form of the chess board, the number and initial position of the pieces, the movements possible to the different pieces, the fact that one piece can eliminate another by moving to the same place and so on. Values that apply to the gameworld, on the other hand, are rules like those stating that it is desirable to eliminate the opponent’s king, or that it is desirable to win. The first set of rules describes a game’s ‘is’ (what is given in a game) and the second the desired state, the game’s ‘ought.’

In addition to such rules, games can (though they do not have to) also contain what I tend to call a ‘semantic surplus.’ This term is meant to designate the fact that, by way of its presentation, games can ascribe a meaning or significance to its existents. Spoken in terms merely of the rule structure, the existents are nothing but functions within the game system, functions that can usually be expressed by numerical values and mathematical relations (which is why games have such an affinity to digital media). But when games com-

municate these existents to the players, they will often do so by using reference. Thus, a piece in chess is not referred to by its systematic properties, but is called a ‘king’ or a ‘pawn,’ and is often designed to visually resemble a king, a tower, or a horse. This is something that games regularly offer, for several reasons; it often helps to understand the game’s system, and it often makes the game more interesting. How far players partake of that offer is mostly up to them. In fact, players constantly increase or decrease the semantics they associate with the structures they encounter: they ascribe additional meaning to them, or choose to ignore potential meaning attached to them. It is this process that leads to the experience of a game system as gameworld, as a fictional world with its own self-contained meaning and rules. For the game rules, the opponents in *Space Invaders* (Nishikado 1978) are merely functions in the game, but the semantic surplus calls them (unnecessarily) ‘Space Invaders,’ and presents them accordingly (though in this case somewhat unconvincingly). (Domsch 2015, 393; see also Domsch 2013, 13–17)

So games are often experienced by players simultaneously as games and as fictional narrative worlds, or, in other words, there is a ludic and a diegetic part to them. This means that the sound that is audible to the player can also belong to these different aspects of the game. Furthermore, and somewhat similar to film, one can first distinguish between two frames of reference for the audible sound: as in film, some sounds are themselves part of the diegesis. These are sounds that could theoretically be heard in the fictional gameworld by the player’s avatar or one of the characters. Examples are the sound of a gun firing or a door opening, but also the sound of the wind or of rain. All of this is part of what we might call the diegetic sound. Then, both in film and in video games, there are sounds that the recipient can hear, but nobody in the storyworld. In film, this is understood to originate from the mediating agent. By this we understand, in practical terms, the collective of the filmmakers (comprising the director, the cameraman, but also the editor, the sound designer and the score’s composer), although we could also call it the “narratorial instance.” This is called the extra-diegetic sound and comprises such things as the musical score, or an extradiegetic narrator’s voice. Theoretically, the extradiegetic sound should run counter to the film medium’s transparency and point to a higher degree of self-reference (i.e., that the filmic presentation is not something that “happens” but that is presented), but in practice, even a very intrusive score only heightens the experience of immersion.

This doubling of the aural levels into diegetic and extradiegetic can be found in exactly the same way in video games. If anything, the musical score has played an even more important role in the new medium, all the way from the mind-numbingly repetitive squeaky sounds of early games to carefully composed and orchestrally recorded scores. But in addition to the aural elements of a game that belong to the game’s representation as gameworld (diegetic sound) and to the mediation of that gameworld (extra-diegetic sound), video games also con-

tain sound that acknowledges the game *as game*, or, in other words, sound that is a communication about game rules. These we will therefore call “ludic sounds.” Below is a table indicating the different possible ascriptions of sound in video games:

Diegetic	Extra-Diegetic	Ludic	
Sound of Rainfall (<i>Heavy Rain</i>)	(Fixed) Game music (<i>Tetris</i>), Expository Narrative Voice		Non-Interactive Interactive
Player’s footsteps	Interactive Score (<i>Fallout 3</i> , <i>Fallout New Vegas</i>)	High-Score sound, Combo Sound	
	Interactive Narrator (<i>Bastion</i> , <i>The Stanley Parable</i>)		

Ludic sounds are of the highest importance in video games. Compared to a predominantly physical game like soccer, video games involve only reduced physicality. The pushing of a button, clicking of a mouse, and even the wielding of a joystick or a gamepad require only minimal physical exertion. Therefore, video games have always had to remind players that they were playing. From the beginning, sound has been used to enhance the satisfying feedback loop of player actions by making them audible. The appeal of games is their affordance of agency, that they give the player the feeling that they are doing something, and this is so satisfying because the game gives the action a *meaning* that goes beyond the actual physical action that is being performed (e.g., pushing a button). Part of the meaning is derived from the game rules: the rules define the value of a certain action (such as a soccer ball crossing a specific line in space), and if the player accepts these rules, these values will hold at least for as long as the game is on. But video games, through the integration of sound, can on the one hand enforce these values audibly, and they can further signpost events. The earliest example of the latter is the game *Pong*, a highly stylized version of a tennis-like game without music, but with a (completely unrealistic) sound indicating whenever the “ball” hits one of the player’s pads.³

The *Pong* sounds are of course a stylized representation of a diegetic sound (where the fictional make-believe is that the players are actually playing tennis and that a ball has just hit a pad), but there are also completely ludic sounds that have no additional diegetic meaning whatsoever. Examples for this are the sound of having reached a new high score, or of having managed a certain combo move or having acquired a game console achievement.

³ See, e.g., <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SHsYjWm8XSI>.

The main purpose of ludic sound is therefore to convey the message: “You are playing right now,” and, to be more specific: “What you are doing has significance *here* (i.e., within the game).” Especially in the early games and because of technical limitations, all the sounds used were completely abstract, which means that they were theoretically diegetic, but mainly perceived as ludic. With the development of realistic sound, the ludic sound is increasingly presented as diegetic sound, as in the explosion of a defeated enemy. The sound of the explosion indicates an obstacle that has been overcome (game rules) and that a spaceship has exploded (game world), with the explosion *as explosion* being of no consequence to the game rules. But in this combination of a diegetic and a ludic sound lies a not insignificant amount of the fascination of video games as *games within a narrative world*. Where a diegetic sound tells the hearer that “something has happened (in the storyworld),” and the ludic sound tells the hearer that “you have done something,” the ludic-diegetic sound essentially says: “you have made something happen in the storyworld!”

Given the nature of their medium, the aural elements of video games can be further distinguished into non-interactive and interactive. As we have seen, game music has provided sometimes mesmerizing and sometimes plain annoying music to drive the player on, and of course, non-interactive sound elements like background music can also enhance narrativity (mainly in analogy to film music). Extra-diegetic music can, for example, set the mood, and in this sense, the music can be genre-enhancing. This can relate both to ludic and to narrative genres. A driving beat can, for example, contribute to the sense of speed and the continuous action of racing games, while a “haunting” music can set the atmosphere for a horror game just as much as for a horror movie.

But other than in film, the extradiegetic sound in video games can react to what the player does and can be reflective of the gameplay situation: Tomohiro Nishikado’s game *Space Invaders*, released in 1978, was one of the first games to do so, as it was the first game to use a continuous background “soundtrack.” It had four simple chromatic descending bass notes repeating in a loop, but the loop was dynamic and interacted with the player, increasing pace as the enemies descended on the player. As video game composer Tommy Tallarico explains:

If you remember in *Space Invaders*, you know, as the ships started to come down, the aliens, and as they got closer and closer, the sound got faster and faster. Now, what the game programmers did was that they took the person’s heart rate, and as they’re getting closer and closer, people would start to panic. Now they’d do the same studies without the sound, and the people wouldn’t panic as much. And it goes to show and prove how significant audio and music are.

On a more complex level, Konami's 1981 arcade game *Frogger* also featured a dynamic approach to video game music, using at least eleven different gameplay tracks, in addition to level-starting and game over themes, which change according to the player's actions. But even today's complex, orchestrated musical scores are being adapted from their use in movies to an interactive form. In modern gameworlds, the score will adapt itself automatically to the player's movements and actions, indicating possible danger, heightening a location's mood or drumming up the motivation for a fight, thus contributing to the player's immersion into a storyworld that can be interacted with, that can be seen, and, last but not least, that can be heard.

The game *Fallout 3* is a very good example of the extent to which the extradiegetic sound design can relate both to the game's rule structure and to its narrative presentation. *Fallout 3* is a game whose generic conventions make it prone to the creation of a narratively rich gameworld. It is both a role-playing game and an open-world game, meaning that the player inhabits and develops a character, acquiring and choosing abilities for that character, but also making decisions "in character." The space that the game provides for this purpose is one in which the player's movement is relatively free (that is, not channelled towards a specific, linear path as in, for example, most first-person shooters). The player is free to explore the vast world of the game (which is no less interesting for being a post-apocalyptic nuclear wasteland filled with mutants, raiders, and deadly robots), and indeed, exploration of the unknown is one of the game's main pleasures.

In a game like this, the game designers therefore cannot know beforehand which path the player is likely to take, which places, characters and situations he will encounter at what time, and in what combination. Simply playing a set musical score over the player's movement would therefore necessarily make one feel detached from the play experience, or would be even jarring in an irritating way if, for example, the player should encounter a deadly enemy while a cheerful tune is playing in the background. Instead, the game's designers created a complex system of different (functional) types of music whose arrangement is done automatically by the game in relation to the player's actions. To get an idea of the complexity of this solution, it is necessary to quote from the game's sound designer, Scott Lawlor, at some length:

Incidental Music. When out in the open wasteland we want the music to be very, very sparse. Incidentals are short pieces of music (five to 15 seconds). We will want to play a sound that contains a collection of these at a certain time interval. The result will be random chunks of music and tones that quietly wisp away in the background. Almost like silence.

Location Music. When approaching an area in the desert we want to draw the player in. Location Music helps accomplish this. Picture the player walking through the empty desert listening to the wispy incidentals. As the player starts to see a house on the horizon, the first layer (of three) starts to play. The player hears the tension change. As he nears the house, a second layer comes in, and once he is in the center of town, the whole music track plays. The same thing happens in reverse as the player leaves the area. This gives a very natural flow to the experience of exploring the wasteland. And to this, we also make sure the music has night and day variations.

Battle Music. While in the wasteland or in small towns, we are generally playing Incidentals or Location Music. In either of these cases the player can get into battles. These tend to be fairly small skirmishes. If the enemy is of significant threat to the player Battle Music will play an intro, a loop, and an outro when the battle is over.

Hostile Music. When a town or location is hostile to the player, we will play Hostile Music. These pieces of music will have three layers; explore, tension and battle. The system will switch between the three based on the threat level to the player.

These various systems should go completely unnoticed. Ideally, players will never realize that any of these systems exist. The systems are created so that the music seems as purposeful and intentional as a composer would score the experience. (Lawlor 2010)

3. Sound, Space, and Narrative

To go back from this concrete example to a more general perspective, we can look at the relation of time and space to narrative in video games. Time and space are of course two very important criteria in narrative, and in the case of video games, both narrative time and narrative space are influenced and shaped by the dimension of game sound. As we have seen, ludic sound can temporally structure the player's game experience, particularly through rhythm and tempo. The frantic speed of many early chiptunes scores suggested the equally fast playing style, just as the accelerating primitive score of *Space Invaders* signalled the rising threat level to the player. In a different example (that was never structurally developed further by other games), the music itself functioned as ludic sound: in Namco's 1982 arcade game *Dig Dug*, the music stopped whenever the player stopped moving. Nowadays, there is a whole genre of rhythm games in which the player has to time his input exactly with the music, such as, most famously, the *Guitar Hero* games.

More to our point, the game's diegetic sound enhances the notion of narrative time. One question concerning narrative time in video games is in how far it relates to the actual play time, defined as the player's active input. In general, situations in games can be based on time or be a-temporal. An example for the first is the real-time length of a soccer match, an example for the latter is the theoretically infinite amount of time that a chess player has to make the

next move. In a-temporal games, time only passes when there is player input, and if the game contains a narrative level, that is also true for narrative time. In a completely turn-based game, the gameworld and its narrative must be understood to pause whenever there is no input from the player. Both of these situations, timed and a-temporal, exist in video games, but their media affordances are strongly geared towards timed situations, because, in contrast to most other kinds of games and game media, video games are active systems that can change independently of player input.⁴

Games without a consistent sound dimension (such as a musical score or diegetic ambient noises like wind or rainfall) can create, in the absence of visual movement on the screen, an irritating uncertainty in the player whether the game is still “going on” if there is no input from the player. One might think of the situation of a player character entering an elevator, and then riding up without being able to *see* the movement (this is often used by games for transitions between levels, to hide the time the game needs to load the new content). In the absence of consistent sound, the player will never know whether he is still “riding the elevator” or if the game has frozen on him. But, on the contrary, if the music and sound are going on – even better if the music is coming from the diegetic level, as in the radio broadcasts of games like *Grand Theft Auto* or *Fallout* – the player gets the sense that narrative time passes independent of him. Especially open-world games put a lot of effort in creating the impression that the game world is “living and breathing” in the sense of consistently changing through time, and the sound design is an important aspect of this.

In video game narrative, space plays a significantly larger role than in other kinds of narrative, mainly because space is the aspect that is most open to the player’s agency. In fact, the experience of space itself can heighten a game’s narrative proclivity. Game spaces have a very high narrative potential, as they have “the ability [...] to evoke the mental representation that we call story” (Ryan 2008, 412). And they do that as an integral part of the gaming experience:

[T]he player experiences her presence within the navigable space of a computer game, but it is not identical to her own space, as her avatar is not identical to her. The difference between the two is narratively relevant fiction. Game spaces are spaces that we can experience through our presence within them as *other* spaces. And this otherness is conveyed by giving this space a story of its own, a story that the player will come to understand through experience and influence through agency. In video games, spaces tell their own stories, that is, they provoke the player to construct these stories within her mind. (Domsch 2013, 99)

⁴ For more on the difference of timed and a-temporal situations in video games, see Domsch (2013, 117–123).

Sound enhances the immersive qualities of a game's space, in that the sound design can emphasize the illusion that the player is actually situated *within* this space. Sound is a very important means of establishing space, and especially immersion in the diegetic space. One might not only think of, for example, the sound of the player's footsteps (highlighting mainly the fact that the player is moving), but of the change of the sound of footsteps when the player is entering different grounds (e.g., moving from hard-packed snow onto concrete), or the changing reverberations of the footsteps when going from a large hall into a narrow corridor.

One of the first games to rely on music and sound design to create an engaging space for their players was 1993's *Myst*. Sound was particularly important for *Myst* since on the one hand, as one of the first games on CD-ROM, it could include heretofore unprecedented amounts of high quality sound, and on the other hand, it attempted to evoke a complex game space shortly before 3D-game engines enabled players of games like *Doom* to actually navigate seamlessly through such spaces.

Today, a lot of effort goes into a sound design that pays attention to the sound's spatial aspects, as becomes apparent, for example, in this excerpt from an interview with Scott Lawlor:

For weapon fire, we wanted to portray a strong sense of space and distance. We wanted to hear the sound of the weapons reflecting off of the distant rocks and reverberating through the open desert. We added functionality to have layered weapon sounds based on distance, and designed the weapon sounds with this in mind. [...] We added subtle sounds to anything we could from broken down cars to piles of dirt. The more subtle sounds we added on the objects the more the ambience would come to life. Every fence, billboard, water tower and sign has sounds attached to it, and really pulls the player into the world. We also changed the physics system to respect the velocity of the objects and change the volume and pitch of them as they fell.

Here we can see the current stage in the development of videogame sound's complexity as a means for creating a realistic representation of a gaming world and of enhancing narrative immersion. None of these very subtle changes are recognizable by the player individually, but they all contribute to the illusion that the virtual space of the video game is a *meaningful* space: not just abstract geometry but a nuclear wasteland (*Fallout 3*), the roaming prairies of the Wild West (*Red Dead Redemption*), or an urban jungle (*Grand Theft Auto IV*).

Though "invisible," the audio components of video games are an integral part both to their communicative structure (indicating aspects of their rules to the players) and of their storytelling and fictional world-building. This becomes maybe nowhere as apparent as in one of the most fascinating recent examples of

experimental game design, the “non-video” game *Papa Sangre*, where the player has to navigate a hostile underworld without being able to see anything, exclusively relying on aural information. In *Papa Sangre*, the player literally can see nothing of the navigable game space. The story level suggests that the player has to enter a kind of underworld – the realm of “Papa Sangre” – in order to save the soul of “someone dear to him.” That underworld is completely devoid of light, so the only option both the player and the player character have is to navigate by sound. This is different from, for example, the early text adventures, which often did not have any visual representation of the game space either, but relied purely on textual description. Still, it was normally assumed that the player *character* was able to actually see the gameworld that the player could not.

In *Papa Sangre*, the visual interface is as much reduced as possible: all the player can see on the screen are two buttons for the player character’s feet (indicating a left or a right step), and part of a wheel with which the player can change his direction. Everything else, the game space as well as the game’s rules, is presented aurally. There is a voice of an unspecified female person who is helping the player and explaining the spaces he encounters, as well as the dangers that lurk within. Most of the time, the player has to acquire certain “musical notes” within a room by going to them, and then finding the exit to the room (also indicated by a sound), all the while avoiding the snarling and growling monsters that prowl the space.

In this game, sound virtually *is* narrative, even without any linguistic narrator. The various sounds that the player hears are turned by him into an understanding of space, but also an interpretation of that space according to the game’s fiction. This automatic and intuitive mental process is made visible when a player retells his play experience, as in this example:

Catherine Zeta-Jones [the voice helping the player along, S.D.] begins the level by stating: “*There’s something in this field more dangerous than a hog. (I hear the putative grim reaper laughing and what sounds like a scythe swinging) A giggling, grinning reaper. Even if you stand still, as quiet as you can, it’ll come and get you. Ready to run.*” As I begin moving through the tall grass (or what sounds like it) I become frenzied, unable to distinctively make out where the reaper is, or where the musical note is. I hear both, vaguely in front of me, but just like in the island, the sound of my charging through the grass, makes it hard to pay attention to other sounds. In an instant I hear the sound of a scythe across my neck, blood spouting forth and the grim reaper laughing. She offers this advice: “*You can outrun a reaper. Listen hard while you run.*” The second and third times I play, I try to move a little more judiciously, taking a step and then considering where the notes and the grim reaper are, and each time I am killed suddenly by the reaper. (Lumumba-Kasongo 2012, emphasis original)

As this survey has shown, to look at the way that video games can convey narration necessarily also means to look at the level of sound. Besides the obvious use of sound and particularly voice to convey narrative – a use that video games share with film – sound is also an indispensable component in all the areas that distinguish video games as a medium capable of narrative: since they are rule-bound systems for interaction, sound provides a communication feedback to the player that can be seamlessly integrated into the fictional semantics of its representation, and sound can subtly but very effectively enhance the player's immersion in the fictional spaces that video games create. With video games, both the activity of play and the (narratively relevant) significance of the play actions are almost completely virtual – and therefore soundless – so one of their most important technical affordances is to make us hear ourselves play, and to hear us play in a specific fictional world.

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Ivan Delazari

Voicing the Split Narrator: Readers' Chores in Toni Morrison's "Recitatif"

1. "Recitatif": A Re-Introduction

Including Nobel Prize winning novelist Toni Morrison's only short story, "Recitatif" (1983), in *The Norton Anthology of American Literature* (2007), the volume editors define "recitatif" as "a vocal performance in which a narrative is not stated but sung," and immediately continue their introduction by stating that "[i]n her work Morrison's voice sings proudly of a past that in the artistic nature of its reconstruction puts all Americans in touch with a more positively usable heritage" (Baym 2007, 2685). By saying so, they not only deprive the title term of its musical overtones, but hurry to read it metaphorically: it is the author as a major literary and public figure who "sings proudly" in her narrative. Since Gayatri Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (cf. Morris 2010), political parameters of the voicing problem have become a central issue in literary studies, and they certainly cannot be ignored, considering how Morrison deliberately positions herself as a spokesperson for black women in the US. However, from a narratological perspective, such a reading only seems to slide along the surface, since the biographical author's voice is not quite what we find in the Morrison short story as opposed to her interviews, speeches or public statements.

"Recitatif" is a famously brilliant example of an intricate play with character identities. From its second paragraph we know that one of the two main characters, Twyla and Roberta, is white and the other is black, but the text makes it difficult to determine which one is which, the narrative signaling either solution in alternating sequence. The girls, their mothers and Maggie, "the kitchen woman" at St. Bonaventure's shelter (St. Bonny's), are all racially unidentified in the text, or underidentified, so that any pair of them consists in a sense of one another's doubles. Particularly the mute Maggie, but the two mothers, too, are subalterns who cannot speak, since "Maggie couldn't talk" (Morrison 2007, 2686), and "[m]y mother danced all night and Roberta's was sick" (2685). Even with our full confidence that Roberta is to Twyla "a girl from a whole other race," we have to face the fact that responsibility for attaching racial tags to the characters is ours rather than the text's (or "reality's"). It is not that no clues are given; on the contrary, there seem to be too many textual cues, all contingent, insufficient and indeci-

sive, since Morrison's point is to reveal how much racist stereotyping there is in the reader's head and how superfluous this stereotyping is. Having made up our minds after recognizing certain details of a character's looks or behavior as *the* clue, we are repeatedly forced to question our view when new contradictory evidence appears, then return to the former piece of information and see how it did not really exclude the alternative solution, and thus was perhaps no 'clue' at all. No matter whether we decide to cancel an earlier conviction, stick to it, or refrain from judgment altogether, we need to consider not so much the text's deliberate controversy as our own grounds for reading race through cultural and social stereotyping. This effect on the reader is implanted in the Morrison plot, as years after St. Bonny's Roberta and Twyla cannot agree on what race Maggie actually was. That argument is essential to their conflicting relationship as adults towards the end of the story, but it also contributes to the unrest of their own racial indeterminacy. Indeed, "Maggie embodies Twyla's and Roberta's intersecting pasts" (Androne 2007, 137), but she also is to them what they are to the reader.

Taking their stands on the opposite sides of the public debate over mandatory busing as a measure for school desegregation, both Twyla and Roberta speak up, breaking away from the subaltern silence of their childhood experience at St. Bonny's, where they were cast out by "[e]ven New York City Puerto Ricans and the upstate Indians" for not being "real orphans with beautiful dead parents in the sky" (2686). It is significant that Twyla and Roberta acquire their voices in contrast and in conflict with each other, so that racial tensions are marking their own identities, but these identities are not even read from within the storyworld by other multicultural kids, who group the two girls together in a whole separate class as if they duplicated each other. Comparing their memories about Maggie later on, they find that even living next to the same people and witnessing the same events result in diametrically opposed experiences. Overcoming the silenced status of their subaltern doubles (as the mothers "never stopped dancing" and "never got well," their voices as irretrievable as Maggie's), they still remain Siamese *Doppelgänger*s. At the open ending of "Recitatif," the reader is to be left fundamentally uncertain as to who is black and who is white, what is wrong and what is right.

Such character duplicity, interpretative ambivalence and Bakhtinian polyphony of the Morrison story arrangement can be attributed to the author's excellent mastering of narrative techniques from such writers as William Faulkner and Virginia Woolf, on whom Toni Morrison once wrote her Master's thesis. This kind of fiction is efficiently analyzed by means of many twentieth-century theoretical tools, from Russian Formalism or Freudian criticism to various modes of post-structuralism, with no apparent need for an especially *audio*-narratological approach. However, a starting point to justify the latter is the rather trivial obser-

vation that "Recitatif" is a case of *Ich-Erzählung*, and one of the very characters with an uncertain racial identity, Twyla, is also the primary diegetic narrator, in Wolf Schmid's classification¹ (Schmid 2010, 67–70). The whole text is Twyla's, not Toni Morrison's recitative: with our "suspension of disbelief" at work, the author has just written down what her fictional character pronounced/voiced/performed, as the story's title suggests. Since Twyla's racial identity is problematized, so is her vocal one. She may be integrated as a personality, but her integrity is made at least partly transcendental for the reader, who is of two minds about what she sounds like. On realistic assumptions, although still perplexed about Maggie, Twyla and Roberta are supposed to know which race they are themselves; but the reader does not know, and as a narrator, Twyla is *split within and by* the reader's wavering perceptions. Unawareness of whether a black or a white girl is talking is comparable to not knowing which of the two is the storyteller, Twyla or Roberta. Although the voice of "Recitatif" is clearly Twyla's, given the same narrative in Roberta's voice we would hear it as different, but equally problematic. This is how Twyla is a split narrator, whose voice we need to be 'trying on' in the solitude of our silent reading, with no one but ourselves to perform through this duality as prompted by the name itself: "twill weave" is weaving with a double thread.

2. Silent Reading as Listening

Physical parameters of the storyworld, all its diegetic events and imagery, are internalized by the reader processing linguistic signs of the text. On the whole, as Walter Ong suggested, interiority is maintained by human hearing, whereas visibility relates us to the outer world: "Sight isolates, sound incorporates" (Ong 1982, 71). If that indeed is the case, silent reading in general is much more about hearing than we are accustomed to admit, and a title such as "Recitatif" invites us to remember that. Historically, silent reading of narratives is a relatively young practice:

Before the spread of printed books, all three literary genres – poetry and prose as well as theater – were usually performed, often in conjunction with some form of music. The silent reading of print gradually replaced reciting and communal reading, and this led to a gap

¹ My use of Schmid's terminological adaptation of Genette is not to discriminate against the latter's or other approaches. Since intricacies of narratorial typologies *per se* are rather marginal for my argument, I pick up Schmid's as one that is simply convenient.

between poetry and prose on the one hand, and drama, which remained a performing art, on the other. (Neubauer 1992, 8)

The listening aspect of silent reading, barely noticed and largely understudied, provides the recipient with opportunities and freedoms quite unavailable in listening to an ancient rhapsode's performance of an epic poem or to our contemporary audiobook, although those opportunities and freedoms are not at all mandatory for readers to take. As my further argument will hopefully demonstrate, the very auditory qualities of "Recitatif" in particular can be ruined by having it read aloud no less than by suppressing its sound effects entirely so that the text remains what it literally is – a linear sequence of printed words which render some fictional events toward certain ethical and political meanings in the short story genre. It seems to be a matter of readers' auditory to-and-fro distancing in relation to the text that is at the core of the aural experience it may invoke.

2.1. Mimetic Speech

Morrison's title belongs to a class of titles that characterize the form of the piece, not its subject matter: it does not communicate *what* is told, but rather *how*. Thematically, the story is not *about* recitative, since no act of singing, reciting or narrating is performed within its diegesis. Morrison's text is a recitative, or rather it imitates a recitative – a *manner* of singing we may agree to define as "mimetic speaking" (Weisstein 1999, 161). Musical imitation of ordinary conversation is not only characteristic of classical opera, where recitatives are also structural units that occur in between arias to maintain information exchanges among characters and contribute to dramatic (inter)action rather than individual characters' emotional expression. Apparently, Morrison's "Recitatif" manifests little connection with opera, of either the *Le Nozze di Figaro* or even the *Porgy and Bess* kind. Yet a similar manner of vocal performance is exercised in songs far beyond the operatic domain. As a matter of fact, singing the blues often sounds like dramatic speaking, with the possibility of occasional, intoned exclamations and sobs, communicating the archetypal story of misery to a compassionate audience, whereby the blues comes to share some mimetic and dialogic qualities of classical recitative.² Evidently, the blues is associated with Morrison much more closely than opera, as proven by the following observation of Trudier Harris's,

2 For a discussion of narrativity in relation to the blues, see Palmer in this volume.

even though the analogy may have been mostly derived from her paralleling "Recitatif" with James Baldwin's celebrated short story, "Sonny's Blues":

In the musical context of the stories, the word "recitatif," with its beautiful sound and sometimes awkward pronunciation, evokes comparison to the blues. A beautiful word applied to a story about the ugly, troubled interracial relationship of two women, recitatif is a long way from its pristine, classical origins. In the ugliness of racial strife, it can serve as an indicator of the blues-like existence of both of Morrison's characters. (Harris 2006, 117)

In Harris, the blues is a content-related, not formal analogy: it is the fundamental "blues matrix" of African American life (Baker 1984, 10) communicated by the verbal rather than musical element of the blues and its cultural implications. Other critics of "Recitatif" touch upon the story's oral quality, but quickly go further past it into a discussion of race and ("bracketed") gender (Goldstein-Shirley 1999) or disability (Sklar 2011; Stanley 2011). Therefore, it may be worthwhile to linger on the verge of interpretation and study the medium of "mimetic speech" more closely.

The title "Recitatif" introduces what follows it as an oral rather than written narrative utterance pronounced by the first-person narrator. What in musical terms is singing imitating speech is in Morrison writing imitating sound. The act of oral performance is not diegetically registered, and although in David Goldstein-Shirley's brilliant interpretation of "Recitatif" as a story within a story, Roberta is the implied diegetic narrator and Twyla her listener acquiring the skill of distrust advocated in African American oral storytelling to become "a critical, competent hearer" and pass it on to the reader (Goldstein-Shirley 1999, 102–107), I am inclined to attribute this aspect of his provokingly paradoxical reading to the scholar's application of a certain typology (Stepito 1991, 195–215). Strictly speaking, "Recitatif" is not Roberta's "framed narrative," since there is very little narrative communication within the plot. The narrative event is elsewhere in Morrison, explicated only paratextually: what frames the story is its title's reference to an otherwise unspecified situation of oral narration.³ Twyla speaks out loud, and this is what Morrison's title instructs the reader to not simply bear in mind but mentally enact. As performer of her recitative, Twyla is to be *heard*, and her actions are her words that urge the reader to aurally embody her outside the printed page – but where and how exactly?

³ This certainly contradicts a defining feature of framings "as **intradiegetic** parts of the **main text**" (Wolf 2006, 181; Wolf's emphasis). Speaking yet more strictly, "Recitatif" is not a framed narrative at all.

2.2. Narratorial Voice Settings

Unlike characters acting within the fictional world, narrators do not tend to push the reader into picturing them visually. They may suffice to be ethereal presences sometimes capable of Cheshire smiles and often granted with either the reader's own or the author's timbre, pitch, and mannerisms as default vocal features. In the former case, we may start by mentally constructing an experience of reading the story aloud, although its physicality is quickly reduced: sensory-motor sub-vocalization of the text retreats as silent reading, "which is, after all, much faster than reading aloud" (Kuzmičová 2013, 117), gains speed, due to increase in our intimacy with the style and plot. Hearing the text as voiced by its author pre-requires a handy idea of what the author sounds like, a degree of familiarity, and the frame the reader sets thereby depends on the frequent fallacy of author-narrator confusion. If the author's voice is thus externalized to the point of approaching a public reading setting, visual identification of the narrator is probable, although its vividness certainly fades as the reader experiences modes of somatic "presence" (cf. Kuzmičová 2012), with fictional signifieds stepping to the foreground in place of the signifying medium. When, as in Morrison, the narrator is also a character, those early mental default settings of the voice are to be gradually transformed to what the character is thought to sound like, as more information about the character is collected. Although corrections to the thus imagined characteristics of narratorial voice may be numerous, they are likely to shape up a cumulative one-way process. The reader is working towards consistency in order to become familiarized with the medium closely enough not to be distracted by it from the content. Unless indicated otherwise, a non-diegetic act of narration does not need any spacing outside the reader's head: there is just a voice telling the story to the reader. Provided it is a character's voice of primary diegetic narration, the mental staging of the narrative act is also reduced to a voiceover, but the assumption is that if the narrator is caught in our internal spotlight, the same character will show up.

Twyla is not speaking her story to Roberta, nor either of the mothers, nor Maggie, but directly to the reader; the thin outer frame of the story's title is the input to the reader's mind, a hole in a shared wall through which Twyla is to be heard. There is nothing unusual about this state of affairs, and no discomfort to the reader is initially caused. What we need to do is simply equip Twyla with a (mental image of a) voice that we consider proper, listen, and in due course switch our entire attention to what is rendered in that voice – that is, in fact, retune the inner ear from the voice to the message that is being voiced. In this respect, Morrison's title just pinpoints what must be the auditory aspect of silent reading in general, which has only recently started to attract literary the-

orists, even though psychophysiological and cognitive research has accumulated considerable scientific findings on the subject. Leaning on "experimental contexts in which V[erbal]A[uditory]I[magery] has proven to depend [...] on lower-order embodied processes, and/or to have a pronounced effect on silent reading" (Kuzmičová 2013, 116), Anežka Kuzmičová introduces the notion of aural "reverberations" experienced by readers of fictional narratives, which, unlike the non-conscious VAI investigated in cognitive science, can be traced via introspection as contributing to the way we construct some particulars of the storyworld embraced by further, more profound interpretations. According to Kuzmičová, "the basic felt quality of all reverberations is that the linguistic medium of a written narrative enters the reader's awareness *qua* spoken discourse" (117). However, beyond the title, the ambiguous race-related cues in the Morrison text may intensify these auditory perceptive processes, "comparably subtle and probably scarce in some readers" (114), and turn optional reverberations into certain chores for the reader to fulfill.

2.3. Reader as Reverberator

Kuzmičová distinguishes between *outer reverberations*, whereby readers, "with notable ease," hear a voice embodied within them as originating elsewhere, even though it is "just a construct" of the mind only retrospectively described as "based on the preceding narrative" (119), and *inner reverberations*, when the text is felt to originate in the reader's own speech apparatus, with motor articulation involved, so that the sound is "subvocally rehearsed" in the reader's own voice. A paradoxical attribute of such identification with the implied (fictitious) speaker is that the opacity of the message rises, its form obscures the content, and the comprehension of even surface meanings is slowed down (120). As for which qualities of the text may cause reverberations of either type, Kuzmičová summarizes their symmetrical complementarity by saying that

inner reverberations may be particularly likely to occur with utterances lacking in *orality, speaker familiarity and situational embedding*. More generally still, inner reverberations may simply result from the language of an utterance appearing markedly non-situated to the reader (for whatever reason), as the raw stuff of language rather than speech proper. (Kuzmičová 2013, 122; my emphasis)

As far as meaning-making is concerned, inner reverberations "imply that interpretation is instantaneously obstructed" (124), whereas the opposite is true for outer reverberations. If we bear in mind that no claim is made to the effect that the silently read narratives reverberate all the time, as reverberations

occur somewhat sporadically and optionally, what in Kuzmičová is presented as a theoretical hypothesis supported by scientific data as well as the theorist's own introspective study of her reading experiences is quite instructive for an audio-narratological reading of Morrison's orchestration of the narrative voice(s) in "Recitatif."

The circumstances of Twyla's telling her story are restricted to the title, which insists on oral narration with no specification for its context. This lack of specification, which could be seen as a lack of situational embedding, is a potential trigger for inner reverberations at the story's opening. Yet, as I have suggested earlier, readers find no problem with such framing. It satisfies us to simply take the narrator's voice out of the diegesis straight into our head, as voiceover, which is a perfectly valid situational embedding for both primary diegetic and primary non-diegetic narration. We are not likely to sweat much in order to make the narrator reverberate from without, and even with a more "markedly *written* style" (Kuzmičová 2013, 121), once we are familiar with it, inner reverberations are likely to cease and give way to either outer reverberations or non-verbal and non-auditory imagery. The *performative* quality of reverberations illustrated by Kuzmičová's use of the verb "rehearse" in describing inner reverberations is essential, but readers' performance certainly exceeds reverberations,⁴ which cannot last permanently throughout the act of reading. Subvocal rehearsals of a difficult passage, perhaps several times, in a way similar to how musicians seek the 'right' articulation by replaying the piece until it sounds good enough to invoke outer reverberations in a potential audience (to the point of ceasing to just 'reverberate'), have to be alternated with smoother 'sight-readings' of the text, with the sounds you actually perform coming back to you as to an external listener, 'with notable ease.' All reverberations as well as other kinds of embodied response to reading originate in the reader. The paradox of inner reverberation is that we (sub)vocalize what we read by appropriating the verbal and the fictional without making either the words or the somatics of the text entirely our own: we are not really there in the fictional realm saying these words. We travel back and forth across the border between reality and storyworld, smuggling voices, because they belong to us anyway. With inner reverberations, we stay where we are and let a fictional speaking voice into our own reading context and speech apparatus; with outer ones, we infiltrate ourselves into the diegetic reality as if we can passively hear what everyone there sounds like. There does not seem to be a dominant or normative, pre-determined

⁴ Cf. the use of "rehearse" in David Goldstein-Shirley's argument on the reader's participation in "Recitatif" as drama or "rhetorical performance" (Goldstein-Shirley 1999, 105).

way of hearing narratives as a series of reverberations. However, conflicts between Kuzmičová's modes of auditory reading may be particularly welcomed by a text such as Morrison's.

3. Rehear(s)ing Race

The title's promise of an oral style for "Recitatif" is fulfilled from the very beginning. The resulting facilitation of a transition from inner to outer reverberation is supported by the fact that the narrator immediately reveals herself as a character with some distinct features of at least her past situation to outline the origins of what she is "now":

My mother danced all night and Roberta's was sick. That's why we were taken to St. Bonny's. People want to put their arms around you when you tell them you were in a shelter, but it really wasn't bad. No big long room with one hundred beds like Bellevue. There were four to a room, and when Roberta and me came, there was a shortage of state kids, so we were the only ones assigned to 406 and could go from bed to bed if we wanted to. And we wanted to, too. We changed beds every night and for the whole four months we were there we never picked one out as our own permanent bed. (Morrison 2007, 2685)

The author has deliberately extracted "all racial codes from a narrative about two characters of different races for whom racial identity is crucial" (Morrison 1992, ix), including phonetic ones: although the style is colloquial, no accent is graphically marked. Obviously, such *My Fair Lady* convictions as that you can tell people by the way they talk were deconstructed as early as G. B. Shaw's *Pygmalion* (1913), which the good old musical was based on. People do speak in various distinctive dialects/sociolects including African American vernacular, but that is by no means a way of telling a person's racial identity. As sociolinguistic studies of "Black English" had shown by the time "Recitatif" was written, although "standard English and 'White English' are considered synonymous terms," "if the speech of blacks and whites within the South and with socioeconomic status held comparable are investigated these alleged differences [between Black and White English] would all but disappear" (Williamson and Thompson 1982, 86). The belief that race can be correctly inferred on the grounds of timbre or other vocal characteristics is another example of the very racial stereotyping Morrison attacks. There is no straight relation between race and voice, as proven by the case of Elvis Presley's initial success, as well as some experiments with tape-recorded black and white American speakers who were completely misidentified by the "judges" (Trudgill 2000, 42). My further argument about the necessity for the reader to renew outer reverberations through reproc-

essing the inner ones, to “rehearse” and rehear, is not based entirely on the assumption that all readers hold racist stereotypes, whether overtly or subconsciously. Alternating the reader’s solutions to identifying characters racially (the problem that becomes the most disturbing riddle of “Recitatif” as echoed/reformulated in Roberta’s “What the hell happened to Maggie?” closing the story, but opening up its question to reverberate on), Morrison links Roberta and Twyla’s individualities with their racial identities. With the two characters paired so tightly, the way the narrator sounds to the reader is subject to change. ‘Correcting’ her race means making her a different person, and since a simultaneous identity shift is to happen to Roberta, we face, to put it musically, a voice exchange if/every time we decide to have them swap races. If the narrator is African American, she is one person; if she is Caucasian, she is a different person. Repeated reinvention of the ‘same’ person in two different bodies, each of the right color, is for erasing not race, but racism (‘eracism’).

3.1. Switching Voices

It takes the story several lines before the narrator is explicitly marked as “whole other” against her counterpart Roberta:

It didn’t start out that way. The minute I walked in and the Big Bozo introduced us, I got sick to my stomach. It was one thing to be taken out of your own bed early in the morning – it was something else to be stuck in a strange place with a girl from a whole other race. (2685)

Since Twyla does not identify her own race in this opening paragraph, does that mean that we are free to hear whatever we want, or have no auditory image of the narrator at all? The freedom is limited to our default settings. We are most likely to be familiar with the author of “Recitatif,” as *The Norton Anthology* reprinting is preceded by a brief but comprehensive account of Morrison’s life and work in the introduction, while the first publication of the story appeared in Amiri and Amina Baraka’s *Confirmation: An Anthology of African American Women* (1983). By such default, Twyla is black – an assumption that may be shattered further in the second paragraph:

And Mary, that’s my mother, she was right. Every now and then she would stop dancing long enough to tell me something important and one of the things she said was that they never washed their hair and they smelled funny. Roberta sure did. Smell funny, I mean. (2685)

One of the most notorious white supremacy stereotypes about black people is voiced by Twyla's mother, and if we are aware of this stereotype, we need to reconsider the initial premises. The white girl inheriting racism is Twyla, and metaphorically, the characters change bodies. Twyla's narrative voice could now sound different in the reader's mind, until the next switching piece of information is thrown in by Morrison.

Even here, with probably the strongest racial cue to mark a whole coming pattern of change, the words signaling it are few, indirect and subtle enough to simply not ring the bell. The reader may fail to hear the words, with the initial outer reverberation of the opening lines going on to deteriorate into a habitual voice indistinctly droning till the text ends. I suggest the notion of the reader's *chores* because noticing the potential textual triggers of the switching in question is not easy, like observing a slight but meaningful difference in your house while going about household routines. My experience of teaching "Recitatif" at St. Petersburg State University in 2010–2013 is that students may well miss this kind of cues, sustaining the initial impression that Twyla is black and seeing Roberta respectively.⁵ As someone who, while watching Luis Buñuel's 1977 film *That Obscure Object of Desire* years before, had completely overlooked the fact that the heroine was played by two different actresses, I was not in the position to blame my students for negligence. Yet in both Morrison's and Buñuel's 'houses,' the chores are assigned, even if some family members are not particularly strong at defamiliarization.

The crucial aspect of Morrison is that the responsibility is handed on to the reader entirely, whether to miss the vocal switch or hear it, and whether to accept the switch or rule it out. Our *performative capacities* for inner reverberation are opened for activation. Unless the "funny smell" signal is ignored, we are to slow down and stop for a while in order to "rehearse," subvocally rearticulating the words in conflict with what was previously embodied as outer reverberation, and make our own decision on whether the words have to sound differently now. Defamiliarizing ourselves with what has become familiar only recently, as "Recitatif" is indeed a *short* story, we need to come to terms with the new state of affairs. If the decision is made to cancel the performative outer reverberation of Twyla's voice as an African American (which we are entitled to do because the performance was really ours), we also need to bring the story back

5 Cf. Goldstein-Shirley's survey results among US students finding that "knowledge of the readers' ethnicity did not help predict whether they speculated that Twyla is white or black or whether Roberta is white or black, but did help predict which clues they used to reach their conclusions" (Goldstein-Shirley 1999, 106). My Russian students' attention was generally unfocused on the "color line" as irrelevant to their own cultural experience.

to consistency by instantaneously ‘replaying’ the preceding paragraphs in that new voice. In this way, the story’s soundtrack, which is probably made up of just occasional reverberations, needs to be *doubled* from the beginning, at least in certain passages, since the memory of ‘incorrect’ reading cannot be deleted. Even thrown into the trash, it returns recycled.

3.2. Double Track as Implied Counterpoint

Early in the story, the dramatic split of the narrator’s voice is not apparent, and even well-equipped critical readers may insist that it does not occur. For instance, without going into the story’s auditory dimensions, Ann Rayson makes a logically convincing and culturally informed argument that Twyla is white (“I read Twyla as Irish Catholic,” Rayson 1996, 41), based on the same episodes and wordings of the text that other critics find ambiguous.⁶ In such determinative readings, distinct colors can be adjusted to the mothers and Maggie, too, even though the latter mission is accomplished by neither Twyla nor Roberta. However, it is the very arbitrariness of the cues that permits them to be used in such a way. Each ambiguity incorporates two certainties. Inner reverberations are potentially summoned even for someone who will deny reconsideration in favor of the narrator’s solidness once constructed. Final clarity of racial identification is achieved in retrospect, with the whole text subject to analysis, whose departure point is the notion of realistic motivation, a resolution of textual inconsistencies being necessarily extratextually drawn from the reader’s competences such as an awareness of the American cultural scene between 1950 and 1980. In progressive reading, though, negation of the split in the narrator’s voice can be achieved either through neglecting inner reverberation triggers or after inner reverberations are conceptualized to confirm the preceding outer ones. The result resembles a double-track recording of the same singer performing the identical score twice in unison: even though the voice engineered by the reader is the same on both tracks, the seams are there to be heard.

Twyla lives in Newburgh, NY, where race riots were common in the nineteen-sixties, and works “behind the counter at the Howard Johnson’s [restaurant] on the Thruway just before the Kingston exit” when and where she meets Roberta off a Greyhound bus accompanied by two male hippies on their way for “an appointment with Hendrix,” of whom Twyla has never heard (2689–2690). Is there

⁶ Trudier Harris suggests a more radical metaphorical solution: “From the perspective of the blues... both women are black” (Harris 2006, 117).

sufficient information given in this episode for us to picture Twyla as African American? If yes, the unwashed hair reference needs to be relocated. Is that conceivable? Yes. But it is the reader's chore to measure this possibility, articulate it in the first person to know how it feels, and send it back to the narrator to resound in either voice.

Twyla and Roberta's next encounter in a Newburgh supermarket, with Roberta glamorously dressed with diamonds and Twyla "dying to know what happened to her, how she got from Jimi Hendrix to Annandale, a neighborhood full of doctors and IBM executives," either forces another shift or legitimates the reader's new thinking of Roberta as a white woman: "Easy, I thought. Everything is so easy for them. They think they own the world" (2691). Both this scene and the next accidental reunion of Twyla and Roberta contain dialogue, which Morrison arranges with a use of echoings, such as in the last episode of reconciliation:

"We were kids, Roberta."

"Yeah. Yeah. I know, just kids."

"Eight."

"Eight."

"And lonely."

"Scared, too." (2698)

In that diegetic exchange of shortly-cut elliptical sentences, two voices are mixed into one another, making it particularly difficult to determine who is speaking, as the two interlocutors say the same things. Outer reverberations are yet again obstructed, as the reader almost needs to count through the turn-taking back to the line explicitly addressed to Roberta, only to see the pointlessness of the count, since the speakers are indistinguishable anyway. Here is how Morrison's recitative becomes contrapuntal: if two people take it in turns to read the lines aloud, no confusion seems to arise, but if they change roles and read again, we are confused. In silent reading, this confusion presents itself as a simultaneity of two alternative readings: until we hear, and probably also see, an African American woman act as one of the characters and a white one as the other, we have the freedom of choice, and even having made it, we can unmake it, with that freedom granted to us until the end of the story, and potentially it is there for endless rereadings, too. Once the responsibility is taken away from us in an external voicing, we lose that freedom, and the double vocal identity can only be replayed later, at another time, which kills the actual counterpoint of musical lines played simultaneously. Therefore, an articulate recitation of "Recitatif" is lethal for its principal auditory effect, which has everything to do with Morrison's message. Roberta's status as Twyla's problematic *Dop-*

pelgänger is manifest in the above short dialogue, which is part of Twyla's recitative. With the flashing voice exchanges in the text, Roberta's voice and pronouncements are contrapuntally included in the single-line of Twyla's narrative, as if both characters took it in turns to speak their stories. The well-known musical analogy is "the implied counterpoint of unaccompanied solo instrumental music":

When composers are writing solo music for instruments capable of playing only one note at a time, they are faced with the problem of holding the interest of the audience in a musical context devoid of harmony and counterpoint. One common solution to this dilemma is to imply additional musical voices by having a rapid alteration between the instrument's high and low registers. This has the effect whereby the listener imagines the continuation of one line of music in the lower register while the music has shifted to the higher register, and vice versa. (Grim 1999, 245–246)

Even if Toni Morrison herself were reading her short story aloud, that would destroy the masterful interaction between the auditory and referential ambivalences of the text, which are available in silent reading's reverberations only. In the author's performance, we would hear Toni Morrison's voice and picture an African-American woman speaking, Twyla embodied in just that one way, whereas in the text there are potentially two embodiments. In this respect, Morrison's 'experiment' in "Recitatif" is of the "Schrödinger's Cat" type, as in Ursula Le Guin's short story (Le Guin 1998). Once the speaking voice is no longer imaginary, the cat in the opened box is found dead, or not there.

4. Concluding Chores

Presenting an early version of this paper at the 2014 Audionarratology conference in Paderborn, I tried to demonstrate the failures of actualized voicings of the story by playing independent audio-recordings of two women reading out the same passages from "Recitatif." One speaker was African American, and the other one white. Without pressure to find out how successful listeners in the audience were at silently guessing each speaker's race by the sound, weighing either possibility against the other, I then attempted to enact Morrison's narrative counterpoint. I had somewhat clumsily mixed the two recordings of the following passage, so that some sentences were pronounced by a solo speaker as either Twyla or Roberta, others simultaneously by both, after which they exchanged parts in the dialogue, and finally got accompanied with their visual images (photo and video) to reveal their race:

Roberta looked over and when she saw me she waved. I didn't wave back, but I didn't move either. She handed her sign to another woman and came over to where I was parked.
"Hi."

"What are you doing?"

"Picketing."

"What for?"

"What do you mean 'What for?' They want to take my kids and send them out of the neighborhood. They don't want to go."

"So what if they go to another school? My boy's being bussed too, and I don't mind. Why should you?"

"It's not about us, Twyla. Me and you. It's about our kids."

"What's more *us* than that?"

"Well, it is a free country."

"Not yet, but it will be."

"What the hell does that mean? I'm not doing anything to you."

"You really think that?"

"I know it."

"I wonder what made me think you were different."

"I wonder what made me think you were different." (2694–2695)

This kind of crazy DJ-ing is what a reader of "Recitatif" is to perform and be aurally exposed to while reading the story silently.

Morrison's is a story demonstrating how readers are entrusted with the full responsibility of 'trying on' racist prejudice and how it is only by chance that they refrain from 'buying it.' Although "meaning-making and interpretation do not have to combine with reverberations" and "the experience of reverberation may be relatively scarce in some readers" (Kuzmičová 2013, 123–124), "Recitatif" seems to be a special case. It is not only the analytical level of a trained scholar's informed interpretation, but the experiential aspect of reading stories that is importantly manipulated by Morrison. The way we can see and hear characters is distorted so that we need to de-automate our immediate embodied mental responses, not logical/analytical procedures. The story is very somatic in how it hinders the "naturally" easy somatic response. It is the story's tendency to turn outer reverberations into inner ones that helps Morrison to achieve an educational goal of acquired responsibility and to challenge the reader morally and intellectually by inflicting reflection: "Inner reverberations bring not only the voice, but also the meaning, the thought lying behind (and emerging from) the expression in question, towards the 'mine' end of the mine/not mine continuum" (Kuzmičová 2013, 128).

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Anežka Kuzmičová

Audiobooks and Print Narrative: Similarities in Text Experience

1. Introduction

Although audiobooks appeared shortly after Edison's invention of the cylinder phonograph, recordings of long-form narrative did not become properly widespread until the recent introduction of high-capacity, and highly portable, digital audio players (Rubery 2011b). It is therefore natural that audiobooks are debated as if they were an innovation of today. A continuation of sorts of the once prevalent communal reading aloud, the audiobook has been praised for offering a number of aesthetic benefits over silent reading. Through the presence of an actual human voice, every single word can seem affectively charged. Through prosody and voice modulation, interpretive paths are offered to the listener that might not have opened up otherwise. Through multiple recordings of single texts by different performers, the protean nature of narrative reception becomes clearer than ever (for a multi-author volume taking up these benefits in case studies of specific audiobooks, see Rubery 2011a). While the general sense of novelty has given rise to new forms of education activism,¹ systematic scholarship on the contemporary audiobook experience remains sparse (for a notable exception, see Wittkower 2011). As usual when a new technology takes over culture narrowly defined, audiobooks also have their adversaries (e.g., Birkerts 1994). Obviously, some aspects of text experience go missing when a narrative is converted from print to sound. Pioneering research (Mangen 2014) is now being produced investigating analogous losses in the transition from print to digital reading. The worry seems warranted with regard to both new media. But audiobooks, unlike e-books, have not been seriously suggested to eventually replace print, or silent reading, across the board. A discussion of the innumerable differences between audiobooks and print, albeit valuable, is therefore not as pressing as it is in the case of e-reading. The present chapter aims to tackle a more modest task: instead of pointing at more or less apparent differences, I will focus on a limited number of underexplored yet crucial similarities.

¹ The LibriVox project, for instance, is an on-line collection containing thousands of free audiobooks recorded by volunteers worldwide. Many of these audiobooks belong to the expository genre, including classical works of philosophy (see Hancher 2011).

The focus on similarities rather than differences is motivated by the current state of the audiobook debate. Comparisons between audiobook listening and print reading often boil down to the fact that audiobook listening, in contrast to reading, is not self-paced, and that this imposes limitations on the recipient's continuous in-depth reflection (Birkerts 1994; Toolan 2008). As a result, audiobook listening is considered a shallow alternative to reading. Indeed, should the listener continuously muse over deeper meanings or intricate details in the text, she would soon lose track of the narrative. Seen as a disadvantage, this inability to systematically reflect on the text can be critical. On the other hand, audiobooks redirect our theoretical attention to features of the narrative experience that cater to its other functions. Rather than stimulating systematic reflection, these features serve purely hedonic purposes such as daydreaming or, more generally, aesthetic pleasure across sensory modalities. Although they may be more dominant in audiobooks than in print reading, I will argue that they are essentially inherent to narrative text reception and shared across the two media. The massive remediation (see also Bolter and Grusin 2000) from print to audio only makes their inherence in reading more conspicuous now than before. I will further argue that these features are to some degree properly functional, i.e., beneficial to the recipient.

Throughout the chapter, the following similarities between audiobook listening and print reading will be explored:

- 1st similarity: The enactive nature of the recipient's mental imagery;
- 2nd similarity: The relative poverty of the recipient's attention;
- 3rd similarity: The occasional richness of the recipient's phenomenal consciousness.

These features of reading seem to have been largely overlooked, or even expressly contradicted, in much of narrative scholarship. This may be partly due to the assumption, traditionally prevailing in the literary academia, that reading is meant to primarily serve systematic, analytical, distanced reflection (see, e.g., Fialho, Zyngier, and Miall 2011).

My argument concerning the three similarities will have a three-step structure. For each similarity, I will begin by isolating an intuition from the audiobook literature concerning an alleged difference between the two media. Then I will question this intuition by pointing at an underlying misconception about print reading, a misconception common among narrative and literary scholars at large. For every intuition, there will be one misconception to be refuted. In refuting it, I will refer to empirical findings from various research disciplines (e.g., cognitive psychology, neuroscience, empirical studies of literature and media), but I will also quote a concrete example of literary narrative for a more

hands-on illustration. Finally, I will explain the possible consequences and functions of the similarity in question as illustrated by the previous steps.

2. Defining Reading and Listening

Before proceeding to the main argument, a closer definition of the two practices in question – i.e., *print reading* and *audiobook listening* – is needed. There are diverse ways of reading a printed narrative and diverse ways of listening to an audiobook. For the purposes of the present chapter, this variation will be delimited by a primary focus on the adult population with developed reading skills and relatively solid reading habits. By print reading (or simply reading), I will thus refer to such reading of printed fictional narrative that is silent, solitary, voluntary, more or less continuous, and done for leisure. Our exemplary reading situation can take place in a single environment or across several different environments, even within a short span of time, e.g., during the daily commute.

A printed book is portable, but the audiobook is essentially defined by its portability. In the target population, audiobooks are largely played during routine tasks (Rubery 2011b) such as travel or physical exercise. By audiobook listening (or simply listening), I will thus refer to such listening to a digital recording of a fictional narrative wherein the listener uses a portable device with a headset. This enables her not only to navigate across environments, but also to experience the narrative in a way most akin to solitary reading.² Our exemplary listening situation is likewise voluntary, more or less continuous, and done for leisure. For even closer adherence to the exemplary reading scenario, the audiobook in question consists preferably of a narrative originally written to be silently read, i.e., a novel or short story that has been remediated into an audiobook with a single voice performer. In the contemporary media ecology, this appears to be a major usage.

The two exemplary situations should be understood as prototypes allowing some degree of variation. What I will say about the possible workings of mental imagery, attention, and phenomenal consciousness in these exemplary situations may likewise be true for scenarios diverging on one or several of the above characteristics. At the same time, numerous variables will need to remain wholly unaccounted for, especially those concerning differences between indi-

² In this respect, similar types of narrative experience may be found in audio guides or experimental performance art such as the mobile phone theatre (see also contributions by Mildorf and Festjens, this volume).

vidual readers' personality traits and instantaneous dispositions. What is certain is that the near-multitasking inherent in the exemplary listening situation enables, by definition, little systematic reflection of the kind typically expected by literary scholars.³

Moreover, unlike pupils cheating on reading assignments, adults with developed reading skills and relatively solid reading habits rarely ask themselves whether they want to read a narrative or listen to one instead. Rather, they choose between the two media based on their instantaneous situation and the type of reception it affords. For instance, as long as they need to walk, print is out of the question. Some frequent scenarios, such as passive transportation, partly overlap in their affordances for both media. Highly distractive transportation environments, however, may foreclose deeper reflection in the case of print reading as well, yet another reason to look for alternative common denominators.

Finally, no inquiry into the experiences of a group as large and diverse as the adult population with developed reading skills and relatively solid reading habits can ever be considered comprehensive. There is no way to account for the virtually endless differences across individuals and individual scenarios within the scope of a single essay. Whenever possible, I will therefore model a hypothetical recipient along the statistical constructs put forward by empirical scholarship, but it would be naïve to suppose that I am fully unaffected by my own introspections, as reader and listener, in doing so. For the sake of simplicity, a distinction will likewise be maintained throughout the chapter between academic (i.e., distanced, analytical) and non-academic (i.e., hedonic) reception practices. It should be noted, however, that this distinction is ultimately an artificial one, and that insofar as literary scholars are human beings, their ways of reading and listening will always bear traces of the non-academic kind of practice. *Vice versa*, many leisure readers may sometimes spontaneously employ reading strategies resembling those of literary scholars.

³ Research on multitasking (Schumacher et al. 2001; Murphy Paul 2013) indicates that highly complex cognitive operations require undivided attention and are thus exempt from multitasking proper, which can at best comprise two very undemanding activities, e.g., listening to the weather report while folding laundry.

3. First Similarity: The Enactive Nature of the Recipient's Mental Imagery

3.1. First Intuition

Mental imagery amounts to a person's subjective sense of perceiving an overtly absent physical reality. Across research disciplines, mental imagery is often dealt with reductively, on one or more levels:

Firstly, readers' mental imagery is typically understood to encompass vicarious perceptions relating only to the referents mentioned or implied in a text (referential imagery). Meanwhile, vicarious perceptions of the words of the text as if pronounced out loud (verbal imagery) are given little or no attention (see also Kuzmičová 2014). The latter, verbal type of mental imagery is ubiquitous in silent reading and obviously relevant to print-to-audio remediation. In fact, the listener's inability to freely imagine the voices of characters and narrators has been highlighted by some critics as a key argument against the audiobook medium (Rubery 2011b). However, as the present chapter focuses on the similarities rather than differences between audiobook and print, I accept this first level of reduction, constraining the recipient's mental imagery to the referential domain.

Secondly, mental imagery at large, including mental imagery in reading, is frequently reduced to visual imagery alone (Connell and Lynott 2012). Mental imagery in other sensory modalities – whether exteroceptive (e.g., touch, hearing, smell, taste), interoceptive (e.g., pain), proprioceptive (e.g., balance), or kinaesthetic (e.g., acceleration) – is rarely studied systematically or even acknowledged, especially in fields like narrative theory (see also Kuzmičová 2014). It is this second level of reduction that needs to be refuted if we are to gain a better understanding of narrative text experience across the two media in question. But let us follow the three-step structure announced above, beginning with a recurrent intuition concerning audiobook listening.

The intuition goes: *Compared to print, audiobooks are better suited for eliciting mental imagery.* The intuition has appeared in theoretical (Wittkower 2011) and empirical-theoretical (Toolan 2008) literature as well as in popular science writing (Laidman 2012). The reasoning behind it is loosely grounded in a notion of within-modality interference. Within-modality interference, a phenomenon explored in the experimental cognitive sciences (De Beni and Moè 2003), entails that mental imaging in a given sensory modality becomes more difficult if a physical stimulus is simultaneously present in the same modality. By this token, it should be comparably difficult to visualize the contents of a narrative while having to decode words on a page, a task that is highly visually taxing.

Audiobooks, engaging the auditory modality instead, should alleviate the difficulty. The intuition has obvious appeal. Yet if we consider our exemplary listening situation, which usually involves some degree of visual environment perception, its appeal becomes less obvious. One's eyes may be somewhat less busy during a walk with a headset on as compared to during reading, but they are busy nevertheless. I will return to within-modality interference as applied to the exemplary situations soon, after raising a more fundamental point of criticism.

3.2. First Misconception

My criticism is that the intuition is based on a misconception concerning mental imagery, a misconception that can be expressed as follows: *The recipient's mental imagery consists in visual pictures before the mind's eye*. Vision is the dominant sense in humans, and mental images are often experienced to have a visual component (see also Spence and Deroy 2013). But static visual pictures or even filmic snippets in the head are inaccurate as a general metaphor for mental imagery elicited by narrative, even though they are by far the most widespread in narrative and literary scholarship (Jajdelska et al. 2010; Troscianko 2013). The metaphor presupposes that the imager's embodied stance *vis-à-vis* the imaged contents is one of a detached spectator, with little or no vicarious involvement in the contents themselves. While readers' mental images, especially those prompted by elaborate static descriptions, may occasionally be experienced as resembling detached pictures in the head, there is substantial evidence that mental imagery is not picturesque but largely enactive instead (Kuzmičová 2012).⁴ Enactive mental images cast us in three-dimensional situations rather than consisting of two-dimensional visual projections. The imager's stance is one of a physically involved experiencer rather than a detached spectator. Consider, for instance, the following passage from Ernest Hemingway's novel *The Garden of Eden*:

[David and Catherine] were always hungry but they ate well. They were hungry for breakfast which they ate at the cafe, ordering brioche and café au lait and eggs, and the type of preserve they chose and the manner in which the eggs were to be cooked was an excitement. [...] On this morning there was brioche and red raspberry preserve and the eggs were boiled and there was a pat of butter that melted as they stirred them and salted them lightly and ground pepper over them in the cups. (Hemingway 1995 [1986], 4)

⁴ Some critics of the picture metaphor (Thompson 2007; Troscianko 2013) even suggest that non-enactive, picturesque mental imagery is outright impossible.

A visual picture before the mind's eye, static or moving, of the above contents may present the imager with the sight of two human figures seated at a café table, eating breakfast. An enactive mental image of the same contents, on the other hand, makes the imager partly adopt the embodied stance of the two adventurous eaters. Compared to mere visual pictures, such enactive imagery has an ampler sensory range. An enactive image of David and Catherine enjoying their breakfast, for instance, would likely enlist the modalities of taste and smell (in relation to the food), touch and movement (in relation to the manual handling of the food), or at least a subset of these. Evidence from neuroimaging, behavioural, and self-report experiments, suggests that mental imagery is grounded in actual sensory and motor physiological processes. Verbally induced flavour images, comprising taste and smell (Eardley and Pring 2011), as well as verbally induced motor representations, comprising touch and movement (Fischer and Zwaan 2008), have been found to activate corresponding areas of the brain and to interfere with overt activity in respective modalities (e.g., sucking candy, rotating a knob). Even if the visual component of the reader's image were not overridden by these other modalities, it would certainly not amount to a finite picture or movie snippet. It would rather resemble the fragmentary sight of a three-dimensional set of objects inviting bodily interaction.

3.3. First Set of Consequences for Text Experience

Now that the recipient's mental imagery has been redefined in terms of enactment, what does the redefinition mean for the intuition that audiobooks prompt more mental imagery than print? Firstly, the visual stimuli in print decoding consist invariably in flat monochrome signs on a page, having little in common with the multimodal sensations (Spence and Deroy 2013) experienced in enactive imagery. Thus the sheer activity of reading does not necessarily have to interfere, or not too strongly, with mental imagery as redefined above. After all, generations of print readers have acknowledged experiencing mental images, even very vivid ones. Secondly, our exemplary listening situation clearly entails more bodily activity, and with it more potential physical stimulation in the different sensory modalities, than any conceivable reading situation. Based on this latter observation alone, one could easily draw the conclusion that due to within-modality interference, listening should afford less mental imagery overall than reading – not more. A reader's body is static, so there should be a lesser risk of enactive imagery becoming suppressed by real action and perception (see, e.g., Chapelle Wojciechowski and Gallese 2011 for this line of reasoning).

At a closer look, things are not as straightforward. Imagine listening to the above narrative passage during a walk with a headset on. Although any environment is potentially stimulating in any sensory modality, one's conscious experience rarely encompasses the entire sensory array. It is true that if you happen to be physically tired, your motor experience can become rather salient as you begin to focus on your aching muscles. Walking may then indeed prevent you from conjuring mental images corresponding to motor tasks, e.g., those of stirring, salting, or peppering a boiled egg. Other sensory features of your activity may be far less conspicuous, though. For instance, smells may occur in the environment (exhaust fumes, trees in bloom), but you may not notice them when it is time to conjure an olfactory mental image of freshly brewed coffee. If you do happen to notice these smells and are thus prevented from imaging fictional ones, there is still plenty left for you to image in the gustatory modality. And unless you are navigating a largely unfamiliar terrain that forces you to stay visually focused, visual input does not entirely prevent you from catching a glimpse of David and Catherine's enticing breakfast table.

Moreover, it should be noted that print reading is never spared from environmental sensory stimulation either, even if reading environments may not change as dynamically as listening environments in the course of a single session. Between listening and reading, it is thus impossible to determine that one activity invites more mental imagery than the other. Rather, imagery affordances always result from the instantaneous configuration of sensory features in the environment, the recipient's readiness to perceive these features, and the specific subset of sensory modalities potentially addressed by the narrative.⁵

Finally, what does the redefined notion of mental imagery add to our understanding of the functions of narrative across the two media? One's psychological set is different in conjuring enactive mental imagery as compared to mentally inspecting a detached visual picture. An enactive image has more of a holistic potential, tapping more deeply into the affective charges of the narrative in question (Jajdelska et al. 2010). In a fraction of a second, it makes the imager experience rather than contemplate the situation rendered in the narrative. Inspecting an image or contemplating a situation would entail some degree of the intellectual distance commended by literary scholarship. Meanwhile, enacting the life of a narrative character, perhaps including some of the corresponding emotions, suggests other receptive functions than systematic reflection.

5 Close sensory overlaps between narrative and environment can, in some cases, result in an enhancement of mental imagery rather than its suppression, see Section 5.2 below.

Let us once again consider the typical scenario in which an adult person with developed reading skills resorts to playing an audiobook on a portable device. Often her alternative option is to walk, exercise, or travel without any narrative input at all (Laidman 2012). What would this alternative option offer her in terms of mental activity? Her mind would most likely be allowed to wander freely in the default mode (see, e.g., Smallwood et al. 2013), engaging in the sort of self-centred daydreaming distinctive for idle minutes on public transit or physically demanding minutes of a jogging session. An important aspect of such daydreaming, then, is the compulsive mental re-enactment of previously experienced life situations or fantasizing about future ones, with more or less mental imagery involved. What audiobooks – similarly to print – do is they bring into these daydreaming scenarios a unique shift in perspective. The life daydreamt about is not the recipient's own but somebody else's. The daily dose of daydreaming partly changes character to *non-self-centred daydreaming*.

The narrative quoted earlier in this section invites the recipient to mentally enact more than just opulent continental meals. In fact, the joyous material life of the protagonists eventually comes into stark contrast with the intricacies of a deteriorating relationship. Mental images of idyllic honeymoon settings can then be experienced in unusual concert with utterly ambiguous, distressful emotions. The power of such highly complex daydreams to impact the recipient's personality (Oatley 2011) and mental wellbeing (Dowrick et al. 2012) has been empirically proven. Non-self-centred daydreaming, afforded by audiobooks and print alike, may thus be considered no less beneficial to mental life than the systematic reflection supposedly impeded by the audiobook.

4. Second Similarity: The Relative Poverty of the Recipient's Attention

4.1. Second Intuition

The second intuition that needs to be put into perspective may be expressed as follows: *Compared to print, audiobooks invite more inattentive processing*. Or perhaps even more strongly: *Unlike print, audiobooks invite inattentive processing*. The intuition has appeared in theoretical writing (Wittkower 2011; more strongly in Birkerts 1994) as well as in popular science writing (Jaffe 2014). To some degree, it (or at least its weaker version) is certainly true. As already mentioned, the exemplary listening situation involves more potential stimuli from the continuously visible and changing environment, and with them more possible distract-

tion. The degree to which the intuition can be further embraced or questioned depends on what is meant by inattentive processing.

From the viewpoint of text experience, at least two different notions of inattention can be distinguished: firstly, there are instances of the recipient becoming more or less distinctly aware of paying attention to other matters than the narrative being read or listened to. This phenomenon is widely known as mind wandering. Although recent empirical studies have shown that listening to a (popular science) text elicits slightly more mind wandering than the (digital) silent reading of the same text (Varao Sousa, Carriere and Smilek 2013), it would be misguided to believe that mind wandering is absent or uncommon in reading (Dixon and Bortolussi 2013). Mind wandering occurs in expert readers and novices alike. Moreover, the recipient's mind does not always wander off to matters entirely unrelated to the narrative. Convergent evidence suggests that elaborate mental digressions to personal life experiences directly cued by a (print) narrative can yield strong aesthetic effects (Miall 2006).

The main focus of the present section, however, is a second, broader notion of inattention. On this notion, inattention is simply the inverse of a recipient's real-time awareness of the specific wording of a stretch of text and/or its possible meaning, also in relation to previous stretches of the same text. In this sense, an instance of inattention can, but does not have to, coincide with or be immediately preceded by mind wandering. To the recipient, inattention in this sense can only become truly manifest when a narrative passage suddenly stops making sense. To a third-person observer, it can become manifest in the recipient's failing of a memory or comprehension check. In most cases, it does not become manifest at all.

4.2. Second Misconception

In terms of inattention so defined, the focal intuition of the present section relies on the following misconception: *Readers of print narrative commonly attend to textual detail*. This view of reading seems to underpin much of advanced literary education as well as literary scholarship. Educators often express their surprise at students failing to report and analyse their assigned reading materials in terms of various subtle connections and verbal nuances. In the words of Louise M. Rosenblatt, a pioneer of modern literary education: "The reader must pay attention to all that these words, and no others, these words, moreover, in a particular sequence, summon up. [...] What is lived through is felt constantly to be linked with the words" (Rosenblatt 1994 [1978], 29). Rosenblatt speaks of poetry

reading primarily, but the concept of narrative reading prevailing in literature classes is largely similar (Fialho, Zyngier and Miall 2011, 238).

The problem is that most readers neither fulfil this ideal nor aspire to it. Empirical studies have shown that people are generally bad at noticing obvious errors that are “hidden” in non-emphatic positions in a text, e.g.: “After an air crash, where should the survivors be buried?” or notoriously, “How many animals of each sort did Moses put in the Ark?” (see Emmott, Sanford and Dawydiak 2007 for a review). This is because readers with developed reading skills rarely take in one word at a time the way it has been suggested by Rosenblatt. Rather, their attention for wording and meaning is partly allocated in retrospect, depending on emergent structure. Unless highly unfamiliar or unexpected in themselves, discrete formulations largely become salient in a reader’s attention and memory only if they prove significant for the continued narrative (see also Perry 1979). In this regard, the attention economy of silent narrative reading may not be entirely dissimilar from that of verbal auditory perception as explicated by Susan Blackmore, psychologist and philosopher of mind:

In a noisy room full of people talking you may suddenly switch your attention because someone has said ‘Guess who I saw with Anya the other day – it was Bernard’. [...] At this point you seem to have been aware of the whole sentence as it was spoken. But were you really? The fact is that you would never have noticed it at all if she had concluded the sentence with a name that meant nothing to you. (Blackmore 2002, 24)

Accordingly, readers’ memory for precise wording is known to be generally poor (e.g., Dixon and Bortolussi 2013, 2). There seems to be relatively little innate capacity on the part of the reader to thoroughly register and interpret textual detail. More importantly, there may also be relatively little spontaneous need to do so. For an approximate illustration, read the following narrative passage from Hemingway’s *A Farewell to Arms*. Read as naturally as possible:

There was a battery of naval guns that had gotten on his nerves. I would recognize them because of their flat trajectory. You heard the report and then the shriek commenced almost instantly. They usually fired two guns at once, one right after the other, and the fragments from the burst were enormous. He showed me one, a smoothly jagged piece of metal over a foot long. It looked like babbitting metal.

“I don’t suppose they are so effective,” Gino said.

“But they scare me. They all sound as though they came directly for you. There is the boom, then instantly the shriek and burst. What’s the use of not being wounded if they scare you to death?” (Hemingway 1962 [1929], 182)

Consider now the expression “babbitting metal” as used in this passage. Most readers probably never encountered the expression before, partly because it

taps into a specialized domain of knowledge (metallurgy), partly because the standard expression for the phenomenon in question (a type of alloy) is now Babbitt, Babbitt metal, or bearing metal – not babbitting metal. Does this mean that most readers halt at the expression to ponder it as they read, or that they put the printed book aside to consult external information sources before they continue reading?⁶ I believe that most readers are not especially bothered by such an isolated instance of meaning opacity, if they notice it in the first place. More often than not Hemingway's use of "babbitting metal" probably has no deeper bearing on further text experience.

Although one's inattention *vis-à-vis* the precise meaning of the expression would show on an objectively administered comprehension test, it is relatively unlikely to prompt one of those moments when the narrative stops making sense, subjectively speaking. And if an unfamiliar expression such as "babbitting metal" can remain largely inconspicuous, how about all the familiar expressions that form the bulk of a narrative? For instance, does ambiguous anaphoric reference as exemplified by the wealth of pronouns in the opening of the excerpt ("his nerves" vs. "I would recognize" vs. "You heard"; emphasis mine) always cause readers to pause and reflect until they are able to determine who is who? Experimental research (Sanford and Emmott 2013, 72–102) suggests that this is not necessarily the case. Rather, it seems that a more large-scale comprehension failure (e.g., concerning a key event or a decision potentially affecting the main course of events) is typically needed for a reader to realize that she has been inattentive, and to deliberately act on her inattention by making a pause in reading.

4.3. Second Set of Consequences for Text Experience

Now that it has been proposed that readers of print narrative are neither very attentive nor bothered by their inattention, what conclusions can we draw from this proposal in relation to audiobook listening, the similarity between the two media, and the possible function of this similarity? The pace of audiobook listening is externally imposed.⁷ In this connection, theorists (e.g., Wittkower 2011) have pointed to the fact that the digital audio players of today do not allow lis-

⁶ Interruptions for information search are believed by some scholars to be more common in e-reading, where search engines are often integrated in the reading device (Wolf and Barzillai 2009).

⁷ However, some audio software enables the listener to adjust the playback speed, a feature purportedly gaining traction in expository reading (Garber 2015).

teners to comfortably circle back in a narrative to rehear discrete passages. Navigating back and forth in an audio narrative remains greatly imprecise, which has led to the assumption that it is not done very frequently, as compared to rereading in print. But is it really correct to assume that readers of print narrative frequently circle back to unattended passages – unless their understanding of key events is severely weakened? My above argument suggests that it is not (see also Toolan 2008).

The question arises why readers and listeners, in contrast to the attitudes commended by literary scholars and educators, may worry so little about their grasp of what they read or listen to. A possible explanation is that circling back to unattended passages may be useful for systematic reflection of the scholarly kind, but way too costly in terms of another inherent function of narrative reception: the recipient's sense of mental *fluency*. It is with the fluency of their experience in mind, I would like to suggest, that recipients prefer trying to catch up with a narrative before taking the radical step of rereading or re-listening. The positive value of experienced fluency has been empirically proven. In a meta-analysis of a large corpus of experimental data obtained with visual and (primitive) verbal stimuli (Reber, Schwarz and Winkielman 2004), processing fluency has been identified as the single most reliable predictor of aesthetic pleasure. Aesthetic pleasure, i.e., the instant joy or sense of beauty triggered by a stimulus without any intermediate reasoning, is in turn a massive factor in leisure reading and listening. As a motivation for the recipient to stick with a narrative in whatever medium, it probably outperforms any need for systematic reflection.

Moreover, an artificially induced sense of fluency has been expressly mentioned as an important benefit of portable audio usage overall. Survey respondents have reported that their hectic daily errands can become significantly more pleasurable with music or narrative playing through a headset, precisely due to the unifying, uninterrupted nature of the auditory stimulus (Bull 2007, 24–49). That this experienced fluency is far from synonymous to the constancy of one's attention *vis-à-vis* the auditory stimulus is obvious in the case of some such listening situations. To the contrary, audiobook listeners largely and willingly engage in a continuous “drifting in and out of attention” (Wittkower 2011, 222). Thus it seems that periodic inattention can contribute to a listener's experience of fluency instead of disturbing it. If the same applies to print reading, the intuition that audiobooks invite more inattentive processing is true only in part and only in its weaker form. Importantly, it loses much of its original significance as soon as we abandon traditional academic preconceptions concerning the inherent levels and value of focal attention in the reception of narrative.

5. Third Similarity: The Occasional Richness of the Recipient's Phenomenal Consciousness

5.1. Third Intuition

The third and final cross-medial similarity to be explored here is the occasional richness of the recipient's phenomenal consciousness. What is phenomenal consciousness? Phenomenal consciousness is closely linked to the previous two aspects of the recipient's experience, i.e., mental imagery and attention. In any given situation, a subject is phenomenally conscious if there is something that gives her the impression of what it is *like* for her, in terms of her subjective experience of the world around her, to be in that situation. For instance, an audiobook listener is phenomenally conscious of a sensory stimulus from the environment, say the smell of exhaust fumes, if this stimulus somehow informs her experience proper of the listening session.

There is a long-standing philosophical debate concerning the nature of phenomenal consciousness. Some philosophers (Dennett 1991) claim that phenomenal consciousness is inherently thin, i.e., that it can only encompass what is in the focus of one's attention. On such a thin account, an audiobook listener could never become phenomenally conscious of a smell from the environment without having to shift her attention away from the audiobook. On the other side of the spectrum, rich accounts of phenomenal consciousness (Searle 1992) suggest that our consciousness is constantly flooded with non-focal stimuli. On this account, the sheer presence of exhaust fumes in one's environment automatically entails that their smell is consciously experienced. These two radical accounts have partly been reconciled in a complex empirical study (Schwitzgebel 2007). The findings of this study suggest that in naturalistic everyday situations, phenomenal consciousness tends to alternate between a thinner and a richer set. In other words, phenomenal consciousness is only occasionally rich, sometimes encompassing non-focal aspects of a situation (e.g., the smell of exhaust fumes during an urban audio session), sometimes not.

This observation has bearing on the third intuition concerning audiobook listening. The intuition goes roughly as follows: *Compared to print reading, audiobook listening is more environmentally situated.* Or even more strongly: *Unlike print reading, audiobook listening is environmentally situated.* The intuition is meant to signify that, because an audiobook listener typically engages in the simultaneous navigation of an environment, her text experience is more contingent on the concurrent environment experience. As a consequence, the overall experience is more arbitrary, subject to external variables. Between two different

environments, one's listening experience of a given narrative should then vary more strongly than one's reading experience of the same narrative. This is how the intuition has been framed in scholarly writing (Wittkower 2011). Once again, the weaker version of the intuition is probably true to some extent, yet it deserves revision with regard to the nature of print reading.

5.2. Third Misconception

Translated into the terms of the phenomenal consciousness debate, audiobook listening is assumed to generally entail richer consciousness relative to print reading. What is more, in narrative scholarship print reading is often assumed to generally entail more or less radically thin phenomenal consciousness. This is the misconception that needs to be dealt with. It is epitomized in one of the basic tenets of the so-called transportation framework, an influential model of narrative reading: *Narrative (print) reading transports you away from your physical environment*. The transportation framework, first introduced in narrative studies by psychologist Richard Gerrig and further developed especially by Melanie Green and colleagues (e.g., Green and Brock 2000), has significantly contributed to our understanding of narrative reading overall. What should be questioned is the idea that transportation into a narrative experience, defined as “an integrative melding of attention, imagery, and feelings” (Green and Brock 2000, 701), occurs at the cost of one's experience of the physical environment.

In a widely used psychometric instrument, transportation is modelled to decrease to the extent that readers report being conscious of their surroundings. The authors support their model by saying that “a transported reader may not notice others entering the room” (Green and Brock 2000, 702). But unless print reading is for some reason exempt from the general workings of phenomenal consciousness, environment occasionally becomes salient in a reader's experience, too. There is no reason why attention for – and mental imagery prompted by – a printed narrative should foreclose all conscious environment experience and *vice versa*. Consider for instance the following narrative passage from Hemingway's *The Garden of Eden*:

The breeze from the sea was blowing through the room and [David] was reading with his shoulders and the small of his back against two pillows and another folded behind his head. He was sleepy after lunch but he felt hollow with waiting for her and he read and waited. (Hemingway 1995 [1986], 45)

The situation rendered in this passage takes place in a rented vacation room during Catherine and David's honeymoon in the Mediterranean. Apart from David's instantaneous impatience, the overall atmosphere at this stage of the story is rather relaxed and idyllic. Imagine a reader reading the passage in a physical setting, or even overall disposition, overlapping with David's. The narrative is then likely to enhance this reader's phenomenal experience of her own environment, say the pressure of physical pillows behind her back or a breeze that happens to be cooling down her skin on a hot day. The overlap between physical and fictional environment may also prop her enactive mental imagery of the situation rendered in the narrative (Kuzmičová 2015). In such cases of relatively close overlap, the physical environment can thus affect mental imagery in a manner precisely opposite to within-modality interference as mentioned earlier in Section 3.1. Compared to reading the same passage on a crowded bus, where one may deliberately strive for a thinner mode of consciousness in order to screen off tiresome outer stimuli (the smell of exhaust fumes, the roar of the engine, the chatter of fellow passengers), the environment is not experienced as wholly extraneous to the narrative. For a brief instant at least, the reader experiences rich phenomenal consciousness.

5.3. Third Set of Consequences for Text Experience

Environmental propping of mental imagery is just one, and possibly relatively sparse, way in which a reader's phenomenal consciousness occasionally becomes rich. Environment experience can also link to text experience on a more general, i.e., more generally aesthetic, level. Let us return to the crowded bus scenario. For most readers a crowded bus represents a less inherently pleasing environment than a coastal vacation dwelling. But its lack of inherent pleasure can vary on a scale. On one end of the scale, an environment can be so unpleasant that one is incapable of reading in it at all. Next on the scale are situations when an environment can only be used for reading provided that the reader succeeds in screening off environmental stimuli altogether, achieving a radically thin mode of phenomenal consciousness.

Next, however, are situations when an environment is experienced as only comparably unpleasant, allowing for a comparably rich mode of phenomenal consciousness during reading. One possible consequence of such situations, then, is a *transfer of aesthetic pleasure* (or simply *aesthetic transfer*) between text and environment. This means that the value-positive experience prompted by a narrative *per se* can make the concurrent environment experience less unpleasant. In highly pleasurable environments, aesthetic transfer may also occur

in the opposite direction. In other words, even a crowded bus can become a distinctly nice and cosy place to be in with an aesthetically pleasing book, and a relatively distressing book can afford a more fluent and pleasing experience once you get off the bus to read on a romantic park bench (for more on this see Kuzmičová 2015).

Aesthetic transfer, I would like to suggest, is the functional side proper of the recipient's rich phenomenal consciousness. It operates – occasionally – in audiobook listening and print reading alike. A population of portable audio player users expressly reported in a survey (Bull 2007, 38–49) that an audiobook or piece of music played through a headset allows them to literally project aesthetic pleasure onto environments (e. g., crowded urban settings) where none would be found otherwise. Moreover, the aesthetic pleasure taken in a narrative likely affects the way an environment is later remembered, and *vice versa*. It has been suggested in this context that an audiobook “binds memory in ways *very different* from written text, due to the simultaneous experience of an arbitrarily related visual field” (Wittkower 2011, 230; emphasis mine). However, there is some evidence that readers, too, vividly recall their changing reading environments in a longer time frame. A research team led by literary scholar Andrew Elfenbein collected an extensive set of reading memories written down between 1777 and 1915. Looking into what aspects of people's reading experiences were typically mentioned upon long-term recall, Elfenbein's analysis (2012) revealed that detailed recollections of reading environment were strongly represented, and consistently correlated with memories of story content. More anecdotally, novelist Marcel Proust went so far as to claim that books read in the more distant past were above all the chronicles of our physical, mundane life and “of the places and days when and where we engaged” (Proust 2011, 18) in reading them. Such accounts of print reading diverge from the intuition that print reading, unlike audiobook listening, is not environmentally situated, or that print narrative transports readers away from their physical environment.

6. Conclusion

Comparisons between established and emergent cultural practices usually highlight relative weaknesses in the latter. If audiobooks were meant to replace print or reading entirely, a thorough empirical investigation of such weaknesses would be critical. For the time being, it is probably fair to say that audiobooks cannot compete with print in their affordances for academic reading strategies relying on close attention to verbal artistry and subtle patterns of meaning organization.

On the other hand, it is also fair to say that academic reading strategies thus defined concern a relatively small group of readers.

In this chapter I isolated three features of audiobook listening which I unpacked with the help of three intuitions concerning alleged differences *vis-à-vis* print reading: the enactive nature of the recipient's mental imagery, the relative poverty of the recipient's attention, and the occasional richness of the recipient's phenomenal consciousness. Rather than presenting them as distinctive of the audiobook, I chose to point at their ubiquity in narrative text reception more generally. It is a virtue rather than a weakness of the audiobook medium that it makes these features emerge in the centre of theoretical attention, disproving common misconceptions concerning print reading. These misconceptions in turn are largely caused by the traditional lack of interest, amongst reader response theorists, in non-academic reading strategies (for a classical example, see Culler 1980).

The three cross-medial similarities may indeed be inversely related to continuous in-depth reflection. Enactive mental imagery (first similarity), compared to a notion of picturesque imaging (first misconception), erases the mental distance required for reflection, and there is nothing overtly systematic or analytical about the non-self-centred daydreaming it enables (first set of consequences). Relatively poor attention (second similarity), unlike its opposite (second misconception), clearly disagrees with academic strategies of reading. In these strategies, any subjective sense of fluency (second set of consequences) becomes necessarily disrupted. Finally, an acknowledgement of rich phenomenal consciousness (third similarity) poses a problem to a view of reading freed from the contingencies of a particular environment (third misconception). It makes a narrative text an even less stable, i.e., analysable, object than traditionally assumed. In fact, the idea of aesthetic transfer from text to environment (third set of consequences) presupposes a shift in the primary role of narrative – from an object of reflection to a means of achieving hedonic states of mind. It must be noted that the long-term cognitive benefits of in-depth reflection remain indisputable (Wolf and Barzillai 2009). Yet audiobooks are often played in situations precluding such reflection anyhow, and should therefore be valued for what they do facilitate: the recipient's wellbeing through daydreaming, fluency, and overall aesthetic pleasure, as also facilitated by non-academic ways of print reading.

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Jarmila Mildorf

Pictures into Sound: Aural World-Making in Art Gallery Audio Guides

Audio guides employ sound, music and voices to inform visitors in an entertaining way about exhibits or pictures and their artists. They mesh biographical and socio-historical details with scholarly discussions of the respective artefact, often resorting to anecdotes and so-called “artist’s statements” (Sandino 2010), i.e., statements made by artists about their own art, gathered from diaries and letters. Audio guides typically come under closer scrutiny in either marketing research, which seeks to optimize audio guide formats in order to increase visitors’ satisfaction with exhibitions (Teffé and Müller-Hagedorn 2008; Jarrier and Bourgeon-Renault 2012), or in the literature on museum pedagogy since museums traditionally aim at teaching and informing their visitors (FitzGerald, Taylor and Craven 2013; Frykman 2009). In both contexts, narrative arguably plays a major role because the design and presentation of audio guide materials will have an impact on how these materials are perceived and digested by users. And yet, the specifically narrative qualities of audio guide materials are often overlooked in the literature, or they seem to be taken for granted as an important feature of ‘good’ audio guide design without anyone asking more directly why this should be the case and, more importantly, how these qualities are achieved.¹ In other words, the questions often missing from the above-mentioned research are: what precisely makes audio guides a) narrative and b) powerful tools for engaging visitors on account of their narrativity?

Narratology as a discipline asks these questions because narrative is at the centre of its theoretical and methodological domain. However, despite narratology’s expansion into various disciplinary fields and across both fictional and non-fictional narrative genres, this form of storytelling practised in art gallery and museum audio guides has not yet been within the purview of the discipline. I suspect that there are at least three reasons for this oversight: first, audio guide materials are *not only* narrative in nature; rather, narrative as one text type is em-

¹ For example, FitzGerald, Taylor and Craven (2013) and Novey and Hall (2007) frequently use the term “audio narrative” or “audio narration” in their articles without specifying what is meant by those terms. Novey and Hall (2007, 264) furthermore describe the audio tour they tested as follows: “Sound and music are used where appropriate to add to the program’s quality,” again without specifying precisely *how* sound and music are used and how they relate to the audio *narratives* (however, cf. Frykman’s (2009, 305) criteria for narratives).

bedded in and alternates with other text types such as description or exposition. Second, audio guide narratives have very distinct pragmatic functions within clearly demarcated situational contexts, which may easily cloud the fact that they are also the result of artistic expression, both on the part of producers and performers. Third, the multimodality of audio guide narratives poses a methodological challenge because attention must be paid not only to text-image relations as in comics or to text-image-sound relations as in film or drama. Instead, the different modes in audio guides also operate on different levels: the painting (or museum exhibit more generally) tells one story² whereas the recorded audio guide text tells a story *about* the picture (and the artist) and in this sense is meta-narrative. Moreover, audio guide narratives have a different physiological impact on listeners because these literally carry the sounds and voices in their ears by means of earphones (Myers 2010). In this regard, the immersive qualities of audio guide narration resemble those of video games or more advanced sound technologies used for film, like surround sound or ambience techniques.³

In this contribution, I discuss an example from the book series *Kunst zum Hören* ['Art for Listening'] published by Hatje Cantz in cooperation with art galleries and audio guide producers, which presents the texts of art gallery audio guides alongside the exhibited pictures in audiobook-cum-exhibition catalogue form, giving visitors (and others) the opportunity to look at the paintings (again) in the book while listening to the audio guide text on CD, presumably at leisure in their own homes. I investigate more closely how these audio guides create a special soundscape by combining observation and visual input with an intimate and purely auditory narrative experience. As I will show, these audio guide narratives create a productive tension between a text that is scripted and its rendition in oral form that is more reminiscent of oral/aural storytelling situations. My

² Whether paintings really 'tell a story' is of course an issue of some debate. The fact that a painting is temporally static means that it can show the passage of time only spatially, e.g., by juxtaposing successive events in different parts of a painting (see Barasch 1997, 245–265), which Marie-Laure Ryan (2004, 141) refers to as "segmentation." Especially paintings which depict only a single moment can at best *allude to* a plot by offering hints in the way the characters and their surroundings are depicted (see Wolf 2002, 73). This "atemporal configuration" (Steiner 2004, 172) of pictorial art became the standard paradigm at the transition point from medieval to Renaissance conventions and is closely linked to artists' notions of realism at the time, as Wendy Steiner's (2004) historical overview demonstrates. Still, pictorial art's 'narrativity' can be said to emerge from onlookers' interpretive engagement with pictures (Barasch 1997, 265; Wolf 2002, 75).

³ From a theoretical perspective, one obviously has to distinguish between listeners' immersion triggered by the *words* used in a story, and their immersion into the *soundscape* of the audio narrative. I will return to this point below.

concrete example is taken from Hatje Cantz' (2010) book on Gustave Courbet, which in turn is based on the exhibition "Courbet – ein Traum von der Moderne" ['Courbet – A Dream of Modernism'], originally shown at the Schirn Kunsthalle Frankfurt from 15 October 2010 to 30 January 2011.⁴ I will analyse the ways in which the voice actress' tone of voice and prosodic modulations, the alternation of speaking voices and musical interventions support as well as implement narrative structure and thus create storyworlds in listeners' minds even beyond the world presented in the chosen picture.

1. Multiple Stories, Narrative Cohesive Ties

One of the first things to note when listening to the recording is that it is surprisingly short. At just under 2:38 min, the spoken text aims at concision while at the same time being both informative and entertaining. In this regard, the audio guide narrative shares with conversational stories one central goal: they must not overtax the listeners' attention span or bore them. Like conversational narratives, the one presented here is not only short but uses a comparatively simple syntax (see Labov 2013, 177). Even though it does not primarily present a string of simple "narrative clauses" in the Labovian sense, it is also not as complex as German written syntax (in academic writing, that is) with less than half of all sentences (excluding direct quotations) being marked by hypotaxis, i.e., involving subordinate clause constructions. Where clauses are conjoined the text seems to favour coordination (or parataxis) over subordination, as can be seen in the causal constructions with "denn" ['for'] (lines 4 and 21) rather than "weil" ['because'] (line 2). This means that finite verbs as carriers of vital semantic content appear in second rather than final position and can thus be processed more quickly (see König and Gast 2007, 260), which is arguably more congenial to online syntactical processing in the absence of written text. On the level of logical coherence, one finds simple dichotomies. For example, when the text explains why Courbet painted this picture it offers two reasons: the first reason, namely that people were interested in buying this pictorial genre, is presented as the 'surface' reason or the reason in the 'foreground' ("vordergründig," line 2). The second reason – that Courbet used the subject matter to depict his own situation – is implicitly presented as the more important reason since it

⁴ Further information on the exhibition including its various publications can be found at: http://www.schirn.de/Courbet_2.html. For reasons of copyright I cannot reproduce the actual painting here but a photographic reproduction can be looked at here: <http://www.centenary.edu/french/art/courbet-le-cerf-a-l'eau-1858.jpg>.

is further elaborated in line 4: “denn auch der Maler fühlte sich damals auf der Flucht” [‘because the painter also felt chased at the time’].⁵ In the end, a similarly simple dichotomy is offered to talk about Courbet’s aims as a painter: he was not so much interested in the objective reality of everyday life but (“sondern,” line 21) in the subjective reality of the dream. Such dichotomies offer simplifications and thus also make the text easier to process.

The text also displays what in text linguistics is called “cohesive ties,” i.e., connections between lexical items across a text which create a network and thus give the text a quality of ‘hanging together.’ In their classic study, Halliday and Hasan (1976) distinguished between “lexical” and “grammatical” cohesion. Among the former, they subsumed “reiteration” and “collocation.” “Grammatical” cohesion comprises phenomena such as “reference,” “substitution,” “ellipsis” and “conjunction.” One can find most of these devices in the text at hand; to give only a few examples: Courbet is anaphorically referred to as “er” [‘he’] (lines 2, 3) or “ihm” [‘him’] (line 21), or is metonymically replaced by the noun “der Maler” [‘the painter’] (line 4). Likewise, “Hirsch” [‘stag’] is twice replaced by its hyperonym or superordinate term “Tier” [‘animal’] (lines 3, 13). Repeated collocations can be found, for example, in “Tiere im *Trab* oder *Galopp*” [‘trotting or galloping animals’] (line 17) and “von *trabenden* und *galoppierenden* Vierbeinern” [‘of trotting or galloping quadrupeds’] (line 19), where the words are repeated in different word forms. “Tiere” and “Vierbeiner” also have a hyperonymic relationship since the latter can be subsumed under the former. Elements of a collocation can even be merged: thus, “Bewegungen” and “Phasen” in line 18 are combined into the compound noun “Bewegungsphasen” in line 19.

More conspicuously, however, the text is very rich in lexical cohesion, i.e., one can find numerous repetitions of words both within sentences and from line to line but also across the text as a whole. For example, one of the leitmotifs in this short text, the ‘dream’ [“Traum”] occurs in lines 9, 11 and 21. Courbet’s name is mentioned five times (lines 1, 4, 6, 10, 20), and the other central ‘protagonist,’ the stag presented in the painting, appears even seven times (lines 2, 4, 6, 8, 11, 15), often collocated with “Wasser” [‘water’], as in the painting’s title (lines 2, 4, 8). Words are also repeated in different word forms and thus link successive

⁵ That only these two reasons are mentioned is obviously a gross oversimplification. There is also the question of the art cultural climate at the time and influences from other painters. As Tseng (2008, 220) points out, Courbet himself admitted to being influenced by Horace Vernet and Sir Edwin Landseer, and he made “sketches after carcasses from the hunt, the butcher’s store, and taxidermy” to “achieve naturalism.” The reduction in the audio guide text is interesting in that it foregrounds personal and psychological explanations, a point I will come back to below.

sentences. For example, the noun “Jäger” [‘hunter’] in line 1 is morphologically related with “Jagd” [‘hunting’] in “Jagdszenen” [‘hunting scenes’] (line 2). The participle “flüchtend” [‘fleeing’] (line 2) is repeated in line 3 and reappears in the noun “Flucht” [‘flight’] (line 4). Many more examples of such associative chains could be mentioned. The text can therefore be said to show “dense cohesion,” which “is characteristic of two-party conversations,” as Tanskanen (2006, 168) notes. Repetition is also a key feature of what Tannen (1989) called “high involvement style,” i.e., a conversational style that aims at engaging the interlocutor. Engaging or involving the listener is also one of the central tasks of audio guide texts.

Repetitions furthermore have a mnemonic function and internally structure the text. Repeated words stick in listeners’ minds. In this connection, it is also worth considering the global structure of this audio guide text. One can divide it into three parts, which all participate in a larger narrative genre while also having a narrative core: part one from lines 1 to 5 offers biographical information on the painter and thus squares in with the life history genre; part two from lines 6 to 15 describes the painting and thus belongs to art history; part three from line 16 to the end offers a more general outline of the development of certain painting techniques related to the depiction of animals (with an excursion to photography) and can thus be placed within art and cultural or even media history. Interestingly, each part is also connected to another one by incorporating its thematic core. Thus, the sentence in line 4, which tells the listener that the picture can be regarded as one of Courbet’s covert self-portraits, anticipates the art historical exposition of the second part, where the description of the painting is elaborated. Similarly, the sentence in the last two lines comes back to Courbet’s agenda and to the significance of the dream in his painting after this part has presented a more general discussion of the problem of painting animals’ movements realistically. In other words, the text is given a more personal touch again (see also line 9).

This feature of presenting a more personal and even psychological account contributes to the text’s narrativity because it infuses expository and descriptive text types with “experientiality” (Fludernik 1996). Thus, the first part would be little more than a biographical sketch if it did not also ascribe feelings to Courbet and allow us an insight into his mind. We are told that he ‘recognised himself in the fleeing animal’ (“erkannte er sich in dem flüchtenden Tier auch selbst wieder,” line 3) and that he ‘felt chased’ (“fühlte sich [...] auf der Flucht,” line 4). Courbet’s affinity with the stag is underlined by the animal’s anthropomorphisation in the painting’s description. Thus, the stag is said to have ‘an expression of despair that is almost human’ (“einen verzweifelten, geradezu menschlichen Ausdruck,” line 13). Line 20 even introduces an instance of hypothetical narra-

tion (or the disnarrated) because we learn that Courbet would probably not have been interested in the discoveries made by photographer Eadweard Muybridge. The largely expository text passage, which explains the historical development of a new realist perspective on movement, is thus infused with a narrativizing technique, the main purposes of which are first, to tie this part back to the actual theme of this audio guide text, and second, to render the account livelier for the listening audience. In this context, the non-verbal sonic features of this text are also very important.

2. Narrating Voices: Functional Roles and Sound Qualities⁶

Two voices are employed to speak the text, a male and a female voice. None of the two voice actors can be considered a narrator in the regular sense of the word because none of them actually ‘tells the story’ in the same sense that someone would tell a personal story in a conversational setting. Erving Goffman already pointed out in his book *Forms of Talk* that the notion of “speaker” can be rather complex. He distinguishes between the “animator,” i.e., the person giving voice to an utterance; the “author,” who selected what is said and how it is said; and the “principal,” i.e., someone whose position or beliefs are expressed through the words that are spoken (Goffman 1981, 144). The function of the two voice actors in this recording is that of “animators.”⁷ They lend their respective voice qualities to the text and thus bring it to life. It is noteworthy that two clearly distinguishable voices are used. They create a contrast between the expository/narrative frame text (spoken by the woman) and the embedded quotations (spoken by the man) in lines 5 and 11. The male voice aptly enacts Courbet himself. The introduction of direct speech dramatizes the story at this point, just as fictional dialogue is used to enliven novels (see Mildorf 2014). Unlike in fictional dialogue, however, listeners do not have to *imagine* characters’ voices. Here, they can *literally hear* them. Direct speech allows ‘Courbet’ to ‘speak for himself,’ i.e., his

⁶ In this part, I use conversation analytical notation to give an idea of the sound side of the spoken text. I intermittently explain the relevant notational conventions in my discussion. For a fuller account, see <http://homepages.lboro.ac.uk/~ssca1/notation.htm>.

⁷ The real author of the text is Ursula Vorwerk. However, because this is a multimodal text one may even consider the entire production team at Linon Medien as the ‘author’ (in the abstract). Whether the voice actors are also “principals,” i.e., they believe what they say to be accurate, remains undecided and is even irrelevant in this context.

emotions are presented more immediately. This creates a sense of ‘authenticity’ as well as bringing the listener closer to the presented ‘character.’

This proximity or immediacy is further underlined by a change in tenses. When the male voice actor speaks his part for the first time (thus also introducing a first-person perspective, if ever so minimally) the account shifts to present tense. Even when the text moves on to the description of the painting itself it remains in present tense. The historical present is widely used in German to relate the contents of a novel or a piece of art more generally. It is therefore not surprising at this point. And yet, when the voice actress relates what can be seen in the painting the present tense once again contributes towards making the content livelier or dramatic. In fact, ‘drama’ is even used as a metaphorical frame to talk about the picture: “...erschafft er eine grandiose Bühne, auf der sich das Drama abspielt” [‘he creates a grandiose stage on which the dramatic action takes place’] (line 7). Before I discuss the sonic presentation of the picture’s subject matter in more detail, I must say a few words about the voice actress’ voice quality.

Listening to the female voice in this audio guide production, probably many people in Germany would recognise the voice of Hannelore Elsner, a German actress well known from numerous TV films and series. After all, as Crowder (1993) argues, there is a non-verbal “auditory memory,” which enables us, for example, to identify instruments by their timbre and pitch, just as it may help us recognise people’s voices.⁸ Even without having a picture of this actress in one’s mind, Elsner’s voice evokes the image of an attractive woman and is very agreeable to listen to.⁹ It is difficult to find appropriate adjectives to describe her voice. A Japanese study (Oguchi and Kikuchi 1997, 58), which asked participants to evaluate unknown readers’ voices, their physical appearance as shown in photographs and their overall attractiveness, offered the following pairs of adjectives for the assessment of speakers’ voice qualities: high-low, bright-dark, clear-unclear, sweet-bitter, tasty-not tasty, generous-severe; and for their manner of speaking: good tempo-bad tempo, affectionate-unaffectionate, articulate-inarticulate,

⁸ Voice recognition is a vibrant research field in phonetics and psychology with application in the industrial development of voice recognition technologies as well as in forensics (Leemann, Kolly and Dellwo 2014).

⁹ There is a large body of research on voice quality and attractiveness. Hughes, Dispenza and Gallup (2004, 303), for example, come to the conclusion that the human voice “provides important information about a host of biologically relevant features such as fluctuating asymmetry, body configuration, and sexual behavior.” A study by Jones et al. (2008) furthermore suggests that especially men’s assessment of female voices also correlates with what social interest men have in women and what social interest they perceive the women to have in them.

rhythmical-not rhythmical.¹⁰ One would think that what individual respondents perceive as “sweet” or “generous” is difficult to tell, and whether they find this or that quality more attractive may be a question of people’s individual taste. Nevertheless, there is considerable consensus, as one of the results of this study shows: “Attractive voices and unattractive voices were significantly different in all criteria except speed of voice” (Oguchi and Kikuchi 1997, 59). Women’s voices were considered to be particularly attractive when they were “bright,” “generous” and “affectionate” (Oguchi and Kikuchi 1997, 60).

Elsner speaks her text in a very clear and articulate manner, taking time to pronounce words carefully. I would describe her voice quality as ‘mellow’ and ‘warm.’ Perhaps ‘generous’ from Oguchi and Kikuchi’s list would be suitable, too. It is also noticeable that she uses regular pauses to accentuate the text at certain points. The Audacity sound spectrogram gives a visual presentation of Elsner’s speaking rhythm (Figure 1):

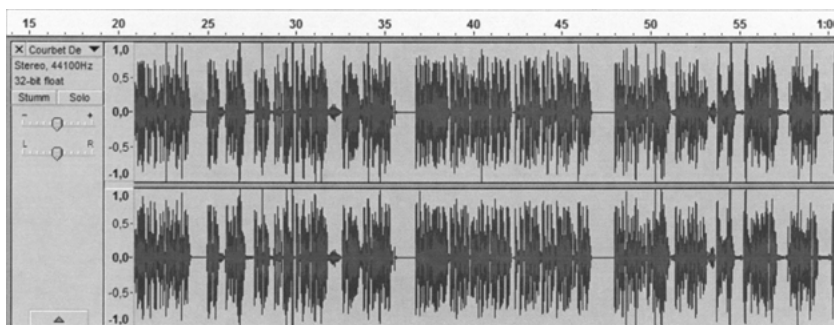


Figure 1: Excerpt from the audio guide narrative in spectrogram view

The spectrogram only shows an excerpt starting at approx. 21 sec and ending at just over 1 min of the recording. Between 36.8 sec and 46.7 sec, the male voice actor, Viktor Pavel, speaks the first direct quotation. Before and after his speaking part, there is a noticeable pause of more than one second, indicating on the sound level the shift from frame text to embedded quotation. Even though both voice actors use their ‘reading voices’ in the sense that they read out a written text, the way they do it differs considerably. Pavel’s short text shows less marked

¹⁰ Depending on one’s research questions and one’s cultural background, one may of course resort to other features of a voice semiotics which contribute to voices’ social functions. For a more linguistically oriented voice quality network, see Van Leeuwen (2009), which is also discussed by Martínez in this volume.

pauses than does Elsner's. Throughout the text, Elsner has a tendency to pause at regular intervals (indicated by dots in brackets or by timed pauses in my transcript), and not just at clause or phrase boundaries, where this would be expected, but even within phrases. In line 4, for example, she pauses twice after the definite article ("Wir dürfen: den: (0.4) "↑Hirsch am ↑Wasser" (0.6) als eines der (0.2) ver↑decken: ↑Selbstbildnisse Courbets ansehen"), thus placing emphasis on the following noun. Elsner also uses what in linguistics is sometimes described as "drawn-out speech," where vowel or consonant sounds are stretched. In my transcript, I indicate such speech by colons after the respective sounds. Often, they are nasals, as can be seen in the spectrogram image of the first clause in line 21 (Figure 2):

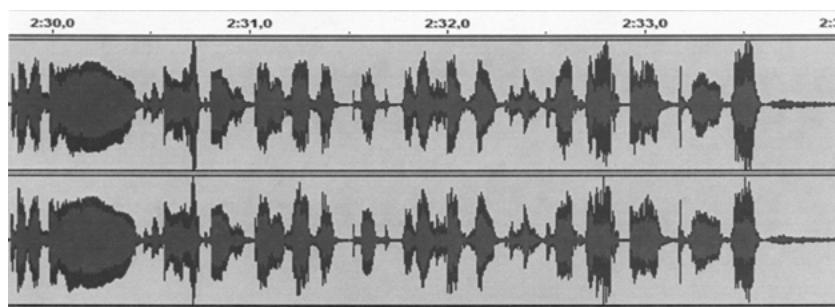


Figure 2: Excerpt from the audio guide narrative in spectrogram view

The ball-shaped wave element at 2:30 min represents the nasal [m] in "ihm." At the end of this clause, we can see the drawing out of the unvoiced [s]-sound in "Alltags." A micro-analysis of the entire piece would yield many more examples. It is this combination of pauses and voicing that seems to constitute Elsner's idiosyncratic speaking style on a suprasegmental level. Indeed, in their study of the temporal suprasegmental features of speech, Leemann, Kolly and Dellwo (2014, 65) found that "between-speaker variability is particularly evident in read speech: variability is extensive on the level of vocalic and consonantal, voiced and voiceless, as well as syllable-peak-to-syllable-peak intervals." The more interesting question is what effects this reading speech style might have on listeners and how it contributes to text/narrative structuring.

3. Voice, Music and Narrative Structure

As I already mentioned, the cadences created by Elsner's measured reading style support the narrative to the extent that the pauses help highlight important key words. At the same time, the intonation contours of the clauses underline changes in the narrative because they slow down or quicken the pace of what is related. For example, when Elsner describes the setting presented in the picture (line 7), the underlying stress pattern is mostly iambic. However, by stressing only some syllables through a rise in pitch ("mit ↑Abendrot und ↑Wolkenhimmel, (0.5) ↑Bäumen und ↑Wasser (0.5)" ['using sunset and a cloudy sky, trees and water'], line 7), the text has more of a dactylic quality and thus creates a 'lulling' rhythm. This changes as soon as the action becomes more dramatic: "↑stürzt der ↑Hirsch mit ↑letzter ↑Kraft ins Wasser. (0.8)" ['the stag takes to the water in a last effort'] (line 8). The distance between stressed syllables is decreased, which seems to increase the pace of what is said and thus gives emphasis to the stag's quick and desperate movement.

Here as elsewhere in the audio guide text, the narrative parts are interlaced with descriptive and expository text. The narrative proper, which depicts the action in the painting and the storyworld, can be found in lines 7, 8 and 12 to 15. The evaluation of what the events are like and, hence, why they are worth telling, is again located at the narratorial level. I already mentioned the anthropomorphisation of the stag in line 13. Likewise, the light in which the stag's antlers are steeped seems to be 'unreal' ("von einem unwirklichen Licht übergossen," line 12), and the idea of a dream is reinforced through the description of the stag's leap into the air: "man ↑meint, der Hirsch würde ↑fliegen" [literally: 'one forms the impression that the stag is flying'] (line 15). The use of the generic pronoun "man" ['one'] is interesting because it invites the onlooker to share this particular perception of the light as 'unreal.'

What is most striking in the rendition of the painting's narrative is its use of music. The cello music for the Courbet book was composed by John McDonald, a contemporary composer, pianist and professor of music at Tufts University. The score for the audio guide project is partially based on a previous film music project (McDonald, personal correspondence), which McDonald describes as follows in a commentary at the end of the libretto to his *Courbet's Impromptu Farewells*, Op. 484 (2011–2012):

In 2009, my Tufts University colleague Dr. Judith Wechsler, art historian and film-maker, invited me to compose music for her film *Dreaming The Modern*, an investigation of Gustave Courbet (1819–1877), the influential French painter who "dreamed" painting toward what we know as modernity. I scored the film music for solo cello, taking Courbet's early self-port-

trait playing the cello as inspiration (Courbet's expression in this portrait is described in *Part 2, Self Doubt*). This music, along with Courbet's own early poems composed as he left his native Ornans for Paris to embark on his career, served as the source for expansion in *Courbet's Impromptu Farewells*. The resulting "biopiece" also sets small excerpts of text about Courbet's life by scholars, the caricaturist Daumier, and Courbet himself. I was moved by the artistic fierceness of Courbet's work and the drama of his life to expand on the ideas used for the film music, and I am pleased to debut the work with the wonderful ANA trio. (McDonald 2012)¹¹

It is noteworthy that the music was initially already composed for a genre that is itself strongly narrative in nature, namely a biographical documentary film ("biopiece").

In the audio guide narrative, the cello starts to play in the midst of the sentence introducing the direct quotation from one of Courbet's letters, which represents a short instance of an artist's statement.¹² At first, the music is barely noticeable, the cello playing a mildly dissonant two-note harmony with a minor seventh interval for almost two bars in three-quarter time. After the direct quotation in line 11, the music becomes more agitated or "drammatico," as the score says. The half notes shift to eighth notes for one bar before they come to rest on a dotted half-note held from the previous bar. The music's vivacity is further increased through another shift to a sequence of sixteenth notes before there is once again a long tone of held half-notes with a length of 5½ quarter notes overall. This long note gives the piece the feel of a break, which overlaps with the one-second break in the spoken text (line 14) before the voice actress describes the stag's leap into the air as if it was flying (line 15). This leap is dramatically enacted by the music's 'leap' to a high tone, A⁴ flat (see the end of the first bar in Figure 3), which is eight semi-tones higher than the highest tone used in the preceding sequence. At this point the score changes from bass clef to treble clef, which indicates that the melody's dynamism not only rests on its move from longer to shorter notes (which increases perceived speed), but also from deeper to higher notes, thus increasing the melody's intensity. As in the spoken text, the relatively high-pitched tone provides stress or emphasis. Unsurprisingly, the music has by this time undergone a *crescendo* to *fortissimo*. While the whole

¹¹ I am grateful to John McDonald for kindly supplying me with the score for *Courbet's Impromptu Farewells*.

¹² As Sandino (2010, 88) points out, "narratives about their objects are, for artists, narratives of identity; to talk about the work is to talk about the self." This idea corresponds with the thrust of the audio guide narrative, which, as I already pointed out, not only combines biographical information with a description of the painting but suggests a close connection between Courbet's life and art.

sequence is powerfully played in *forte* (loudly) and *con forza* (with force) or occasionally even *sforzando* (with emphasis), the recurrent *crescendos* support the tonal moves and can be said to imitate the dynamics of the stag's galloping movement, which becomes increasingly panicky.



Figure 3: Excerpt from John McDonald's *Courbet's Impromptu Farewells*, Op. 484

In terms of narrative structure, one can say that the music supports the story's "complicating action" and "climax," where the dramatic action comes to a head. The painting captures this climactic moment by showing the stag in mid-air. The action is 'frozen,' as it were, and onlookers cannot know how the story is going to end: Will the stag be killed after all? Will it make a narrow escape? The suspense created through this lack of closure is captured by the audio guide narrative through a lengthy pause in speech (line 15), during which the cello continues to play at this high pitch, moving even higher to D⁵, on which the music then fades out. Prior to this ending, as we can see in the excerpt from the score (Figure 3), the music even increases its dramatic quality by diversifying its pitch range in this sequence from a fairly narrow range involving a number of semi-tone moves up and down within a perfect fourth interval to an interval of an octave at the beginning of the 6/8 time signature. Since here no conclusion is offered either, one could perhaps see the music at this point as a premature "coda," which "brings the time of reference back to the present time of narration" (Labov 2013, 32), precluding the question 'And then what happened?' The music replicates the stag's distress or even panic through its high-pitched, largely dissonant quality (due to the many half-steps or semi-tones), and it once again stops in mid-air (literally) like the stag (and the narrative as a whole, albeit metaphorically).

One may think that such open-ended and dissonant music could be disturbing rather than pleasant to audiences' ears and could therefore potentially put gallery visitors off. In social science research terms, there is a danger that the wrong kind of music can decrease the "attracting power" or "holding time" (Novey and Hall 2007, 262) of audio guides. However, despite the fact that the

amygdala, which “plays a central role in the processing of salient negative emotions, fear in particular,” is “activated by sad and dissonant music” (Brattico and Pearce 2013, 49), psychological research has also shown that respondents’ assessment of music as evoking “sad” or “happy” emotions depends on the kind and frequency of exposure to such music (Schellenberg, Peretz and Vieillard 2008) and even on the time of day when the music is listened to (Brabant and Toiviainen 2014). Brattico and Pearce (2013, 50) therefore “suggest using valence to indicate positive and negative affective character and including pleasure or enjoyment as an extra dimension,” i.e., disentangling respondents’ (intellectual) evaluation of music as ‘happy,’ ‘sad’ or whatever from their actual emotional responses to that music. Another factor that may influence listeners’ responses to audio guide music and to the audio guide presentation as a whole is the space in which an audio guide is listened to.

4. A Note on Sound, Space and Immersion

Multimodal discourse analysis, like many other research areas to date, acknowledges space as a semiotic system and assigns communicative functions to it (Stenglin 2009). Even though the focus in this paper is on sounds (including voices and music) they of course do not occur in a spatial vacuum. Audio guides as used in museums and galleries typically occupy a position close to and even inside the bodies of the persons carrying them. In this regard, what Myers (2010, 59) says of artistic guided walks is equally true of the use of audio guides in museum spaces:

Rather than the locus of performance being centred exclusively in the body of the artist as performer and the audience being involved as a passive participant, an active mode of participation is set in motion, which calls upon a range of perceptual, imaginative and bodily sensitivities and skills...

The audio guide also calls upon visitors’ perceptions and creates viewpoints both in the literal sense of the word but also metaphorically: it guides listeners to view pictures from a certain spatial vantage point and to fix their gaze onto certain elements in the picture, while also offering interpretations and ‘ways of seeing.’ Since viewing pictures with the help of audio guides is a multi-sensorial experience different “bodily sensitivities” are addressed: not only may we become engrossed in a picture because of the words that tell us something about it, but the very voices, sounds and music employed to enrich the experience can trigger very concrete physical reactions (see also Festjens, this volume).

We may have a tingling sensation of pleasure, a warm sensation of comfort, our muscles may relax or become tense, etc.

Furthermore, the fact that we are completely surrounded by sound can change our imaginative investment in a picture. As Chaves and Rebelo (2012, 219) point out: “In sound lies the potential for elsewhere and the possibility that even for just a few seconds a listener is transported into imagined worlds, in a process made up of memories and moods.” This transportation by means of the imagination creates “earpoints” (Myers 2010, 61) as well as viewpoints. By listening to audio guide narratives, we can at least imaginatively begin to assume other points of perception, e. g., inside the picture’s ‘storyworld,’ or the imagined historical life world of the artist, etc. Audio guides also afford “evocative listening” (Chaves and Rebelo 2012), whether purposefully or accidentally, because the sounds, voices and music we hear may trigger associations unrelated to the artefact at hand. In my example, the well-known voice of Hannelore Elsner may make visitors think of her in her various acting roles, which may distract them from looking at the pictures attentively.

The specific example investigated in this contribution obviously raises a host of additional questions as regards sound, space and perception because in their audiobook-cum-exhibition catalogue format, the audio guide texts are consumed differently. If we imagine someone sitting at home in an easy chair listening to the texts from a CD player while looking at the pictures in the book, we can easily see that the “earpoints” created under these circumstances may well be different and that the mental images evoked in the listening process may well be influenced by one’s immediate surroundings at home.¹³ Children may frequently interrupt one’s listening experience and thus interfere in the immersive process, or a cat may cross the book and bar one’s view of the picture, and so on. Numerous scenarios can be thought up. Obviously, a lot more research can be done as regards the nexus between listening, imagining, immersion, space and body. Nevertheless, what seems to be a connecting point is the role that narrative plays in and for audio guide presentations.

5. Conclusion

In this contribution, I investigated an audio text with a view to identifying how sound, verbal text and painting work together in narrative terms. Webb and

¹³ For a similar discussion of the influence of one’s spatial surroundings on the listening experience in audiobook listening, see Kuzmičová’s contribution in this volume.

Mann (2014, 8) are probably right in saying that a “sound-only approach is likely to be more niche than core” in museum guide presentations since museums typically aim at informing visitors. And verbal input has a vital role to play here. However, when one looks at the affective side of audio guide texts (Teffé and Hagedorn 2008), narrative with its key feature of “experientiality” (Fludernik 1996) is of the essence at all modal levels. The example showed that narrative not only infuses the spoken text, i.e., the words presented by the audio guide. Narrative structure was also shown to be reinforced and supported by the speakers’ pauses in speech, their intonation contours and rhythmic cadences, even their idiosyncratic voice qualities. I also showed that the music not only serves as a background but that it even assumes narrative functions itself (see also Porto Requijo, this volume) by replicating the climactic structure of the story told in the picture and by serving as a coda to the unfinished story, thus adding ‘plasticity’ to the two-dimensional pictorial genre.

One must be careful not to use the term ‘narrative’ in an overly extensive or even inflationary way, as seems unfortunately to be the case in some audio guide research. As I hope to have made clear throughout, narrative as one text type is intertwined with descriptive and expository text, and the ‘narratives’ created through the picture and the music can either be regarded as narrative only in a metaphorical sense or, and this would be my suggestion, as more literally narrative if one takes into account the role that the imagination plays when visitors begin to be ‘drawn into’ the artefact’s storyworld or the storyworld of the artist’s life.

Appendix

- 1 Courbet war ein ↑passionierter Jäger. (0.7)
- 2 Den “↑Hirsch am ↑Wasser,” auch “Ins ↑Wasser flüchtender ↑Hirsch” genannt, begann er während seines Aufenthalts 1858/59 (.) in ↑Frankfurt zu malen, vordergründig, weil es für solche ↑Jagdszenen eine ↑breite ↑Käuferschicht gab. (0.7)
- 3 Zu↑gleich <er↑kann:te er sich in dem ↑flüchten:den: ↑Tier> auch ↑selbst wieder. (0.9)
- 4 Wir dürfen: den: (0.4) “↑Hirsch am ↑Wasser” (0.6) als eines der (0.2) ver↑decken: ↑Selbstbildnisse Courbets ansehen, (0.9) denn auch der ↑Maler fühlte sich damals auf der Flucht. (1.2)
- 5 “Ich durchquere fremde Länder, um die geistige ↑Unabhängigkeit zu finden, die ich brauche, (0.2) auch um ↑diese Re↑gierung, die mich ↑nicht in Ehren leben lässt, zu überstehen.” (1.3)
- 6 Courbet setzt den ge↑hetzten Hirsch (.)↑eindrucksvoll in Szene, (0.4)
- 7 mit ↑Abendrot und ↑Wolkenhimmel, (0.5) ↑Bäumen und ↑Wasser (0.5) erschafft er eine ↑grandiose ↑Bühne, (0.6) auf der sich das ↑Drama ↑abspielt. (0.8)

- 8 Die ↑Hundemeute auf den Fersen, (0.3) ↑stürzt der ↑Hirsch mit ↑letzter ↑Kraft ins Wasser. (0.8)
- 9 >Aber zu↑gleich< (.) >hat das Ge↑mälde< (.) auch etwas:: von einem ↑Traum. (0.7)
- 10 Courbet sagt es [↑selbst (0.2) in einem Brief (1.0)]
[onset: cello music]
- 11 “Der Hirsch zieht wie ein ↑Strich, wie ein Traum vorüber.” (1.6)
- 12 Kopf, Hals und Ge↑weihspitzen (0.4) sind von einem ↑unwirklichen ↑Licht übergossen.
- 13 >Mitten in der Bewegung wendet das Tier den Kopf zum Himmel empor, mit einem ver↑zweifelten, geradezu ↑menschlichen Ausdruck.<
- 14 Und dann die Be↑wegung ↑selber (.) ↑alle vier ↑Läufe in der ↑Luft [(1.0)]
[long note]
- 15 man ↑meint, der Hirsch würde ↑fliegen. [(20.0)]
[music] [onset high note, music continues for 20 sec.]
- 16 In der ↑Tat ist die Bewegung ↑nicht na↑turgetreu. (0.3)
- 17 Tiere im ↑Trab oder Ga↑lopp zu malen, (0.3) ↑stellte für die Maler damals gene↑rell ein Problem dar. (0.5)
- 18 >Die Be↑bewegungen der Beine sind ↑so schnell<, (0.5) dass man die ↑Phasen mit bloßem Auge nicht erfassen kann. (0.5)
- 19 Erst Jahre ↑später hielt der englische ↑Fotopionier (0.5) Eadweard (.)↑Muybridge (0.5) die Be↑bewegungsphasen von ↑trabenden und galop↑pierenden ↑Vierbeinern (0.6) auf seri↑ellen: (.) Fotogra↑fien fest. (0.8)
- 20 >Aber ↑das hätte Courbet wohl< nur am Rande interessiert, (0.5)
- 21 denn ↑ihm:: ging es ↑nicht um die ↑objektive ↑Wirklichkeit des ↑Alltags, (0.6) >sondern um die< (0.2)↑subjektive Wirklichkeit (.) des ↑Traums.

(1) Courbet was a passionate hunter. (2) He began to paint his “Stag Taking to the Water,” also called “Stag at Bay,” during his stay in Frankfurt in 1858/59, primarily because there was a considerable clientele for such hunting paintings. (3) At the same time, he recognised himself in the fleeing animal. (4) We can regard “Stag Taking to the Water” as one of Courbet’s covert self-portraits because the painter also felt chased at the time: (5) “I travel through foreign countries to find the intellectual independence I need, also to survive this government, which doesn’t allow me to live an honourable life.” (6) Courbet stages the hunted stag impressively: (7) using sunset and a cloudy sky, trees and water, he creates a grandiose stage on which the dramatic action takes place. (8) Followed closely by a pack of hounds, the stag takes to the water in a last effort. (9) But the painting also has something of a dream about it. (10) Courbet says it himself in a letter: (11) “The stag passes by at a stroke, like a dream.” (12) Head, neck and antlers are steeped in an unreal light. (13) In the middle of its movement, the animal turns its head and lifts it to the sky, with an expression of despair that is almost human. (14) And then there is the movement itself: all four legs are up in the air; (15) it is as if the stag was flying. (16) Indeed, this movement is not true to nature. (17) To paint trotting or galloping animals generally posed a challenge for painters at that time. (18) The movements of the legs are so fast that one cannot dis-

cern their separate motional phases just by looking at them. (19) It was only years later that Eadweard Muybridge, an English pioneer of photography, captured trotting and galloping quadrupeds in motion in serial photographs. (20) However, this would not have been of much interest to Courbet (21) because he was not concerned with the objective reality of everyday life but with the subjective reality of dreams.

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Notes on Contributors

Lars Bernaerts is Professor of Dutch Literature at Ghent University (Belgium). Previously, he taught literary theory at the Vrije Universiteit Brussel. His research and publications focus on narratology, experimental fiction, modern Dutch literature, and cognitive literary studies. Together with Dirk De Geest, Luc Herman, and Bart Vervaeck, he edited *Stories and Minds* (2013, University of Nebraska Press), a book on cognitive narratology. He is a co-director of the Center for the Study of Experimental Literature (SEL, joint research group at Ghent University & Vrije Universiteit Brussel), and editor-in-chief of the journal *Spiegel der Letteren*.

Ivan Delazari is currently a PhD Fellow at Hong Kong Baptist University, working on musico-literary intermediality in contemporary American fiction. After completing his first PhD on *Axiological Patterns in William Faulkner's Fictional World* (2003), he taught at St. Petersburg State University for ten years, resigning as Associate Professor of Literary History in 2015. In 2009–2010, he was a Fulbright Visiting Scholar at the University of Mississippi. His research interests have gradually shifted from American literature and cultural studies to cognitive narratology, the theory of intermediality and the performativity of aesthetic response. He has published over 50 articles on a variety of subjects in American, British, and comparative literature.

Sebastian Domsch is Professor for Anglophone literatures at the Ernst-Moritz-Arndt-Universität Greifswald. His research interests are eighteenth-century and contemporary literature, literary theory, the narratology of computer games and graphic novels. He is the author of *Absenz – Simulation – Karneval: Eine Untersuchung der postmodernen Erzählverfahren in Robert Coovers Romanwerk* (WVT, 2005), *Cormac McCarthy* (text + kritik, 2012), *The Emergence of Literary Criticism in 18th-Century Britain: Discourse between Attacks and Authority* (De Gruyter 2014) and *Storyplaying: Agency and Narrative in Video Games* (De Gruyter 2013) as well as numerous articles.

Thijs Festjens, M.A., is working on a PhD thesis about “Documentary Generations in German Literature” at Ghent University. His research interests are The New Objectivity, First World War Studies, German documentary theatre and the (acoustic) performance of the document. His publications (with Gunther Martens) include: “Chronik des angekündigten Untergangs einer Fluggesellschaft. Sabenation: go home and follow the news,” in: *Rimini Protokoll Close-*

Up: Lektüren (2015); “Ein Trieb zum Dokumentarischen: Akustik und Authentizität in Jüngers Kriegstagebüchern (1914–1918),” in: *Text & Kontext* (2013).

Elke Huwiler is Assistant Professor at the German Department of the University of Amsterdam. She has published on German ‘Hörspiele,’ radio drama adaptations, the narratology of audio drama, as well as performances of audio plays. She also works on historical theatre plays and the narratology of theatre. Her main publications in the field of audionarratology are her book *Erzähl-Ströme im Hörspiel: Zur Narratologie der elektroakustischen Kunst* (2005) and her articles “Storytelling by Sound: A Theoretical Frame for Radio Drama Analysis”; “Radio Drama Adaptations: An Approach towards an Analytical Methodology” and “The Performed Radio Play: Andreas Ammer and the Re-Invention of the Art Form.”

Till Kinzel received his Dr. phil. (2002) and Habilitation (2005) from the Technical University of Berlin. He has published books on Allan Bloom (*Platonische Kulturkritik in Amerika*; 2002), Nicolás Gómez Dávila (2003, 4th enlarged ed. 2015), Philip Roth (*Die Tragödie und Komödie des amerikanischen Lebens*, 2006) and Michael Oakeshott (2007). Most recently, he has edited a number of writings and translations by Johann Joachim Eschenburg and co-edited *Imaginary Dialogues in English* (2012) and *Imaginary Dialogues in American Literature and Philosophy* (2014, both with Jarmila Mildorf), as well as *Johann Joachim Eschenburg und die Künste und Wissenschaften zwischen Aufklärung und Romantik* (2013) and a book on the reception of Edward Gibbon in Germany (2015; both with Cord-Friedrich Berghahn).

Anežka Kuzmičová is a postdoctoral researcher in the Department of Culture and Aesthetics, Stockholm University. Her main research area is reading as mental process, embodied experience, and situated practice. Within this area she has published on topics such as readers’ immersion, mental imagery, or the role of the physical environment in reading. She is currently involved in collaborative projects with researchers in the cognitive and social sciences, investigating various psychological effects of literary fiction as well as the impact of digitization on reading behaviour more generally. She is the author of *Mental Imagery in the Experience of Literary Narrative: Views from Embodied Cognition* (Stockholm University, 2013). Her articles have appeared in *Communication Theory*, *Journal of Literary Theory*, *Samlaren*, *Semiotica*, *Style*, and in a number of edited volumes.

Bartosz Lutostański is a PhD candidate at the University of Gdańsk, Poland. He has actively participated in organising four literary conferences in Poland. He has taught narrative theory, literary theory and British literature. His list of pub-

lications includes studies of contemporary literature (S. Beckett, W. Gombrowicz, J. Berger) and narratology. He is also a musician and a translator of numerous articles by, amongst others, H. Porter Abbott, S.E. Gontarski and Wlad Godzich into Polish.

María Ángeles Martínez is assistant professor of English Linguistics at the Complutense University of Madrid. Her research interests are in the fields of cognitive stylistics, cognitive narratology, narrative discourse analysis, and multimodal storytelling. Her articles and chapters deal with the linguistic organization of narrative discourse and its bearing on reception, and she has had her work published in journals such as *Narrative* (2014) and *Poetics Today* (2002), as well as in several collective volumes.

Jarmila Mildorf did her PhD in sociolinguistics at the University of Aberdeen and is now a Senior Lecturer for English language and literature at the University of Paderborn. Her research interests are in narratology, sociolinguistics, dialogue studies, stylistics, gender studies, as well as literature and medicine. She is the author of *Storying Domestic Violence: Constructions and Stereotypes of Abuse in the Discourse of General Practitioners* (University of Nebraska Press 2007) and has co-edited five books, among them *Narrative: Knowing, Living, Telling* (with Matti Hyvärinen and Kai Mikkonen, special issue of *Partial Answers* 2008) and *Imaginary Dialogues in American Literature and Philosophy: Beyond the Mainstream* (with Till Kinzel, 2014).

Alan Palmer is an independent scholar living in Weardale, County Durham. His first book *Fictional Minds* (University of Nebraska Press, 2004) was a co-winner of the MLA Prize for Independent Scholars and also a co-winner of the Perkins Prize (awarded by the Society for the Study of Narrative Literature). A special issue of the journal *Style* (45:2, Summer 2011) was devoted to the subject of his second book, *Social Minds in the Novel* (published by the Ohio State University Press in 2010). His chief areas of interest are cognitive narratology, the nineteenth-century novel and the history of country and western music.

M. Dolores Porto Requejo is a Senior Lecturer in English Linguistics at the Universidad de Alcalá, Madrid. Her research has always been related to the cognitive processes in the interpretation of discourse, whether literary, technical, journalistic or multimedia. Among her last publications, all of them in the Cognitive Linguistics framework, “The Life of the *Green Shoots* Metaphor in the Spanish Media” (*Metaphor and the Social World*, 2012), “Newspaper Metaphors: Reusing Metaphors Across Media Genres” (*Metaphor and Symbol* 2013) and “From Local

to Global: Visual Strategies of Glocalisation in Digital Storytelling” (*Language and Communication*, 2014). She is a member of the Research Project *Analysis of Discourse Strategies in Persuasive Communication* (MICINN FFI2012 30790).

Zoë Skoulding is a poet, translator, editor and critic. She has published four collections of poetry, most recently *The Museum of Disappearing Sounds* (Seren, 2013), shortlisted for the Ted Hughes Award for New Work in Poetry, and *Remains of a Future City* (Seren, 2008). She has performed her work at many international festivals, often incorporating electronic sound in her readings as well as collaborating with musicians. Her monograph *Contemporary Women's Poetry and Urban Space: Experimental Cities* was published by Palgrave Macmillan in 2013, and she was editor of Poetry Wales 2008–2014. She is Senior Lecturer in the School of English at Bangor University.

Markus Wierschem studied English and American Literary and Cultural Studies, Philosophy, and Media Studies at St. Olaf College and the University of Paderborn. He interned for then U.S. Senator Chuck Hagel in Washington, D.C., and received his Master's Degree in 2010. He is a recipient of the 2014 Raymund Schwager Memorial Essay Award. Recent publications include: “Searching for Truth in the Death-Deferring Dialogue of McCarthy’s *The Sunset Limited*,” in: *Imaginary Dialogues in American Literature and Philosophy* (Winter 2014); and “The Poetics of Anamorphosis and the Art of Entropy,” in: *LaborARTorium: Forschung im Denkraum zwischen Wissenschaft und Kunst* (with Anna-Sophie Jürgens; Transcript 2015). He teaches American Studies at Paderborn University while writing his dissertation on violence, myth, and entropy in Cormac McCarthy’s novels.

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